

Category Theory Illustrated

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Category Theory Illustrated

In memory of

Francis William Lawvere

1937 - 2023

“Try as you may,
you just can’t get away,
from mathematics”

Tom Lehrer

The story behind this book

I was interested in math as a kid, but was always messing up calculations, so I decided it was not my thing and started pursuing other interests, like writing and visual art.

A little later I got into programming and I found that this was similar to the part of mathematics that I enjoyed. I started using functional programming in an effort to explore the similarity and to improve myself as a developer. I discovered category theory a little later.

Some 5 years ago I found myself jobless for a few months and decided to publish some of the diagrams that I drew as part of the notes I kept when was reading “Category Theory for Scientists” by David Spivak. The effort resulted in a rough version of the first two chapters of this book, which I published online.

A few years after that some people found my notes and encouraged me write more. They were so nice that I forgot my imposter syndrome and got to work on the next several chapters.

On math

Ever since Newton's Principia, the discipline of mathematics is viewed in the somewhat demeaning position of "science and engineering's workhorse" — only "useful" as a means for helping scientists and engineers to make technological and scientific advancements, i.e., it is viewed as just a tool for solving "practical" problems.

Because of this, mathematicians are in a weird and, I'd say, unique position of always having to defend what they do with respect to its value for *other disciplines*. I again stress that this is something that would be considered absurd when it comes to any other discipline.

People don't expect any return on investment from *physical theories*, e.g., no one bashes a physical theory for having no utilitarian value.

And bashing philosophical theories for being impractical would be even more absurd — imagine bashing Wittgenstein, for example:

"All too well, but what can you do with the picture theory of language?" "Well, I am told it does have its applications in programming language theory..."

Or someone being sceptical to David Hume's scepticism:

"That's all fine and dandy, but your theory leaves us at square one in terms of our knowledge. What the hell are we

expected to do from there?”

Although many people don't necessarily subscribe to this view of mathematics as a workhorse, we can see it encoded inside the structure of most mathematics textbooks — each chapter starts with an explanation of a concept, followed by some examples, and then ends with a list of problems that this concept solves.

There is nothing wrong with this approach, but mathematics is so much more than a tool for solving problems. It was the basis of a religious cult in ancient Greece (the Pythagoreans), it was seen by philosophers as means to understanding the laws which govern the universe. It was, and still is, a language which can allow for people with different cultural backgrounds to understand each other. And it is also art and a means of entertainment. It is a mode of thinking, Or we can even say it is thinking itself. Some people say that “writing is thinking”, but I would argue that writing, when refined enough, and free from any kind of bias in on the side of the author, automatically becomes *mathematical writing* — you can almost convert the words into formulas and diagrams.

Category theory embodies all these aspects of mathematics, so I think it's very good grounds to writing a book where all of them shine — a book that isn't based on solving of problems, but exploring concepts and seeking connections between them. A book that is, overall, pretty.

Who is this book for

So, who is this book for? Some people would phrase the question as “Who *should* read this book”, but if you ask it this way, then the answer is “nobody”. Indeed, if you think in terms of “should”, mathematics (or at least the type of mathematics that is reviewed here) won’t help you much, although it is falsely advertised as a solution to many problems (whereas it is, in fact, (as we established) something much more).

Let’s take an example — many people claim that Einstein’s theories of relativity are essential for GPS-es to work properly. Due to relativistic effects, the clocks on GPS satellites tick faster than identical clocks on the ground.

They seem to think that if the theory didn’t exist, the engineers that developed the GPSes would have faced this phenomenon in the following way:

Engineer 1: Whoa, the clocks on the satellites are off by X nanoseconds!

Engineer 2: But that’s impossible! Our mathematical model predicts that they should be correct.

Engineer 1: OK, so what do we do now?

Engineer 2: I guess we need to drop this project until we have a viable mathematical model that describes time in the universe.

Although I am not an expert in special relativity, I suspect that the way this conversation would have developed would be closer to the following:

Engineer 1: Whoa, the clocks on the satellites are off by X nanoseconds!

Engineer 2: This is normal. There are many unknowns.

Engineer 1: OK, so what do we do now?

Engineer 2: Just adjust it by X and see if it works. Oh, and tell that to some physicist. They might find it interesting.

In other words, we can solve problems without any advanced math, or with no math at all, as evidenced by the fact that the Egyptians were able to build the pyramids without even knowing Euclidean geometry. And with that I am not claiming that math is so insignificant, that it is not even good enough to serve as a tool for building stuff. Quite the contrary, I think that math is much more than just a simple tool. So going through any math textbook (and of course especially this one) would help you in ways that are much more vital than finding solutions to “complex” problems.

Some people say that we don't use maths in our daily life. But, if true, that is only because other people have solved all hard problems for us and the solutions are encoded on the tools that we use, however not knowing math means that you will be forever a consumer, bound to use those existing tools and solutions and thinking patterns, not being able to do anything on your own.

And so “Who is this book for” is not to be read as who should, but who *can* read it. Then, the answer is “everyone”.

About category theory

Like we said, the fundamentals of mathematics are the fundamentals of thought. Category theory allows us to formalize those fundamentals that we use in our daily (intellectual) lives.

The way we think and talk is based on intuition that develops naturally and is a very easy way to get our point across. However, intuition also makes it easy to be misunderstood — what we say usually can be interpreted in many ways, some of which are wrong. Misunderstanding of these kinds are the reason why biases appear. Moreover, certain people (called “sophists” in ancient Greece) would introduce biases on purpose in order to twist the discourse in the direction that suits them.

It's in such situations, that people often resort to *formulas* and *diagrams* to refine their thoughts. Diagrams (even more than formulas) are ubiquitous in science and mathematics.

Category theory formalizes the concept of diagrams and their components — arrows and objects — to create a language for presenting all kinds of ideas. In this sense, category theory is a way to unify knowledge, both mathematical and scientific, and to unite various modes of thinking with common terms.

As a consequence of that, category theory and diagrams are also a very understandable way to communicate a formal concept clearly, something I hope to demonstrate in the following pages.

Summary

In this book we will visit various such modes of knowledge and along the way, see all kinds of mathematical objects, viewed through the lens of categories.

We start with *set theory* in chapter 1, which is the original way to formalize different mathematical concepts.

Chapter 2 we will make a (hopefully) gentle transition from sets to *categories* while showing how the two compare and (finally) introducing the definition of category theory.

In the next two chapters, 3 and 4, we jump into two different branches of mathematics and introduce their main means of abstraction, *groups and orders*, observing how they connect to the core category-theoretic concepts that we introduced earlier.

Chapter 5 also follows the main formula of the previous two chapters, getting to the heart of the matter of why category theory is a universal language, by showing its connection with the ancient discipline of *logic*. As in chapters 3 and 4, we start with a crash course in logic itself.

The connection between all these different disciplines is examined in chapter 6, using one of the most interesting category-theoretical concepts — the concept of a functor.

In chapter 7 we review another more interesting and more advanced categorical concept, the concept of a *natural transformation*.

Acknowledgments

Thanks to my wife Dimitrina, for all her support.

My daughter Daria, my “anti-author” who stayed seated on my knees when I was writing the second and third chapters and mercilessly deleted many sentences, most of them bad.

Thanks to my high-school arts teacher, Mrs Georgieva who told me that I have some talent, but I have to work.

Thanks to Prathyush Pramod who encouraged me to finish the book and is also helping me out with it.

And also to everyone else who submitted feedback and helped me fix some of the numerous errors that I made — knowing myself, I know that there are more.

Sets

Let's begin our inquiry by looking at the basic theory of sets. Set theory and category theory share many similarities. We can view category theory as a *generalization* of set theory. That is, it's meant to describe the same thing as set theory (everything?), but to do it in a more abstract manner, one that is more versatile and (hopefully) simpler.

In other words, sets are an *example of a category* (the *proto-example*, we might say), and it is useful to have examples.

What is an Abstract Theory

Instead of asking what can be defined and deduced from what is assumed to begin with, we ask instead what more general ideas and principles can be found, in terms of which what was our starting-point can be defined or deduced. Bertrand Russell, from Introduction to Mathematical Philosophy

Most scientific and mathematical theories have a specific *domain*, which they are tied to, and in which they are valid. They are created with this domain in mind and are not intended to be used outside of it. For example, Darwin's theory of evolution is created in order to explain how different *biological species* came to evolve using natural selection, quantum mechanics is a description of how particles behave at a specific scale, etc.

Even mathematical theories, although they are not inherently *bound* to a specific domain (like the scientific theories) are at least strongly related to some domain, as for example differential equations are created to model how events change over time.

Set theory and category theory are different, they are not created to provide a rigorous explanation of how a particular phenomenon works, instead they provide a more general framework for explaining all kinds of phenomena. They work less like tools and more like languages for defining tools. Such theories are called *abstract* theories.

The borders of the two are sometimes blurry. All theories *use abstraction*, otherwise they would be pretty useless: without abstraction Darwin would have to speak about specific animal species or even individual animals. The difference is that abstract theories have *core concepts* that don't refer to anything in particular, and are instead left for people to generalize on. All theories are applicable outside of their domains, but set theory and category theory do not have a domain to begin with.

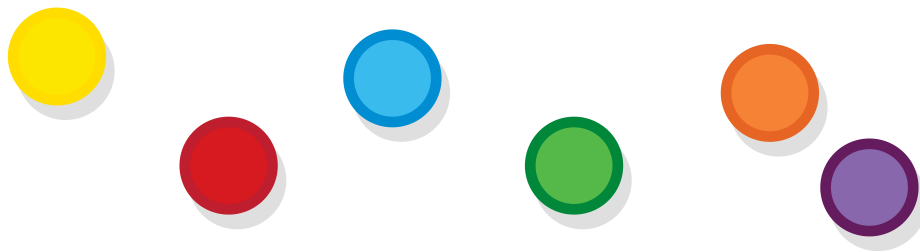
Concrete theories, like the theory of evolution, are composed of concrete concepts. For example, the concept of a *population*, also called a *gene-pool*, refers to a group of individuals that can interbreed. Abstract theories, like set theory, are composed of abstract concepts, like the concept of a set. The concept of a set by itself does not refer to anything. However, we cannot say that it is an empty concept, as there are countless things that can be represented by sets, for example, gene pools can be (very aptly) represented by sets of individual animals. Animal species can also be represented by sets — a set of all populations that can theoretically interbreed.

You've already seen how abstract theories may be useful. Because they are so simple, they can be used as building blocks to many concrete theories. Because they are common, they can be used to unify and compare different concrete theories, by putting these theories in common grounds (this is very characteristic of category theory, as we will see later). Moreover, good (abstract) theories can serve as *mental models* for developing our thoughts.

Sets

“A set is a gathering together into a whole of definite, distinct objects of our perception or of our thought—which are called elements of the set.” – Georg Cantor

Perhaps unsurprisingly, everything in set theory is defined in terms of sets. A set is a collection of things where the “things” can be anything you want (like individuals, populations, genes, etc.) Consider, for example, these balls.



Balls

Let's construct a set, call it G (as gray) that contains *all* of them as elements. There can only be one such set: because a set has no structure (there is no order, no ball goes before or after another, there are no members which are “special” with respect to their membership of the set.) Two sets that contain the same elements are just two pictures of the same set.



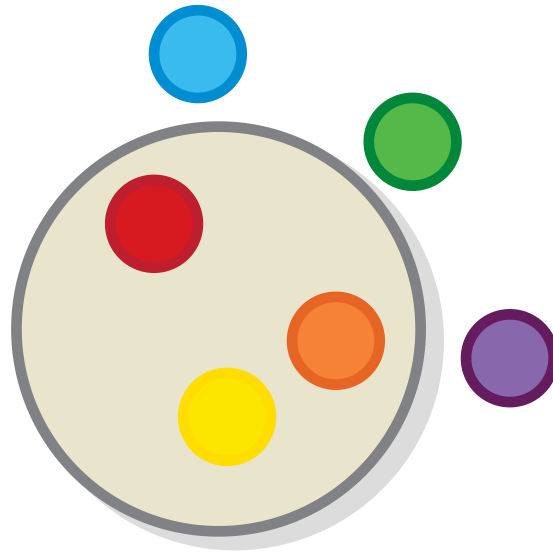
The set of all balls

This example may look overly-simple, but in fact, it's just as valid as any other.

The key insight that makes the concept useful is the fact that it enables you to reason about several things as if they were one.

Subsets

Let's construct one more set. The set of *all balls that are warm in color*. Let's call it Y (because in the diagram, it's colored in **y**ellow).



The set of all balls of warm colors

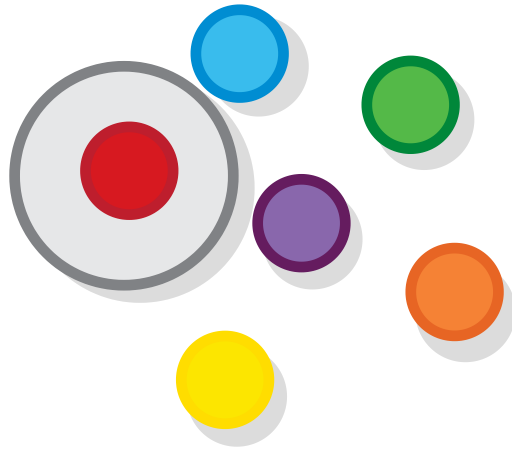
Notice that Y contains only elements that are also present in G . That is, every element of the set of Y is also an element in the set G . When two sets have this relation, we may say that Y is a *subset* of G (or $Y \subseteq G$). A subset resides completely inside its superset when the two are drawn together.



Y and G together

Singleton Sets

The set of all *red balls* contains just one ball. We said above that sets summarize *several* elements into one. Still, sets that contain just one element are perfectly valid — simply put, there are things that are *one of a kind*. The set of kings/queens that a given kingdom has is a singleton set.

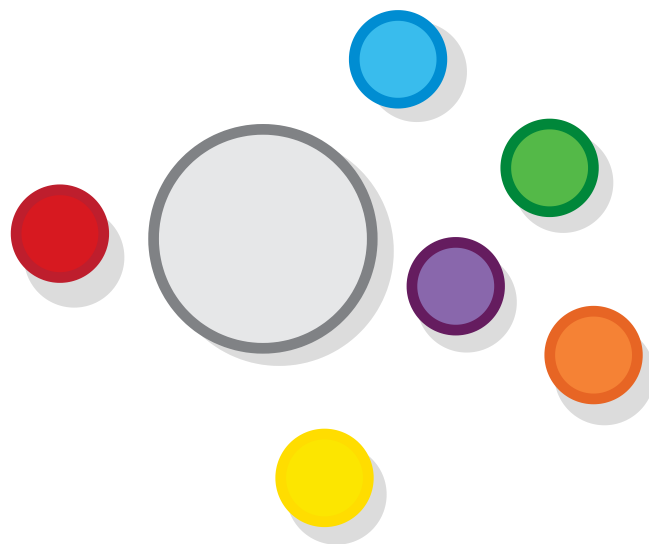


The singleton set of red balls

What's the point of the singleton set? Well, it is part of the language of set theory, e.g., if we have a function which expects a set of given items, but if there is only one item that meets the criteria, we can just create a singleton set with that item.

The Empty set

Of course if one is a valid answer, zero can be also. If we want a set of all *black balls* B or all the *white balls*, W , the answer to all these questions is the same — the empty set.



The empty set

Because a set is defined only by the items it contains, the empty set is *unique* — there is no difference between the set that contains zero *balls* and the set that contains zero *numbers*, for instance. Formally, the empty set is marked with the symbol $\emptyset$ (so $B = W = \emptyset$).

The empty set has some special properties, for example, it is a subset of every other set. Mathematically speaking, $\forall A \rightarrow \emptyset \subseteq A$ ($\forall$ means “for all”)

Functions

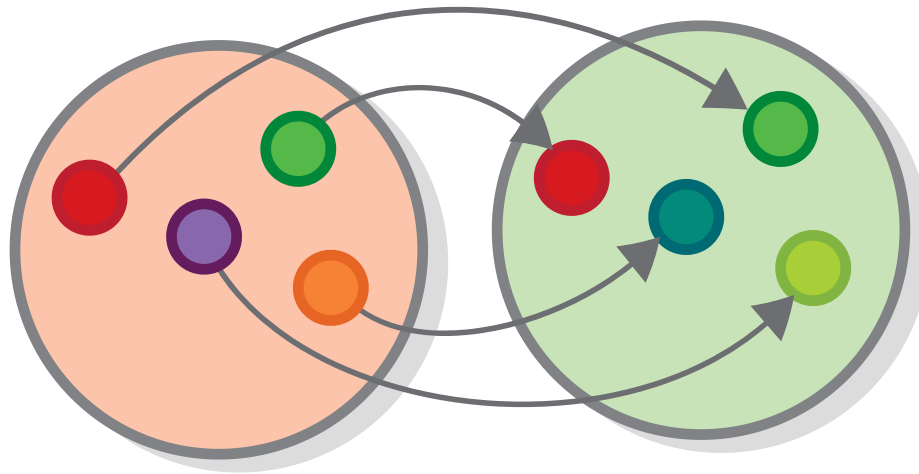
“By function I mean the unity of the act of arranging various representations under one common representation.” — Immanuel Kant, from “The Critique of Pure Reason”

A function is a relationship between two sets that matches each element of one set, called the *source set* of the function, with exactly one element from another set, called the *target set* of the function.

These two sets are also called the *domain* and *codomain* of the function, or its *input* and *output*. In programming, they go by the name of *argument type* and *return type*. In logic, they correspond to the *premise* and *conclusion* (we will get there). We might also say, depending on the situation, that a given function *goes* from this set to that other one, *connects* this set to the other, or that it *converts* a value from this set to a value from the other one. These different terms demonstrate the multifaceted nature of the concept of function.

Different types of functions

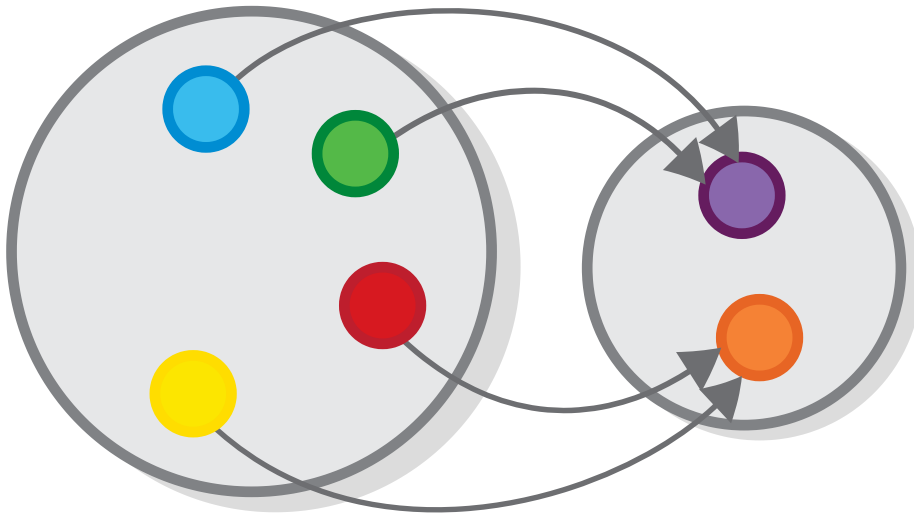
Here is a function f , which converts each ball from the set R to the ball with the opposite color in another set G (in mathematics a function's name is often accompanied by the names of its source and target sets, like this: $f : R \rightarrow G$)



Opposite colors

This is probably one of the simplest type of function that exists — it encodes a *one-to-one relationship* between the sets. That is to say, *one* element from the source is connected to exactly *one* element from the target (and the other way around).

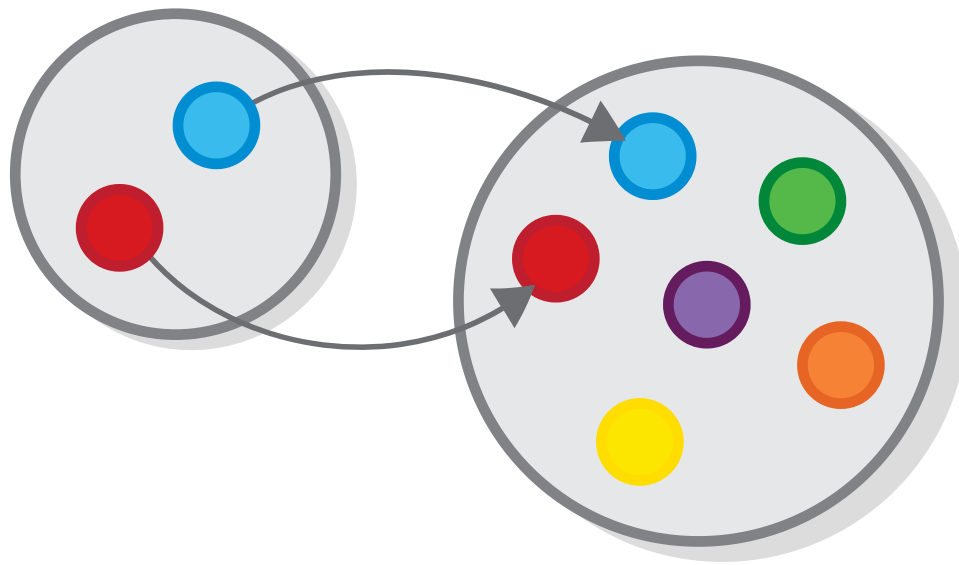
But functions can also express relationships of the type *many-to-one*, where *many* elements from the source might be connected to *one* element from the target (but not the other way around). Below is one such function.



Function from a bigger set to a smaller one

Such functions might represent operations such as *categorizing* a given collection of objects by some criteria, or partitioning them, based on some property that they might have.

A function can also express relationships in which some elements from the target set do not play a part.



Function from a smaller set to a bigger one

An example might be the relationship between some kind of pattern or structure and the emergence of this pattern in some more complicated context.

We saw how versatile functions are, but there is one thing that you cannot have in a function. You cannot have a source element that is not mapped to anything, or that is mapped to more than one target element — that would constitute a *many-to-many* relationship and as we said functions express many-to-one relationships. There is a reason for that “design decision”, and we will arrive at it shortly.

Functions in everyday life

Sets and functions can express relationships between all kinds of objects, and even people. Every question that you ask that has an answer can be expressed as a function.

The question “How far are we from New York?” is a function with set of all places in the world as source set and its target set consisting of the set of all positive numbers.

The question “Who is my father?” is a function whose source is the set of all people in the world.

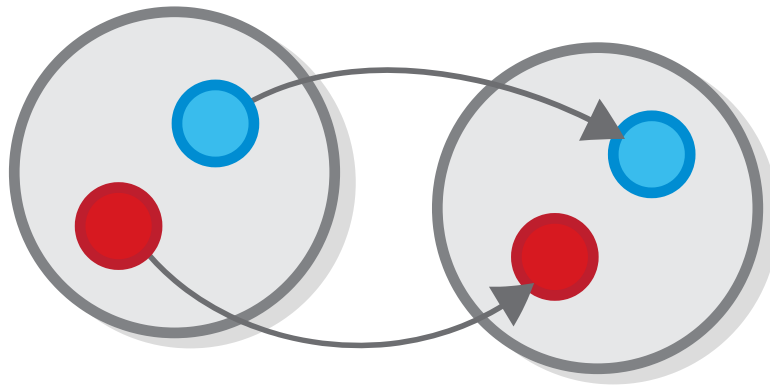
Task 1: What is the target of this function?

Note that the question “Who is my child?” is *NOT* a straightforward function, because a person can have no children, or can have multiple children. We will learn to represent such questions as functions later.

Task 2: Do all functions that we drew at the beginning *express* something? Do you think that a function should express something in order to be valid?

The Identity Function

For every set G , no matter what it represents, we can define the function that does nothing, or in other words, a function which maps every element of G to itself. It is called *the identity function* of G or $ID_G : G \rightarrow G$.

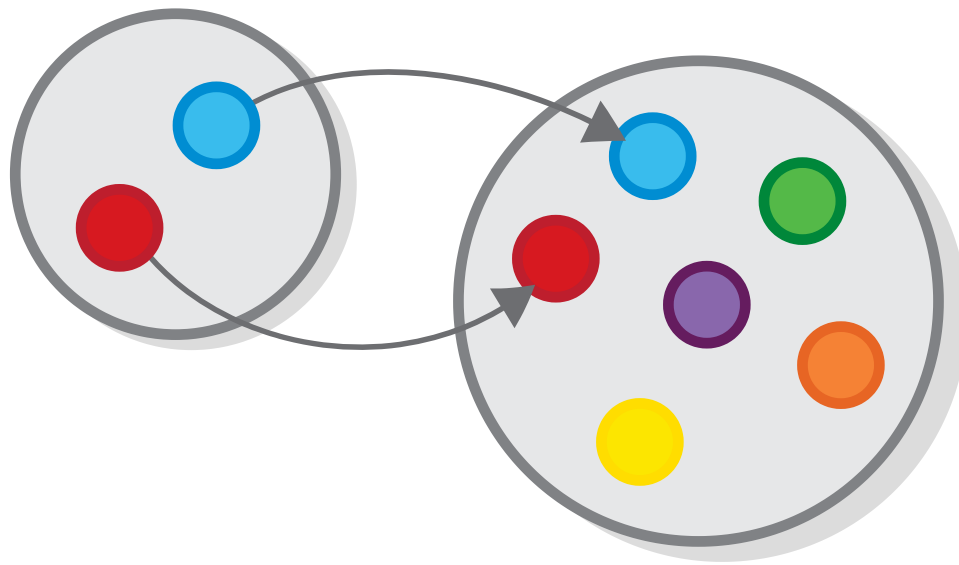


The identity function

You can think of ID_G as a function which represents the set G in the realm of functions. Its existence allows us to prove many theorems, that we “know” by intuition, formally.

Functions and Subsets

For each set and subset, no matter what they represent, we can define a function (called the *image* of the subset) that maps each element of the subset to itself:

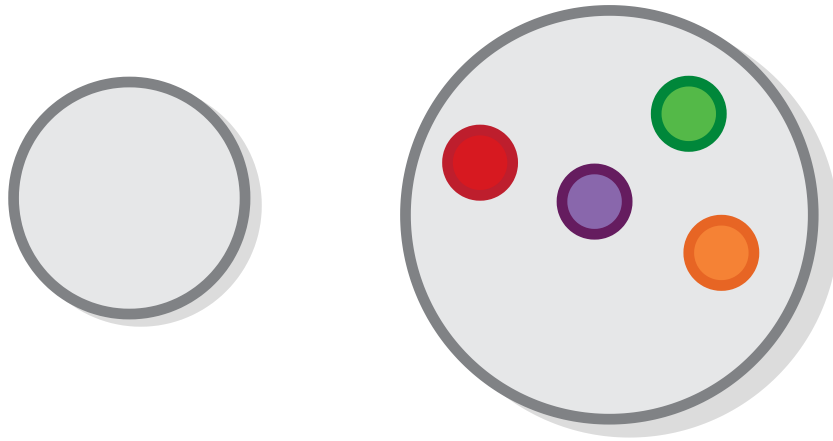


Function from a smaller set to a bigger one

Every set is a subset of itself, in which case this function is the same as the identity.

Functions and the Empty Set

Although it doesn't look like it, there is a unique function from the empty set to any other set.



Function with empty set

Task 3: Is this really valid? Why? Check the definition.

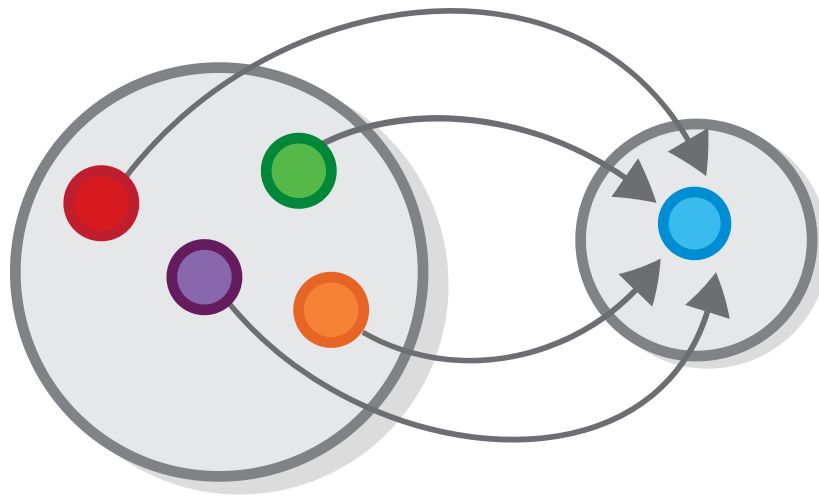
If you still aren't convinced, check this out: 1. There is a function between a subset and a its superset 2. The empty set is a subset of any other set.

So, evidently, this function has to exist!

Task 4: What about the other way around. Are there functions with the empty set as a target as opposed to its source?

Functions and Singleton Sets

There is a unique function from any set to any singleton set.



Function with a singleton set

Task 5: Is this really the only way to connect *any* set to a singleton set in a valid way?

Task 6: Again, what about the other way around?

Sets and numbers

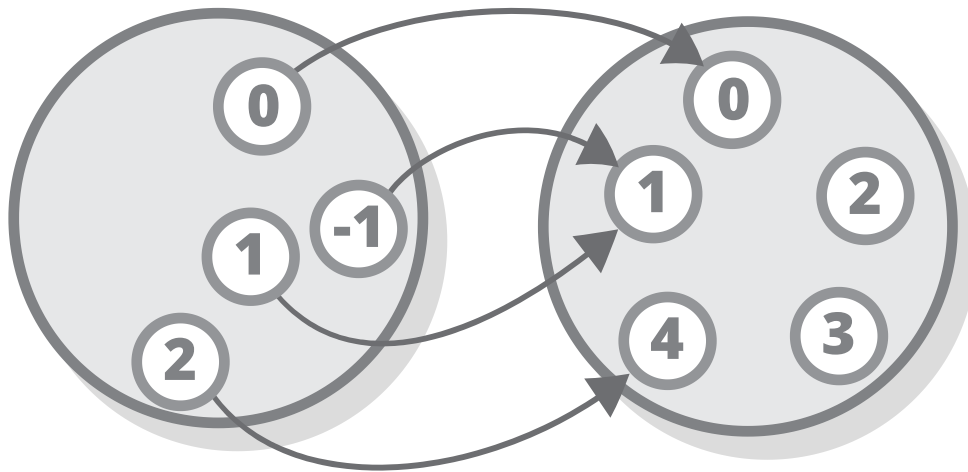
All numerical operations can be expressed as functions acting on the set of (different types of) numbers.

Number sets

Because not all functions work on all numbers, we separate the set of numbers to several sets, many of which are subsets to one another, such the set of whole numbers $\mathbb{Z} := \dots - 3 - 2, -1, 0, 1, 2, 3, \dots$, the set of positive whole numbers, (also called “natural” numbers), $\mathbb{N} := 1, 2, 3, \dots$. We also have the set of Real numbers $\mathbb{R}$, which includes almost all numbers and the set of positive real numbers (or $\mathbb{R}_{>0}$).

Number functions

Each numerical operation is a function between two of these sets. For example, squaring a number is a function from the set of real numbers to the set of real non-negative numbers (because both sets are infinite, we cannot draw them in their entirety, however we can draw a part of them).



The square function

I will use the occasion to reiterate some of the more important characteristics of functions:

- All numbers in the target have (or should have) two arrows pointing at them (one for the positive square root and one for the negative one), and that is OK.
- Zero from the source set is connected to itself in the target set — that is permitted.
- Some numbers aren't the square of any other number — that is also permitted.

Overall everything is permitted, as long as you can always provide exactly one result (also known as *The result*[™]) per value. For numerical operations, this is always true, simply because math is designed this way.

Every generalization of number has first presented itself as needed for some simple problem: negative numbers were

needed in order that subtraction might be always possible, since otherwise $a - b$ would be meaningless if a were less than b ; fractions were needed in order that division might be always possible; and complex numbers are needed in order that extraction of roots and solution of equations may be always possible.

Bertrand Russell, from Introduction to Mathematical Philosophy

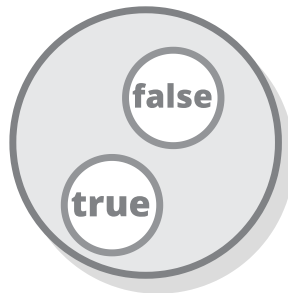
Note that most mathematical operations, such as addition, multiplication, etc. require two numbers in order to produce a result. This does not mean that they are not functions, it just means they're a little fancier. Depending on what we need, we may present those operations as functions from the sets of *tuples* of numbers to the set of numbers, or we may say that they take a number and return a function. More on that later.

Sets and Functions in Programming

Sets are used extensively in programming, especially in their incarnation as *types* (also called *classes*). All sets of numbers that we discussed earlier also exist in most languages as types.

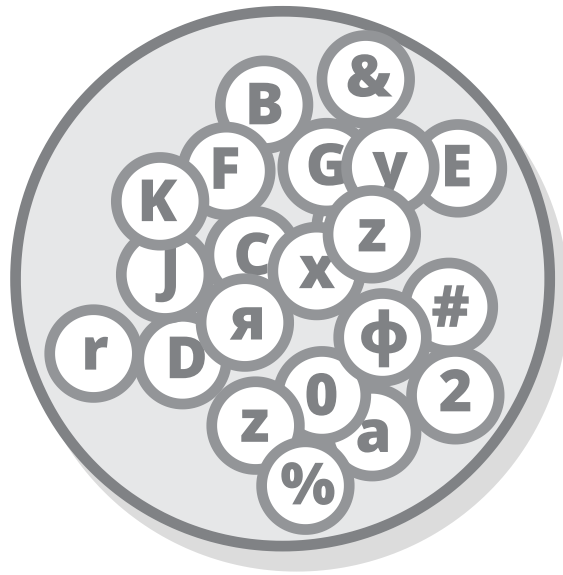
Sets and types

Sets are not exactly the same thing as types, but all types are (or can be seen as) sets. For example, we can view the Boolean type as a set containing two elements — `true` and `false`.



Set of boolean values

Another very basic set that is used in programming is the set of keyboard characters, or `char`. Characters are actually used rarely by themselves and mostly as parts of sequences.



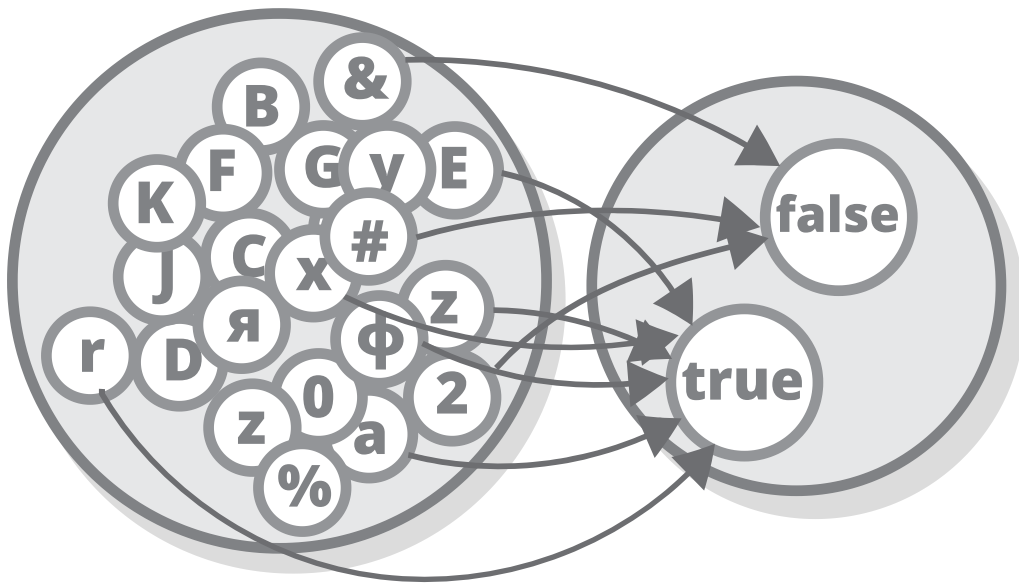
Set of characters

Most of the types that are used in programming are *composite* types — they are a combination of the primitive ones that are listed here. Again, we will cover these later.

Task 7: What is the type equivalent of subsets in programming?

Functions and methods/subroutines

Some functions in programming (also called methods, subroutines, etc.) kinda resemble mathematical functions — they sometimes take one value of a given type (or in other words, an element that belongs to a given set) and always return exactly one element which belongs to another type (or set). For example, here is a function that takes an argument of type `Char` and returns a `Boolean`, indicating whether the character is a letter.



A function from Char to Boolean

However functions in most programming languages can also be quite different from mathematical functions — they can perform various operations that have nothing to do with returning a value. These operations are sometimes called side effects.

Why are functions in programming different? Well, figuring a way to encode *effectful* functions in a way that is mathematically sound isn't trivial and at the time when most programming paradigms that are in use today were created, people had bigger problems than the their functions not being mathematically sound (e.g. actually being able to run any program at all).

Nowadays, many people feel that mathematical functions are too limiting and hard to use. And they might be right. But mathematical functions have one big advantage over non-mathematical ones — their type signature tells you almost everything about what the function does (this is probably the reason why most functional languages are strongly-typed).

Purely-functional programming languages

We said that while all mathematical functions are also programming functions, the reverse is not true for *most* programming languages. However, there are some languages that only permit mathematical functions, and for which this equality holds. They are called *purely-functional* programming languages.

Such languages don't support functions that perform operations like rendering stuff on screen, doing I/O, etc. (in this context, such operations are called "side effects".

In purely functional programming languages, such operations are *outsourced* to the language's runtime. Instead of writing functions that directly perform a side effect, for example `console.log('Hello')`, we write functions that return a type that represents that side effect (for example, in Haskell side effects are handled by the `IO` type) and the runtime then executes those functions for us.

We then link all those functions into a whole program, often by using a thing called *continuation passing style*.

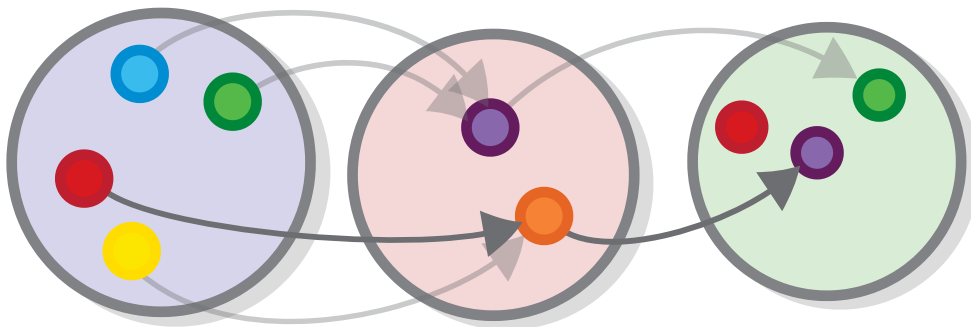
Functional Composition

Now, we were just about to reach the heart of the matter regarding the topic of functions. And that is functional composition. Assume that we have two functions, $g : Y \rightarrow P$ and $f : P \rightarrow G$ and the target of the first one is the same set as the source of the second one.



Matching functions

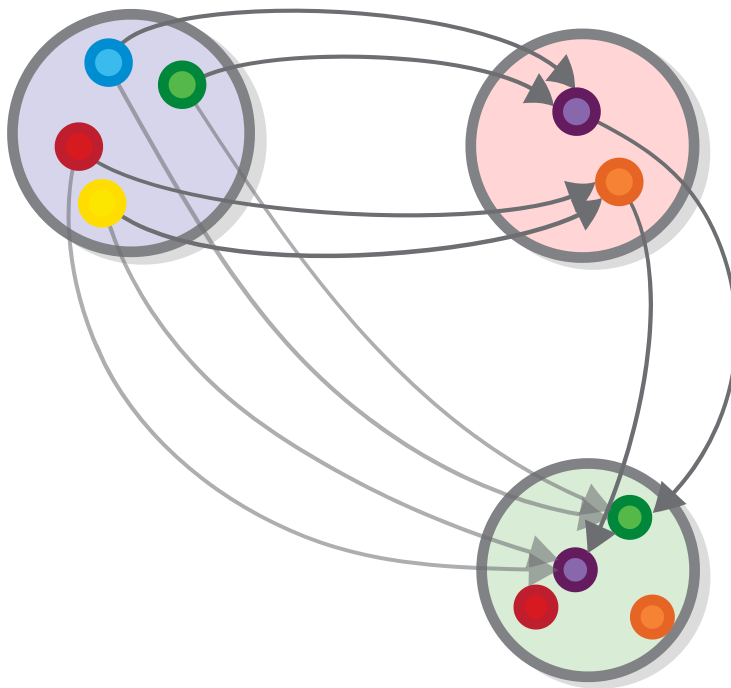
If we apply the first function g to some element from set Y , we will get an element of the set P . Then, if we apply the second function f to *that* element, we will get an element from type G .



Applying one function after another

We can define a function that is the equivalent to performing the operation described above. That would be a function such that, if you follow the arrow h for any element of set Y you will get to the same element of the set G as the one you will get if you follow both the g and f arrows.

Let us call it $h : Y \rightarrow G$. We may say that h is the *composition* of g and f , or $h = f \circ g$ (notice that the first function is on the right, so it's similar to $b = f(g(a))$).



Functional composition

Composition is the essence of all things categorical. The key insight is that the sum of two parts is no more complex than the parts themselves (and therefore can be summed again).

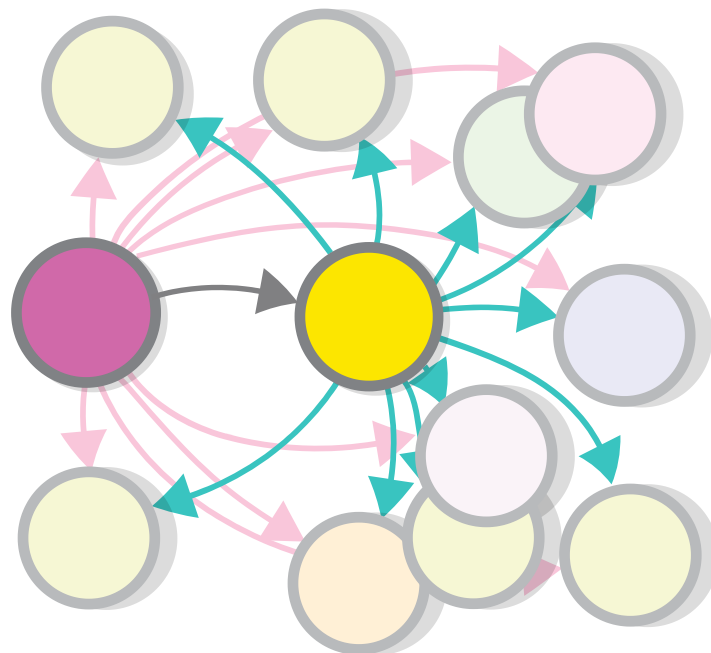
Task 8: Think about which qualities of a function make composition possible, e.g., does it work with other types of

relationships, like many-to-many and one-to-many.

Composition of relationships

To understand how powerful composition is, consider the following: one set being connected to another means that each function from the second set can be transferred to a corresponding function from the first one.

If we have a function $g : P \rightarrow Y$ from set P to set Y , then for every function f from the set Y to any other set, there is a corresponding function $f \circ g$ from the set P to the same set. In other words, every time you define a new function from Y to some other set, you gain one function from P to that same set for free.



Functional composition connect

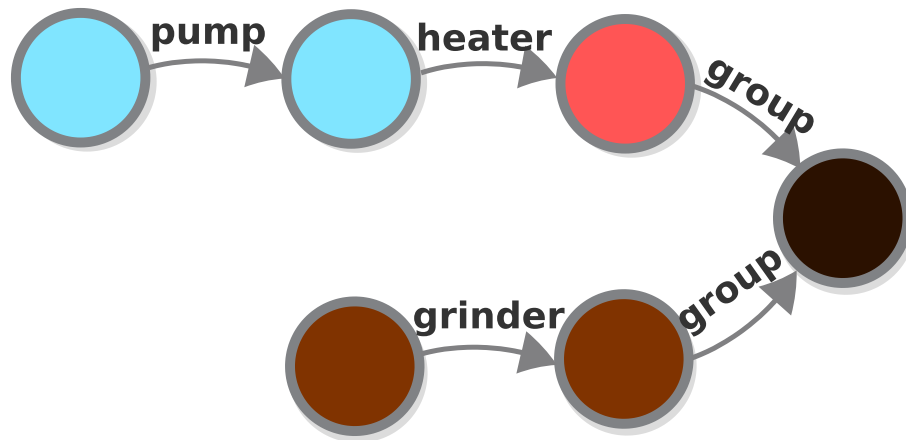
For example, if we again take the relationship between a person and his mother as a function with the set of all people in the world as source, and the set of all people that have children as its target, composing this function with other similar functions would give us all relatives on a person's mother side.

Although you might be seeing functional composition for the first time, the intuition behind it is there — we all know that each person whom our mother is related to is automatically our relative as well — our mother's father is our grandfather, our mother's partner is our father, etc.

Composition in engineering

Besides being useful for *analyzing* relationships that already exist, the principle of composition can help you in the practice of *building* objects that exhibit such relationships i.e. engineering.

One of the main ways in which modern engineering differs from ancient craftsmanship is the concept of a *part/module/component* - a product that performs a given function that is not made to be used directly, but is instead optimized to be combined with other such products in order to form a "end-user" product. For example, an *espresso machine* is just a combination of the components, such as , *pump*, *heater*, *grinder group* etc, when composed in an appropriate way.



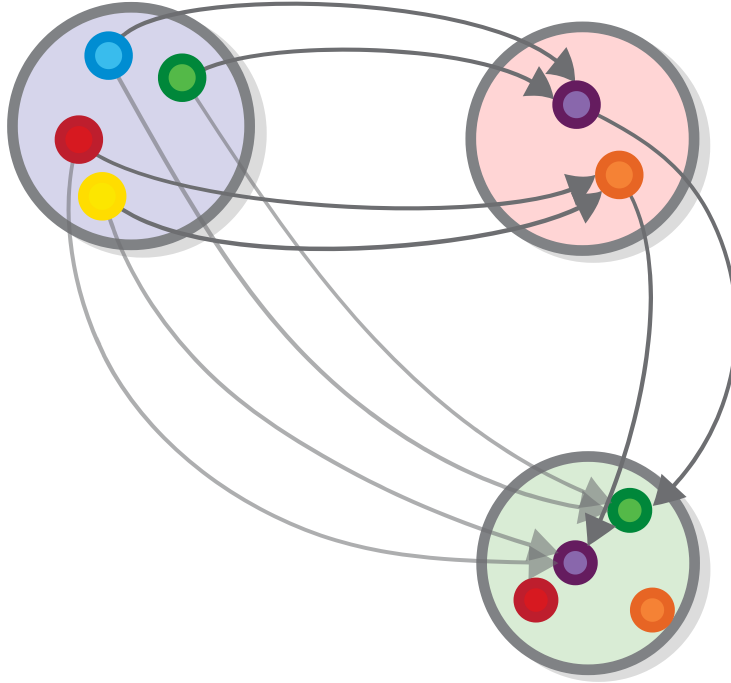
A espresso machine

Task 9: Think about what would be those functions' sources and targets.

By the way, diagrams that are “zoomed out” that show functions without showing set elements are called *external diagrams*, as opposed to the ones that we saw before, which are *internal*.

Composition and external diagrams

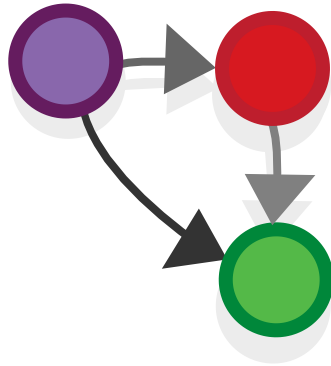
Let's look at the diagram that demonstrates functional composition in which we showed that successive application of the two composed functions $(f \circ g)$ and the new function (h) are equivalent.



Functional composition

We showed this equivalence by drawing an *internal* diagram, and explicitly drawing the elements of the functions' sources and targets in such a way that the two paths are equivalent.

Alternatively, we can just *say* that the arrow paths are all equivalent (all arrows starting from a given set element ultimately lead to the same corresponding element from the resulting set) and draw the equivalence as an external diagram.



An external diagram, showing functional composition of two functions

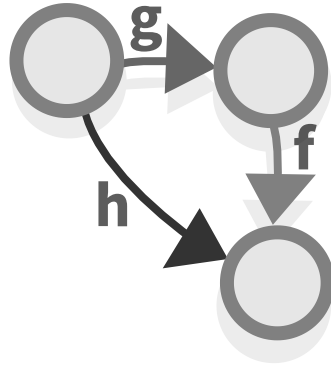
Or alternatively, if you want to express it as a formula (where $\circ$ is the composition operator).



An external diagram, showing functional composition of two functions, as a formula

The external diagram is a more appropriate representation of the concept of composition, as it is more general. In fact, it is so general that it can actually serve as a *definition of functional composition*.

The composition of two functions f and g is a third function h defined in such a way that all the paths in this diagram are equivalent.

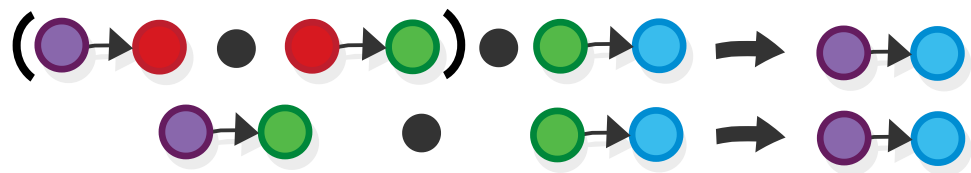


Functional composition - general definition

If you continue reading this book, you will hear more about diagrams in which all paths are equivalent (they are called *commuting diagrams*, by the way).

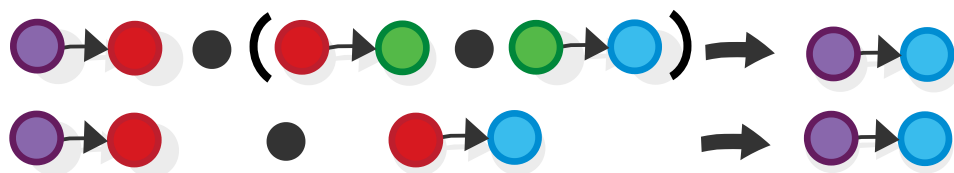
Associativity

If we want compose more than two functions we might wonder if the order in which we compose the functions matters for the final outcome i.e. whether combining two functions and then combining the result with a third function...



Composing functions (f and g) and c

...would yield the same result as composing the second and the third functions, before adding the first one.



Composing functions f and (g and c)

The answer is yes — as long as the order is maintained, the result would always be the same. This property of functions is called *associativity*.

Task 10: Draw the above diagrams as internal diagrams: define three functions that compose with one another (you can use the two functions that we defined earlier, you only would have to make a third one) compose them in the two ways shown above and check if the result is the same.

Category theory — a hint for the definition

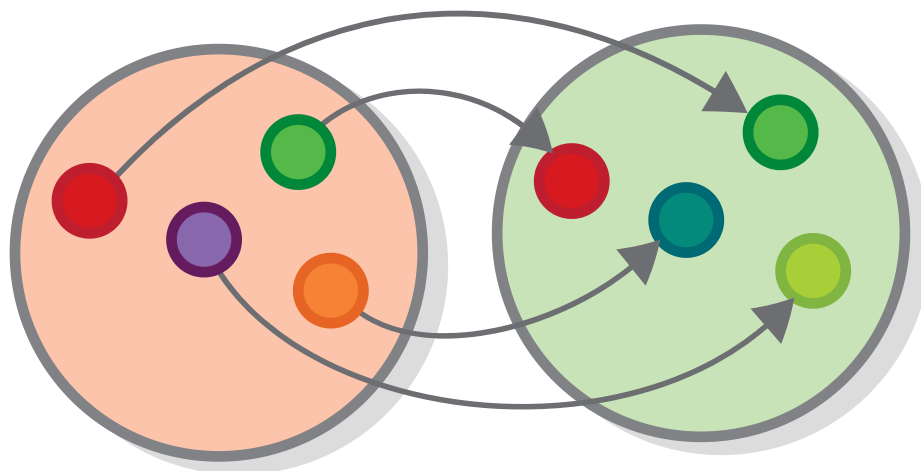
At this point you might be worried that I had forgotten that I am supposed to talk about category theory and I am just presenting a bunch of irrelevant concepts. I may indeed do that sometimes, but not right now — the fact that *functional composition* can be presented without even mentioning category theory doesn't stop it from being one of category theory's *most important concepts*.

In fact, we can say (although this is not an official definition) that category theory is the study of things that are *function-like* (we call them *morphisms*). They have a source and a target, they compose with one another (associatively) and they can be represented by external diagrams.

And there is another way of defining category theory without defining category theory: it is what you get if you replace the concept of equality with the concept of *isomorphism*. We haven't talked about isomorphisms yet, but this is what we will be doing for the rest of this chapter.

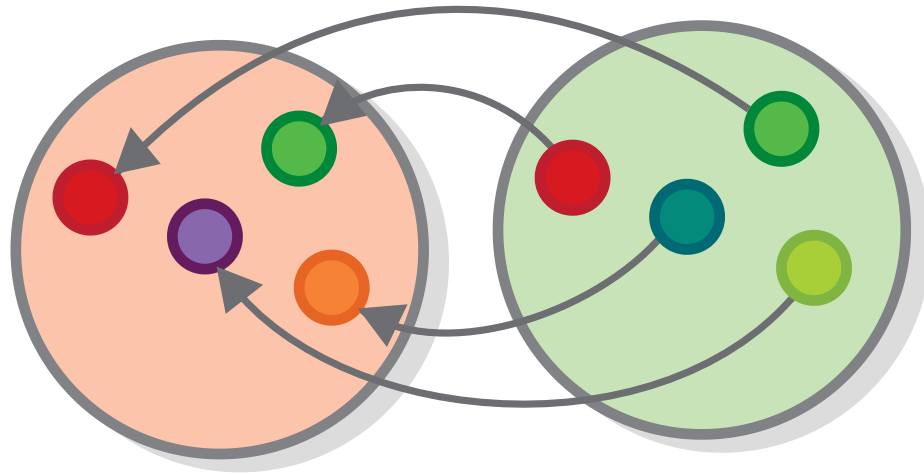
Isomorphism

To explain what isomorphism is, we go back to the examples of the types of relationships that functions can represent, and to the first and most elementary of them all — the *one-to-one* type of relationship. We know that all functions have exactly one element from the source set, pointing to one element from the target set. But for one-to-one functions *the reverse is also true* — exactly one element from the target set points to one element from the source.



Opposite colors

If we have a one-to-one-function that connects sets that are of the same size (as is the case here), then this function has the following property: all elements from the target set have exactly one arrow pointing at them. In this case, the function is *invertible*. That is, if you flip the arrows of the function and its source and target, you get another valid function.



Opposite colors

Invertible functions are called *isomorphisms*. When there exists an invertible function between two sets, we say that the sets are *isomorphic*. For example, because we have an invertible function that converts the temperature measured in *Celsius* to temperature measured in *Fahrenheit*, and vice versa, we can say that temperatures measured in Celsius and Fahrenheit are isomorphic.

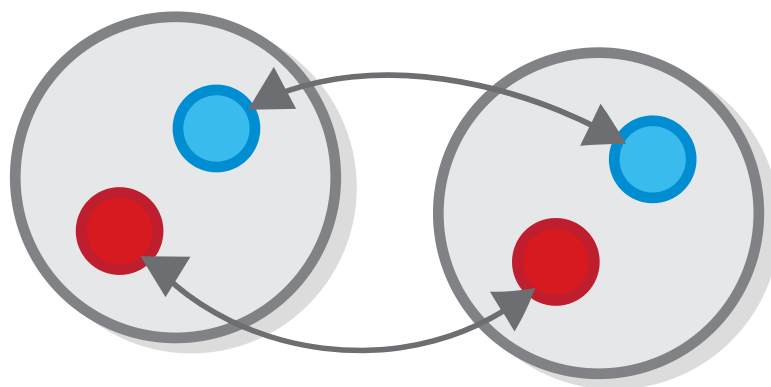
Isomorphism means “same form” in Greek (although actually their form is the only thing which is different between two isomorphic sets).

More formally, two sets A and B are isomorphic (or $A \cong B$) if there exist functions $f : A \rightarrow B$ and its reverse $g : B \rightarrow A$, such that $f \circ g = ID_B$ and $g \circ f = ID_A$.

Notice how the identity function comes in handy.

Isomorphism and identity

If you look closely you would see that the identity function is invertible too (its reverse is itself), so each set is isomorphic to itself in that way.

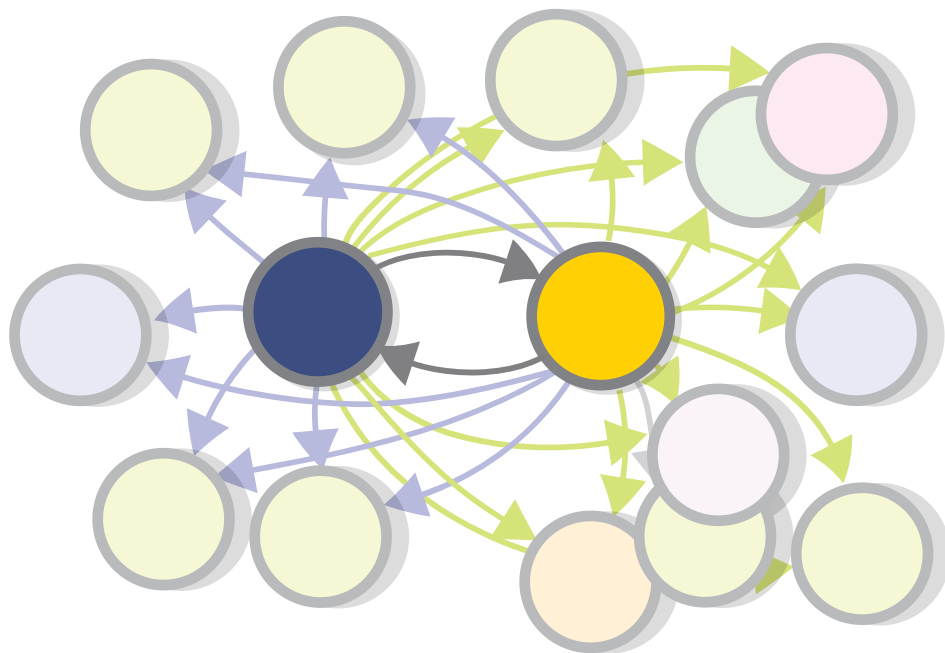


The identity function

Therefore, the concept of an isomorphism contains the concept of equality — all equal things are also isomorphic.

Isomorphism and composition

An interesting fact about isomorphisms is that if we have functions that convert a member of set A to a member of set B , and the other way around, then, because of functional composition, we know that any function from/to A has a corresponding function from/to B .



The architecture of isomorphism

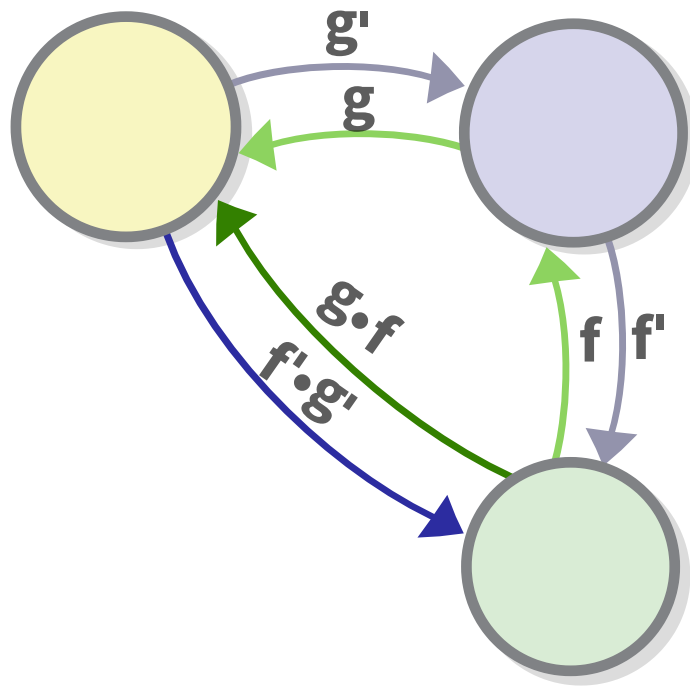
For example, if you have a function “is the partner of” that goes from the set of all married people to the same set, then that function is invertible. That is not to say that you are the same person as your significant other, but rather that every statement about you, or every relation you have to some other person or object is also a relation between them and this person/object, and vice versa.

Composing isomorphisms

Another interesting fact about isomorphisms is that if we have two isomorphisms that have a set in common, then we can obtain a third isomorphism between the other two sets that would be the result of their (the isomorphisms) composition.

Composing two isomorphisms into another isomorphism is possible by composing the two pairs of functions that make up

the isomorphism in the two directions.



Composing isomorphisms

Informally, we can see that the two morphisms are indeed reverse to each other and hence form an isomorphism. If we want to prove that fact formally, we will do something like the following:

Given that if two functions are isomorphic, then their composition is equal to an identity function, proving that functions $g \circ f$ and $f' \circ g'$, are isomorphic is equivalent to proving that their composition is equal to identity.

$$g \circ f \circ f' \circ g' = id$$

But we know already that f and f' are isomorphic and hence $f \circ f' = id$, so the above formula is equivalent to (you can reference the diagram to see what that means):

$$g \circ id \circ g' = id$$

And we know that anything composed with id is equal to itself, so it is equivalent to:

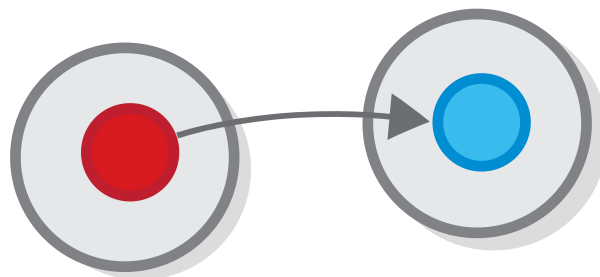
$$g \circ g' = id$$

which is true, because g and g' are isomorphic and isomorphic functions composed are equal to identity.

By the way, there is another way to obtain the isomorphism — by composing the two morphisms one way in order to get the third function and then taking its reverse. But to do this, we have to prove that the function we get from composing two bijective functions is also bijective.

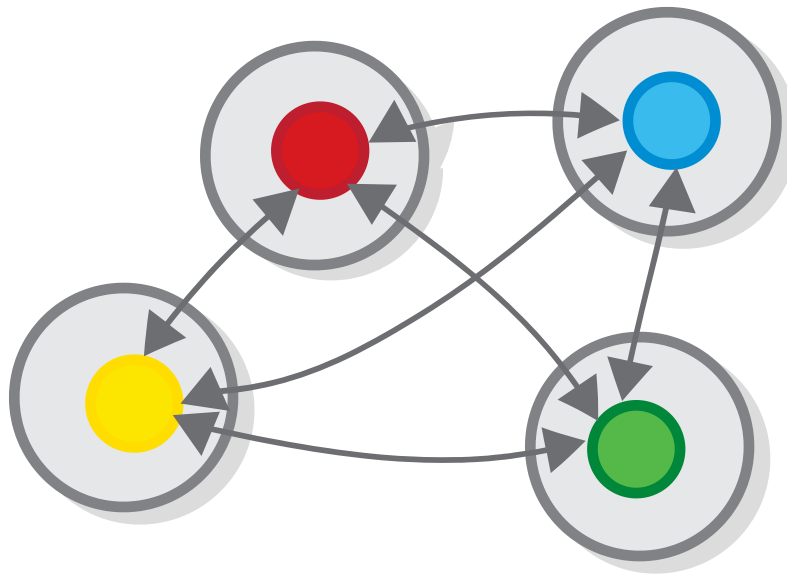
Isomorphisms Between Singleton Sets

Between any two singleton sets, we may define the only possible function.



The only possible function between singletons

The function is invertible, which means that all singleton sets are isomorphic to one another, and furthermore (which is important) they are isomorphic *in one unique way*.



Isomorphic singletons

Following the logic from the last paragraph, each statement about something that is one of a kind can be transferred to a statement about another thing that is one of a kind.

Equivalence relations and isomorphisms

We said that isomorphic sets aren't necessarily the same set (although the reverse is true). However, it is hard to get away from the notion that being isomorphic means that they are *equal* or *equivalent* in some respect. For example, all people who are connected by the *isomorphic* mother/child relationship share some of the same genes.

And in computer science, if we have functions that convert an object of type A to an object of type B and the other way around (as for example the functions between a data structure and its id), we also can pretty much regard A and B as two formats of the same thing, as having one means that we can easily obtain the other.

Equivalence relations

What does it mean for two things to be equivalent? The question sounds quite philosophical, but there is actually a formal way to answer it, i.e., there is a mathematical concept that captures the concept of equality in a rather elegant way — the concept of an *equivalence relation*.

So what is an equivalence relation? We already know what a relation is — it is a connection between two sets (an example of which is function). But when is a relation an equivalence relation? Well, according the definition, it's when it follows three

laws, which correspond to three intuitive ideas about equality. Let's review them.

Reflexivity

The first idea that defines equivalence, is that *everything is equivalent with itself*.

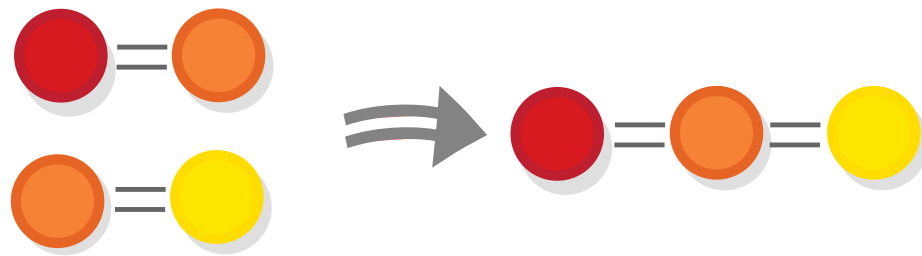


Reflexivity

This simple principle translates to the equally simple law of *reflexivity*: for all sets A , $A = A$.

Transitivity

According to the Christian theology of the Holy Trinity, the Jesus' Father is God, Jesus is God, and the Holy Spirit is also God, however, the Father is not the same person as Jesus (neither is Jesus the Holy Spirit). If this seems weird to you, that's because it breaks the second law of equivalence relations, transitivity. Transitivity is the idea that things that are both equal to a third thing must also equal between themselves.



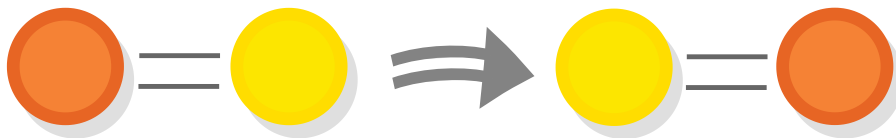
Transitivity

Mathematically, for all sets A , B and C , if $A = B$ and $B = C$ then $A = C$.

Note that we don't need to define what happens in similar situations that involve more than three sets, as they can be settled by just multiple application of this same law.

Symmetry

If one thing is equal to another, the reverse is also true, i.e, the other thing is also equal to the first one. This idea is called *symmetry*. Symmetry is probably the most characteristic property of the equivalence relation, which is not true for almost any other relation.



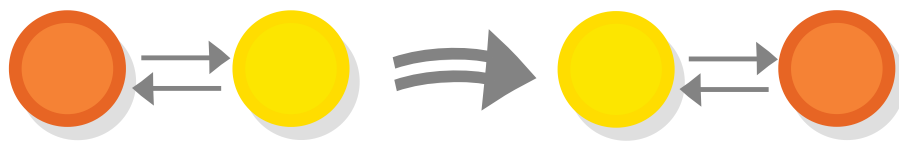
symmetry

In mathematical terms: if $A = B$ then $B = A$.

Isomorphisms as equivalence relations

Isomorphisms *are* indeed equivalence relations. And “incidentally”, we already have all the information needed to prove it (in the same way in which James Bond seems to always incidentally have exactly the gadgets that are needed to complete his mission).

We said that the most characteristic property of the equivalence relation is its *symmetry*. And this property is satisfied by isomorphisms, due to the isomorphisms’ most characteristic property, namely the fact that they are *invertible*.



Symmetry of isomorphisms

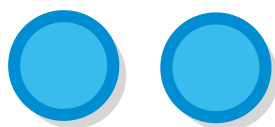
Task 11: One law down, two to go: Go through the previous section and verify that isomorphisms also satisfy the other equivalence relation laws.

The practice of using isomorphisms to define an equivalence relation is very prominent in category theory where isomorphisms are denoted with $\cong$, which is almost the same as $=$ (and is also similar to having two opposite arrows connecting one set to the other).

Interlude — numbers as isomorphisms

Many people would say that the concept of a number is the most basic concept in mathematics. But actually they are wrong — *sets and isomorphisms are more basic!* Or at least, numbers can be defined using sets and isomorphisms.

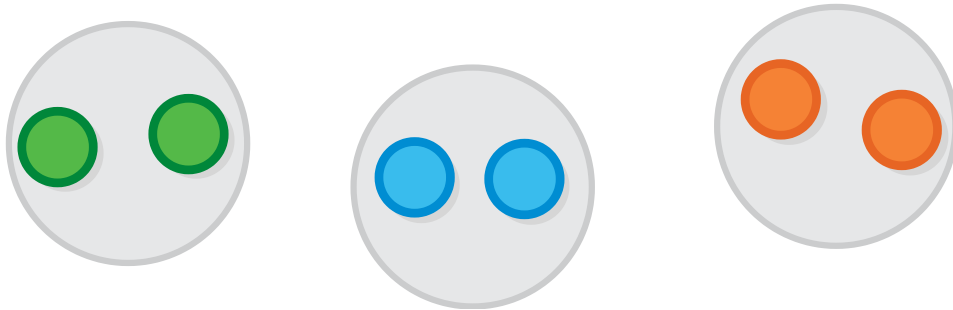
To understand how, let's think about how you teach a person what a number is (in particular, here we will concentrate on the *natural*, or counting numbers). You may start your lesson by showing them a bunch of objects that are of a given quantity, like for example if you want to demonstrate the number 2, you might bring them like two pencils, two apples or two of something else.



Two balls

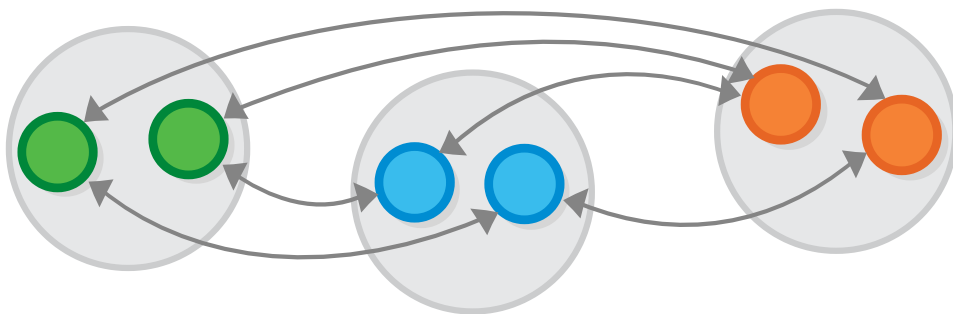
When you do that, it would be important to highlight that you are not referring to only the left object, or only about the right one, but that we should consider both things at once, i.e., both things as one, so if the person to whom you are explaining happens to know what a set is, this piece of knowledge might

come in handy. Also, being good teachers, we might provide them with some more examples of sets of 2 things.



A set of two balls

This is a good starting point, but the person may still be staring at the objects instead of the structure — they might ask if this or that set is 2 as well. At this point, if the person whom you are explaining happens to know about isomorphisms (let's say they lived in a cave with nothing but this book with them), you can easily formulate your final definition, saying that the number 2 is represented by those sets and all other sets that are isomorphic to them, or by the *equivalence class* of sets that have two elements, as the formal definition goes (don't worry, we will learn all about equivalence classes later).



A set of two balls

At this point there are no more examples that we can add. In fact, because we consider all other sets as well, we might say

that this is not just a bunch of examples, but a proper *definition* of the number 2. And we can extend that to include all other numbers. In fact, the first definition of a natural number (presented by Gottlob Frege in 1884) is roughly based on this very idea.

Before we close this chapter, there is one meta-note that we should definitely make: according to the definition of a number that we presented, a number is not an *object*, but a whole *system of interconnected objects*, containing in this case an infinite number of objects. This may seem weird to you, but it's actually pretty characteristic of the categorical way of modeling things.

Addendum: The case of composition in software development

An unstructured monolithic design is not a good idea, except maybe for a tiny operating system in, say, a toaster, but even there it is arguable.— Andrew S. Tanenbaum

Software development is a peculiar discipline — in theory, it should be just some sort of *engineering*, however the way it is executed in practice is sometimes closer to *craftsmanship*, with the principle of composition not being utilized to the fullest.

To see why, imagine a person (e.g. me), tinkering with some sort of engineering problem e.g. trying to fix a machine or modify it to serve a new purpose. If the machine in question is mechanical or electrical, this person will be forced to pretty much make due with the components that already exist, simply because they can rarely afford to manufacture new components themselves (or at least they would avoid it if possible). This limitation, forces component manufacturers to create components that are versatile and that work well together, in the same way in which pure functions work well together. And this in turn makes it easy for engineers to create better machines without doing all the work themselves.

But things are different if the machine in question is software-based — due to the ease with which new software components can be rolled out, our design can blur the line that separates

some of the components or even do away with the concept of component altogether and make the whole program one giant component (*monolithic design*). Worse, when no ready-made components are available, this approach is actually easier than the component-based approach that we described in the previous paragraph, and so many people use it.

This is bad, as the benefits of monolithic design are mostly short-term — not being separated to components makes programs harder to reason about, harder to modify (e.g. you cannot replace a faulty component with a new one) and generally more primitive than component-based programs. For these reasons, I think that programmers are losing out if they are not utilizing the principles of functional composition. In fact, I was so unhappy with the situation that I decided to write a whole book on applied category theory to help people understand the principles of composition better, it's called *Category Theory Illustrated* (Oh wait, I am writing that right now, aren't I?)

Anyway, the composition approach is sometimes used in programming, and when it is used, it tends to work rather well. To see some examples, you don't need to look further than the pipe operator in Unix (`|`), which feeds the standard output of a program into the standard input of another program.

If you *want* to look further, look at the Haskell programming language, or some of the numerous libraries for functional programming for other languages. There is also a whole programming paradigm based on functional composition, called "concatenative programming" utilized in languages like Forth and Factor.

Answers

Task 1: What is the target of the function “Who is my father?”

It is the set of all people who are fathers. Or the set of all people, period (a function can always be upgraded by expanding its target set).

Task 2: Do all functions that we drew at the beginning *express* something? Do you think that a function should express something in order to be valid?

No, a function does not *need* to express a meaningful relationship to be valid, but still, the functions that *interest* us do express something.

We will talk a lot about this in the following chapters.

Task 3: Is the function from the empty set to any other set really valid? Why? Check the definition.

Yes, it is valid. Zero is a natural number! This is called *vacuous truth*, when the condition is satisfied simply because there are no cases to check.

Task 4: What about the other way around? Are there functions with the empty set as a target as opposed to its source?

No, there are not. With one exception. Read on to find out.

Task 5: Is the function from any set to a singleton set really the only way to connect them in a valid way?

Yes. As the singleton set contains exactly one element, so there is only one way to define a function with it as target.

Task 6: Again, what about the other way around?

For any set A , there is one function from a singleton set to A (i.e. $\emptyset \rightarrow A$, for each element of A . We will encounter these functions in the following chapter.

Task 7: What is the type equivalent of subsets in programming?

The type equivalent is a *subtype*. e.g a type Square is a subtype of Rectangle, meaning every Square *is a* Rectangle (and all functions that expect an argument of type Rectangle accept Square (but not the other way around)).

Task 8: Think about which qualities of a function make composition possible. Does it work with other types of relationships, like many-to-many and one-to-many?

Many-to-one relationships (functions) guarantee that there is exactly *one* output for each input, i.e. when you connect the output of g to the input of f , there is no ambiguity about what to pass.

With one-to-many or many-to-many relationships, the output can consist of *many* values.

Task 9: Think about what would be those functions' sources and targets. (Referring to espresso machine components)

Grinder : WholeCoffeeBeans $\rightarrow$ GroundCoffee Heater : Water $\rightarrow$ HotWater

etc

Task 10: Draw the above diagrams as internal diagrams: define three functions that compose with one another (you can use the two functions that we defined earlier, you only would have to make a third one) compose them in the two ways shown above and check if the result is the same.

You are on your own here, sorry :)

Task 11: One law down, two to go: Verify that isomorphisms also satisfy the other equivalence relation laws [Reflexivity and Transitivity].

First, reflexivity — for any set A , the identity function $id_A : A \rightarrow A$ is an isomorphism — its inverse is itself. So, every set is isomorphic to itself ($A \cong A$).

Transitivity: we want to prove that if we have isomorphisms $A \cong B$ and $B \cong C$, we have $A \cong C$.

Isomorphisms $A \cong B$ consists of functions $A \rightarrow B$ and $B \rightarrow A$.

Similarly, $B \cong C$ consists of functions $B \rightarrow C$ and $C \rightarrow B$.

Composing these functions appropriately, we get two functions $A \rightarrow C$ and $C \rightarrow A$, which are invertible, because their components are invertible.

From Sets to Categories

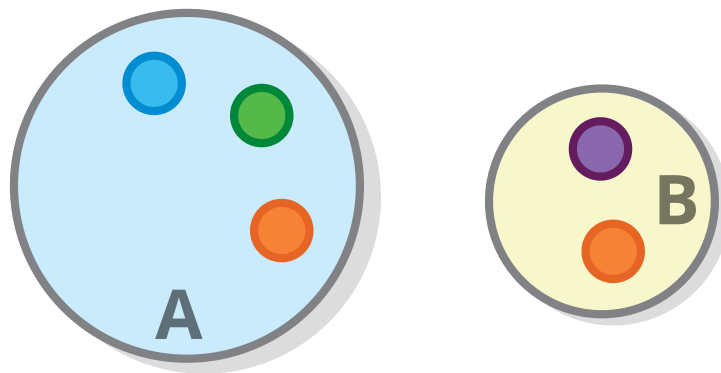
In this chapter, we will see some more set-theoretic constructs, but we will also introduce their category-theoretic counterparts in an effort to gently introduce the concept of a category itself.

When we are finished with that, we will try (and almost succeed) to define categories from scratch, without actually relying on set theory.

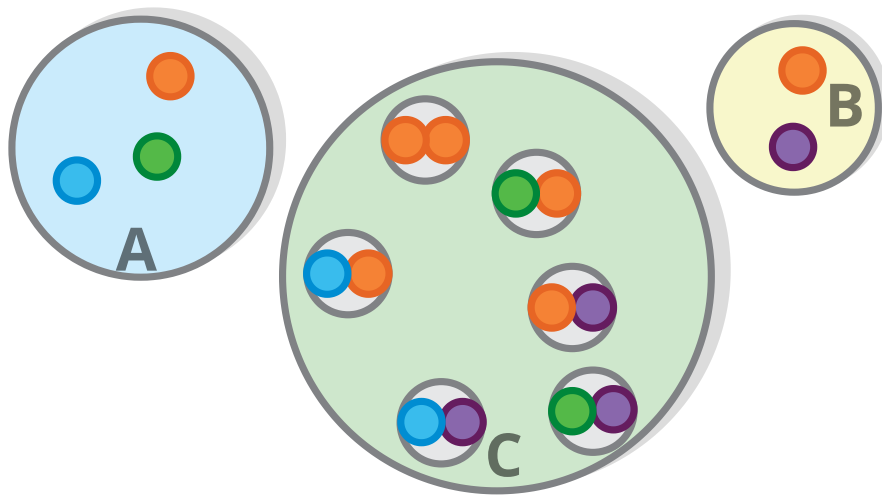
Products

In the previous chapter, we needed a way to construct a set whose elements are *composite* of the elements of some other sets e.g. when we discussed mathematical functions, we couldn't define $+$ and $-$ because we could only formulate functions that take one argument. Similarly, when we introduced the primitive types in programming languages, like `Char` and `Number`, we mentioned that most of the types that we actually use are *composite* types. So how do we construct those?

So, consider the set A (containing a 's) and the set B (containing B 's)



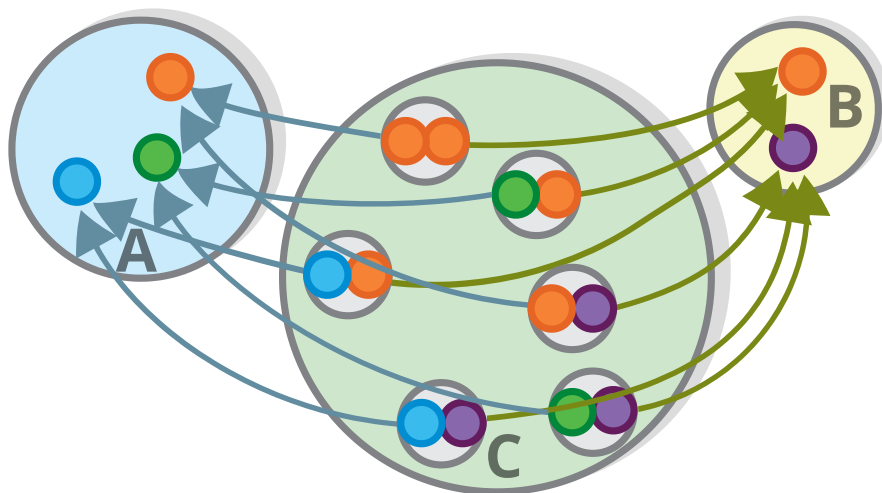
The *Cartesian product* (or *tuple*) of sets A and B (denoted $A \times B$) is the set of *ordered pairs* that contain one element of the set A and one element of the set B . Or formally speaking: $A \times B = \{(a,b)\}$ where $a \in A, b \in B$ ($\in$ means "is an element of").



Product

Task 1: Why is this called a product? Hint: How many elements does it have?

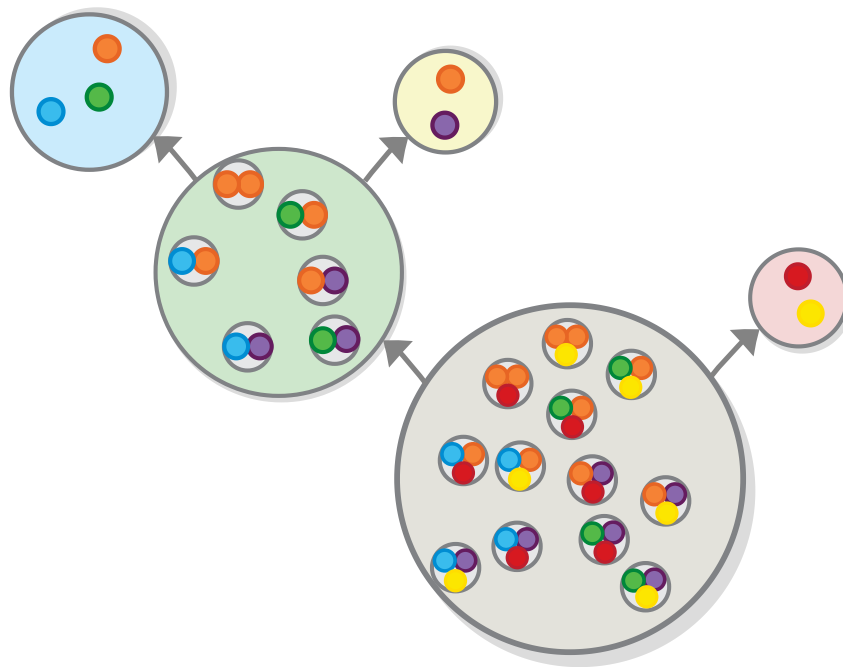
Naturally, the product comes equipped with two functions, one for each property, which take a pair and extracts the value of the property, so $C \rightarrow A$ and $C \rightarrow B$, called the product's *projections* (in programming terms, we would dub these the “getters”) — the functions for retrieving back it's constituent values).



Product

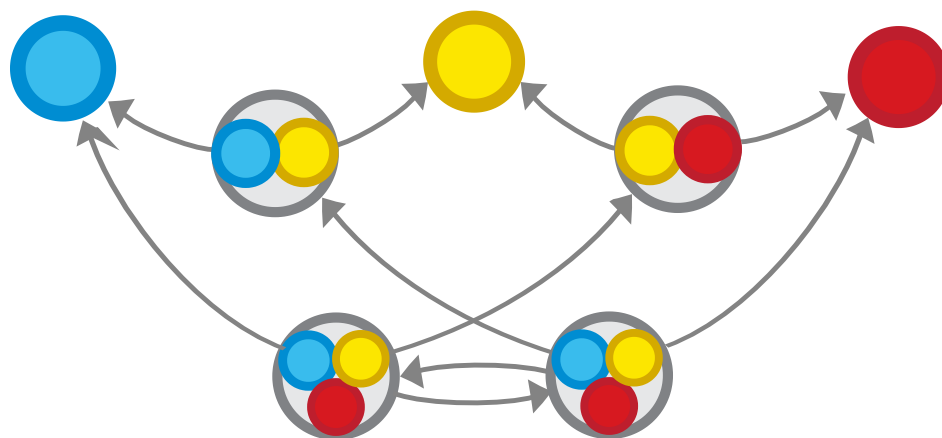
Triple product

There are occasions where we want to combine not two, but three sets into a product (e.g. $A \times B \times C$). We can achieve that by combining the first and second one into a product and then combining their product with the third set, (so it will be $(A \times B) \times C$).



Triple product

There is another way to make a triple product of three sets — combining the second and the third one and then combining the result with the first one (so $A \times (B \times C)$, but it doesn't actually matter which one you use, as the end results would be isomorphic $(A \times B) \times C \cong A \times (B \times C)$).



Triple product

You might recognize this isomorphism, from the definition of functional composition. It means that the cartesian product operation is (like functional composition), *associative*.

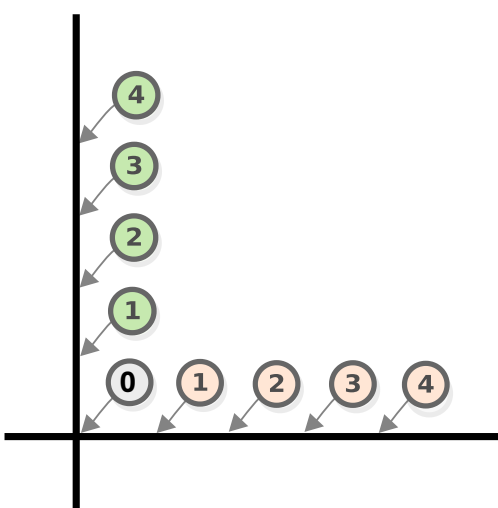
Interlude — coordinate systems

The concept of *Cartesian product* was first defined by the mathematician and philosopher René Descartes, as a basis for the *Cartesian coordinate system*, which is why both concepts are named after him (although it does not look like it, as they use the Latinized version of his name).

Most people know how a Cartesian coordinate system works, but an equally interesting question, which few people think about, is how we can define it using sets and functions.

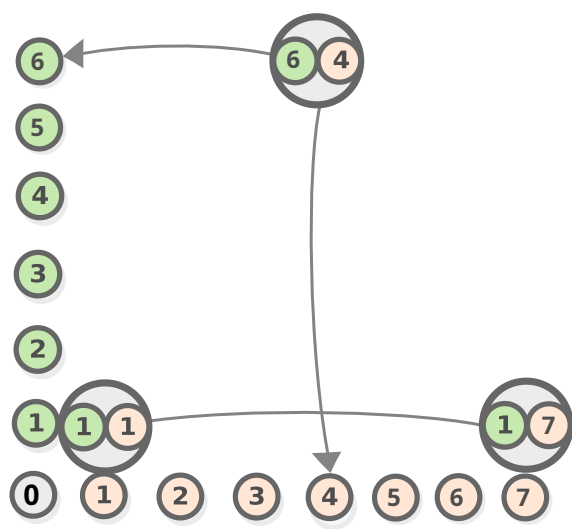
A Cartesian coordinate system consists of two perpendicular lines, situated on a *Euclidean plane* and some kind of mapping that resembles a function, connecting any point in these two lines to a number, representing the distance between the point

that is being mapped and the lines' point of overlap (which is mapped to the number 0).



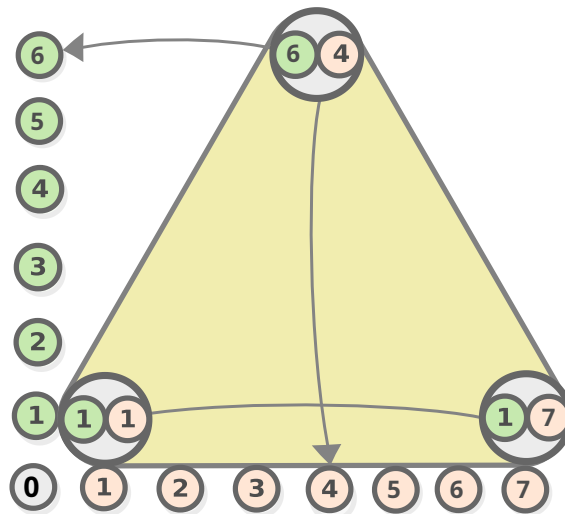
Cartesian coordinates

Using this construct (as well as the concept of a Cartesian product), we can describe not only the points on the lines but any point on the Euclidean plane. We do that by measuring the distance between the point and those two lines.



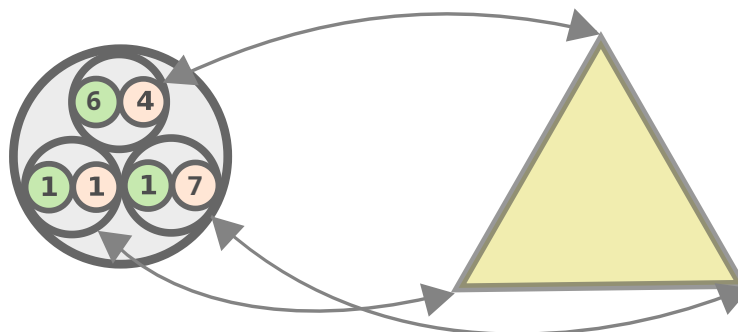
Cartesian coordinates

And, since the point is the main primitive of Euclidean geometry, the coordinate system allows us to also describe all kinds of geometric figures such as this triangle (which is described using products of products).



Cartesian coordinates

So we can say that the Cartesian coordinate system is some kind of function-like mapping between sets of *products of numbers* and *geometric figures* that correspond to these numbers, using which we can derive some properties of the figures using the numbers (for example, using the products in the example below, we can compute that the triangle that they represent has a base of 6 units and height of 5 units).



Cartesian coordinates

What's even more interesting is that this mapping is one-to-one, which makes the two realms *isomorphic* (traditionally we say that the point is *completely* described by the coordinates, which is the same thing).

With that, our effort to represent Cartesian coordinates with sets is complete, except we haven't described the mapping that connects points and numbers. The mapping resembles a function and exhibits all relevant properties of a function (many-to-one mapping (or one-to-one in this case)), however, as we said, functions are mappings between *sets* and in this case, even if we can think of the coordinate system as a set (of points and figures), geometrical figures are definitely not a set, as they have a lot of additional things going on (or additional *structure*, as a category theorist would say). So, defining this mapping formally would require us to also formalize both geometry and algebra, and moreover to do so in a way in which they would be compatible with one another. These are some of the ambitions of category theory and this is what we will attempt to do later in this book.

But before we continue with that, let's see some other neat uses of products.

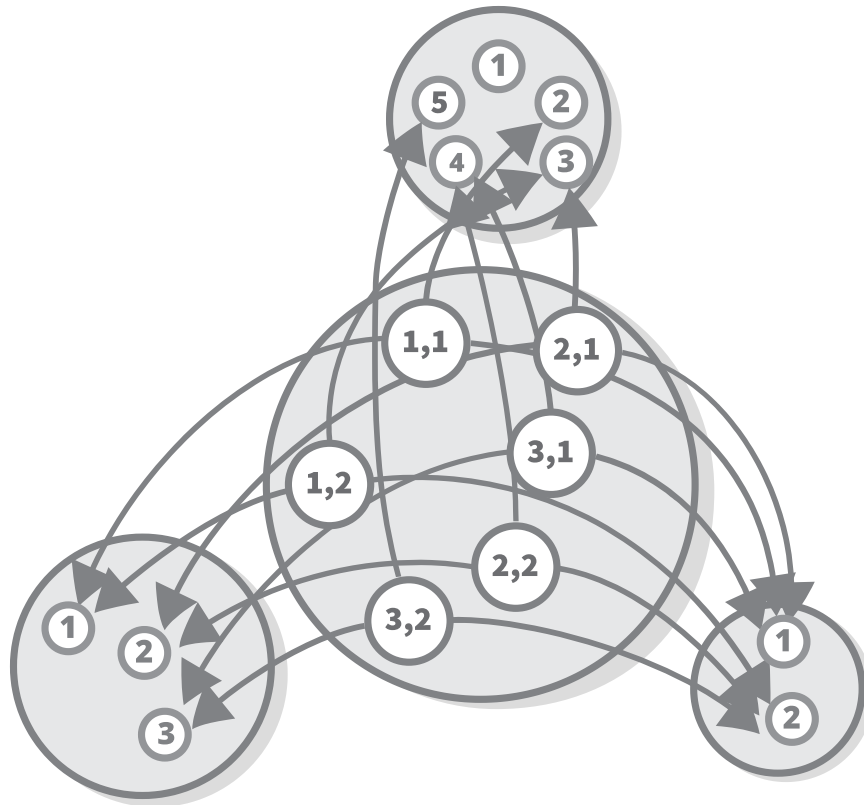
Products as Objects

In the previous chapter, we established the correspondence of various concepts in programming languages and set theory — sets resemble types, and functions resemble methods/subroutines. This picture is made complete with

products, that are like stripped-down *classes* (also called *records* or *structs*) — the sets that form the product correspond to the class's *properties* (also called *members*) and the functions for accessing them are like what programmers call *getter methods* e.g. the famous example of object-oriented programming of a Person class with name and age fields is nothing more than a product of the set of strings, and the sets of numbers. And objects with more than two values can be expressed as compositions of nested products (e.g. a record with 3 members a , b and c could be expressed as nested tuples $(a, (b, c))$, or more formally $a \times b \times c$.

Using Products to Define Numeric Operations

Products can also be used for expressing functions that take more than one argument (and this is indeed how multi-param functions are implemented in languages that actually have tuples, like the ones from the ML family). For example, “plus” is a function from the set of products of two numbers to the set of numbers, so, $+ : \mathbb{Z} \times \mathbb{Z} \rightarrow \mathbb{Z}$.

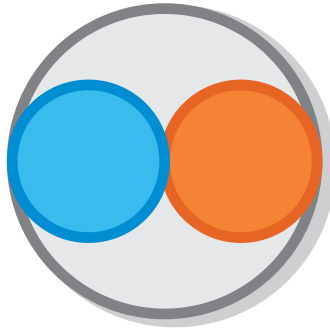


The plus function

By the way, such functions (ones that take two objects of one type and return a third object of the same type) are called *operations*.

Defining products in terms of sets

A product is, as we said, a set of *ordered* pairs (formally speaking $A \times B \neq B \times A$). So, to define a product we must define the concept of an ordered pair. So how can we do that?



A pair

Note that an ordered pair of elements is not just a set containing the two elements (that would be an _ unordered pair_) but it also contains information about which of those objects comes first and which one goes second in the pair. In programming, we have the ability to assign names to each member of an object, which accomplishes the same purpose.

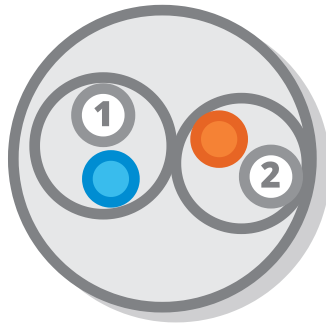
The order of elements in the pair is important. While some mathematical operations (such as addition) don't care about order, others (such as subtraction) do. In programming, when we manipulate an object we obviously want to access a specific property of the object, not just any random property.

So does that mean that we have to define ordered pairs as a "primitive" type like we defined sets if we want to use them? That's possible, but there is another approach if we can define a construct that is *isomorphic* to the ordered pair, using only sets, we can use that construct instead of them. And mathematicians have come up with multiple ingenious ways to do that. Here is the first one, which was suggested by Norbert Wiener in 1914. Note the smart use of the fact that the empty set is unique.



A pair, represented by sets

The next one was suggested by Felix Hausdorff in the same year. In order to use that one, we just have to define 1, and 2 first.



A pair, represented by sets

Suggested in 1921 by Kazimierz Kuratowski, this one uses just the component of the pair.



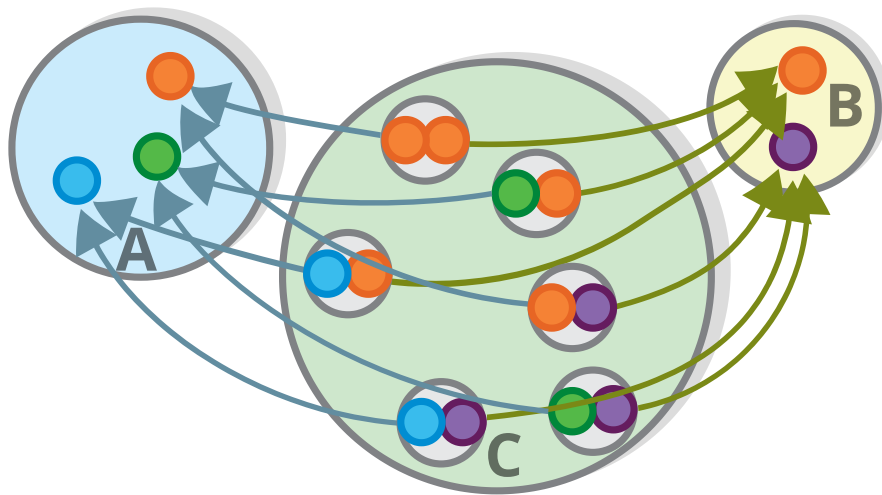
A pair, represented by sets

Defining products in terms of functions

The product definitions presented in the previous section worked by *zooming in* into the individual elements of the product and seeing what they are made of. We may think of this as a *low-level* approach to the definition. This time (and throughout the most of this book) we will do the opposite — we will try to be as oblivious to the contents of our sets as possible i.e. instead of zooming in we will *zoom out* and attempt to fly over the difficulties that we met in the previous section by providing a definition of a product in terms of functions and *external* diagrams.

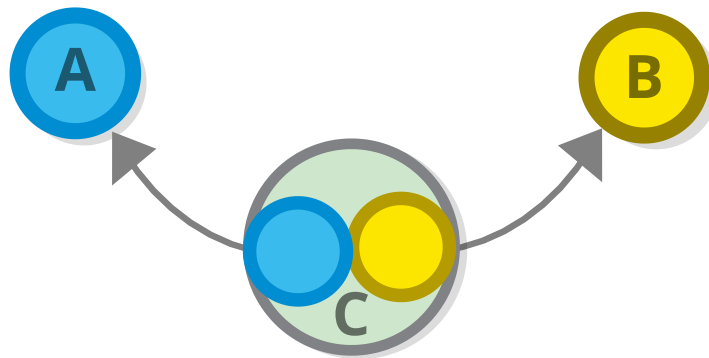
To define products in terms of external diagrams, we must, given two sets, devise a way to pinpoint the set that is their product, by looking at the functions that come from/to them.

And what are the functions are guaranteed to exist for all products. Of course that would be the projections, the functions for retrieving back the two elements of the product $C \rightarrow A$ and $A \times B \rightarrow B$. What would a product be without them?



Product

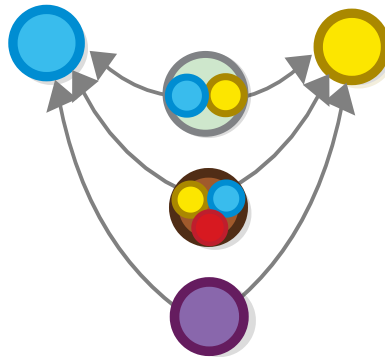
Now if we switch to the (semi) external view, this diagram already provides some definition of what a product is: if we have an object C for which there are functions $C \rightarrow A$ and $A \times B \rightarrow B$, then C can potentially be the product of A and B ($A \times B$).



Product, external diagram

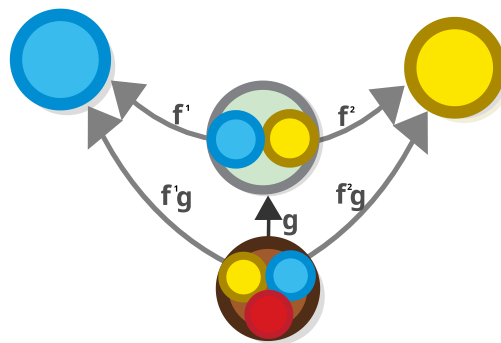
However, this definition is not complete, as the product A and B , is not the *only* set for which such functions can be defined. For example, a set of triples (which is like a product, but has three elements) $A \times B \times X$ for any element X also qualifies. Any other set

that would happen to have some functions to A and B , and would, by this definition, be “impostor products”.



Product, external diagram

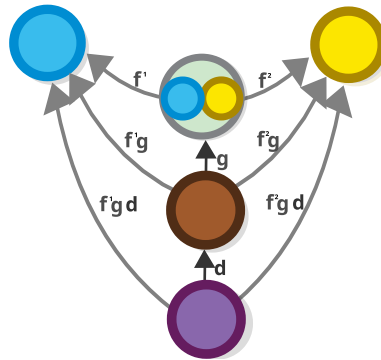
Upon further inspection we discover that there are ways to expose those impostors. Take the set of triples, $A \times B \times X$ as an example. Looking at the canonical function that converts a triple to a product $A \times B \times X \rightarrow A \times B$, we realize that $A \times B \times X$ is *only connected to A and B because of this function*. That is, if we dub it $g : A \times B \times X \rightarrow A \times B$ and let f^1 and f^2 be the arrows for retrieving elements of a product ($f^1 : A \times B \rightarrow A$ and $f^2 : A \times B \rightarrow B$), then, the arrow that connects the triple $A \times B \times X$ to A and B are just the compositions f^1g and f^2g .



Product, external diagram

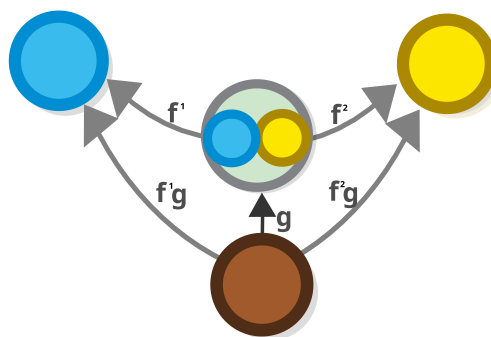
We claim that the same reasoning applies to all other objects that can take the place of our product — they all are connected

to the product, and their getters are just the result of this connection. Why? Intuitively, all such objects would be *more complex* than the product and you can always have a function that converts a more complex structure to a simpler one by just throwing information away (in the same way in which we threw the third element of the triple).



Product, external diagram

More formally, if we suppose that there is a set I that can serve as an impostor of the product of sets A and B (i.e. that I is such that there exists two functions $I \rightarrow A$ and $I \rightarrow B$, then there must also exist a unique function with the type signature $g : I \rightarrow A \times B$, that converts the impostor product to the real product, such that the above two functions would be just the composition of g with the usual “getter” functions of the product ($f^1 : A \times B \rightarrow A$ and $f^2 : A \times B \rightarrow B$). In other words, whichever object we pick for I , this diagram would commute (oh no, not this diagram again).



Product, universal property

You would see a lot of similar diagrams in this book. In category theory, we often (always) define properties that a given object might possess, by defining a structure such that all similar objects can be converted to it. This is what we call a *universal property*, but it is too early to go into more detail, (after all we haven't even yet said what category theory is).

Isomorphism and equality

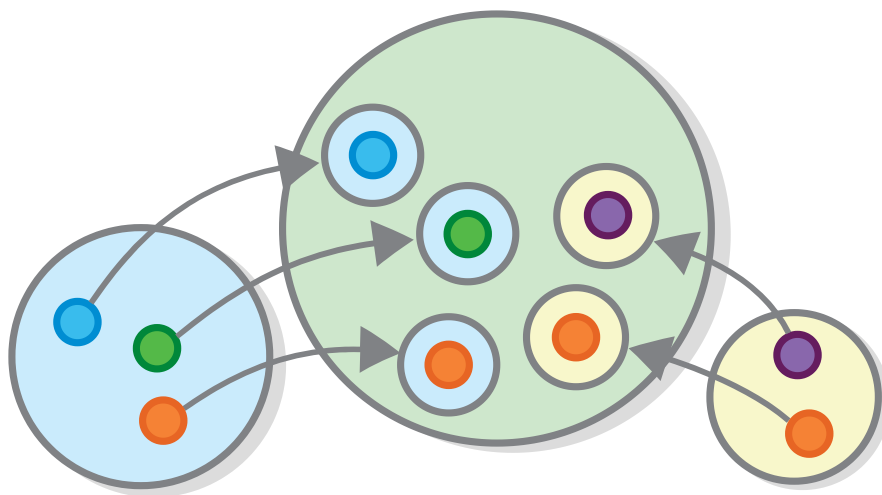
One thing that we should point out, is that this definition (as all the previous ones, by the way) does not rule out the sets which are *isomorphic* to the product. When we represent things using universal properties, an isomorphism is treated as equality.

This is the same viewpoint that we adopt in programming, especially when we work on the higher level — there might be many different implementations of pair, but as long as they work in the same way (i.e. we can convert one to the other and vice versa) they are all the same to us.

Sums

We will now study a construct that is pretty similar to the product but at the same time is very different. Similar because, like the product, it is a relation between two sets which allows you to unite them into one, without erasing their structure. But different as it encodes a very different type of relation — a product encodes an *and* relation between two sets, while the sum encodes an *or* relation.

The sum of two sets B and Y , denoted $B + Y$ is a set that contains *all elements from the first set combined with all elements from the second one*.



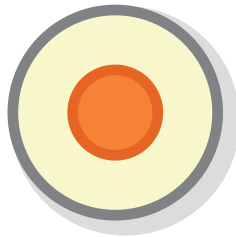
Sum or coproduct

We can immediately see the connection with the *or* logical structure: For example, because a parent is either a mother or a father of a child, the set of all parents is the sum of the set of mothers and the set of fathers, or $P = M + F$.

Defining Sums in Terms of Sets

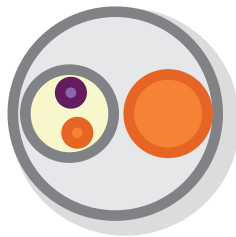
As with the product, representing sums in terms of sets is not so straightforward e.g. when a given object is an element of both sets, then it appears in the sum twice which is not permitted, because a set cannot contain the same element twice.

As with the product, the solution is to put some extra structure.



A member of a coproduct

And, as with the product, there is a low-level way to express a sum using sets alone. Incidentally, we can use pairs.



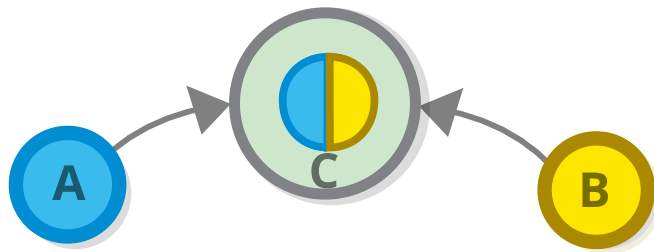
A member of a coproduct, examined

Defining sums in terms of functions

As you might already suspect, the interesting part is expressing the sum of two sets using functions. To do that, we have to go

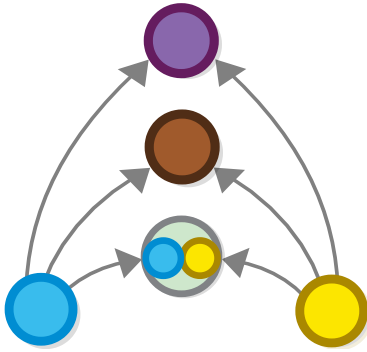
back to the conceptual part of the definition. We said that sums express an *or* relation between two things.

A property of every *or* relation is that if something is an A that something is also an $A \vee B$ (The $\vee$ symbol means *or* by the way). For example, if my hair is *brown*, then my hair is also *either blond or brown*. This is what *or* means, right? This property can be expressed as a function, two functions actually — one for each set that takes part in the sum relation (for example, if parents are either mothers or fathers, then there surely exist functions $mothers \rightarrow parents$ and $fathers \rightarrow parents$).



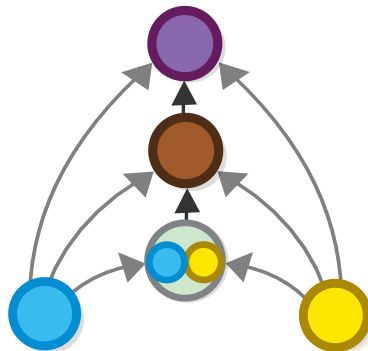
Coproduct, external diagram

As you might have already noticed, this definition is pretty similar to the definition of the product from the previous section — the difference being reversed arrows. And the similarities don't end here. As with products, we have sets that can be thought of as *impostor* sums — ones for which these functions exist, but which also contain additional information.



Coproduct, external diagram

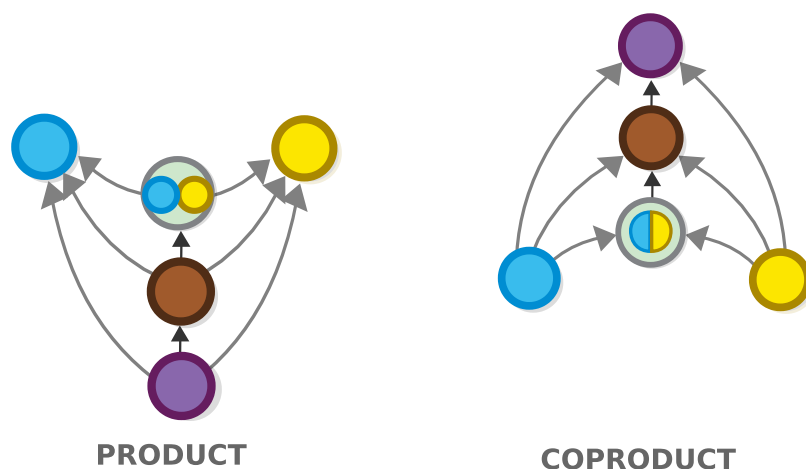
All these sets express relationships which are more vague than the simple sum, and therefore given such a set, there would exist a unique function that would distinguish it from the true sum. The only difference is that, unlike the functions that define products, this time this function goes *from the sum* to the impostor.



Coproduct, external diagram

Interlude: Categorical Duality

The concepts of product and sum might already look similar in a way when we view them through their internal diagrams. The *external* view makes this similarity precise — these two diagrams are one and the same diagram, only their arrows are flipped — many-to-one relationships become one-to-many and the other way around.



Coproduct and product

The universal properties that define the two constructs are the same as well — if we have a sum $A + B$, for each impostor sum, such as $A + B + X$, there exists a trivial function $A + B \rightarrow A + B + R$.

And, if you remember, with products the arrows go the other way around — the equivalent example for a product would be the function $A \times B \rightarrow A \times B \times R$

This fact uncovers a deep connection between the concepts of the *product* and *sum*, which is not otherwise apparent — they are

each other's opposites. *Product* is the opposite of *sum* and *sum* is the opposite of *product*.

In category theory, concepts that have such a relationship are said to be *dual* to each other. So, the concepts of *product* and *sum* are dual. This is why sums are known in a category-theoretic setting as *converse product*, or *coproduct* for short. This naming convention is used for all dual constructs in category theory.

De Morgan duality

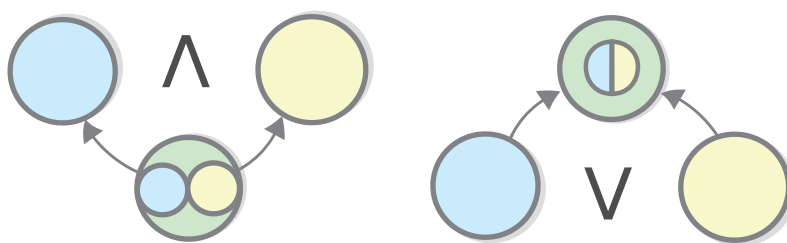
Now let's look at how the concepts of product and sum from the viewpoint of *logic*. We mentioned that:

- The *product* of two sets contains an element of the first one *and* one element of the second one.
- A *sum* of two sets contains an element of the first one *or* one element of the second one.

When we view those sets as propositions, we discover the concept of the *product* ($\times$) corresponds exactly to the *and* relation in logic (denoted $\wedge$). From this viewpoint, the function $Y \times B \rightarrow Y$ can be viewed as an instance of a logical rule of inference called *conjunction elimination* (also called *simplification*) stating that, $Y \wedge B \rightarrow Y$, for example, if your hair is partly blond and partly brown, then it is partly blond.

By the same token, the concept of a *sum* ($+$) corresponds to the *or* relation in logic (denoted $\vee$). From this viewpoint, the function $Y \rightarrow Y + B$ can be viewed as an instance of a logical rule of inference called *disjunction introduction*, stating that, $Y \rightarrow Y \vee B$ for example, if your hair is blond, it is either blond or brown.

This means, among other things, that the concepts of *and* and *or* are also dual — an idea which was put forward in the 19th century by the mathematician Augustus De Morgan and is henceforth known as *De Morgan duality*, and which is a predecessor to the modern idea of duality in category theory, that we examined before.



Coproduct and product

The duality of $\wedge$ and $\vee$ can be seen in the two formulas that are most often associated with De Morgan which are known as De Morgan laws (although De Morgan didn't actually discover those (they were previously formulated, by William of Ockham (of "Ockham's razor" fame, among other people))).

$$\neg(A \wedge B) = \neg A \vee \neg B$$

$$\neg(A \vee B) = \neg A \wedge \neg B$$

You can read the second formula as, for example, if my hair is not blond *or* brown, this means that my hair is not blond *and* my hair is not brown, and vice versa (the connection works both ways)

Now we will go through the formulas and we will try to show that they are actually a simple corollary of the duality between *and* and *or*

Let's say we want to find the statement that is opposite of "blond *or* brown".

$$A \vee B$$

The first thing we want to do is, to replace the statements that constitute it with their opposites, which would make the statement "not blond *or* not brown"

$$\neg A \vee \neg B$$

However, this statement is clearly not the opposite of "blond *or* brown"(saying that my hair is not blond *or* not brown does in fact allow it to be blond and also allows for it to be brown, it just doesn't allow it to be both of these things).

So what have we missed? Simple: we replaced the propositions with their opposites, but we didn't replace the *operator* that connects them — it is still *or* for both propositions. So we must replace it with *or* converse. As we said earlier, and as you can see by analyzing this example, this operator is *and* So the formula becomes "not blond *and* not brown".

$$\neg A \wedge \neg B$$

Saying that this formula is the opposite of "blond and brown" — is the same thing as saying that it is equivalent to its negation, which is precisely what the second De Morgan law says.

$$\neg(A \vee B) = \neg A \wedge \neg B$$

And if we "flip" this whole formula (we can do that without changing the signs of the individual propositions, as it is valid for all propositions) we get the first law.

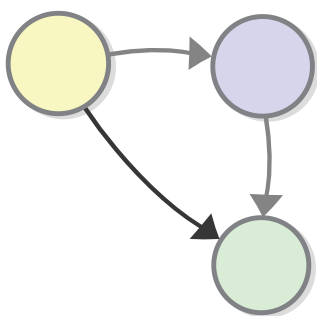
$$\neg(A \wedge B) = \neg A \vee \neg B$$

This probably provokes a lot of questions and we have a whole chapter about logic to address those. But before we get to it, we have to see what categories (and sets) are.

Defining the rest of set theory using functions

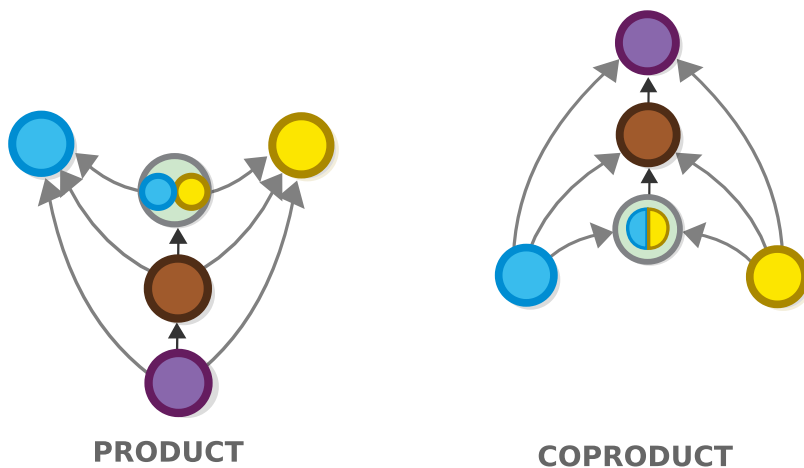
So far in the book, we saw some amazing ways of defining set-theoretic constructs without looking at the set elements and by only using functions and external diagrams.

In the first chapter, we defined functions and functional composition with this diagram.



Functional composition

And now, we also defined products and sums.



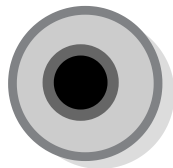
Coproduct and product

What's even more amazing, is that we can define *all of set-theory*, based just on the concept of functions, as discovered by the category theory pioneer Francis William Lawvere.

Defining set elements using functions

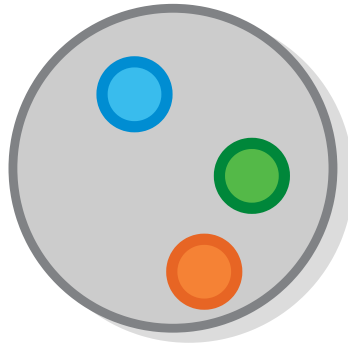
Traditionally, everything in set theory is defined in terms of two things: *sets* and *elements*, so, if we want to define it using *sets* and *functions*, we must define the concept of a *set element* in terms of functions.

To do so, we will use the singleton set.



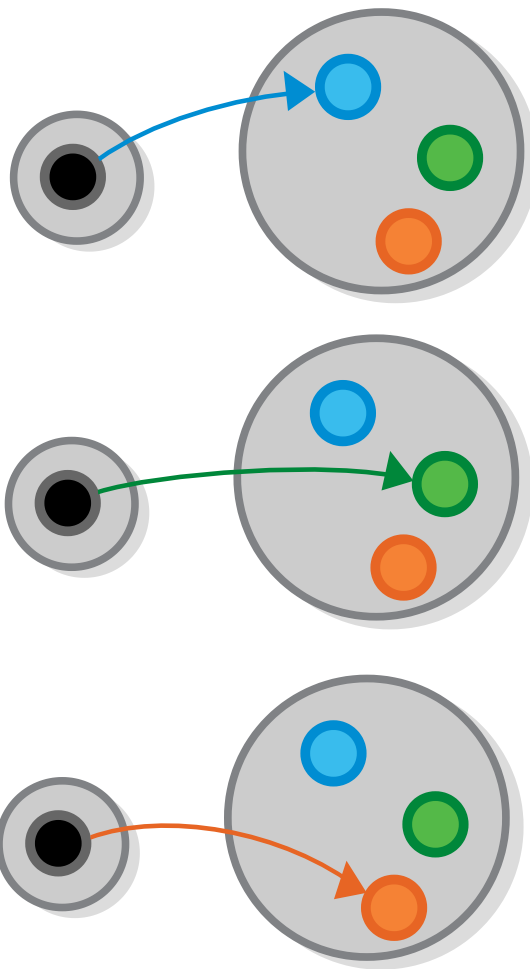
The singleton set

OK, let's start by taking a random set which we want to describe.



A set of three elements

And let's examine the functions from the singleton set, to that random set.



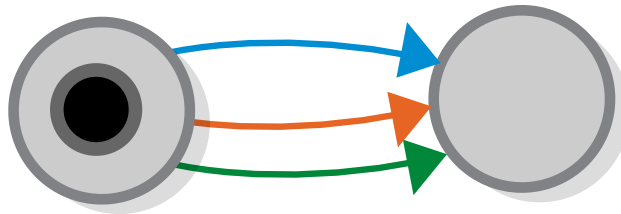
Functions from the singleton set

It's easy to see that there would be exactly one function for each element of the set i.e. that each element of any set X is isomorphic to a function $1 \rightarrow X$ (where 1 means the singleton set).

So, we can say that what we call “elements” of a set are the functions from the singleton set to it.

Defining the singleton set using functions

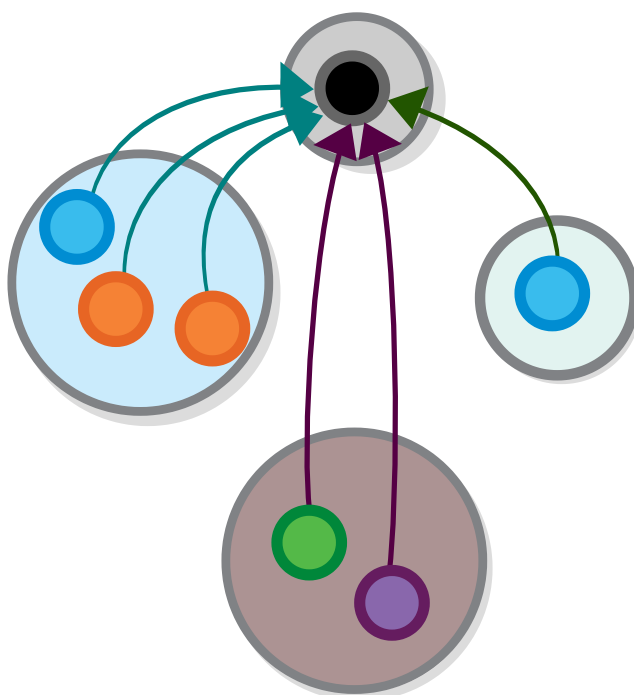
Now, after coming up with a definition of a set *element*, based on functions, we can try to draw the elements of our set as an external diagram.



Functions from the singleton set

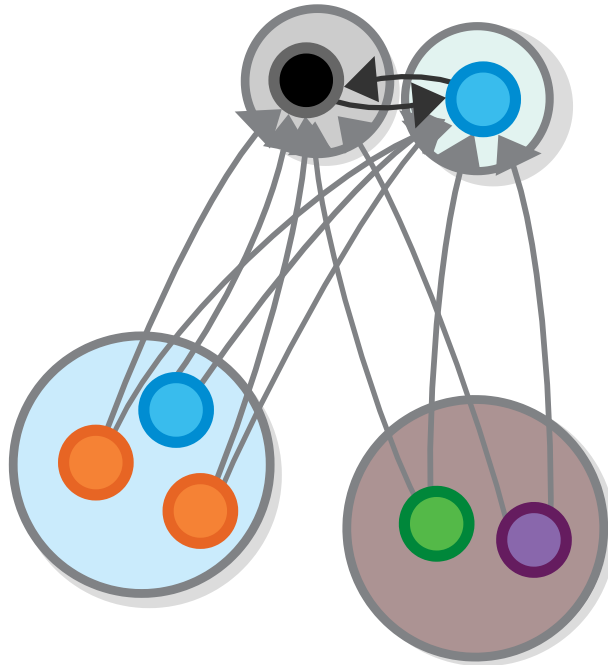
However, our diagram is not yet fully external, as it depends on the idea of the singleton set, i.e. the set with one *element*. Furthermore, this makes the whole definition circular, as we cannot define the concept of a one-element set, without the concept of element.

To avoid these difficulties, we devise a way to define the singleton set, using just functions. We do it in the same way that we did for products and sums - by using a unique property that the singleton set has. In particular, there is exactly one function from any other set to the singleton set i.e. if 1 is the singleton set, then we have exactly one function $X \rightarrow 1$ for all objects X i.e. $\forall X \exists! (X \rightarrow 1)$ (where $\exists!$ means “Exists unique”).



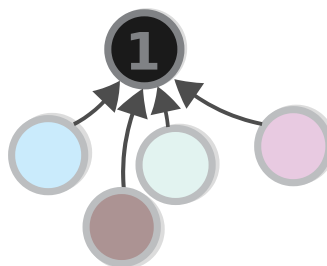
Terminal object

It turns out that this property defines the singleton set uniquely i.e. there is no other set that has it, other than the sets that are isomorphic to the singleton set. This is simply because, if there are two sets that have it, those two sets would also have unique functions between *themselves* so they would be isomorphic to one another. More formally, if we have two sets X and Y such that $\exists! X \rightarrow 1 \wedge \exists! Y \rightarrow 1$ and they both hold this property (“exactly one function from any other set to this set”) then we also have $X \cong Y$.



Terminal object

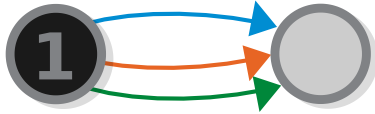
And because there is no other set, other than the singleton set that has this property, we can use it as a definition of the singleton set and say that if we have $\forall X \exists ! X \rightarrow 1$, then 1 is the singleton set.



Terminal object

With this, we acquire a fully external definition (up to an isomorphism) of the singleton set, and thus a definition of a set

element — the elements of a given set are just the functions from the singleton set to that set.



Functions from the singleton set

Note that from this property it follows that the singleton set has exactly one element, which confirms that our definition is correct.



Functions from the singleton set

Task 2: Why exactly does it follow (check the definition)?

Defining the empty set using functions

The empty set is, of course, the set that has no elements, but how would we say this without referring to elements?

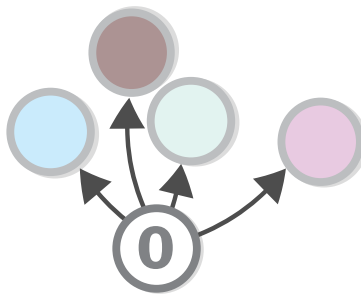
In the previous chapter, we noted an interesting property of the empty set:

there is a unique function from the empty set to any other set.

And, again, since the empty set is the only set that has this property, we can reverse the above statement and use it as a definition:

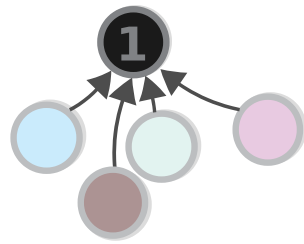
the empty set is the set such that there exists a function from it to any other set.

Task 3: why is the functions to the empty set unique?

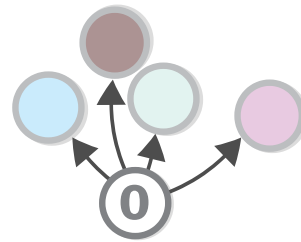


Initial object

Observant readers will notice the similarities between the diagrams depicting the initial and terminal object (yes the two concepts are, of course, dual of each other).



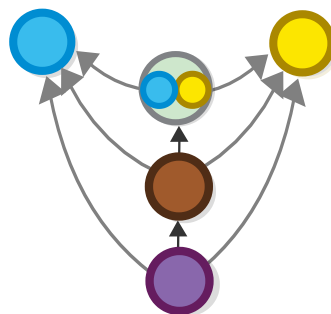
TERMINAL OBJECT



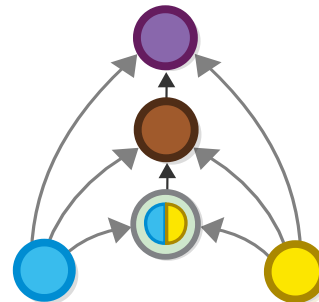
INITIAL OBJECT

Initial terminal duality

Some *even more* observant readers (folks, keep it down please, you are *too observant*) may also notice the similarities between the product/coproduct diagrams and the initial/terminal object diagrams.



PRODUCT



COPRODUCT

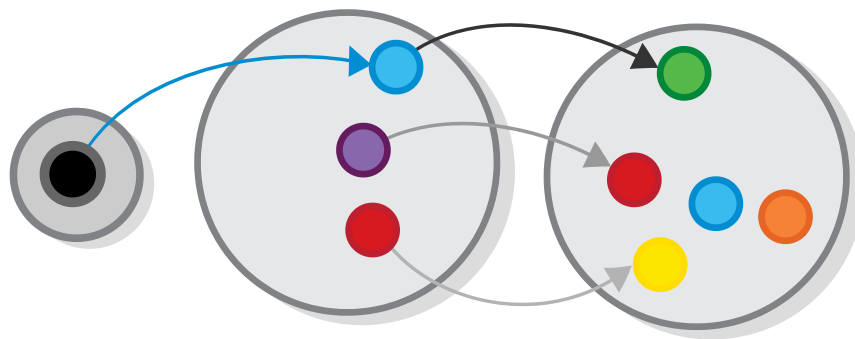
Coproduct and product

The similarity of the diagrams, is due to a similar general approach of defining things — in both cases we find the property that makes a given concept useful and then define the concept so it has this property*.

Functional application

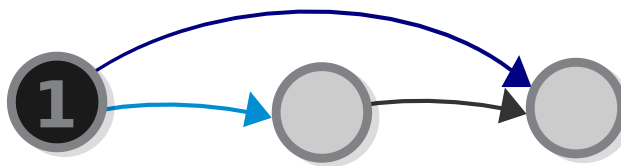
After seeing the functional definition of set elements, we might be inclined to ask the following: If elements are represented by functions, then how do you *apply* a given function to an element of a set, (and retrieve an element of another set)?

The answer is surprisingly simple — *selecting* an element from a set is the same as constructing a function from the singleton set to that element.



Functional application - internal diagram

And then *applying* a function to an element is the same as *composing* the element function, with the function we want to apply.



Functional application - external diagram

The result is the function that represents the element returned by the applied function.

Conclusion

This was a taste of Lawvere's Elementary Theory of the Category of Sets (ETCS) which constitutes a rigorous definition of set theory (equivalent to ZFC set theory) using only the concept of a function.

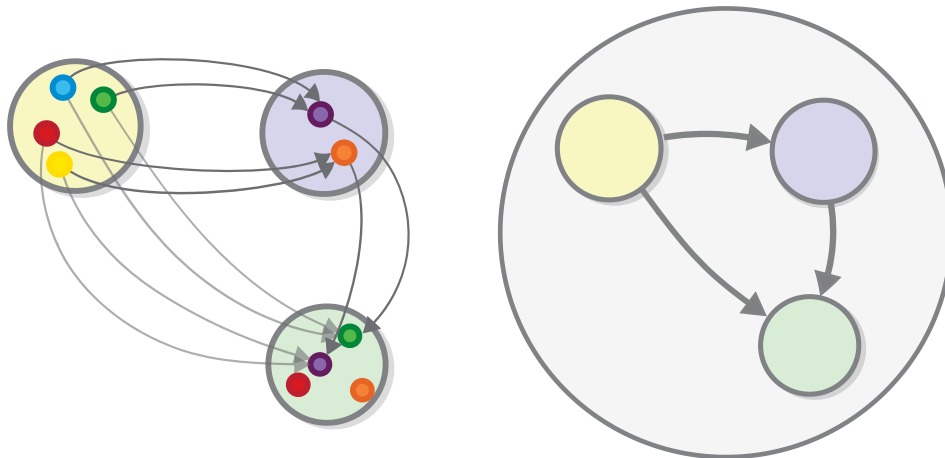
We can cover this theory in its entirety, listing all axioms that are needed, but for now it is probably more important to understand why do we need in the first place?

The short answer: because it is more general than the traditional definition, this new definition also applies to objects that are not exactly sets but are *like* sets in some respects.

You may say that they apply to entirely different *categories of objects* (nudge, nudge).

Categories brierly

Maybe it is about time to see what a category is. Here is a short definition: a category consists of objects (an example of which are sets) and morphisms that go from one object to another (which behave as functions) and that are composable. We can say a lot more about categories, and even present a formal definition, but for now, it is sufficient for you to remember that sets are one example of a category and that categorical objects are like sets, except that we don't see their elements i.e. category-theoretic notions are captured by the external diagrams, while strictly set-theoretic notions can be captured by internal ones.



Category theory and set theory compared

When we are within the realm of sets, we can view each set as a collection of individual elements. In category theory, we don't

have such a notion. However, taking this notion away allows us to define concepts such as the sum and product sets in a whole different and more general way. Plus we always have a way to “go back” to set theory, using the tricks from the last section.

Category Theory	Set theory	Programming Languages
Category	N/A	N/A
Objects	and Sets	and
Morphisms	Functions	Classes and methods
N/A	Element	Object

Notice the somehow weird, (but actually completely logical) symmetry (or perhaps “reverse symmetry”) between the world as viewed through the lenses of set theory, and the way it is viewed through the lens of category theory:

Category Theory	Set theory
Category	N/A
Objects and Morphisms	Sets and functions
N/A	Element

By switching to external diagrams, we lose sight of the particular (the elements of our sets), but we gain the ability to zoom out and see the whole universe where we have been previously trapped. In the same way that the whole realm of sets can be thought of as one category, a programming language can also be thought of as a category. The concept of a category allows us to find and analyze similarities between these and other structures.

NB: The word “Object” is used in both programming languages and in category theory, but has completely different meanings. A categorical object is equivalent to a *type* or a *class* in programming language theory.

Sets VS Categories

One remark before we continue: in the last section, we may have made it seem like category theory and set theory are somehow competing with each other. Perhaps that notion would be somewhat correct if category and set theory were meant to describe *concrete* phenomena, in the way that the theory of relativity and the theory of quantum mechanics are both supposed to explain the physical world. Concrete theories are conceived mainly as *descriptions* of the world, and as such it makes sense for them to be connected in some sort of hierarchy.

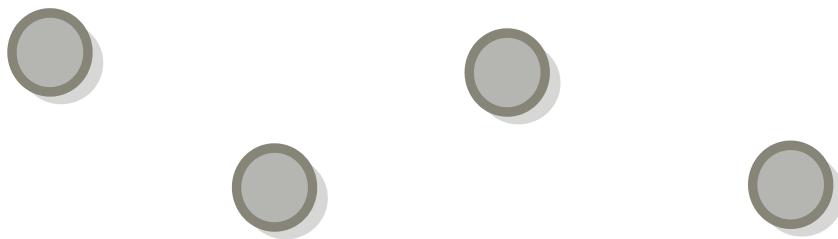
In contrast, abstract theories, like category theory and set theory, are more like *languages* for expressing such descriptions — they still can be connected, and *are* connected in more than one way, but there is no inherent hierarchical relationship between the two and therefore arguing over which of the two is more basic, or more general, is just a chicken-and-egg problem, as you will see in the next chapter.

Categories (again)

“...deal with all elements of a set by ignoring them and working with the set’s definition.” — Dijkstra (from “On the cruelty of really teaching computing science”)

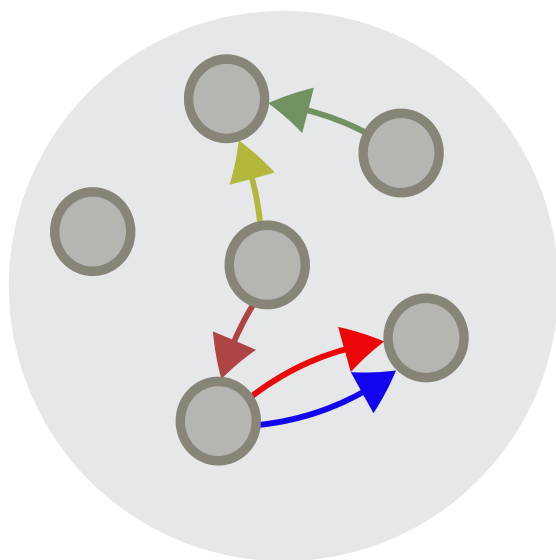
All category theory books, including this one, start by talking about set theory. Looking back, I really don’t know why this is the case — books that focus on a given subject usually don’t start off by introducing an *entirely different subject*, (before even starting to talk about the main one). Perhaps the set-first approach *is* the best way to introduce people to categories. Or perhaps using sets to introduce categories is one of those things that people do just because everyone else does it. But, one thing is for certain — we don’t *need* to study sets in order to understand categories. So now I would like to start over and talk about categories as a foundational concept. So let’s pretend like this is a new book (I wonder if I can dedicate this to a different person).

A category is a collection of objects (things) where the “things” can be anything you want. Consider, for example, these ~~colorful~~ gray balls:



Balls

A category consists of a collection of objects as well as some arrows connecting objects to one another. We call the arrows *morphisms* (for now you can think of them as functions).



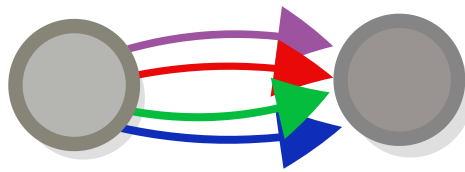
A category

Wait a minute, we said that all sets form a category, but at the same time, any one set can be seen as a category in its own right (just one which has no morphisms). This is true and very characteristic of category theory — one structure can be examined from many different angles and may play many different roles, often in a recursive fashion.

This particular equivalence (a set as a category with no morphisms) is, however, rarely useful. Not because it's incorrect in any way, but rather because category theory is *all about the morphisms* — if the *arrows* in set theory are nothing but a connection between the sets that serve as their source and a destination, in category theory it's the *objects* that are nothing but a source and destination for the arrows that connect them to

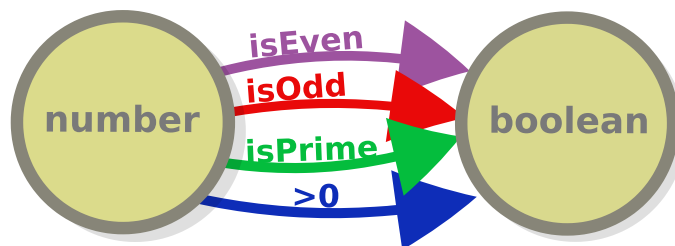
other objects. This is why, in the diagram above, the arrows, and not the objects, are colored: if you ask me, the category of sets should really be called *the category of functions*.

Speaking of which, note that objects in a category can be connected by multiple arrows and that having the same source and target sets does not in any way make arrows equivalent.



Two objects connected with multiple arrows

Why that is true is pretty obvious if we go back to set theory for a second (OK, maybe we really *have* to do it from time to time). There are, for example, an infinite number of functions that go from number to boolean, and the fact that they have the same input type and the same output type (or the same *type signature*, as we like to say) does not in any way make them equivalent to one another.



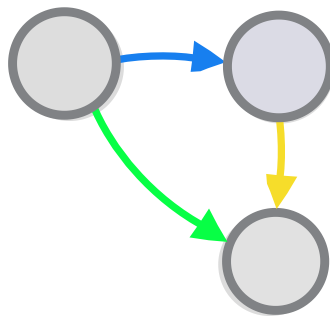
Two sets connected with multiple functions

There are some types of categories that have only one morphism between two objects (in each direction), but we will talk about them later.

Composition

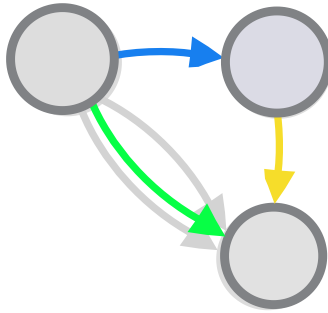
The most important requirement for a structure to be called a category is that *two morphisms can make a third*, or in other words, that morphisms are *composable*.

Given three objects and two successive arrows with between them, we can make a third arrow (in set theory, it is equivalent to the consecutive application of the first two).



Composition of morphisms

Formally, this requirement says that there should exist an *operation*, usually denoted with the symbol $\circ$ such that for each pair of morphisms $g : A \rightarrow B$ and $f : B \rightarrow C$, there exists a morphism $(f \circ g) : A \rightarrow C$.



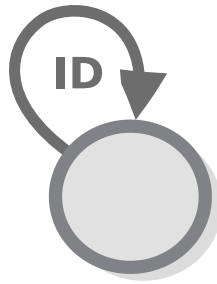
Composition of morphisms in the context of additional morphism

If you remember, in set theory, we picked functions, as opposed to the other types of relations because they are composable. Here we just invent the concept of a morphism and define it to be composable (in the same way as we invented the (co)products and later the empty and singleton set). Let's see where this definition gets us.

NB: Note, that functional composition is read from right to left. e.g. applying g and then applying f is written $f \circ g$ and not the other way around. (You can think of it as a shortcut to $f(g(a))$). Some may find it useful to pronounce "" as "after", e.g. $\$f ; ; \g .

The law of identity

To have numbers, you have to have a zero. The zero of category theory is what we call the "identity morphism" for each object. In short, this is a morphism that doesn't do anything.



The identity morphism (but can also be any other morphism)

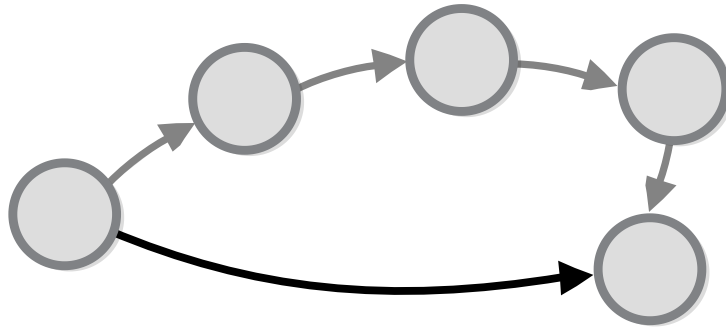
It's important to mark this morphism because there can be (let's again add this very important, and by now probably also very boring, reminder) many morphisms that go from one object to the same object. For example, in the category of sets, we deal with a multitude of functions that have the set of numbers as source and target, such as negate, square, add one, and are not at all the identity morphism.

A structure must have an identity morphism for each object in order for it to be called a category — this is known as the *law of identity*.

Task 4: What is the identity morphism in the category of sets?

The law of associativity

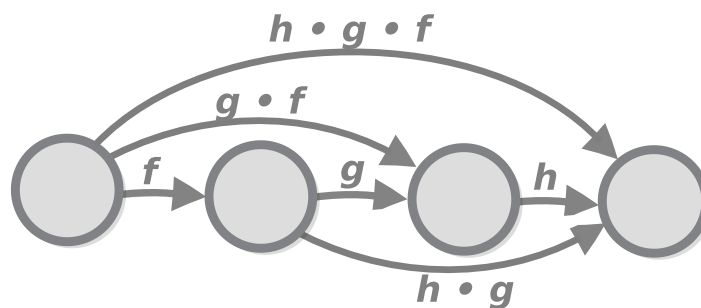
Composition is special not only because you can take any two morphisms with appropriate signatures and make a third, but because you can do so indefinitely, i.e. for each n successive arrows, each of which has as a source object the target object of the previous, we can draw one (exactly one) arrow that is equivalent to the consecutive application of all n arrows.



Composition of morphisms with many objects

If we carefully review the definition above, we can see that it can be reduced to multiple applications of the following formula: given 3 objects and 2 morphisms between them f g h , combining h and g and then combining the end result with f should be the same as combining h to the result of g and f (or simply $(h \circ g) \circ f = h \circ (g \circ f)$).

This formula can be expressed using the following diagram, which would only commute if the formula is true (given that all our category-theoretic diagrams are commutative, we can say, in such cases, that the formula and the diagram are equivalent).



Composition of morphisms with many objects

This formula (and the diagram) is the definition of a property called *associativity*. Being associative is required for functional composition to really be called functional composition (and thus

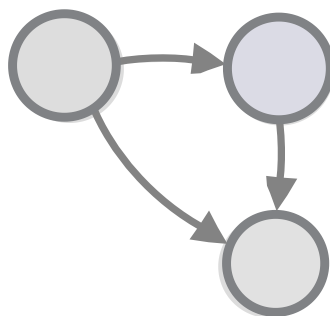
for a category to really be called a category). It is also required for our diagrams to work, as diagrams can only represent associative structures (imagine if the diagram above would not commute, that would be super weird).

Associativity is not just about diagrams. For example, when we express relations using formulas, associativity just means that brackets don't matter in our formulas (as evidenced by the definition $(h \circ g) \circ f = h \circ (g \circ f)$).

And it is not only about categories either, it is a property of many other operations on other types of objects as well e.g. if we look at numbers, we can see that the multiplication operation is associative e.g. $(1 \times 2) \times 3 = 1 \times (2 \times 3)$. While division is not $(1/2)/3 \neq 1/(2/3)$.

Commuting diagrams

The diagrams above use colours to illustrate the fact that the green morphism is equivalent to the other two (and not just some unrelated morphism), but in practice this notation is a little redundant, as the *only* reason to draw diagrams in the first place is to represent paths that are equivalent to each other. All other paths would just belong in different diagrams.



Composition of morphisms - a commuting diagram

As we mentioned briefly in the last chapter, all diagrams that are like that (ones in which any two paths between two objects are equivalent to one another) are called *commutative diagrams* (or diagrams that *commute*). All diagrams in this book (except the incorrect ones, nudge nudge) commute.

More formally, a commuting diagram is a diagram in which given two objects a and b and two sequences of morphisms between those two objects, we can say that those sequences are equivalent.

The diagram above is one of the simplest commuting diagrams.

NB: Despite the fact that all diagrams in books commute, in general, **not all diagrams commute**. That is, there are many morphisms with the same type signature that are not equivalent to one another.

Summary

For future reference, let's restate what a category is:

A category is a collection of *objects* (we can think of them as *points*) and *morphisms* (or *arrows*) that go from one object to another, where:

- Each object has to have the identity morphism.
- There should be a way to compose two morphisms with an appropriate type signature into a third one, in a way that is *associative*.

This is it.

Addendum: Why are categories like that?

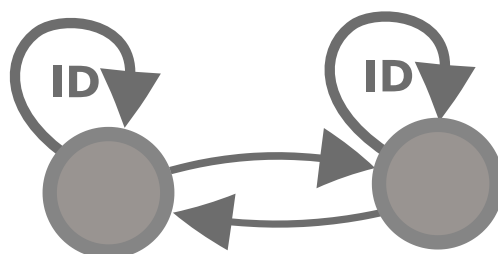
Why are categories defined by those two laws and not some other two (or one, three, four etc.). laws? From one standpoint, the answer to that seems obvious — we study categories because they *work*. I mean, look at how many applications there are... But at the same time, category theory is an abstract theory, so everything about it is kinda arbitrary: you can remove a law — and you get another theory that looks similar to category theory (although it might actually turn out to be quite different in practice). Or you can add one more law and get yet another theory (there are indeed such laws and such theories, and we will cover them later). So if this specific set of laws works better than any other, then this fact demands an explanation. Not a *mathematical* explanation (e.g. we cannot in any way *prove* that this theory is better than some other one), but an explanation nevertheless. What follows is *my* attempt to provide such an explanation, regarding the laws of *identity* and *associativity*.

Identity and isomorphisms

The reason the identity law is required is by far the more obvious one. Why do we need to have a morphism that does nothing? It's because morphisms are the basic building blocks of our language, we need the identity morphism to be able to speak properly. For example, once we have the concept of identity morphism defined, we can define a category-theoretic definition of an *isomorphism*, based on it (which is important, because the concept of an isomorphism is very important for category theory).

As we said in the previous chapter, an isomorphism between two objects (A and B) consists of two morphisms — ($A \rightarrow B$ and $B \rightarrow A$) such that their compositions are equivalent to the identity functions of the respective objects. Formally, objects A and B are isomorphic if there exist morphisms $f: A \rightarrow B$ and $g: B \rightarrow A$ such that $f \circ g = ID_B$ and $g \circ f = ID_A$.

And here is the same thing expressed with a commuting diagram.



Isomorphism

Like the previous one, the diagram expresses the same (simple) fact as the formula, namely that going from one object (A or B) to the other and then back again to the starting object is the same as applying the identity morphism i.e. doing nothing.

Associativity and reductionism

If, in some cataclysm, all of scientific knowledge were to be destroyed, and only one sentence passed on to the next generations of creatures, what statement would contain the most information in the fewest words? I believe it is the atomic hypothesis (or the atomic fact, or whatever you wish to call it) that all things are made of atoms—little particles that move around in perpetual motion, attracting each other when they are a little distance apart, but repelling upon being squeezed into one another. In that one sentence, you will see, there is an enormous amount of information about the world, if just a little imagination and thinking are applied. — Richard Feynman

Associativity — what does it mean and why is it there? In order to tackle this question, we must first talk about another concept — the concept of *reductionism*:

Reductionism is the idea that the behaviour of complex phenomena can be understood in terms of a number of *simpler* and more fundamental phenomena. In other words, that things keep getting simpler and simpler as they get “smaller” (or when they are viewed from a lower level). An example of reductionism is the idea that the behaviour of matter can be understood completely by studying the behaviours of its constituents i.e. atoms (the word means “undividable”).

Whether the reductionist view is *universally valid*, i.e. whether it is possible to devise a *theory of everything* that describes the whole universe with a set of very simple laws, is a question over which we can argue until that universe's inevitable collapse. What is certain, though, is that *reductionism underpins all our understanding*, especially when it comes to science and mathematics — each scientific discipline is based on a set of simple *fundaments* (e.g. elementary particles in particle physics, chemical elements in chemistry etc.) on which it builds on its much more complex theories.

Commutativity

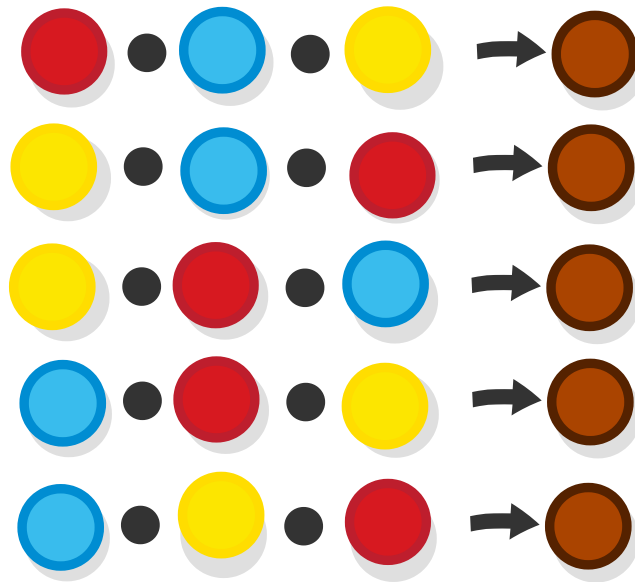
So, if this principle is so important, it would be beneficial to be able to formalize it (i.e. to translate it into mathematical language), and this is what we will try to do now. One way to state the principle of reductionism is to say that *each thing is nothing but a sum of its parts* i.e. if we combine the same set of parts, we always get the same result. To formalize that, we get a set of objects (balls) and a way to combine them (which we will denote with a dot).

So, if we have a given “recipe”, for example



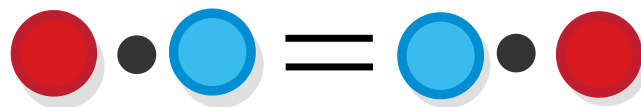
Commutativity

Then, we would also have



Commutativity

Or quite simply



Commutativity

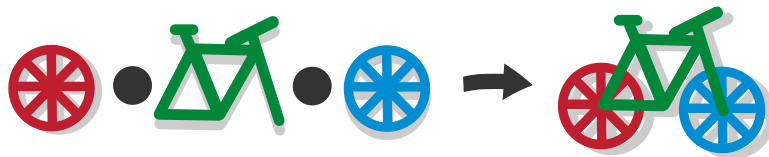
Incidentally, this is the definition of a mathematical law called *commutativity*.

A simple context where this law applies — the natural numbers are commutative under the operation of addition, e.g. $1 + 2 = 2 + 1$ (we will learn more about this in the chapter on groups).

Task 5: If our objects are sets, what set operations can play the part of the dot in this example (i.e. which ones are commutative)?

Associativity

Sometimes we observe phenomena that still can be represented as a combination of a given set of fundamentals, but only when they are combined in a *specific* way (as opposed to *any* combination, as in commutative contexts) e.g. as any mechanic can confirm, a bicycle is indeed just the combination of wheels and frameset...



bikes are not commutative

...but that does not mean that every combination of the above parts constitutes a bicycle. For example, placing the front wheel of the bicycle on the rear end of the frame would result would not result in a working bicycle. And combining two wheels one with another is just not possible.



bikes are not commutative

And, to take a formal example, if function A can be combined with B to get C...



functions are not commutative

...would not automatically mean that B can be combined with A to get the same result



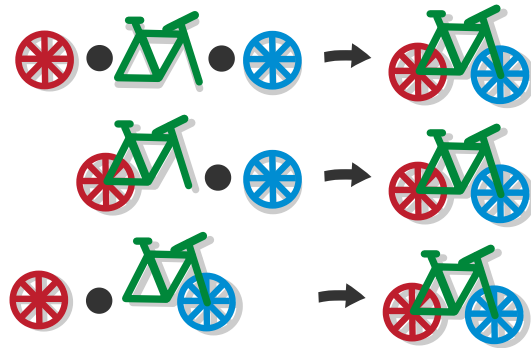
functions are not commutative - 2

Side note: composing any function with any other is only possible for functions that have the same set, both as source and target, but even then the end result would not always be the same.



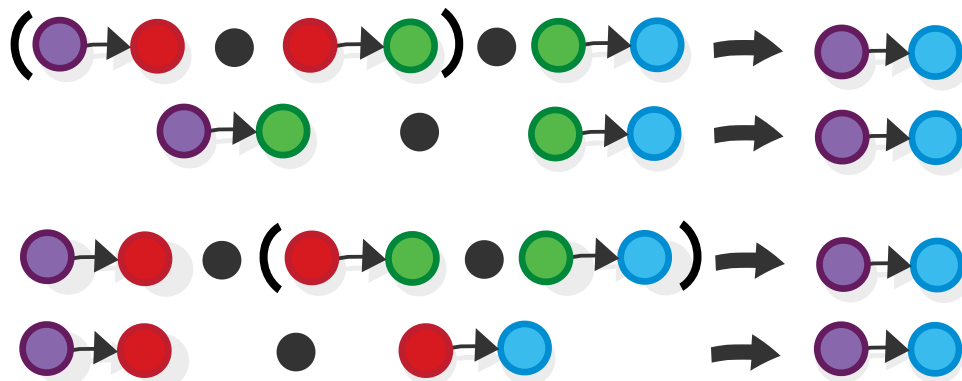
functions are sometimes commutative - 2

Anyway, we determined that functional composition (as well as bike building) does not obey the law of commutativity i.e. not all functions (or bike parts) compose with all other ones. But still, we know that *some* of them do, i.e. if you align the function signatures (or in the case of the bicycle if you use the proper parts in the proper places) they would come together seamlessly. So, the *order by which we combine the individual parts doesn't matter for the final outcome* e.g. when we are assembling a bicycle, it doesn't matter if we attach the front wheel to the frame first, or the back wheel, the result will be the same.



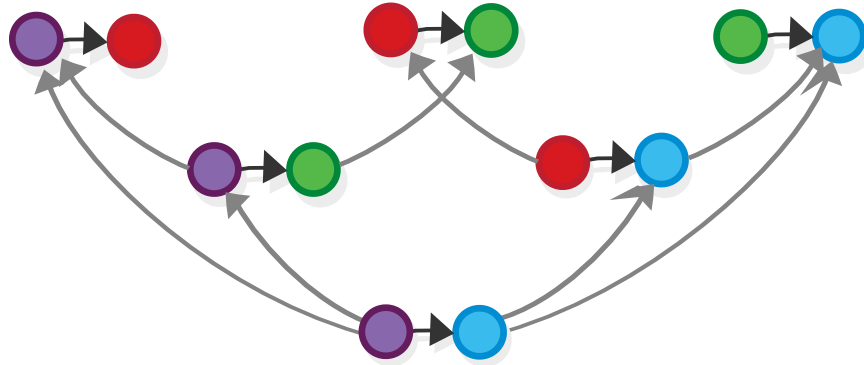
bikes are associative

Similarly, when combining functions, each pair of functions can, at any time, be replaced by the function that we get by combining them.



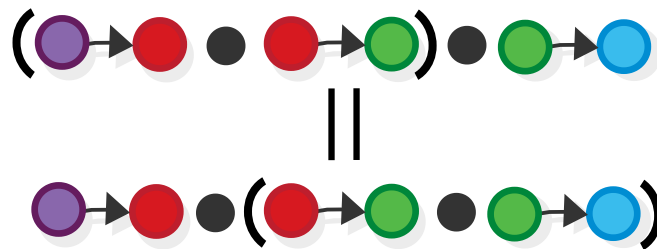
$$A \rightarrow X . (X \rightarrow B . B \rightarrow C) = D, (A \rightarrow X . X \rightarrow B) . B \rightarrow C = D$$

In other words, all different ways of combining a given set of functions at the end converge into one and the same result.



$$A . (B . C) = D, (A . B) . C = D$$

This fact is captured by a more restrictive version of commutativity, that we call *associativity*, which for functions, is usually formulated like this.



$$A \rightarrow X . (X \rightarrow B . B \rightarrow C) = (A \rightarrow X . X \rightarrow B) . B \rightarrow C$$

Or more generally (for any operation).

$$((\text{red} \bullet \text{green})) \bullet \text{blue} = \text{red} \bullet (\text{green} \bullet \text{blue})$$

$$A . (B . C) = D, (A . B) . C = D$$

This is the essence of associativity — it gives us the ability to study complex phenomenon by zooming in on a part that you want to examine in a given moment, and looking at it in isolation.

Note that the operator we defined only allows for combining things in one dimension (you can attach a thing left and right, but not up or down). Later we will learn about an extension of the concept of a category theory (called monoidal category) that “supports” working in 2 dimensions.

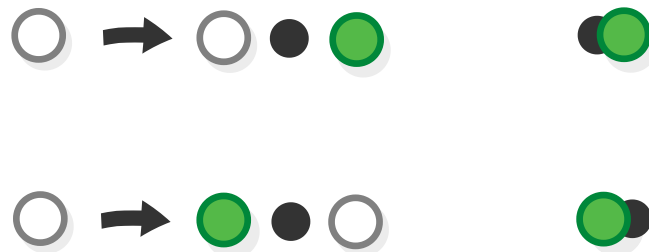
Task 6: Actually, in this chapter, we already defined a case of 2-dimensional composition, only we didn’t *say* it is 2-dimensional composition. Did you see it?

Associativity and commutativity

We said that associativity is a more restricted version of commutativity. This is true in a formal way, as we show here. By now, you might realize that a composition operator for morphisms in a given category (the thing we denote by the dot) is itself a morphism, that accepts a pair of morphisms and returns yet another morphism (so $A \times B \rightarrow C$).

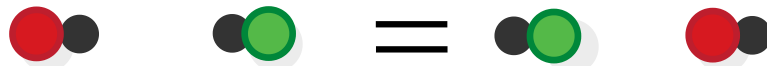
Given a composition operator for a category and one morphism from that same category (in this case the green ball), create two more morphisms (which we call the “curried” morphisms (more in the next chapter)) ($A \rightarrow C$ and $B \rightarrow C$) by just fixing the second or the first argument of the operator, correspondingly i.e. a morphism that attaches the green ball at the “front” of the

function that we have as an argument (produces its source) and one that attaches it at the “end” (accepting its target as a source).



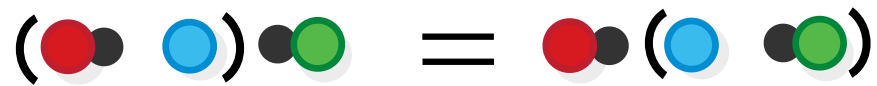
$$(A \times B) \rightarrow C = A \rightarrow B \rightarrow C$$

Now, take two such morphisms, with different directions and different objects and ask yourself: under what conditions would those two morphisms commute i.e. when would that formula be satisfied?



$$(A \times B) \rightarrow C = A \rightarrow B \rightarrow C$$

Expanding the formula gives us the answer: they commute when the original dot operator is associative.



$$(A \otimes B) \rightarrow C = A \rightarrow B \rightarrow C$$

Thus, we established a connection between associativity and commutativity.

Answers

Task 1: Why is this called a product? Hint: How many elements does it have?

The Cartesian product is called a “product” because the number of elements in $A \times B$ equals the *product* of the number of elements in A and B e.g. if A has 2 elements and B has 3 elements, then $A \times B$ has $2 \times 3 = 6$ elements

Task 2: Why exactly does it follow [that the singleton set has exactly one element]?

There is exactly one function from any set to the singleton set, including the singleton set itself.

So, there is exactly one function from $1 \rightarrow 1$. But functions $1 \rightarrow X$ correspond to elements of X . So 1 really has exactly one element.

Task 3: Why is the function to the empty set unique?

As we established, there is exactly one such function, the peculiar “empty function”.

Task 4: What is the identity morphism in the category of sets?

In the category of sets, the identity morphism for a set A is the *identity function* $id_A : A \rightarrow A$ which maps each element to itself.

Check the laws!

Task 5: If our objects are sets, what set operations can play the part of the dot in this example (i.e. which ones are commutative)?

Commutative set operations:

- *Set union*: the set of elements in A or B (or both): $1, 2 \cup 2, 3 = 1, 2, 3 = 2, 3 \cup 1, 2$
- *Set intersection* the set of elements in both A and B : $1, 2 \cap 2, 3 = 2 = 2, 3 \cap 1, 2$

Non-commutative operations: - Set difference ($A - B \neq B - A$)

Task 6: Actually, in this chapter, we already defined a case of 2-dimensional composition, only we didn't say it is 2-dimensional composition. Did you see it?

Yes we did — products.

a function $f: A \rightarrow B$, can be composed with a function $g: B \rightarrow C$, to obtain $g \circ f: A \rightarrow C$ (functional composition).

But, $f: A \rightarrow B$ can also be composed with a function $f': A' \rightarrow B'$ (or any other signature, really), to obtain $f \times f': A \times A' \rightarrow B \times B'$!

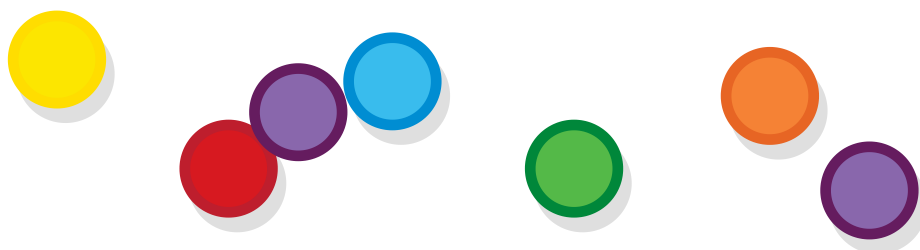
Monoids etc

Since we are done with categories, let's look at some other structures that are also interesting — monoids. Like categories, monoids/groups are abstract systems consisting of a set of elements and operations for manipulating these elements, however, the operations look different than the operations we have for categories. Let's see them.

What are monoids

Monoids are simpler than categories. A monoid is defined by a collection/set of elements (called the monoid's *underlying set*, together with a *monoid operation* — a rule for combining two elements that produces a third element one of the same kind.

Let's take our familiar colorful balls.



Balls

We can define a monoid based on this set by specifying an operation for “combining” two balls into one. An example of such an operation would be blending the colours of the balls as if we are mixing paint.

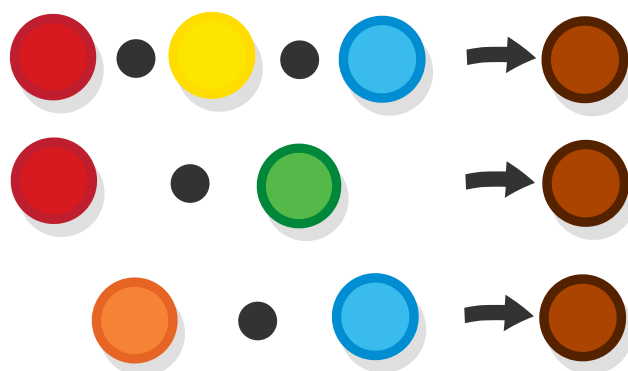


An operation for combining balls

You can probably think of other ways to define a similar operation. This will help you realize that there can be many ways to create a monoid from a given set of set elements i.e. the monoid is not the set itself, it is the set *together with the operation*.

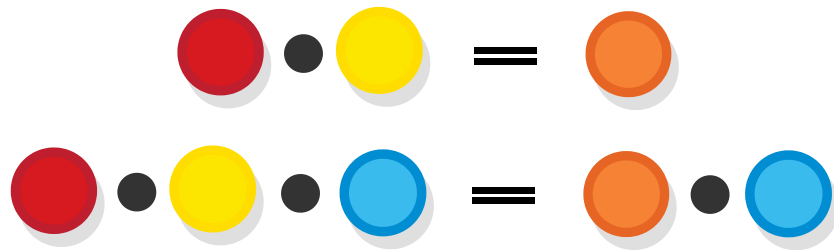
Associativity

The monoid operation should, like functional composition, be *associative* i.e. the way in which elements are grouped when applying the operation does not make any difference.



Associativity in the color mixing operation

When an operation is associative, this means we can use all kinds of algebraic operations to any sequence of terms (or in other words to apply equation reasoning), like for example we can replace any element with a set of elements from which it is composed, or add a term that is present at both sides of an equation and retain the equality of the existing terms.



Associativity in the color mixing operation

The identity element

Actually, not any (associative) operation for combining elements makes for a monoid (it makes for a *semigroup*, which is also a thing, but that's a separate topic). To be a monoid, a set must feature what is called an *identity element* of the operation, a concept of which you are already familiar from both sets and categories — it is an element that when combined with any other element gives back that same element (not the identity but the other one). Or simply $x \cdot i = x$ and $i \cdot x = x$ for any x .

In the case of our color-mixing monoid, the identity element is the white ball (or perhaps a transparent one, if we have one).



The identity element of the color-mixing monoid

As you probably remember from the last chapter, functional composition is also associative and it also contains an identity element, so you might start suspecting that it forms a monoid in some way. This is indeed the case, but with one caveat, which we will talk about later.

Basic monoids

To keep the suspense, before we discuss the relationship between monoids and categories, we are going through see some simple examples of monoids.

Monoids from numbers

Mathematics is not only about numbers, however, numbers do tend to pop up in most of its areas, and monoids are no exception. The set of natural numbers $\mathbb{N}$ ($\{0, 1, 2, 3, \dots\}$) forms a monoid when combined with the all too familiar operation of addition (or *under* addition as it is traditionally said). This monoid is denoted $\langle \mathbb{N}, + \rangle$ (in general, all monoids are denoted by specifying the set and the operation, enclosed in angle brackets).

$$1 + 1 = 2$$

The monoid of numbers under addition

If you see a $1 + 1 = 2$ in your textbook you know you are either reading something very advanced, or very simple, although I am not really sure which of the two applies in the present case.

Anyways, the natural numbers also form a monoid under multiplication as well.

$$1 \times 1 = 1$$

The monoid of numbers under multiplication

Task 1: Which are the identity elements of those monoids?

Task 2: Go through other mathematical operations and verify that they are monoidal.

Task 3: The natural numbers form a monoid under multiplication, but not a group. Find out why.

Monoids from boolean algebra

Thinking about operations that we covered, we may remember the boolean operations *and* and *or*. Both of them form monoids, which operate on the set, consisting of just two values *{True, False}*.

Task 4: Prove that **AND** $\wedge$ is associative by expanding the formula $(A \wedge B) \wedge C = A \wedge (B \wedge C)$ with all possible values. Do the same for *or*.

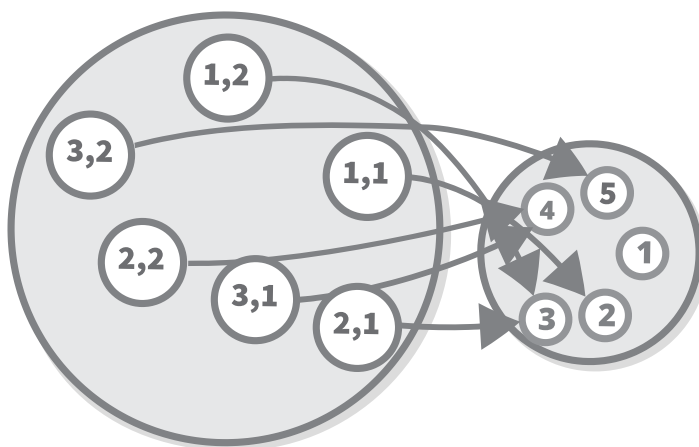
Task 5: Which are the identity elements of the *and* and *or* operations?

Monoid operations in terms of set theory

We now know what the monoid operation is, and we even saw some simple examples. However, we never defined the monoid rule/operation formally i.e. using the language of set theory with which we defined everything else. Can we do that? Of course we can — everything can be defined in terms of sets.

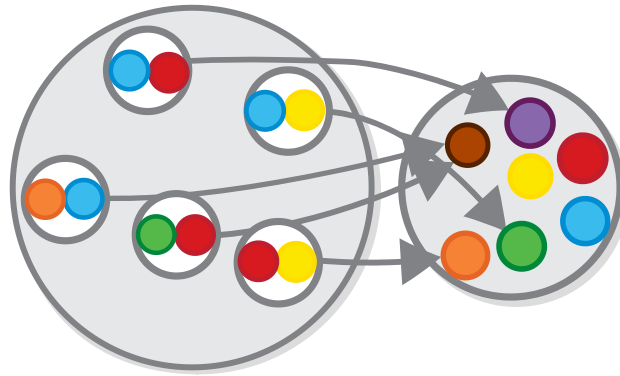
We said that a monoid consists of two things: a set (let's call it A), and a monoid operation that acts on that set. Since A is already defined in set theory (because it is just a set), all we have to do is define the monoid operation.

Defining the operation is not hard at all. Actually, we have already done it for the operation $+$ — in Chapter 2, we said that *addition* can be represented in set theory as a function that accepts a product of two numbers and returns a number (formally $+$: $\mathbb{Z} \times \mathbb{Z} \rightarrow \mathbb{Z}$).



The plus operation as a function

Every other monoid operation can also be represented in the same way — as a function that takes a pair of elements from the monoid's set and returns one other monoid element.



The color-mixing operation as a function

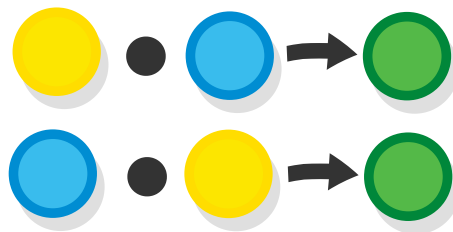
Formally, we can define a monoid from any set A , by defining an (associative) function with type signature $A \times A \rightarrow A$. That's it. Or to be precise, that is *one way* to define the monoid operation. And there is another way, which we will see next. Before that, let's examine some other types of structures.

Other monoid-like objects

Monoid operations obey two laws — they are *associative* and there exists an *identity element*. In some cases, we come across operations that also obey other laws that are also interesting. Imposing more (or less) rules to the way in which objects are combined results in the definition of other monoid-like structures.

Commutative (abelian) monoids

Looking at the monoid laws and the examples we gave so far, we observe that all of them obey one more rule (law) which we didn't specify — the order in which the operations are applied is irrelevant to the end result.



Commutative monoid operation

Such operations (ones for which combining a given set of elements yields the same result no matter which one is first and which one is second) are called *commutative* operations. Monoids with operations that are commutative are called *commutative monoids*.

As we said, addition is commutative as well — it does not matter whether I have given you 1 apple and then 2 more, or if I have given you 2 first and then 1 more.

$$\mathbf{x} + \mathbf{y} = \mathbf{y} + \mathbf{x}$$

Commutative monoid operation

All monoids that we examined so far are also *commutative*. We will see some non-commutative ones later.

Groups

A group is a monoid such that for each of its elements, there is another element which is the so-called “inverse” of the first one where the element and its inverse cancel each other out when applied one after the other. Plain-English definitions like this make you appreciate mathematical formulas more — formally we say that for all elements x , there must exist x' such that $x \bullet x' = i$ (where i is the identity element).

If we view *monoids* as a means of modelling the effect of applying a set of (associative) actions, we use *groups* to model the effects of actions which are also *reversible*.

A nice example of a group, which is related to a monoid we covered, is the set of integers under addition — the operation is again (+), but the objects are the *integers* $\mathbb{Z}$, not the natural

numbers $\mathbb{N}$ (so it's not $\{0, 1, 2, 3...\}$, but $\{... - 3, - 2 - 1, 0, 1, 2, 3...\}$). The negative numbers are added, as the natural numbers don't have inverses. The inverse of each number is its opposite number (positive numbers' inverse are negatives and vice versa).

In this instance, the above formula becomes $x + (-x) = 0$

The study of groups is a field that is much bigger than the theory of monoids (and perhaps bigger than category theory itself). And one of its biggest branches is the study of "symmetry groups" which we will look into next.

Summary

Before we move on — the algebraic structures that we saw above can be summarized based on the laws that define them in this table:

	Semigroups	Monoids	Groups
Associativity	X	X	X
Identity	X	X	X
Invertability			X

And now on to symmetry groups.

Symmetry groups and group classifications

An interesting kind of groups/monoids are the groups of *symmetries* of geometric figures. Given some geometric figure, a symmetry is an action after which the figure is not displaced (e.g. it can fit into the same mold that it fitted before the action was applied).

We won't use the balls this time, because in terms of symmetries, they have just one position and hence just one action — the identity action (which is its own reverse, by the way).

Instead, let's take this triangle, which, for our purposes, is the same as any other triangle. We are not interested in the triangle itself, but in its rotations. The only thing we need to make ourselves believe is that this is an “unrotated” triangle i.e. the one which represents the identity rotation.



A triangle

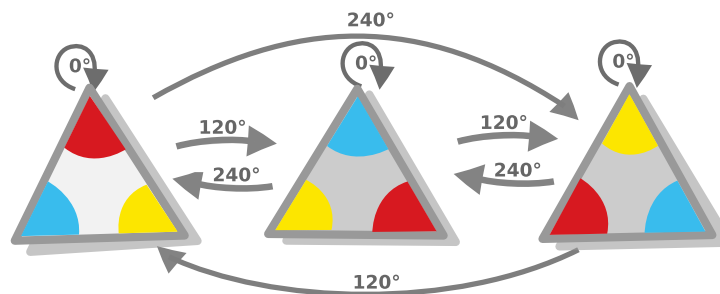
Groups of rotations

Let's first review the group of ways in which we can rotate our triangle i.e. its *rotation group*. A geometric figure can be rotated without displacement in positions equal to the number of its sides, so, for our triangle, there are 3 positions.



The group of rotations in a triangle

Connecting the dots (or the triangles in this case) shows us that there are just 3 possible rotations that get us from any state of the triangle to any other one — a *120-degree rotation* (i.e. flipping the triangle one time) and a *240-degree rotation* (i.e. flipping it twice, or equivalently, flipping it once in the opposite direction) and the identity action of 0-degree rotation.



The group of rotations in a triangle

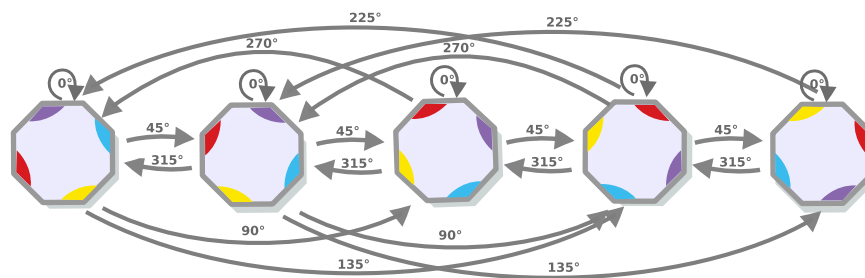
The rotations of a triangle form a monoid — the *rotations are objects* (of which the zero-degree rotation is the identity) and the monoid operation which combines two rotations into one is just

the operation of performing the first rotation and then performing the second one.

NB: Note once again that the elements in the group are the *rotations*, not the triangles themselves, actually the group has nothing to do with triangles, as we shall see later.

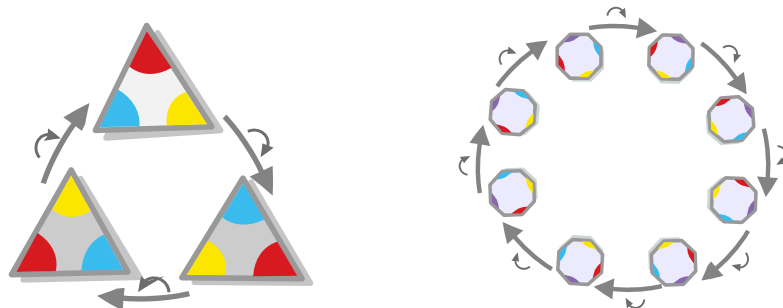
Cyclic groups/monoids

The diagram that enumerates all the rotations of a more complex geometrical figure looks quite messy at first.



The group of rotations in a more complex figure

But it gets much simpler to grasp if we notice the following: although our group has many rotations, and there are more still for figures with more sides (if I am not mistaken, the number of rotations is equal to the number of the sides), *all those rotations can be reduced to the repetitive application of just one rotation*, (for example, the 120-degree rotation for triangles and the 45-degree rotation for octagons). Let's make up a symbol for this rotation.



The group of rotations in a triangle

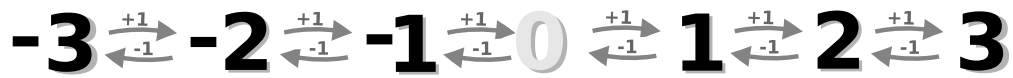
Symmetry groups that have such “main” rotation, and in general, groups and monoids that have an object that is capable of generating all other objects by its repeated application, are called *cyclic groups*. The “main” rotation is called the group’s *generator*.

All rotation groups/monoids are cyclic groups. Another example of a cyclic monoid is, yes, the natural numbers under addition, with $+1$ as the generator.



The monoid of natural numbers under addition

The *group* of integers under addition is cyclic too — here we can use $+1$ or -1 as the generator (as whichever of the two we choose, we would get the other one by applying the inverse wall).



The group of integers under addition

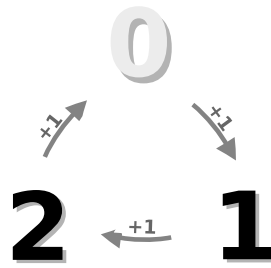
Wait, how can this be a cyclic group when there are clearly no cycles? This is because the integers are an *infinite* cyclic group.

A number-based example of a finite cyclic group is the group of integers under *modular arithmetic* (sometimes called “clock arithmetic”). Modular arithmetic’s operation is based on a number called the modulus (let’s take 12 for example). In it, each number is mapped to the *remainder of the integer addition of that number and the modulus*.

For example: $1 \pmod{12} = 1$ (because $1/12 = 0$ with 1 remainder) $2 \pmod{12} = 2$ etc.

But $13 \pmod{12} = 1$ (as $13/12 = 1$ with 1 remainder) $14 \pmod{12} = 2$, $15 \pmod{12} = 3$ etc.

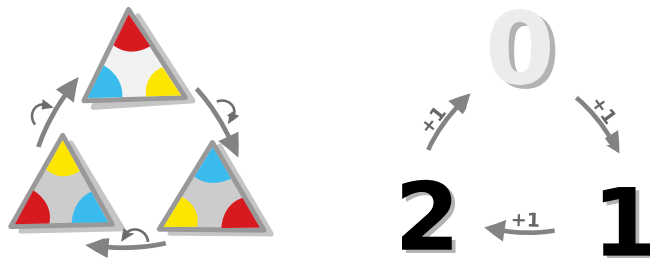
In effect, numbers “wrap around” forming a group with as many elements as the modulus number. For example, a group representation of modular arithmetic with modulus 3 has 3 elements.



The group of numbers under addition

All cyclic groups that have the same number of elements (or that are of the *same order*) are isomorphic to each other (careful readers might notice that we haven't yet defined what a group isomorphism is, even more careful readers might already have an idea about what it is).

For example, the group of rotations of the triangle is isomorphic to the group of integers under the addition with modulo 3.



The group of numbers under addition

All cyclic groups are *commutative* (or “abelian” as they are also called).

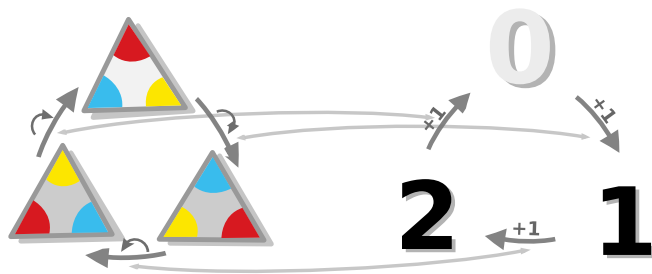
Task 6: Show that there are no other groups with 3 objects, other than Z_3 .

There are abelian groups that are not cyclic, but, as we shall see below, the concepts of cyclic groups and abelian groups are

deeply related.

Group isomorphisms

We already mentioned group isomorphisms, but we didn't define what they are. Let's do that now — an isomorphism between two groups is an isomorphism (f) between their respective sets of elements, such that for any a and b we have $f(a \circ b) = f(a) \circ f(b)$. Visually, the diagrams of isomorphic groups have the same structure.



Group isomorphism between different representations of S_3

As in category theory, in group theory isomorphic groups are considered instances of one and the same group. For example, the one above is called Z_3 .

Finite groups

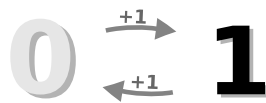
Like with sets, the concept of an isomorphism in group theory allows us to identify common finite groups.

The smallest group is just the trivial group Z_1 that has just one element.

0

The smallest group

The smallest non-trivial group is the group Z_2 which has two elements.



The smallest non-trivial group

Z_2 is also known as the *boolean group*, due to the fact that it is isomorphic to the *True, False* set under the operation that negates a given value.

Like Z_3 , Z_1 and Z_2 are cyclic.

Group/monoid products

We already saw a lot of abelian groups that are also cyclic, but we didn't see any abelian groups that are not cyclic. So let's examine what these look like. This time, instead of looking into individual examples, we will present a general way for producing abelian non-cyclic groups from cyclic ones — it is by uniting them by using *group product*.

Given any two groups, we can combine them to create a third group, comprised of all possible pairs of elements from the two groups and of the sum of all their actions.

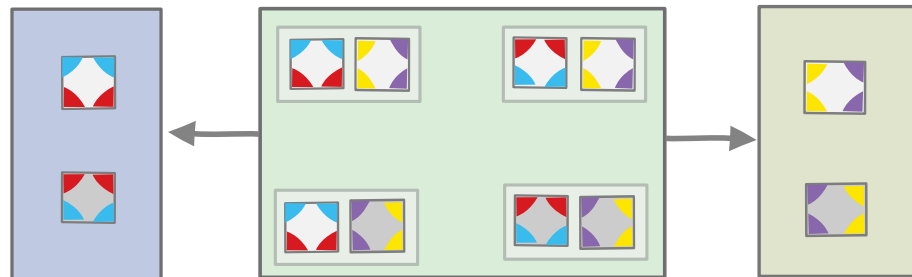
Let's see how the resulting group looks after taking the product of the following two groups (which, having just two elements and one operation, are both isomorphic to Z_2). To make it easier to imagine them, we can think of the first one as based on the vertical reflection of a figure and the second, as the horizontal reflection.



Two trivial groups

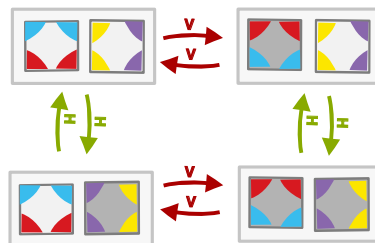
(again we have to pretend that the left versions of the figures are the “unflipped” versions, while the right ones are flipped (although it can work the other way around too))

We get the set of elements of the new group by taking *the Cartesian product* of the set of elements of the first group and the set of elements of the second.



Two trivial groups

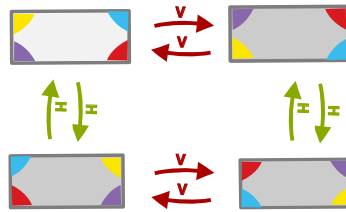
And the *actions* of a product group are comprised of the actions of the first group, combined with the actions of the second, where each action is applied only to the element that is a member of its original group, leaving the other element unchanged.



Klein four

The product of the two groups presented is called the *Klein four-group* and it is the simplest *non-cyclic Abelian* group.

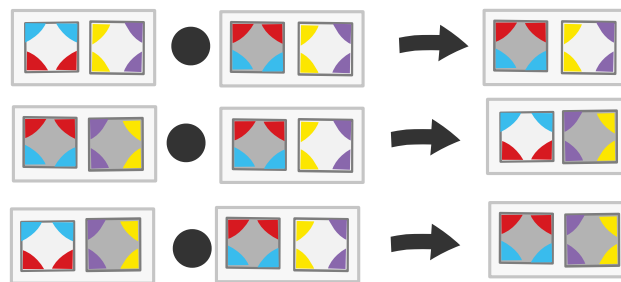
Another way to present the Klein four-group is the *group of symmetries of a non-square rectangle*.



Klein four

Task 7: Show that the two representations are isomorphic.

Here are some examples of how elements of the Klein four-group are combined.



Klein four

(i.e. horizontal/vertical rotations cancel each other out, while a horizontal rotation doesn't cancel out a vertical one.)

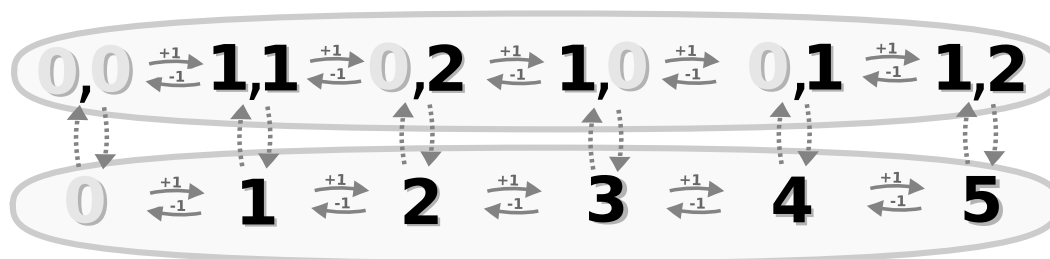
The Klein four-group is *non-cyclic* (because there are not one, but two generators) — vertical and horizontal spin. It is, however, still *abelian*, because the ordering of the actions still does not matter for the end result. Actually, the Klein four-group is the *smallest non-cyclic group*.

Cyclic product groups

In the previous chapter, we saw one *non-cyclic* product group (the Klein four-group), which was a product of *cyclic groups*. Most product groups (even the product of cyclic groups) would be non-cyclic, because it would have the generators of both groups that comprise it, i.e. even if the two original groups are cyclic and thus have 1 generator each, their product would still have 2 generators. But the product of two cyclic groups would still be cyclic if the number of elements of those groups (their *orders*) have some common divisor other than 1 (i.e. if they are *not relatively prime numbers*).

So, if you combine two groups with orders that have some common divisor (as 2 and 2, which are both divided by 2), then, their product would not be cyclic. But, if you combine two groups with orders that are relatively prime, (like 2 and 3) you would get a cyclic group.

Furthermore, the product of two relatively prime groups would be isomorphic to a cyclic group of the same order, as the product of the orders of its components e.g. the product of Z_3 and Z_2 is isomorphic to the group Z_6 ($Z_3 \times Z_2 \cong Z_6$)



Chinese remainder theorem

This is a consequence of an ancient result, known as the *Chinese Remainder theorem*.

Abelian product groups

Product groups are *abelian*, provided that the *groups that form them* are abelian. We can see that this is true by noticing that, although there is more than one generator, each acts only on its own part of the group, and so doesn't interfere with any others.

Fundamental theorem of Finite Abelian groups

Products provide one way to create non-cyclic abelian groups — by creating a product of two or more cyclic groups. The fundamental theory of finite abelian groups is a result that tells us that *this is the only way* to produce non-cyclic abelian groups i.e.

All abelian groups are either cyclic or products of cyclic groups.

We can use this law to gain an intuitive understanding of what Abelian groups are, but also to test whether a given group can be broken down to a product of more elementary groups.

Color-mixing monoid as a product

To see how can we use this theorem, let's revisit our color mixing monoid that we saw earlier.



color-mixing group

As there doesn't exist a color that, when mixed with itself, can produce all other colors, the color-mixing monoid is *not cyclic*. However, the color mixing monoid *is abelian*. So according to the theorem of finite abelian groups (which is valid for monoids as well), the color-mixing monoid must be (isomorphic to) a product.

And it is not hard to find the monoids that form it — although there isn't one color that can produce all other colors, there are three colors that can do that — the prime colors. This observation leads us to the conclusion that the color-mixing monoid, can be represented as the product of three monoids, corresponding to the three primary colors.



color-mixing group as a product

You can think of each color monoid as a boolean monoid, having just two states (colored and not-colored).



Cyclic groups, forming the color-mixing group

Or alternatively, you can view it as having multiple states, representing the different levels of shading.



Color-shading cyclic group

In both cases, the monoid would be cyclic.

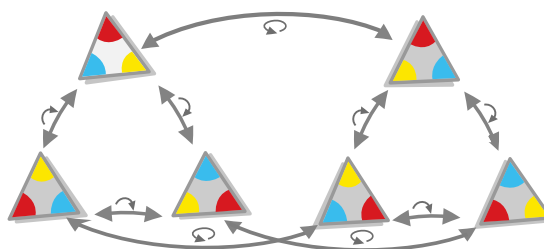
Dihedral groups

Now, let's finally examine a non-commutative group — the group of rotations *and reflections* of a given geometrical figure. It is the same as the last one, but here besides the rotation action that we already saw (and its composite actions), we have the action of flipping the figure vertically, an operation which results in its mirror image:



Reflection of a triangle

Those two operations and their composite results in a group called Dih_3 that is not abelian (and is furthermore the *smallest* non-abelian group).



The group of rotations and reflections in a triangle

Task 8: Prove that this group is indeed not abelian.

Task 9: Besides having two main actions, what is the defining factor that makes this and any other group non-abelian?

Groups that represent the set of rotations and reflections of any 2D shape are called *dihedral groups*.

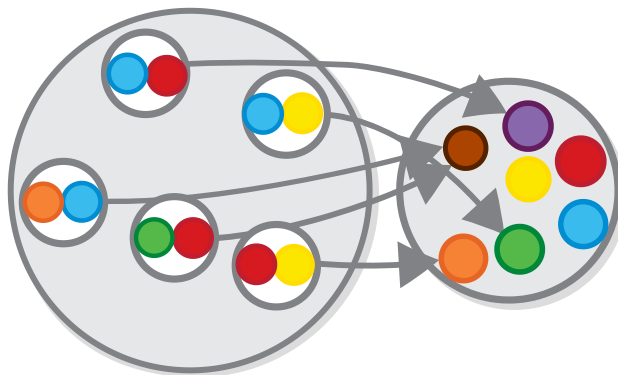
Groups/monoids categorically

Now it's the place for the grand reveal — *groups/monoids are categories*. More precisely, monoids are a *specific type of categories*, (and groups too).

This is not to say that the definition that we examined, where we describe them as sets and binary operations, is a lie. It just says that there is an alternative, categorical definition, which is equivalent to it. Let's dive in.

Monoid elements as objects

When we defined monoids, we presented their elements as *objects* and their operation — as a function/morphism that converts two objects into a third one. Then, we introduced a way for representing such operations using set theory — as functions that take a *pair* of elements from the monoid's set and return one other monoid element.



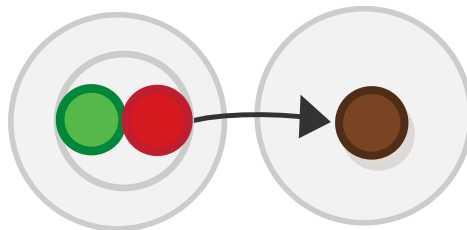
The color-mixing operation as a function

Under this correspondence, this specific mixing in the color-mixing monoid...



Monoid operation

...corresponds to this specific *point* in the above function (point, being a mapping of a specific element of the set).



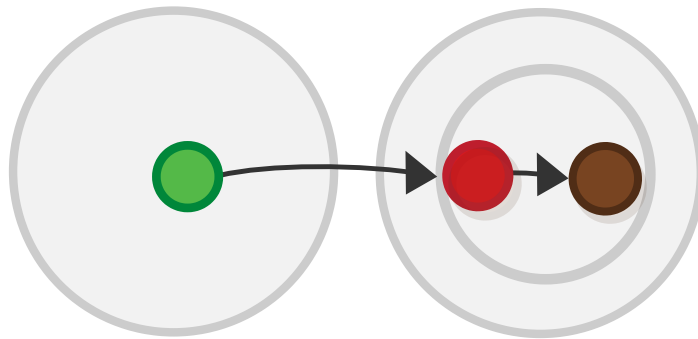
Monoid operations as functions from pair of objects to a third object: $(A \times B) \rightarrow C$

However, this is not the only way to represent multi-argument functions set-theoretically — there is another, equally interesting way, that doesn't rely on any data structures, but only on functions.

Monoid elements as morphisms

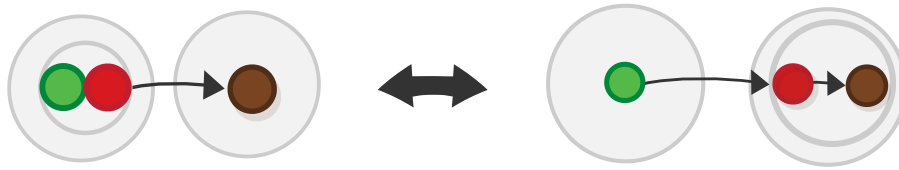
We saw that for some groups, like the groups of symmetries and rotations, the group elements can be understood not as objects but as *actions*. This is actually true for all other groups as well, e.g. the *red ball* in our color-blending monoid can be seen as the action of *adding the color red* to the mix, the number 2 in the monoid of addition can be seen as the operation $+ 2$ etc.

Formally, any function that takes a pair of objects, can be transformed to a function that takes one object and returns a *function* that takes the other one and returns the result.



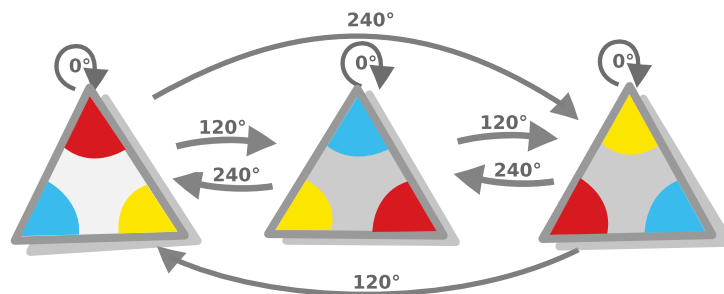
Monoid operations as functions $(A \times B) \rightarrow C = A \rightarrow B \rightarrow C$

This transformation is called *currying* in the name of Haskell Curry, although it was invented some years earlier by Moses Schönfinkel (*Schönfinkelisation* didn't stick out for some reason). So, Schönfinkel discovered that the following two expressions are isomorphic.



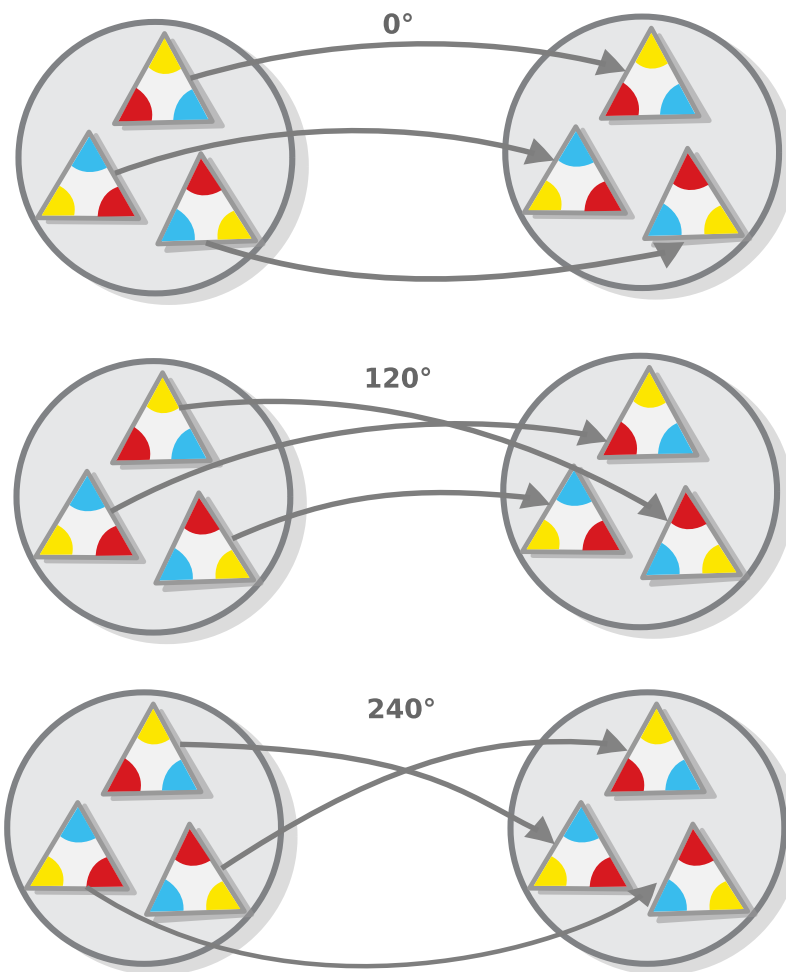
The equivalence of curried and uncurried functions

Let's take a step back and examine the groups/monoids that we covered so far in light of this equivalence e.g. let's examine the symmetric group Z_3 :



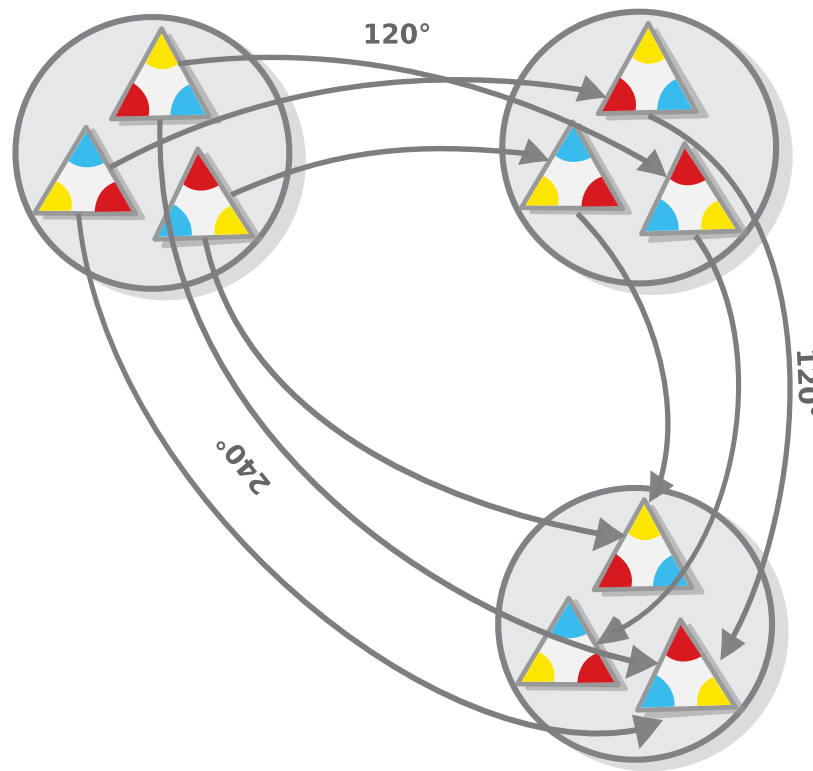
The group of rotations in a triangle - group notation

The elements of this group can be viewed as functions which take a figure and rotate it a given amount of degrees.



The group of rotations in a triangle - set notation

And, we can represent the group operation itself as functional composition.



The group of rotations in a triangle - set notation and normal notation

Formally, the 3 elements of Z_3 can be seen as 3 bijective (invertible) functions from a set of 3 elements to itself (in group-theoretic context, these kinds of functions are called *permutations*, by the way).

We can do the same for the addition monoid — numbers can be seen not as *quantities* (as in two apples, two oranges etc.), but as *operations*, (e.g. as the action of adding two to a given quantity).

Formally, the operation of the addition monoid, that we saw above has the following type signature.

$$+ : \mathbb{Z} \times \mathbb{Z} \rightarrow \mathbb{Z}$$

Because of the isomorphism we presented above, this function is equivalent to the following function.

$$+ : \mathbb{Z} \rightarrow (\mathbb{Z} \rightarrow \mathbb{Z})$$

When we apply an element of the monoid to that function (say 2), the result is the function $+ 2$ that adds 2 to a given number.

$$+ 2 : \mathbb{Z} \rightarrow \mathbb{Z}$$

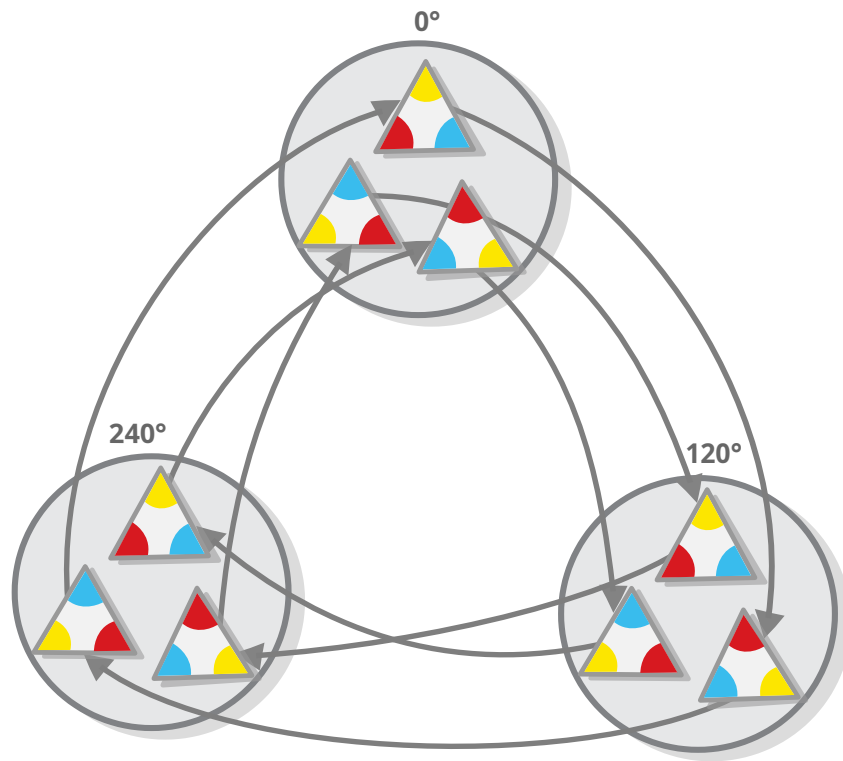
And because the monoid operation is always given in the context of a given monoid, we can view the element 2 and the function $+ 2$ as equivalent in the context of the monoid.

$$2 \cong + 2$$

In other words, in addition to representing the monoid elements in the set as *objects* that are combined using a function, we can represent them as *functions* themselves.

Monoid operations as functional composition

As we said, when monoid elements are represented as functions, the monoid operation is represented as functional composition. The functions that represent the monoid elements have the same set as source and target, or the same *signature*, as we say (formally, they are of the type $A \rightarrow A$ for some A). Because of that, they all can be composed with one another, and the result of such compositions would also have the same signature.



The group of rotations in a triangle - set notation

This is true for all monoids, e.g. number functions can also be combined using functional composition.

$$+ 2 \circ + 3 \cong + 5$$

So, basically, the functions that represent the elements of a monoid also form a monoid, under the operation of functional composition (and the functions that represent the elements that form a group also form a group).

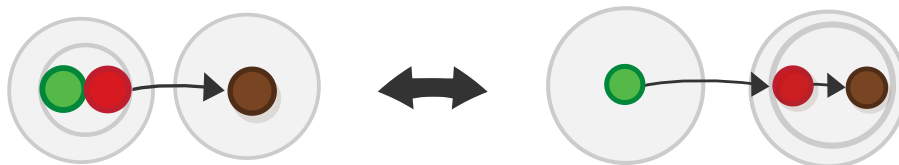
Task 10: Which are the identity elements of function groups?

Task 11: Show that the functions representing inverse group elements are also inverse.

Interlude: Currying

Take any function that accepts a pair of arguments of a given type (say A and B) and maps them into some result of type C , so $A \times B \rightarrow C$ (in the case of monoids, the signature would be $A \times A \rightarrow A$, as all monoid objects are of the same type).

Schönfinkel showed that for each such function, there exists a function that maps the first of the two arguments (i.e. from A) to *another function* that maps the second argument to the final result (i.e. $B \rightarrow C$). So $A \rightarrow (B \rightarrow C)$, and vice versa.



The equivalence of curried and uncurried functions

In programming, currying is achieved by a higher-order function. Here is how such a function might be implemented.

```
const curry = <A, B, C> (f:(a:A, b:B) => C) => (a:A) => (b:B) =>
```

And equally important is the opposite function, which maps a curried function to a multi-argument one, which is known as *uncurry*.

```
const uncurry = <A, B, C> (f:(a:A) => (b:B) => C) => (a:A, b:B)
```

There is a lot to say about these two functions, starting from the fact that their existence gives rise to an interesting relationship between the concept of a *product* and the concept of a *morphism* in category theory, called an *adjunction*. But we will cover this later. For now, we are interested in the fact the two function representations are isomorphic, formally $A \times B \rightarrow C \cong A \rightarrow B \rightarrow C$.

By the way, this isomorphism can be represented in terms of programming as well. It is equivalent to the statement that the following function always returns true for any arguments,

```
(...args) => uncurry(curry(f))(...args) === f(...args)
```

This is one part of the isomorphism, the other part is the equivalent function for curried functions.

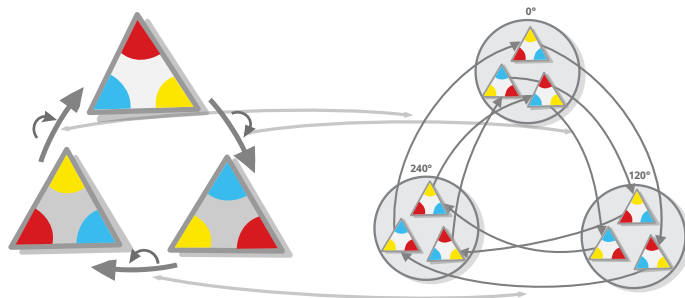
Task 12: Write the other part of the isomorphism.

Cayley's theorem

Once we learn how (using currying) to represent the elements of any monoid as permutations that also form a monoid, it isn't too surprising to learn that this constructed permutation monoid is isomorphic to the one from which it was constructed. This is a result known as the Cayley's theorem:

Any group is isomorphic to its corresponding permutation group.

Formally, if we use *Perm* to denote the permutation group then $Perm(A) \cong A$ for any *A*.



The group of rotations in a triangle — set notation and normal notation

Or in other words, representing the elements of a monoid/group as permutations actually yields a representation of the monoid itself (sometimes called its *standard representation*).

Cayley's theorem may not seem very impressive, but that only shows how influential it has been as a result (and how much we learned).

Interlude: Symmetric groups

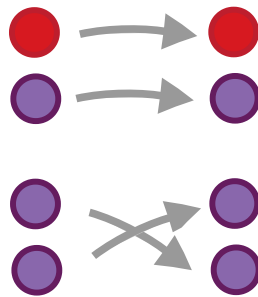
The first thing that you have to know about the symmetric groups is that they are *not the same thing as symmetry groups*. Once we have that out of the way, we can understand what they actually are: given a natural number n , the symmetric group of n , denoted S_n (symmetric group of degree n) is the group of all possible permutations of a set with n elements. The number of the elements of such groups is equal to $1 \times 2 \times 3 \dots \times n$ or $n!$ (n-factorial).

So, for example, the group S_1 of permutations of the one-element set has just 1 element (because a 1-element set has no other functions to itself other than the identity function).



The S_1 symmetric group

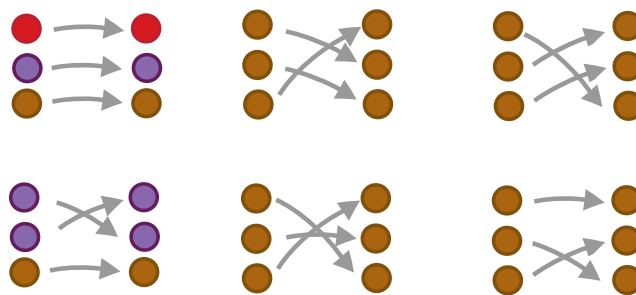
The group S_2 , has $1 \times 2 = 2$ elements, because there are two ways to arrange a set of two elements.



The S_2 symmetric group

(by the way, the colors are there to give you some intuition as to why the number of permutations of a n -element set is $n!$).

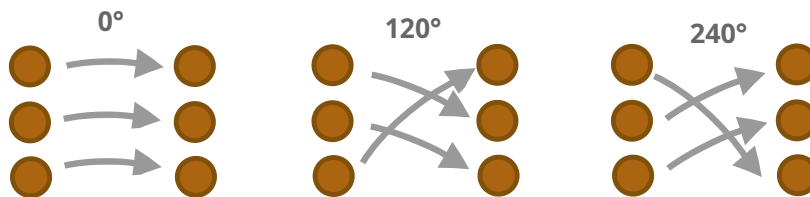
And with S_3 we are already feeling the power of exponential (and even faster than exponential!) growth of the factorial function — it has $1 \times 2 \times 3 = 6$ elements.



The S_3 symmetric group

Each symmetric group S_n contains all groups of order n — this is so because (as we saw in the prev section) every group with n elements is isomorphic to a set of permutations on the set of n elements and the group S_n contains *all such* permutations that exist.

Here are some examples: - S_1 is isomorphic to Z_1 , the *trivial group*, and S_2 is isomorphic to Z_2 , the *boolean group*, (but no other symmetric groups are isomorphic to cycle groups) - The top three permutations of S_3 are isomorphic to the group Z_3 .



The S_3 symmetric group

- S_3 is also isomorphic to Dih_3 (but no other symmetric group is isomorphic to a dihedral group)

Based on this insight, can state Cayley's theorem in terms of symmetric groups in the following way:

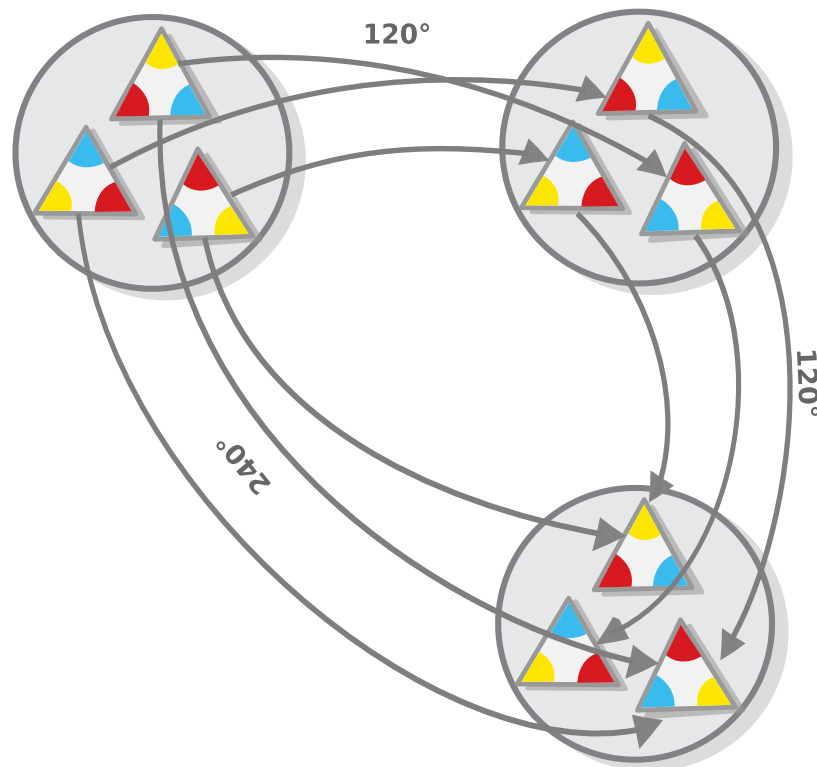
All groups are isomorphic to subgroups of symmetric groups.

Task 13: Show how the two are equivalent.

Fun fact: the study of group theory actually started by examining symmetric groups, so this theorem was actually a prerequisite for the emergence of the normal definition of groups that we all know and love (OK, at least *I* love it) — it provided a proof that the notion described by this definition is equivalent to the already existing notion of symmetric groups.

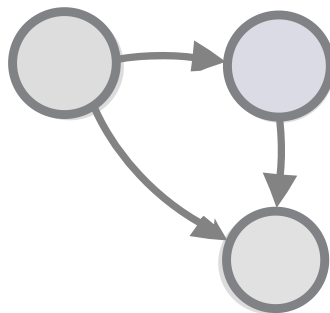
Monoids as categories

We saw that converting the monoid's elements to actions/functions yields an accurate representation of the monoid in terms of sets and functions.



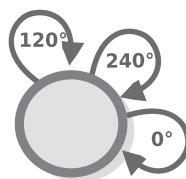
The group of rotations in a triangle - set notation and normal notation

However, it seems that the set part of the structure in this representation is kinda redundant — you have the same set everywhere — so, it would do good if we can simplify it. And we can do that by depicting it as an external (categorical) diagram, like this one.



The group of rotations in a triangle - categorical notation

But wait, if the monoids' underlying *sets* correspond to *objects* in category theory, then the corresponding category would have just one object. And so the correct representation would involve just one point from which all arrows come and to which they go.



The group of rotations in a triangle - categorical notation

The only difference between different monoids would be the number of morphisms that they have and the relationship between them.

The intuition behind this representation from a category-theoretic standpoint is encompassed by the law of *closure* that monoid and group operations have and that categories lack — it is the law stating that applying the operation (functional composition) on any two objects always yields the same object, e.g. no matter how you flip a triangle, you still get a triangle. As Tom Lehrer sings, “Try as you may, you just can’t get away from mathematics”. In the case of monoids, we can’t get away from the object.

Categories Monoids Groups			
Associativity	X	X	X
Identity	X	X	X
Invertibility			X
Closure	X	X	X

When we view a monoid as a category, this law says that all morphisms in the category should be from one object to itself - a monoid, any monoid, can be seen as a *category with one object*. The converse is also true: any category with one object can be seen as a monoid.

Let’s elaborate on this thought by reviewing the definition of a category from chapter 2.

A category is a collection of *objects* (we can think of them as points) and *morphisms* (arrows) that go from one object to another, where: 1. Each object has to have an identity

morphism. 2. There should be a way to compose two morphisms with an appropriate type signature into a third one in a way that is associative.

Aside from the little-confusing fact that *monoid objects are morphisms* when viewed categorically, this describes exactly what monoids are.

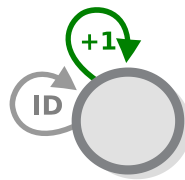
Categories have an identity morphism for each object, so for categories with just one object, there should also be exactly one identity morphism. And monoids do have an identity object, which when viewed categorically corresponds to that identity morphism.

Categories provide a way to compose two morphisms with an appropriate type signature, and for categories with one object, this means that *all morphisms should be composable* with one another. And the monoid operation does exactly that — given any two objects (or two morphisms, if we use the categorical terminology), it creates a third.

Philosophically, defining a monoid as a one-object category corresponds to the view of monoids as a model of how a set of (associative) actions that are performed on a given object alter its state. Provided that the object's state is determined solely by the actions that are performed on it, we can leave it out of the equation and concentrate on how the actions are combined. And as per usual, the actions (and elements) can be anything, from mixing colors, to adding quantities to a given set of things etc.

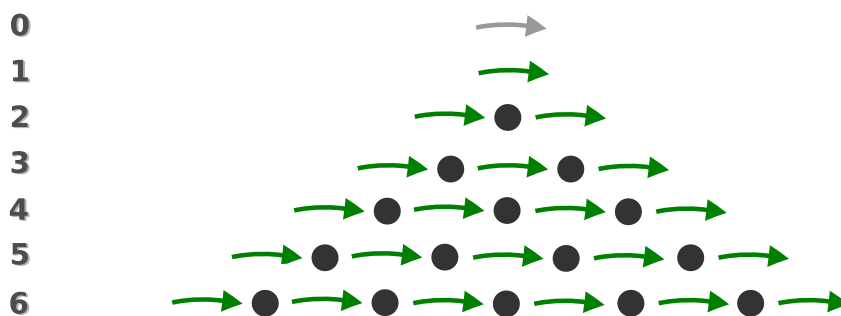
Group/monoid presentations

When we view cyclic groups/monoids as categories, we would see that they correspond to categories that (besides having just one object) also have *just one morphism* (which, as we said, is called a *generator*) along with the morphisms that are created when this morphism is composed with itself. In fact, the infinite cyclic monoid (which is isomorphic to the natural numbers), can be completely described by this simple definition.



Presentation of an infinite cyclic monoid

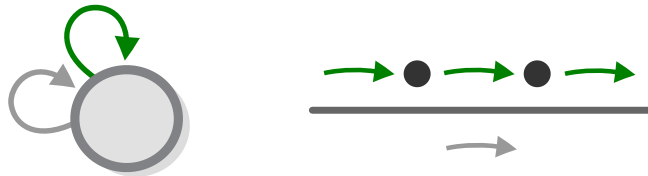
This is so because applying the generator again and again yields all elements of the infinite cyclic group. Specifically, if we view the generator as the action $+1$ then we get the natural numbers.



Presentation of an infinite cyclic monoid

Finite cyclic groups/monoids are the same, except that their definition contains an additional law, stating that that once you compose the generator with itself n number of times, you get

identity morphism. For the cyclic group Z_3 (which can be visualized as the group of triangle rotations), this law states that composing the generator with itself 3 times yields the identity morphism.



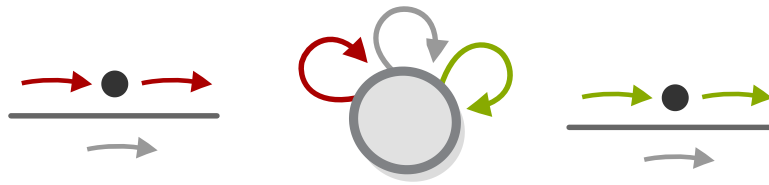
Presentation of a finite cyclic monoid

Composing the group generator with itself, and then applying the law, yields the three morphisms of Z_3 .



Presentation of a finite cyclic monoid

We can represent product groups this way too. Let's take Klein four-group as an example. The Klein four-group has two generators that it inherits from the groups that form it (which we considered as vertical and horizontal rotation of a non-square rectangle) each of which comes with one law.



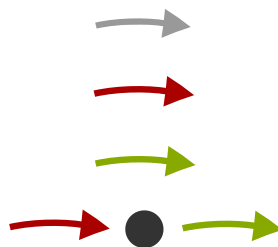
Presentation of Klein four

To make the representation complete, we add the law for combining the two generators.



Presentation of Klein four - third law

And then, if we start applying the two generators and follow the laws, we get the four elements.



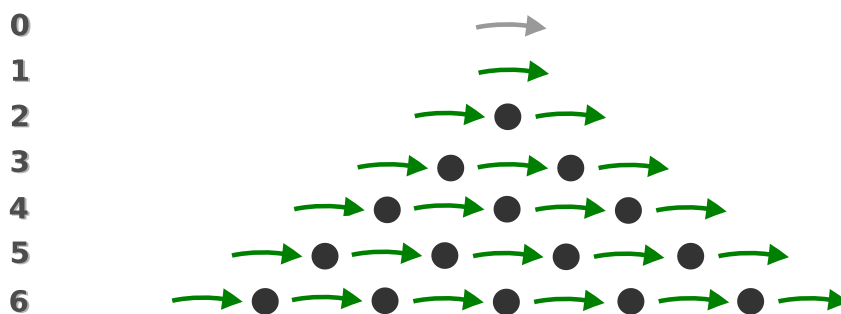
The elements of Klein four

The set of generators and laws that defines a given group is called the *presentation of a group*. Every group has a presentation.

Free monoids

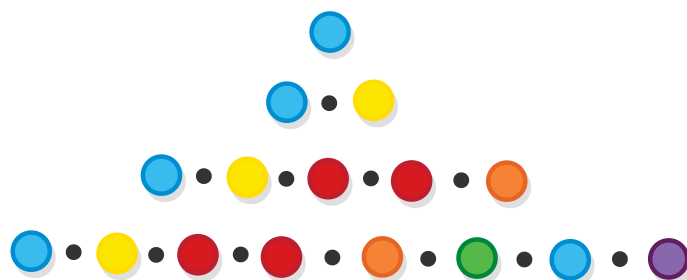
We saw how picking a different selection of laws gives rise to various types of monoids. But what monoids would we get if we pick no laws at all? These monoids (we get a different one depending on the set we pick) are called *free monoids*. The word “free” is used in the sense that once you have the set, you can upgrade it to a monoid for free (i.e. without having to define anything else).

If you revisit the previous section you will notice that we already saw one such monoid. The free monoid with just one generator is isomorphic to the monoid of natural numbers.



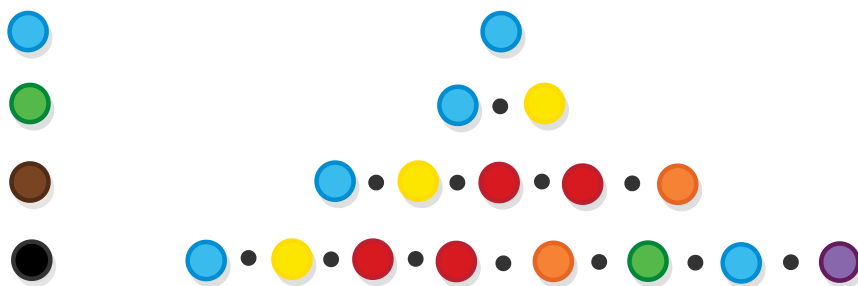
The free monoid with one generator

We can make a free monoid from the set of colorful balls — the monoid’s elements would be sequences of all possible combinations of the balls.



The free monoid with the set of balls as a generators

The free monoid is a special one — each element of the free monoid over a given set can be converted to a corresponding element in any other monoid that uses the same set of generators by just applying the monoid's laws. For example, here is how the elements above would look if we apply the laws of the color-mixing monoid.



Converting the elements of the free monoid to the elements of the color-mixing monoid

Task 14: Write up the laws of the color-mixing monoid.

If we put on our programmers' hat, we will see that the type of the free monoid under the set of generators T (which we can denote as `FreeMonoid<T>`) is isomorphic to the type `List<T>` (or `Array<T>`, if you prefer) and that the intuition behind the special property that we described above is actually very simple: keeping objects in a list allows you to convert them to any other structure i.e. when we want to perform some manipulation on a bunch of objects, but we don't know exactly what this manipulation is, we just keep a list of those objects until it's time to do it.

While the intuition behind free monoids seems simple enough, the formal definition is not easily written... yet, simply because

we have to cover more stuff.

We understand that being the most general of all monoids for a given set of generators, a free monoid can be converted to all of them. i.e. there exists a function from it to all of them. But what kind of function would that be? Tune in after a few chapters to find out.

Answers

Task 1: Which are the identity elements of those monoids?

For the monoid of natural numbers under addition, it is zero: $n + 0 = n$ and $0 + n = n$.

For the monoid of natural numbers under *multiplication* — 1: $n \times 1 = n$ and $1 \times n = n$

Task 2: Go through other mathematical operations and verify that they are monoidal.

Here are some monoids:

All (finite) strings under *string concatenation* (+), with the empty string as identity: - Associative: $(a + b) + c == a + (b + c)$ - Identity: $s + "" == "" + s = s$

All natural numbers under the *maximum* function, with 0 as identity: - Associative: $\max(\max(a, b), c) == \max(a, \max(b, c))$ - Identity: $\max(a, 0) = a$

All $n \times n$ matrices, under *matrix multiplication*, with the identity matrix - Associative: $(AB)C = A(BC)$ - Identity: $AI = IA = A$

Task 3: The natural numbers form a monoid under multiplication, but not a group. Find out why.

Because they lack *inverses*.

Numbers do have multiplicative inverses, but they are fractions, thus not natural e.g. the inverse of 2 is $1/2$.

Real numbers also don't have inverses for all numbers (which one is missing?).

Task 4: Prove that **AND** $\wedge$ is associative by expanding the formula $(A \wedge B) \wedge C = A \wedge (B \wedge C)$ with all possible values.

We can prove this by drawing what we call a *truth table* (more info in the next chapter).

A	B	C	$A \wedge B$	$(A \wedge B) \wedge C$	$B \wedge C$	$A \wedge (B \wedge C)$
T	T	T	T	T	T	T
T	T	F	F	F	F	F
T	F	T	F	F	F	F
T	F	F	F	F	F	F
F	T	T	F	F	T	F
F	T	F	F	F	F	F
F	F	T	F	F	F	F
F	F	F	F	F	F	F

Task 5: Which are the identity elements of the AND and OR operations?

For **AND** operation the identity element is *True*, for **OR**, it is *False*.

Task 6: Show that there are no other groups with 3 objects, other than Z_3 .

Take any group with 3 elements $\{e, a, b\}$ where e is identity.

In such a group, we necessary have

$$a \circ b = e$$

and

$$b \circ a = e$$

Why? $a \circ b$ cannot be equal to a , as that would make b the identity element, $b = e$ (and the group would really be $\{e, a\}$), and it cannot be equal to b , as it would make a identity.

In other words, a and b are each other's inverses.

Therefore, we must also have

$$a \circ a = b$$

and

$$b \circ b = a$$

Why? $a \circ a$ cannot be equal to e as that would mean $a = e$. And it cannot be equal to a , as that would mean a is it's own inverse, and we established that it's inverse is b . Same for $b \circ b$.

So, we already established the result of applying the operation of any element of our group with any other, and we can conclude that our group is isomorphic to Z_3 .

Furthermore, we did this without assuming anything about this group other than that it has three elements. So, every group with three elements, is (as our example group) isomorphic to Z_3 .

Task 7: Show that the two representations [of Klein four-group] are isomorphic.

This is a nice exercise in relating spatial intuition to computation.

A non-square rectangle has two independent ways it can be rotated, while keeping the symmetry – horizontal and vertical (let's annotate them H and V).

For each of these two ways, there are two positions in which the figure can be, let's call them "normal" and "flipped". Let's annotated them 0 and 1. So, we have:

$$H = \{0, 1\}$$

$$V = \{0, 1\}$$

The position of the figure is composed of two pieces of information, whether it is flipped horizontally or not, or whether it is flipped vertically, i.e. its state is the cartesian product of H and V .

$$H \times V = \{(0,0), (0,1), (1,0), (1,1)\}$$

It's not hard to see that if we add the standard product group operation to this product set, we will get the Klein four-group.

Task 8: Prove that the group $[Dih_3]$ is indeed not abelian.

The proof entails providing a counterexample, which is easy: if r is the 120° rotation and f is the reflection over a vertical axis, we have. $f \circ r \neq r \circ f$

Task 9: Besides having two main actions, what is the defining factor that makes this and any other group non-abelian?

The defining factor is that *the actions don't commute*. $a \circ b \neq b \circ a$

i.e. the actions must be somehow interdependent with one another (one changes the state of the other) e.g. if we flip a figure horizontally, then rotating it would make it go in a different direction that if it wasn't flipped (as opposed to the figure in the Klein four-group, in which the horizontal and vertical reflections are independent of one another).

Task 10: Which are the identity elements of function groups?

No catch here, the identity element is the identity function.

Task 11: Show that the functions representing inverse group elements are also inverse.

Combining a group element with it's inverse would result in the identity element:

$$1 + (-1) = 0$$

This equation also holds for their corresponding functions:

$$+1 \circ -1 = +0$$

Task 12: Write the other part of the [currying] isomorphism.

```
// First part (given)
const curry = <A, B, C>(f: (a: A, b: B) => C) =>
  (a: A) => (b: B) => f(a, b)

// Second part (other direction)
const uncurry = <A, B, C>(f: (a: A) => (b: B) => C) =>
  (a: A, b: B) => f(a)(b)

// The isomorphism property:
// For all f: (a: A, b: B) => C, we have uncurry(curry(f)) = f
// For all g: (a: A) => (b: B) => C, we have curry(uncurry(g)) =
```

Task 13: Show how the two [Cayley's theorem formulations] are equivalent.

The two formulations are: 1. "Any group is isomorphic to its corresponding permutation group" 2. "All groups are isomorphic to subgroups of symmetric groups"

They are equivalent, because the permutation group is a subgroup of a symmetric group:

1. The symmetric group with a given number of elements is the group of *all* permutations of that number of elements.
2. A permutation group with a given number of elements is a group that contains *some* permutations of that number of elements.

So, we can get any permutation group of a given order if we remove some elements from the symmetric group of that order. e.g. the 3 permutations that form Z_3 , the group of rotations of a

triangle, can be found amongst the 6 permutations that form S_3 the symmetry group of order 3.

Task 14: Write up the laws of the color-mixing monoid.

Our generators are the primary colors — *Red*, *Yellow* and *Blue*

And from the picture, we know that:

- $Blue \circ Yellow = Green$
- $Yellow \circ Red = Orange$
- $Blue \circ Yellow \circ Red = Brown$

etc.

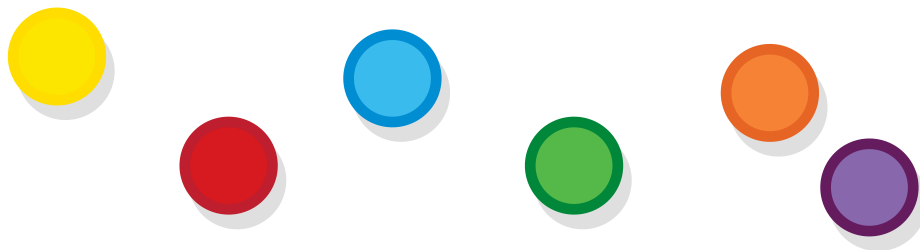
Orders

Given a set of objects, there can be numerous criteria, based on which to order them (depending on the objects themselves) — size, weight, age, alphabetical order etc.

However, currently we are not interested in the *criteria* that we can use to order objects, but in the *nature of the relationships* that define order. Of which there can be several types as well.

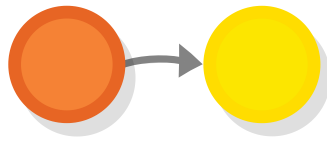
Mathematically, the order as a construct is represented (much like a monoid) by two components.

One is a *set of things* (e.g. colorful balls) which we sometimes call the order's *underlying set*.



Balls

And the other is a *binary relation* between these things, which are often represented as arrows.

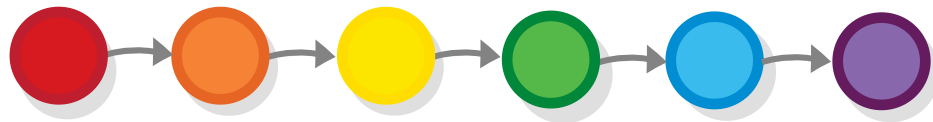


Binary relation

Not all binary relationships are orders — only ones that fit certain criteria that we are going to examine as we review the different types of order.

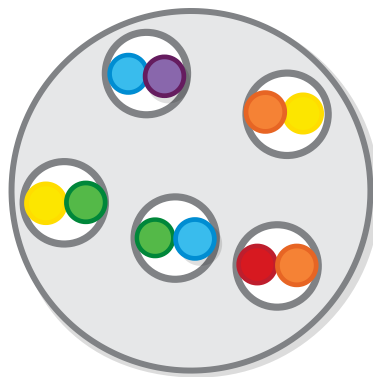
Linear order

Let's start with an example — the most straightforward type of order that you think of is *linear order* i.e. one in which every object has its place depending on every other object. In this case the ordering criteria is completely deterministic and leaves no room for ambiguity in terms of which element comes before which. For example, order of colors, sorted by the length of their light-waves (or by how they appear in the rainbow).



Linear order

Using set theory, we can represent this order, as well as any other order, as a cartesian products of the order's underlying set with itself.



Binary relation as a product

And in programming, orders are defined by providing a function which, given two objects, tells us which one of them is “bigger” (comes first) and which one is “smaller”. It isn’t hard to see that this function is actually a definition of a cartesian product.

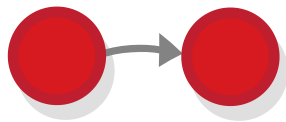
```
[1, 3, 2].sort((a, b) => {  
  if (a > b) {  
    return true  
  } else {  
    return false  
  }  
})
```

However (this is where it gets interesting) not all such functions (and not all cartesian products) define orders. To really define an order (e.g. give the same output every time, independent of how the objects were shuffled initially), functions have to obey several rules.

Incidentally, (or rather not incidentally at all), these rules are nearly equivalent to the mathematical laws that define the criteria of the order relationship i.e. those are the rules that define which element can point to which. Let’s review them.

Reflexivity

Let’s get the most boring law out of the way — each object has to be bigger or equal to itself, or $a \leq a$ for all a (the relationship between elements in an order is commonly denoted as $\leq$ in formulas, but it can also be represented with an arrow from first object to the second.)



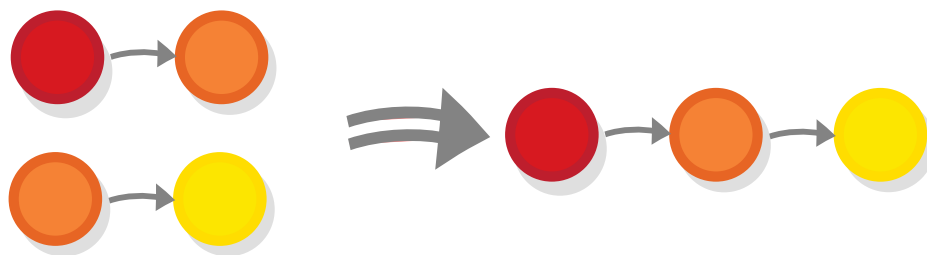
Reflexivity

There is no special reason for this law to exist, except that the “base case” should be covered somehow.

We can formulate it the opposite way too and say that each object should *not* have the relationship to itself, in which case we would have a relation than resembles *bigger than*, as opposed to *bigger or equal to* and a slightly different type of order, sometimes called a *strict* order.

Transitivity

The second law is maybe the least obvious, (but probably the most essential) — it states that if object a is bigger than object b , it is automatically bigger than all objects that are smaller than b or $a \leq b \wedge b \leq c \rightarrow a \leq c$.

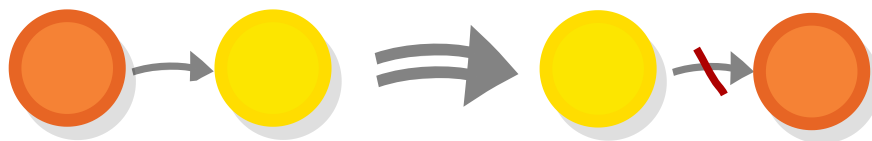


Transitivity

This is the law that to a large extent defines what an order is: if I am better at playing soccer than my grandmother, then I would also be better at it than my grandmother's friend, whom she beats, otherwise I wouldn't really be better than her.

Antisymmetry

The third law is called antisymmetry. It states that the function that defines the order should not give contradictory results (or in other words you have $x \leq y$ and $y \leq x$ only if $x = y$).



antisymmetry

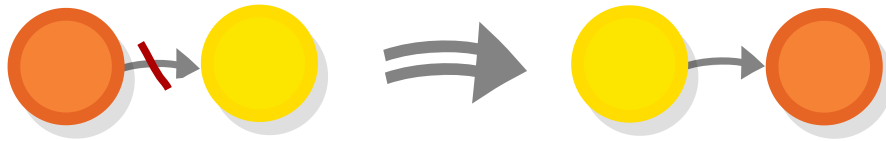
It also means that no ties are permitted — either I am better than my grandmother at soccer or she is better at it than me.

Totality

The last law is called *totality* (or *connexity*) and it mandates that all elements that belong to the order should be *comparable* ($a \leq b \vee b \leq a$). That is, for any two elements, one would always be “bigger” than the other.

By the way, this law makes the reflexivity law redundant, as reflexivity is just a special case of totality when a and b are one

and the same object, but I still want to present it for reasons that will become apparent soon.



connexity

Actually, here are the reasons: this law does not look so “set in stone” as the rest of them i.e. we can probably think of some situations in which it does not apply. For example, if we aim to order all people based on soccer skills there are many ways in which we can rank a person compared to their friends their friend’s friends etc. but there isn’t a way to order groups of people who never played with one another.

Orders, like the order people based on their soccer skills, that don’t follow the totality law are called *partial orders*, (and linear orders are also called *total orders*.)

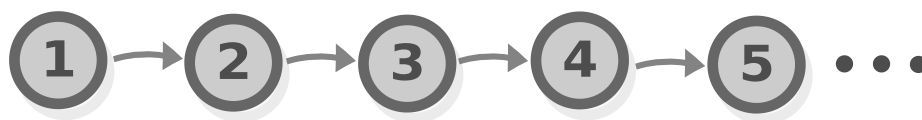
Task 1: Previously, we covered a relation that is pretty similar to this. Do you remember it? What is the difference?

Task 2: Think about some orders that you know about and figure out whether they are partial or total.

Partial orders are actually much more interesting than linear/total orders. But before we dive into them, let’s say a few things about numbers.

The order of natural numbers

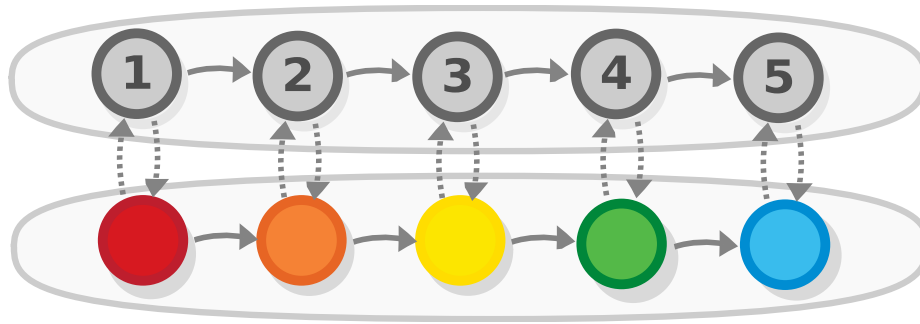
Natural numbers form a linear order under the operation *bigger or equal to* (the symbol of which we have been using in our formulas.)



numbers

In many ways, numbers are the quintessential order — every finite order of objects is isomorphic to a subset of the order of numbers, as we can map the first element of any order to the number 1, the second one to the number 2 etc (and we can do the opposite operation as well).

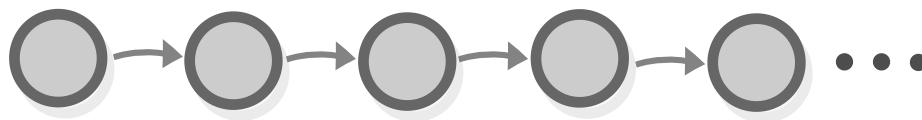
If we think about it, this isomorphism is actually closer to the everyday notion of a linear order, than the one defined by the laws — when most people think of order, they aren't thinking of a *transitive*, *antisymmetric* and *total* relation, but are rather thinking about criteria based on which they can decide which object comes first, which comes second etc. So it's important to notice that the two are equivalent.



Linear order isomorphisms

From the fact that any finite order of objects is isomorphic to the natural numbers, it also follows that all linear orders of the same magnitude are isomorphic to one another.

So, the linear order is simple, but it is also (and I think that this isomorphism proves it) the most *boring* order ever, especially when looked from a category-theoretic viewpoint — all finite linear orders (and most infinite ones) are just isomorphic to the natural numbers and so all of their diagrams look the same way.



Linear order (general)

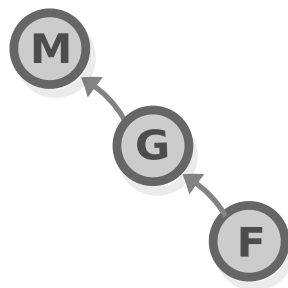
However, this is not the case with partial orders that we will look into next.

Partial order

Like a linear order, a partial order consists of a set plus a relation, with the only difference that, although it still obeys the *reflexive*, *transitive* and the *antisymmetric* laws, the relation does not obey the law of *totality*, that is, not all of the sets elements are necessarily ordered. I say “necessarily” because even if all elements are ordered, it is still a partial order (just as a group is still a monoid) — all linear orders are also partial orders, but not the other way around. We can even create an *order of orders*, based on which is more general.

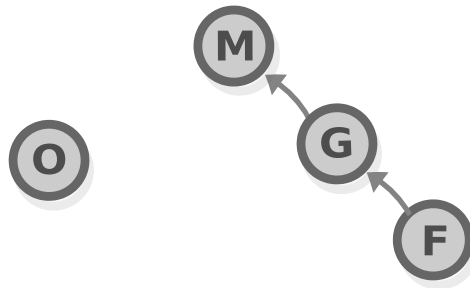
Partial orders are also related to the concept of an *equivalence relations* that we covered in chapter 1, except that *symmetry* law is replaced with *antisymmetry*.

If we revisit the example of the soccer players rank list, we can see that the first version that includes just **m**yself, my **g**randmother and her **f**riend is a linear order.



Linear soccer player order

However, including this **o**ther person whom none of us played yet, makes the hierarchy non-linear i.e. a partial order.

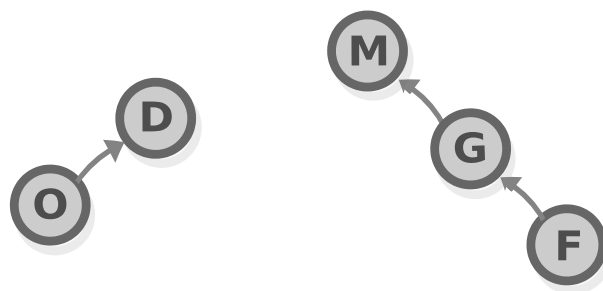


Soccer player order - leftover element

This is the main difference between partial and total orders — partial orders cannot provide us with a definite answer of the question who is better than who. But sometimes this is what we need — in sports, as well as in other domains, there isn't always an appropriate way to rate people linearly.

Chains

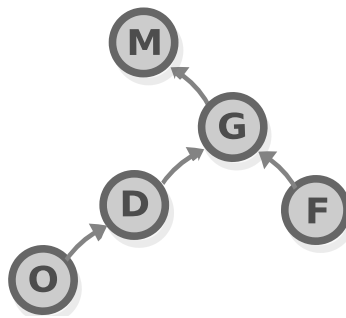
Before, we said that all linear orders can be represented by the same chain-like diagram, we can reverse this statement and say that all diagrams that look something different than the said diagram represent partial orders. An example of this is a partial order that contains a bunch of linearly-ordered subsets, e.g. in our soccer example we can have separate groups of friends who play together and are ranked with each other, but not with anyone from other groups.



Soccer order - two hierarchies

The different linear orders that make up the partial order are called *chains*. There are two chains in this diagram $m \rightarrow g \rightarrow f$ and $d \rightarrow o$.

The chains in an order don't have to be completely disconnected from each other in order for it to be partial. They can be connected as long as the connections are not all *one-to-one* i.e. ones when the last element from one chain is connected to the first element of the other one (this would effectively unite them into one chain.)



Soccer order - two hierarchies and a join

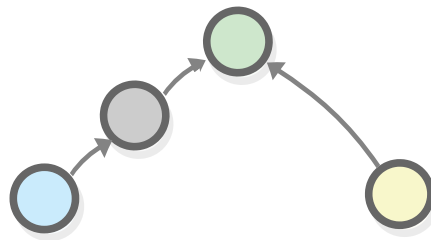
The above set is not linearly-ordered. This is because, although we know that $d \leq g$ and that $f \leq g$, the relationship between d and f is *not* known — any element can be bigger than the other one.

Greatest and least objects

Although partial orders don't give us a definitive answer to "Who is better than who?", some of them still can give us an answer to the more important question (in sports, as well as in other domains), namely "Who is number one?" i.e. who is the

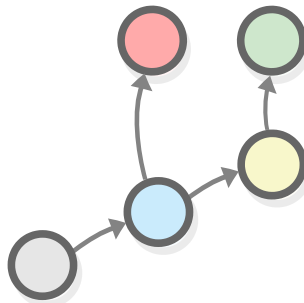
champion, the player who is better than anyone else. Or, more generally, the element that is bigger than all other elements.

We call such element the *greatest element*. Some (not all) partial orders do have such element — in our last diagram m is the greatest element, in this diagram, the green element is the biggest one.



Join diagram with one more element

Sometimes we have more than one elements that are bigger than all other elements, in this case none of them is the greatest.

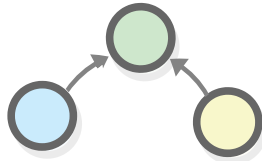


A diagram with no greatest element

In addition to the greatest element, a partial order may also have a least (smallest) element, which is defined in the same way.

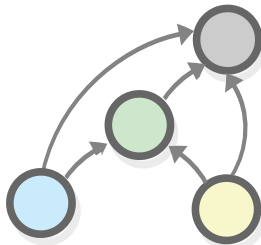
Joins

The *least upper bound* of two elements that are connected as part of an order is called the *join* of these elements, e.g. the green element is a join of the other two.



Join

There can be multiple elements bigger than a and b (all elements that are bigger than c are also bigger than a and b), but only one of them is a join. Formally, the join of a and b is defined as the smallest element that is bigger than both a and b (i.e. smallest c for which $a \leq c$, and $b \leq c$.)

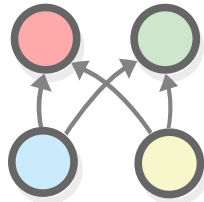


Join with other elements

Given any two elements in which one is bigger than the other (e.g. $a \leq b$), the join is the bigger element (in this case b).

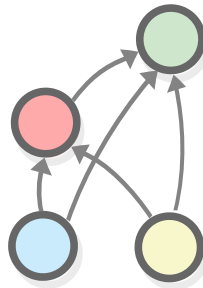
In a linear orders, the *join* of any two elements is just the bigger element.

Like with the greatest element, if two elements have several upper bounds that are equally big, then none of them is a *join* (a join must be unique).



A non-join diagram

If, however, one of those elements is established as smaller than the rest of them, it immediately qualifies.

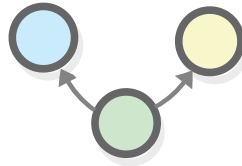


A join diagram

Task 3: Which concept in category theory reminds you of joins?

Meets

Given two elements, the biggest element that is smaller than both of them is called the *meet* of these elements.



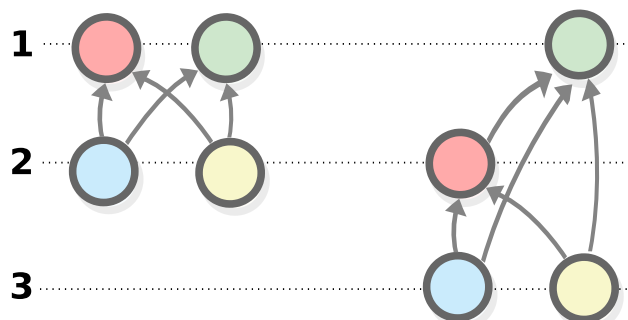
Meet

The same rules as for the joins apply.

Hasse diagrams

The diagrams that we use in this section are called “Hasse diagrams” and they work much like our usual diagrams, however they have an additional rule that is followed — “bigger” elements are always positioned above smaller ones.

In terms of arrows, the rule means that if you add an arrow to a point, the point *to* which the arrow points must always be above the one *from* which it points.



A join diagram

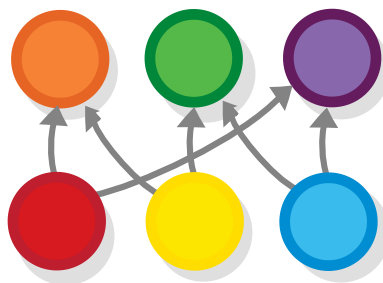
This arrangement allows us to compare any two points by just seeing which one is above the other e.g. we can determine the

join of two elements, by just identifying the elements that they connect to and see which one is lowest.

Color order

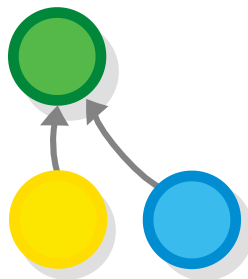
We all know many examples of total orders (any form of chart or ranking is a total order), but there are probably not so many obvious examples of partial orders that we can think of off the top of our head. So let's see some. This will give us some context, and will help us understand what joins are.

To stay true to our form, let's revisit our color-mixing monoid and create a *color-mixing partial order* in which all colors point to colors that contain them.



A color mixing poset

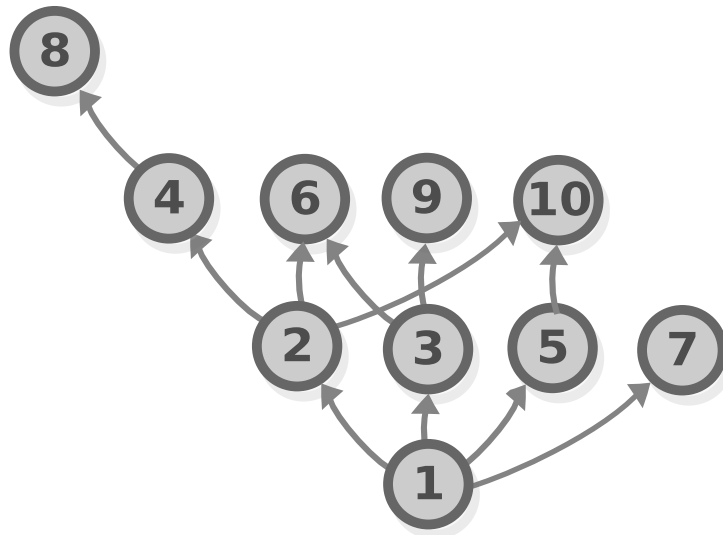
If you go through it, you will notice that the join of any two colors is the color that they make up when mixed. Nice, right?



Join in a color mixing poset

Numbers by division

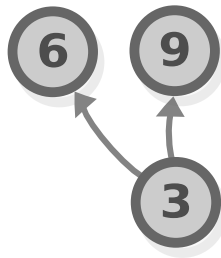
We saw that when we order numbers by “bigger or equal to”, they form a linear order (*the* linear order even.) But numbers can also form a partial order, for example they form a partial order if we order them by which divides which, i.e. if a divides b , then a is before b e.g. because $2 \times 5 = 10$, 2 and 5 come before 10 (but 3, for example, does not come before 10.)



Divides poset

And it so happens (actually for very good reason) that the join operation again corresponds to an operation that is relevant in the context of the objects — the join of two numbers in this partial order is their *least common multiple*.

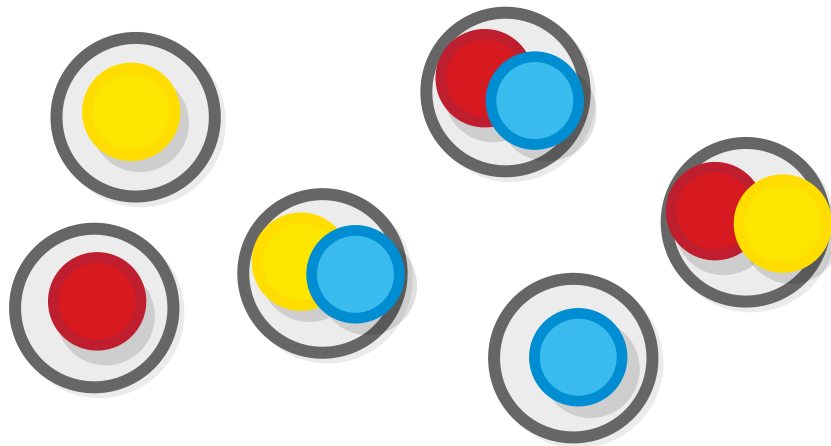
And the *meet* (the opposite of join) of two numbers is their *greatest common divisor*.



Divides poset

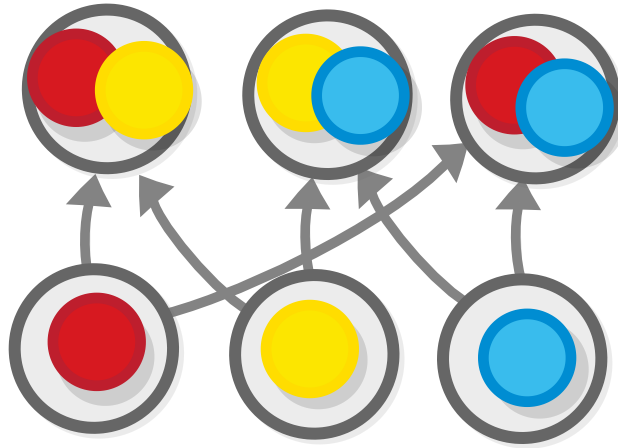
Inclusion order

Given a collection of all possible sets containing a combination of a given set of elements...



A color mixing poset, ordered by inclusion

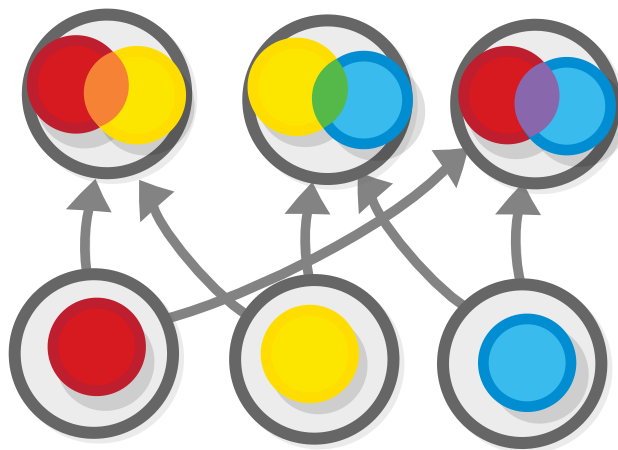
...we can define what is called the *inclusion order* of those sets, in which a comes before b if a *includes* b , or in other words if b is a *subset* of a .



A color mixing poset, ordered by inclusion

In this case the *join* operation of two sets is their *union*, and the *meet* operation is their set *intersection*.

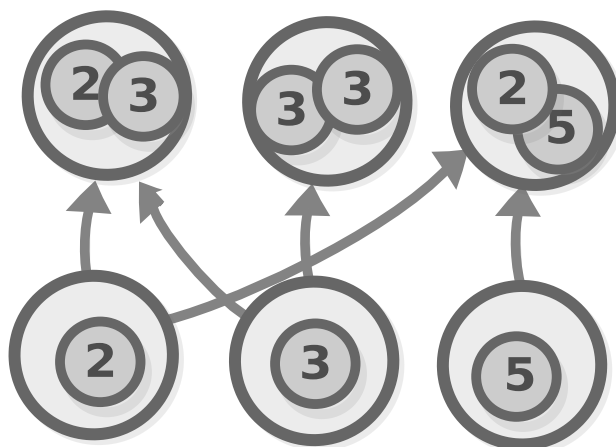
This diagram might remind you of something — if we take the colors that are contained in each set and mix them into one color, we get the color-blending partial order that we saw earlier.



A color mixing poset, ordered by inclusion

The order example with the number dividers is also isomorphic to an inclusion order, namely the inclusion order of all possible sets of *prime* numbers, including repeating ones (or alternatively

the set of all *prime powers*). This is confirmed by the fundamental theory of arithmetic, which states that every number can be written as a product of primes in exactly one way.



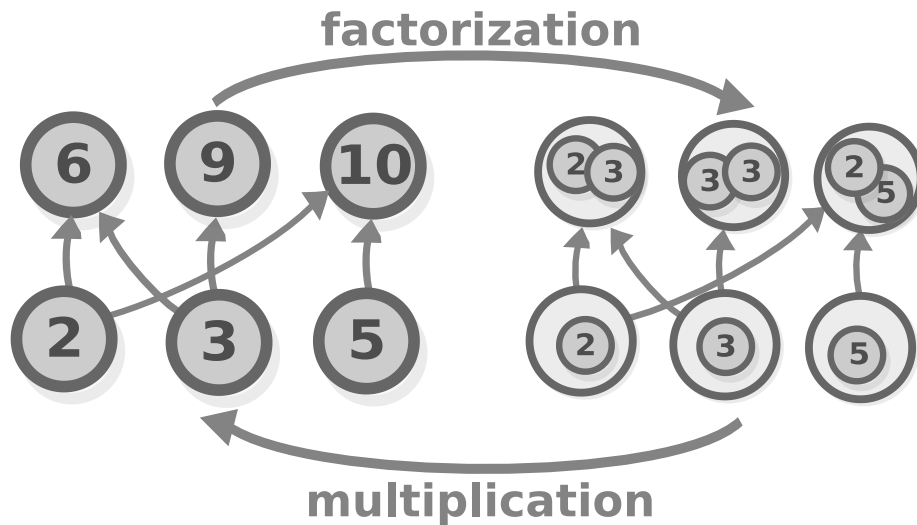
Divides poset

Order isomorphisms

We mentioned order isomorphisms several times already so this is about time to elaborate on what they are. Take the isomorphism between the number partial order and the prime inclusion order as an example. Like an isomorphism between any two sets, it is comprised of two functions:

- One function from the prime inclusion order, to the number order (which in this case is just the *multiplication* of all the elements in the set)
- One function from the number order to the prime inclusion order (which is an operation called *prime factorization* of a

number, consisting of finding the set of prime numbers that result in that number when multiplied with one another).



Divides poset

An order isomorphism is essentially an isomorphism between the orders' underlying sets (invertible function). However, besides their underlying sets, orders also have the arrows that connect them, so there is one more condition: in order for an invertible function to constitute an order isomorphism, it has to *respect those arrows*, in other words it should be *order preserving*. More specifically, applying this function (let's call it F) to any two elements in one set (a and b) should result in two elements that have the same corresponding order in the other set (so $a \leq b$ if and only if $F(a) \leq F(b)$). Birkhoff's representation theorem —

So far, we saw two different partial orders, one based on color mixing, and one based on number division, that can be represented by the inclusion orders of all possible combinations of sets of some *basic elements* (the primary colors in the first

case, and the prime numbers (or prime powers) in the second one.) Many other partial orders can be defined in this way. Which ones exactly, is a question that is answered by an amazing result called *Birkhoff's representation theorem*. They are the *finite* partial orders that meet the following two criteria:

1. All elements have *joins* and *meets*.
2. Those *meet* and *join* operations *distribute* over one another, that is if we denote joins as meets as $\vee$ or $\wedge$, then $x \vee (y \wedge z) = (x \vee y) \wedge (x \vee z)$.

The partial orders that meet the first criteria are called *lattices*. The ones that meet the second one are called distributive lattices.

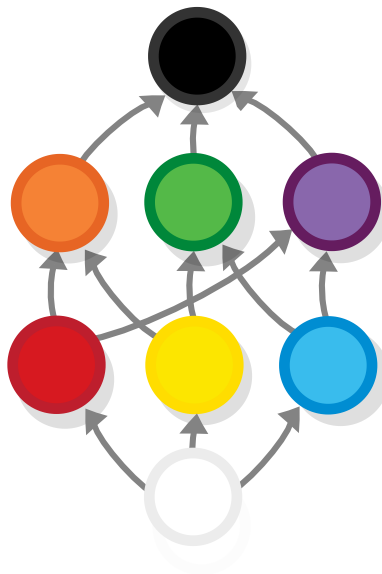
And the “prime” elements which we use to construct the inclusion order are the elements that are not the *join* of any other elements. They are also called *join-irreducible* elements.

By the way, the partial orders that are *not* distributive lattices are also isomorphic to inclusion orders, it is just that they are isomorphic to inclusion orders that *do not contain all possible combinations* of elements.

Lattices

We will now review the orders for which Birkhoff's theorem applies i.e. the *lattices*. Lattices are partial orders, in which every two elements have a *join* and a *meet*. So every lattice is also partial order, but not every partial order is a lattice (we will see even more members of this hierarchy).

Most partial orders that are created based on some sort of rule are distributive lattices, like for example the partial orders from the previous section are also distributive lattices when they are drawn in full, for example the color-mixing order.



A color mixing lattice

Notice that we added the black ball at the top and the white one at the bottom. We did that because otherwise the top three elements wouldn't have a *join* element, and the bottom three wouldn't have a *meet*.

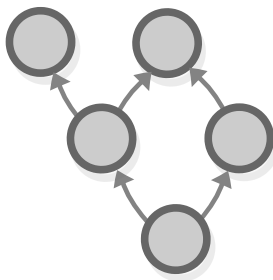
Bounded lattices

Our color-mixing lattice, has a *greatest element* (the black ball) and a *least element* (the white one). Lattices that have a least and greatest elements are called *bounded lattices*. It isn't hard to see that all finite lattices are also bounded.

Task 4: Prove that all finite lattices are bounded.

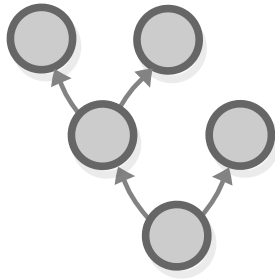
Interlude — semilattices and trees

Lattices are partial orders that have both *join* and *meet* for each pair of elements. Partial orders that just have *join* (and no *meet*), or just have *meet* and no *join* are called *semilattices*. More specifically, partial orders that have *meet* for every pair of elements are called *meet-semilattices*.



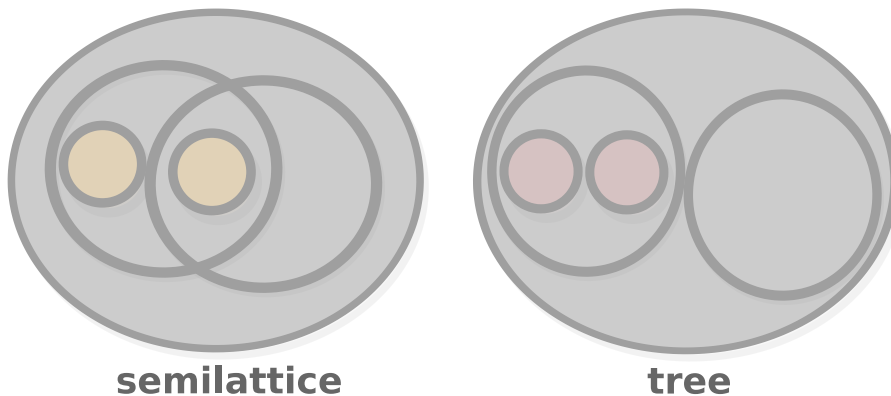
Semilattice

A structure that is similar to a semilattice (and probably more famous than it) is the *tree*.



Tree

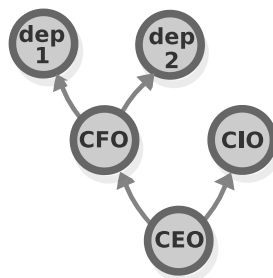
The difference between the two is small but crucial: in a tree, each element can only be connected to just one other element (although it can have multiple elements connected to it). If we represent a tree as an inclusion order, each set would “belong” in only one superset, whereas with semilattices there would be no such restrictions.



Tree and semilattice compared

A good intuition for the difference between the two is that a semilattice is capable of representing much more general relations, so for example, the mother-child relation forms a tree (a mother can have multiple children, but a child can have *only one* mother), but the “older sibling” relation forms a lattice, as a child can have multiple older siblings and vice versa.

Why am I speaking about trees? It's because people tend to use them for modeling all kinds of phenomena and to imagine everything as trees. The tree is the structure that all of us understand, that comes at us naturally, without even realizing that we are using a structure — most human-made hierarchies are modeled as trees. A typical organization of people are modeled as trees - you have one person at the top, a couple of people who report to them, then even more people that report to this couple of people.



Tree

(Contrast this with informal social groups, in which more or less everyone is connected to everyone else.)

And, cities (ones that are designed rather than left to evolve naturally) are also modeled as trees: you have several neighborhoods each of which has a school, a department store etc., connected with to each other and (in bigger cities) organized into bigger living units.

The implications of the tendency to use trees, as opposed to lattices, to model are examined in the ground-breaking essay “A City is Not a Tree” by Christopher Alexander.

In simplicity of structure the tree is comparable to the compulsive desire for neatness and order that insists the

candlesticks on a mantelpiece be perfectly straight and perfectly symmetrical about the center. The semilattice, by comparison, is the structure of a complex fabric; it is the structure of living things, of great paintings and symphonies.

In general, it seems that hierarchies that are specifically designed by *people*, such as cities tend to come up as trees, whereas hierarchies that are natural, such as the hierarchy of colors, tend to come be lattices.

Interlude: Formal concept analysis

In the previous section we (along with Christopher Alexander) argued that lattice-based hierarchies are “natural”, that is, they arise in nature. Now, we will see an interesting way to uncover such hierarchies, given a set of objects that share some attributes. This is an overview of a mathematical method, called *formal context analysis*.

The data structure that we will be analyzing, called *formal context* consists of 3 sets. Firstly, the set containing all *objects* that we will be analyzing (denoted as G).



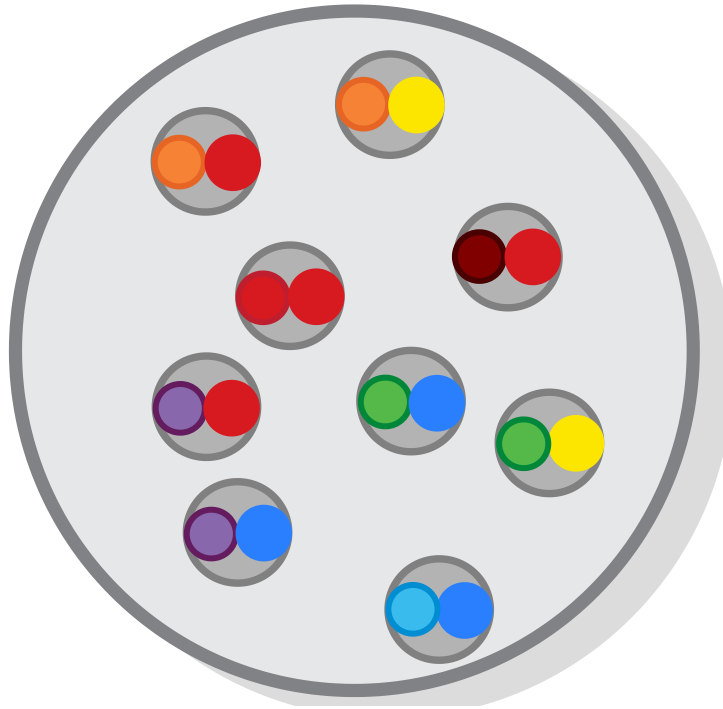
Formal concept analysis - function

Secondly, a set of some *attributes* that these objects might have (denoted as M). Here we will be using the 3 base colors.



Formal concept analysis - function

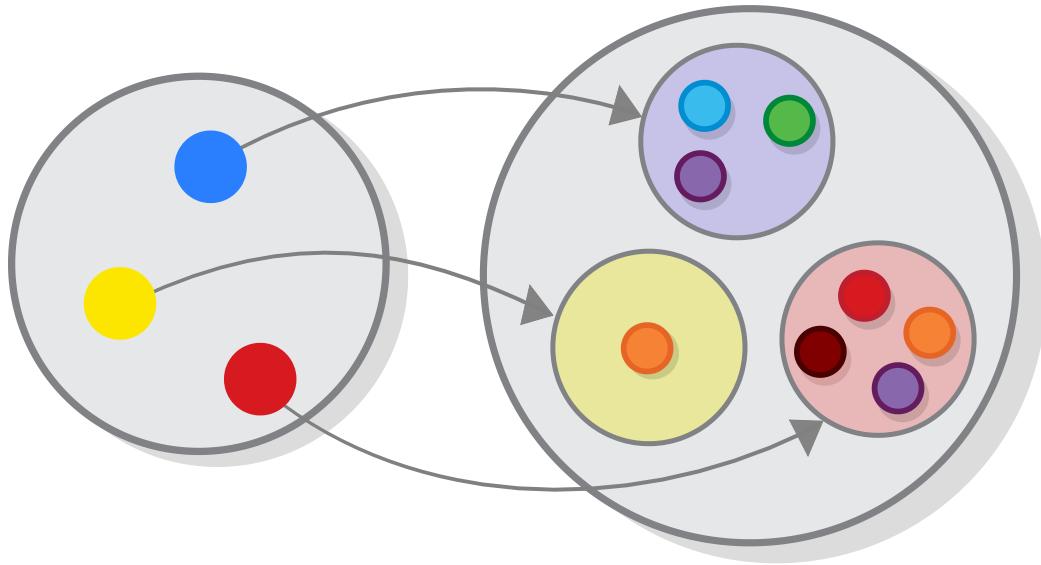
And finally a set of relation (called *incidence*) that expresses which objects have which attributes, expressed by a set of pairs $G \times M$. So, having a pair containing a ball and a base color (yellow for example) would indicate that the color of the ball contains (i.e. is composed of) the color yellow (among other colors).



Formal concept analysis - function

Now, let's use these sets to build a lattice.

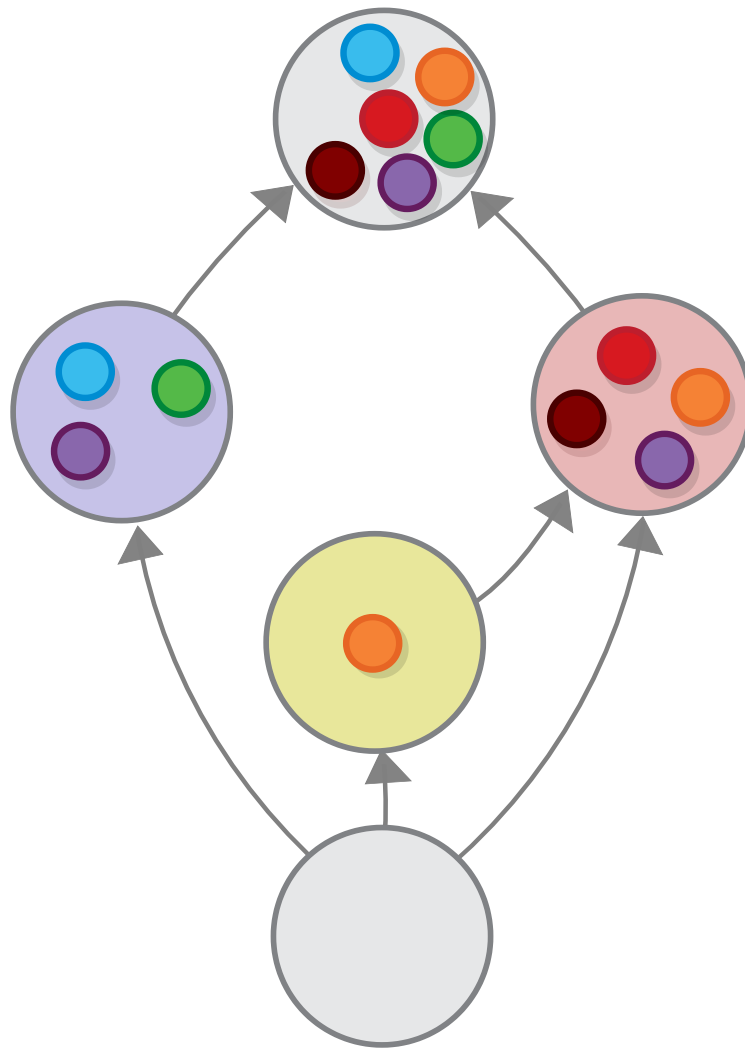
First step: From the set of pairs, we build a function, connecting each attributes with the set of objects that share this attribute (we can do this because functions are relations and relations are expressed by pairs).



Formal concept analysis - function

Take a look at the target of this function, which is a set of sets. Is there some way to order those sets in order to visualize them better? Of course, we can order them by inclusion. In this way, each attribute would be connected to an attribute that is shared by a similar set of objects.

Add top and bottom values, and we get a lattice.



Formal concept analysis - function

Ordering the concept as a lattice might help us see connections between the concepts, in the context e.g. we see that *all balls in our set that contain the color yellow also contain the color red*.

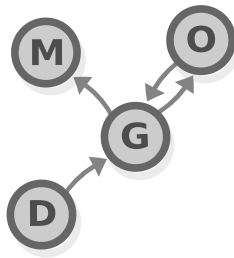
Task 5: Take a set of object and one containing attributes and create your own concept lattice. Example: the objects can be lifeforms: fish, frog, dog, water weed, corn etc. and attributes can be their characteristics: "lives in water", "lives in land", "can move", "is a plant", "is an animal" etc.

Preorder

In the previous section, we saw how removing the law of *totality* from the laws of (linear) order produces a different (and somewhat more interesting) structure, called *partial order*. Now let's see what will happen if we remove another one of the laws, namely the *antisymmetry* law. If you recall, the antisymmetry law mandated that you cannot have an object that is at the same time smaller and bigger than another one. (or that $a \leq b \Leftrightarrow b \not\leq a$).

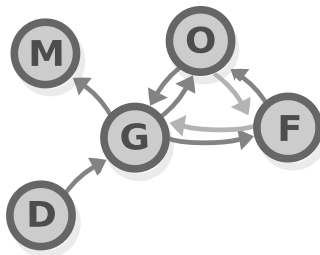
	Linear order	Partial order	Preorder
Element Comparability	$a \leq b$ or $b \leq a$	$a \leq b$ or $b \leq a$ or neither	$a \leq b$ or $b \leq a$ or neither or both
Reflexivity	X	X	X
Transitivity	X	X	X
Antisymmetry	X	X	-
Totality	X	-	-

The result is a structure called a *preorder* which is not exactly an order in the everyday sense — it can have arrows coming from any point to any other: if a partial order can be used to model who is better than who at soccer, then a preorder can be used to model who has beaten who, either directly (by playing him) or indirectly.



preorder

Preorders have just one law — *transitivity* $a \leq b \wedge b \leq c \rightarrow a \leq c$ (two, if we count *reflexivity*). The part about the indirect wins is a result of this law. Due to it, all indirect wins (ones that are wins not against the player directly, but against someone who had beat them) are added as a direct result of its application, as seen here (we show indirect wins in lighter tone).



preorder in sport

And as a result of that, all “circle” relationships (e.g. where you have a weaker player beating a stronger one) result in just a bunch of objects that are all connected to one another.

All of that structure arises naturally from the simple law of transitivity.

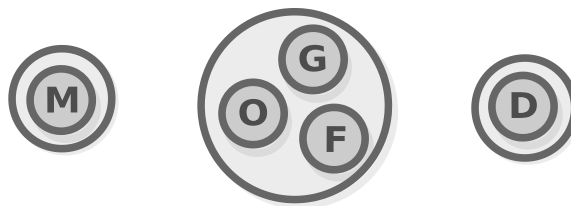
Preorders and equivalence relations

Preorders may be viewed as a middle-ground between *partial orders* and *equivalence relations*. As the missing exactly the property on which those two structures differ — (anti)symmetry. Because of that, if we have a bunch of objects in a preorder that follow the law of *symmetry*, those objects form an equivalence relation. And if they follow the reverse law of *antisymmetry*, they form a partial order.

Equivalence relation Preorder Partial order

Reflexivity	Reflexivity	Reflexivity
Transitivity	Transitivity	Transitivity
Symmetry	-	Antisymmetry

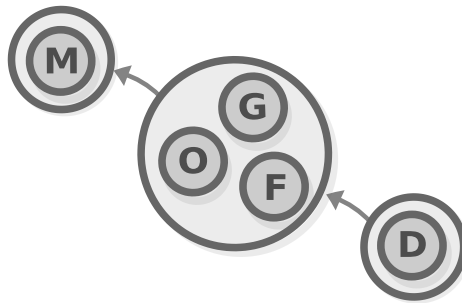
In particular, any subset of objects that are connected with one another both ways (like in the example above) follows the *symmetry* requirement. So if we group all elements that have such connection, we would get a bunch of sets, all of which define different *equivalence relations* based on the preorder, called the preorder's *equivalence classes*.



preorder

And, even more interestingly, if we transfer the preorder connections between the elements of these sets to connections between the sets themselves, these connections would follow

the *antisymmetry* requirement, which means that they would form a *partial order*.

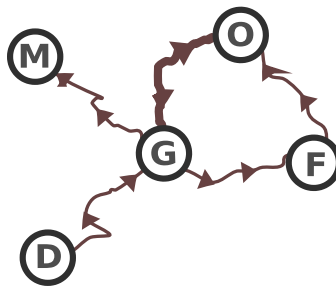


preorder

In short, for every preorder, we can define the *partial order of the equivalence classes of this preorder*.

Maps as preorders

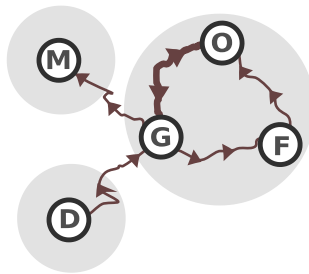
We use maps to get around all the time, often without thinking about the fact that that they are actually diagrams. More specifically, some of them are preorders — the objects represent cities or intersections, and the relations represent the roads.



A map as a preorder

Reflexivity reflects the fact that if you have a route allowing you to get from point a to point b and one that allows you to go from b to c , then you can go from a to c as well. Two-way roads may

be represented by two arrows that form an isomorphism between objects. Objects that are such that you can always get from one object to the other form equivalence classes (ideally all intersections would be in one equivalence class, else you would have places from which you would not be able to go back from).

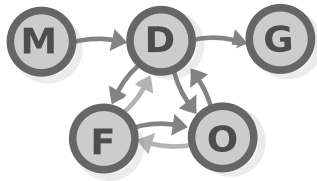


preorder

However, maps that contain more than one road (and even more than one *route*) connecting two intersections, cannot be represented using preorders. For that we would need categories (don't worry, we will get there).

State machines as preorders

Let's now reformat the preorder that we used in the previous two examples as a Hasse diagram that goes from left to right. Now, it (hopefully) doesn't look so much like a hierarchy, nor like map, but like a description of a process (which, if you think about it, is also a map just one that is temporal rather than spatial.) This is actually a very good way to describe a computation model known as *finite state machine*.



A state machine as a preorder

A specification of a finite state machine consists of a set of states that the machine can have, which, as the name suggest, must be finite, and a bunch of transition functions that specify which state do we transition to (often expressed as tables.)

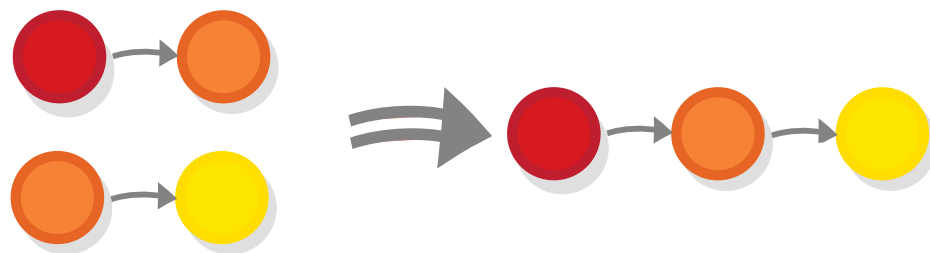
But as we saw, a finite state machine is similar to a preorder with a greatest and least object, in which the relations between the objects are represented by functions.

Finite state machines are used in organization planning e.g. imagine a process where a given item gets manufactured, gets checked by a quality control person, who, if they find some deficiencies, pass it to the necessary repairing departments and then they check it again and send it for shipping. This process can be modeled by the above diagram.

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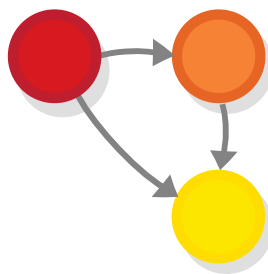
Orders as categories

We saw that preorders are a powerful concept, so let's take a deeper look at the law that governs them — the transitivity law. What this law tells us that if we have two pairs of relationship $a \leq b$ and $b \leq c$, then we automatically have a third one $a \leq c$.



Transitivity

In other words, the transitivity law tells us that the $\leq$ relationship composes i.e. if we view the “bigger than” relationship as a morphism we would see that the law of transitivity is actually the categorical definition of *composition*.



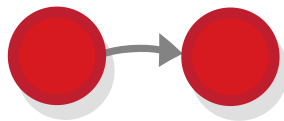
Transitivity as functional composition

(we have to also verify that the relation is associative, but that's easy)

So let's review the definition of a category again.

A category is a collection of *objects* (we can think of them as points) and *morphisms* (arrows) that go from one object to another, where: 1. Each object has to have the identity morphism. 2. There should be a way to compose two morphisms with an appropriate type signature into a third one in a way that is associative.

Looks like we have law number 2 covered. What about that other one — the identity law? We have it too, under the name *reflexivity*.



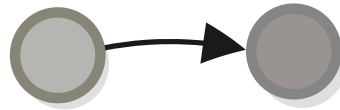
Reflexivity

So it's official — preorders are categories (sounds kinda obvious, especially after we also saw that orders can be reduced to sets and functions using the inclusion order, and sets and functions form a category in their own right.)

And since partial orders and total orders are preorders too, they are categories as well.

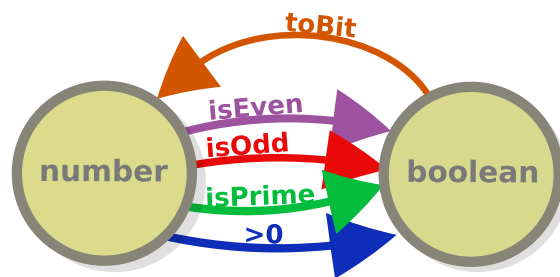
When we compare the categories of orders to other categories, (like the quintessential category of sets), we see one thing that immediately sets them apart: in other categories there can be *many different morphisms (arrows)* between two objects and in

orders can have *at most one morphism*, that is, we either have $a \leq b$ or we do not.



Orders compared to other categories

In the contrast, in the category of sets where there are potentially infinite amount of functions from, say, the set of integers and the set of boolean values, as well as a lot of functions that go the other way around, and the existence of either of these functions does not imply that one set is “bigger” than the other one.



Orders compared to other categories

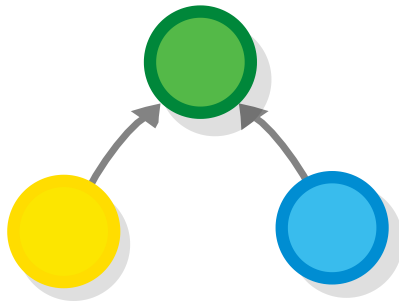
So, an order is a category that has at most one morphism between two objects. But the converse is also true — *every category* that has at most one morphism between objects is an order (or a *thin* category as it is called in category-theoretic terms).

An interesting fact that follows trivially from the fact that they have at most one morphism between given two objects is that in thin categories *all diagrams commute*.

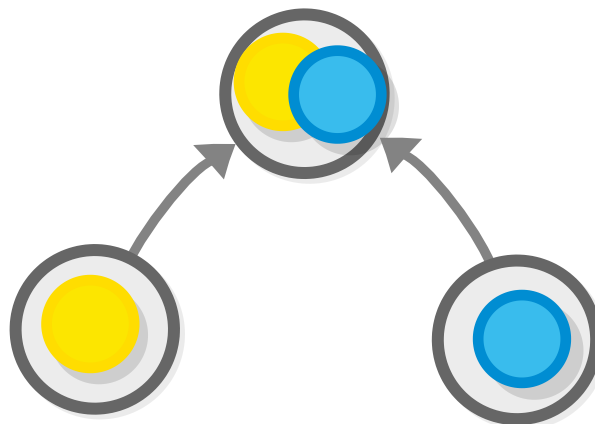
Task 6: Prove this.

Products and coproducts

While we are rehashing diagrams from the previous chapters, let's look at the diagram defining the *coproduct* of two objects in a category, from chapter 2.



If you recall, this is an operation that corresponds to *set inclusion* in the category of sets.

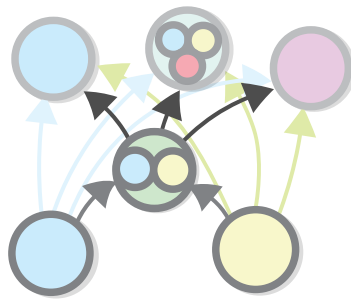


Joins as coproduct

But wait, wasn't there some other operation that that corresponded to set inclusion? Oh yes, the *join* operation in orders. And not merely that, but joins in orders are defined in the exact same way as the categorical coproducts.

In category theory, an object G is the coproduct of objects Y and B if the following two conditions are met:

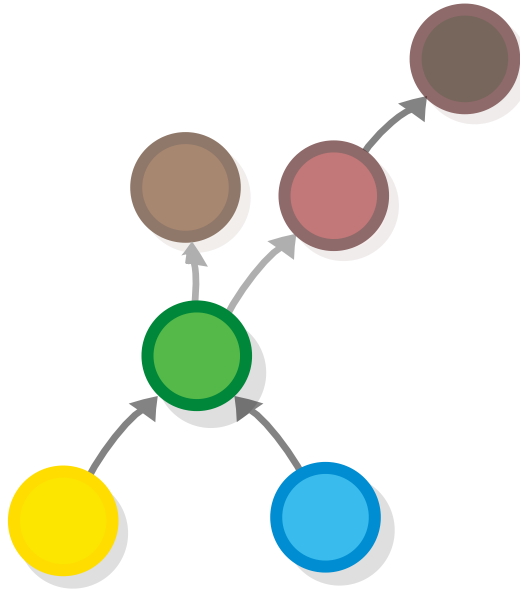
1. We have a morphism from any of the elements of the coproduct to the coproduct, so $Y \rightarrow G$ and $B \rightarrow G$.
2. For any other object P that also has those morphisms (so $Y \rightarrow P$ and $B \rightarrow P$) we would have morphism $G \rightarrow P$.



Joins as coproduct

In the realm of orders, we say that G is the *join* of objects Y and B if:

1. It is bigger than both of these objects, so $Y \leq G$ and $B \leq G$.
2. It is smaller than any other object that is bigger than them, so for any other object P such that $P \leq G$ and $P \leq B$ then we should also have $G \leq P$.



Joins as coproduct

We can see that the two definitions and their diagrams are the same. So, speaking in category theoretic terms, we can say that the *categorical coproduct* in the category of orders is the *join* operation. Which of course means that *products* correspond to *meets*.

Overall, orders (thin categories) are often used for exploring categorical concepts in a context that is easier to understand e.g. understand the *order-theoretic* concepts of meets and joins would help you better understand the *more general categorical* concepts of products and coproducts).

Orders are also helpful when they are used as thin categories i.e. as an alternative to “full-fledged” categories, in contexts when we aren’t particularly interested in the difference between the morphisms that go from one object to another. We will see an example of that in the next chapter.

Answers

Task 1: Previously, we covered a relation that is pretty similar to this. Do you remember it? What is the difference?

It's the *equivalence relation* from Chapter 1.

Both equivalence relations and orders are reflexive and transitive. The difference is that:

- Equivalence relations are symmetric (if $a = b$ then you always have $b = a$)
- Orders are *antisymmetric* (if $a \leq b$ then you cannot have $b \leq a$)

i.e. hierarchy is the opposite of equality (but they are also quite similar in some respects).

Task 2: Think about some orders that you know about and figure out whether they are partial or total.

Total Orders: - Alphabetical order - Chronological order

Partial Orders: - Divisibility of integers — some numbers divide others, but some are incomparable (neither divides the other). - "Ancestor of" relation — your parents and grandparents are before you, your children — after you, but other people are neither.

Task 3: Which concept in category theory reminds you of joins?

Joins correspond to *coproducts* in category theory.

Task 4: Prove that all finite lattices are bounded.

To prove all finite lattices are bounded, we have to find the top and bottom element of a random finite lattice. To do that:

1. Take the set of all elements in the lattice.
2. Take their join.
3. Done, you found the top element (T).

Similarly, the bottom element is the *meet* of all elements.

This works, since a lattice has to have joins for all sets of elements (and finite number of objects can be put into a set).

The proof relies on finiteness, e.g. you cannot get the set of all integers.

Task 5: Take a set of objects and one containing attributes and create your own concept lattice.

Here is a classic example:

Objects (G)

{Fish, Frog, Dog, WaterWeed, Corn}

Attributes (M):

{LivesInWater, LivesOnLand, CanMove, IsPlant, IsAnimal}

Incidence relation:

- Fish: LivesInWater, CanMove, IsAnimal
- Frog: LivesInWater, LivesOnLand, CanMove, IsAnimal
- Dog: LivesOnLand, CanMove, IsAnimal
- WaterWeed: LivesInWater, IsPlant
- Corn: LivesOnLand, IsPlant

Attribute sets:

- LivesInWater: {Fish, Frog, WaterWeed}
- LivesOnLand: {Frog, Dog, Corn}
- CanMove: {Fish, Frog, Dog}
- IsPlant: {WaterWeed, Corn}
- IsAnimal: {Fish, Frog, Dog}

Now draw the lattice!

Task 6: Prove that in thin categories all diagrams commute.

The proof is simple:

1. Given a path of arrows between two objects A and B , we can compose those arrows to get a single arrow $A \rightarrow B$
2. There can be, by definition, only one arrow connecting two objects in a thin category (only one $A \rightarrow B$ morphism).

So, all paths that connect a given pair of objects are equivalent to this morphism.

Logic

Now let's talk about one more *seemingly* unrelated topic just so we can "surprise" ourselves when we realize it's category theory. By the way, in this chapter there will be another surprise in addition to that, so don't fall asleep.

Also, I will not merely transport you to a different branch of mathematics, but to an entirely different discipline - *logic*.

What is logic

Logic is the science of the *possible*. As such, it is at the root of all other sciences, all of which are sciences of the *actual*, i.e. that which really exists. For example, if science explains how our universe works then logic is the part of the description which is also applicable to any other universe that is *possible to exist*. A scientific theory aims to be consistent with both itself and observations, while a logical theory only needs to be consistent with itself (and true regardless of observations).

Logic studies the *rules* by which knowing one thing leads you to conclude (or *prove*) that some other thing is also true, regardless of the things' domain (e.g. scientific discipline) and by only referring to their form.

On top of that, it (logic) tries to organize those rules in *logical systems* (or *formal systems* as they are also called).

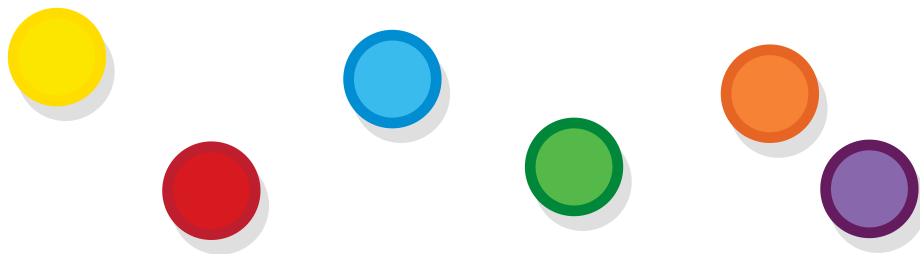
Logic and mathematics

Seeing this description, we might think that the subject of logic is quite similar to the subject of set theory and category theory, as we described it in the first chapter - instead of the word "formal" we used another similar word, namely "abstract", and instead of "logical system" we said "theory". This observation would be quite correct - today most people agree that every mathematical theory is actually logic plus some additional definitions added to it. For example, part of the reason why *set theory* is so popular as a theory for the foundations of mathematics is that it can be

defined by adding just one single primitive to the standard axioms of logic which we will see shortly - the binary relation that indicates *set membership*. Category theory is close to logic too, but in a quite different way.

Primary propositions

A consequence of logic being the science of the possible is that in order to do anything at all in it, we should have an initial set of propositions that we accept as true or false. These are also called “premises”, “primary propositions” or “atomic propositions” as Wittgenstein dubbed them.



Balls

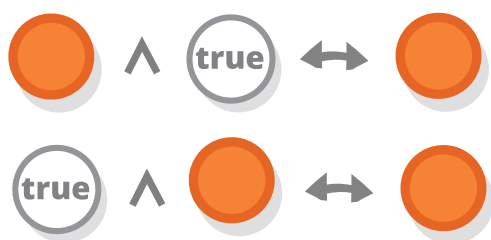
In the context of logic itself, these propositions are abstracted away (i.e. we are not concerned about them directly) and so they can be represented with the colorful balls that you are familiar with.

Composing propositions

At the heart of logic, as in category theory, is the concept of *composition* - if we have two or more propositions that are somehow related to one another, we can combine them into one

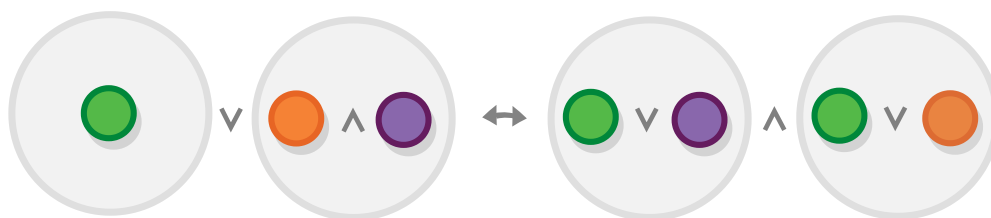
using a logical operators, like “and”, “or” “follows” etc. The results would be new propositions, which we might call *composite propositions* to emphasize the fact that they are not primary.

This composition resembles the way in which two monoid objects are combined into one using the monoid operation. Actually, some logical operations do form monoids, like for example the operation *and*, with the proposition *true* serving as the identity element.



Logical operations that form monoids

However, unlike monoids/groups, logics study combinations not just with one but with *many* logical operations and *the ways in which they relate to one another*, for example, in logic we might be interested in the law of distributivity of *and* and *or* operations and what it entails.



The distributivity operation of “and” and “or”

Important to note that $\wedge$ is the symbol for *and* and $\vee$ is the symbol for *or* (although the law above is actually valid even if *and* and *or* are flipped).

The equivalence of primary and composite propositions

When looking at the last diagram, it is important to emphasize that, propositions that are composed of several premises (symbolized by gray balls, containing some other balls) are not in any way different from “primary” propositions (single-color balls) and that they compose in the same way (although in the leftmost proposition the green ball is wrapped in a gray ball to make the diagram prettier).

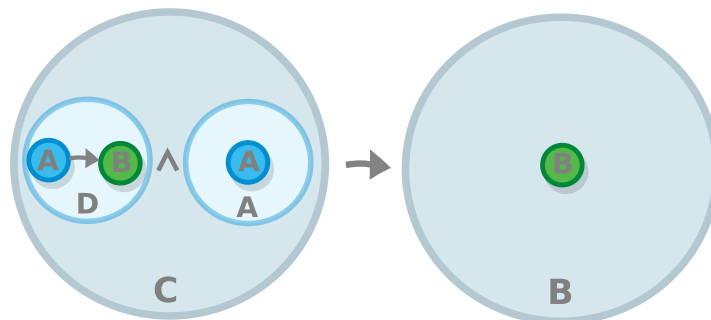


Balls as propositions

Modus ponens

As an example of a proposition that contains multiple levels of nesting (and also as a great introduction of the subject of logic in its own right), consider one of the oldest (it was already known by Stoics at 3rd century B.C.) and most famous propositions ever, namely the *modus ponens*.

Modus ponens is a proposition that is composed of two other propositions (which here we denote A and B) and it states that if proposition A is true and also if proposition $(A \rightarrow B)$ is true (that is if A implies B), then B is true as well. For example, if we know that "Socrates is a human" and that "humans are mortal" (or "being human implies being mortal"), we also know that "Socrates is mortal."



Modus ponens

Let's dive into this proposition. We can see that it is composed of two other propositions in a *follows* relation, where the proposition that follows (B) is primary, but the proposition from which B follows is not primary (let's call that one C - so the whole proposition becomes $C \rightarrow B$.)

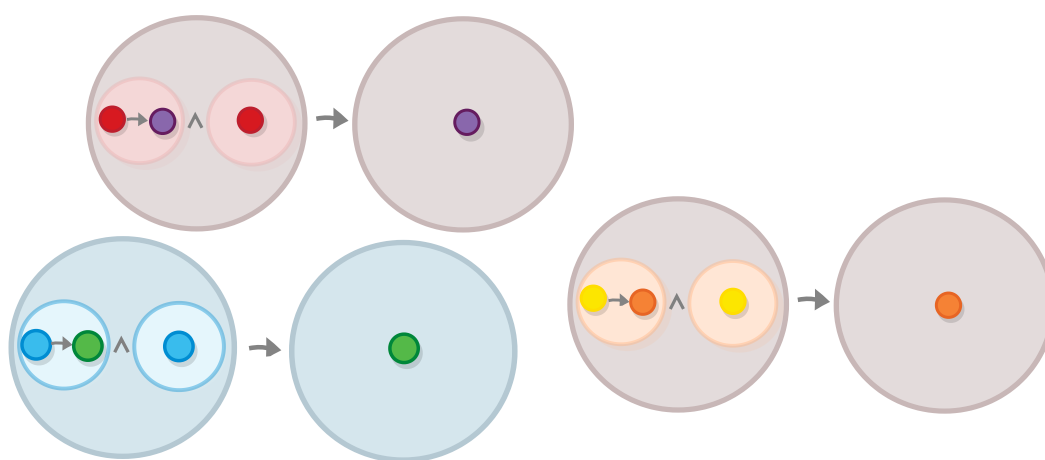
Going one more level down, we notice that the C proposition is itself composed of two propositions in an *and*, relationship - A and let's call the other one D (so $A \wedge D$), where D is itself composed of two propositions, this time in a *follows* relationship - $A \rightarrow B$. But all of this is better visualized in the diagram.

Tautologies

We often cannot tell whether a given composite proposition is true or false without knowing the values of the propositions that

it is made of. However, with propositions such as *modus ponens* we can: *modus ponens* is *always true*, regardless of whether the propositions that form it are true or false. If we want to be fancy, we can also say that it is *true in all models of the logical system*, a model being a set of real-world premises are taken to be signified by our propositions.

For example, our previous example will not stop being true if we *substitute* "Socrates" with any other name, nor if we substitute "mortal" for any other quality that humans possess.

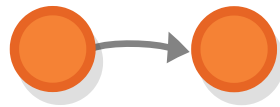


Variation of modus ponens

Propositions that are always true are called *tautologies*. And their more-famous counterparts that are always false are called *contradictions*. You can turn each tautology into contradiction, or the other way around, by adding a "not".

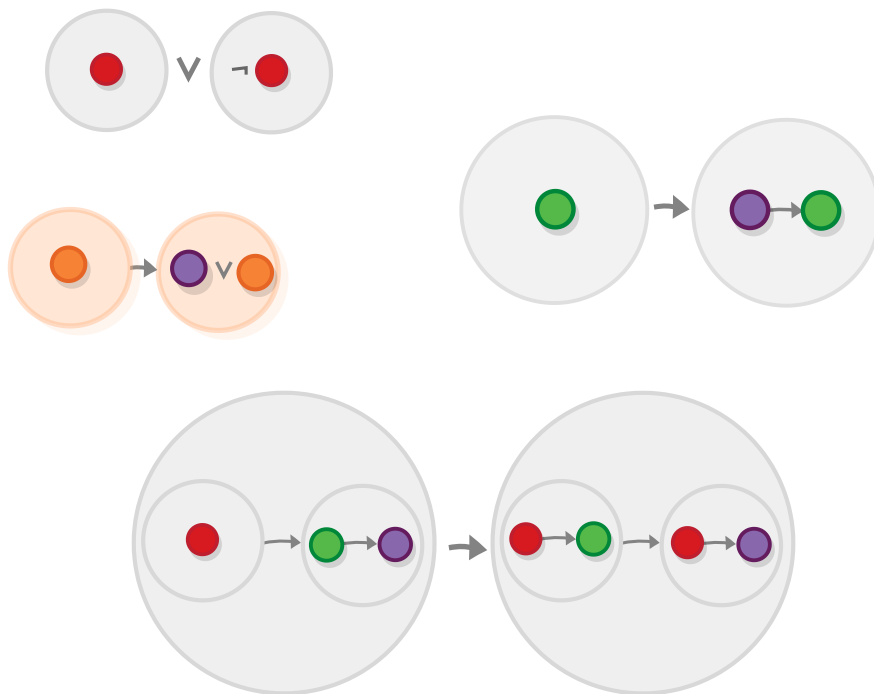
The other statements, ones which may be true or false depending on the values of some other propositions are called "contingent statements". In logic, we don't care about contingent statements — after all, those are studied in all other sciences (and we are not like other sciences).

The simplest tautology is the so called law of identity, the statement that each proposition implies itself (e.g. "All bachelors are unmarried"). It may remind you of something.



Identity tautology

Here are some more complex (less boring) tautologies (the symbol $\neg$ means "not"/negation).



Tautologies

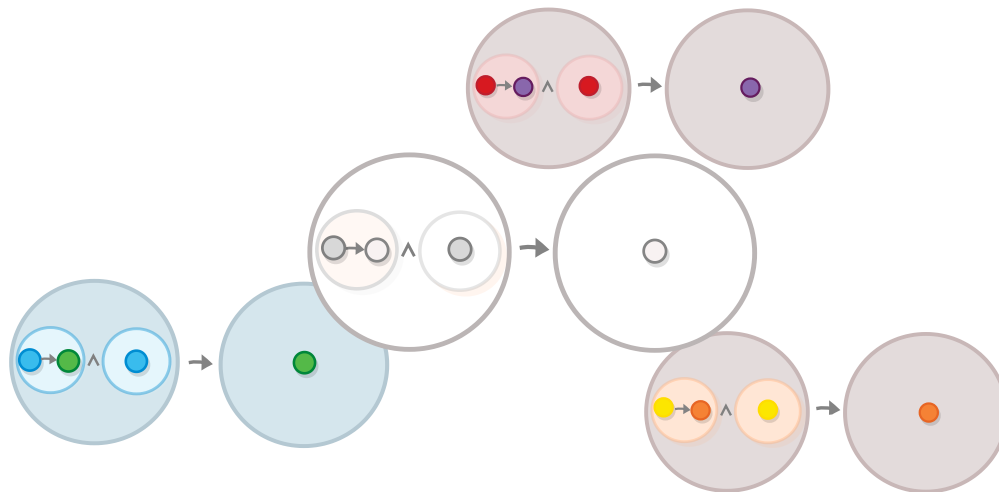
We will learn how to determine which propositions are a tautologies shortly, but first let's see why are tautologies

important in the first place.

Axiom schemas/Rules of inference

Tautologies are useful because they are the basis of *axiom schemas/rules of inference*. And *axiom schemas* and *rules of inference* serve as starting point from which we can generate other true logical statements by means of substitution.

Realizing that the colors of the balls in modus ponens are superficial, we may want to represent the general structure of modus ponens that all of its variations share.

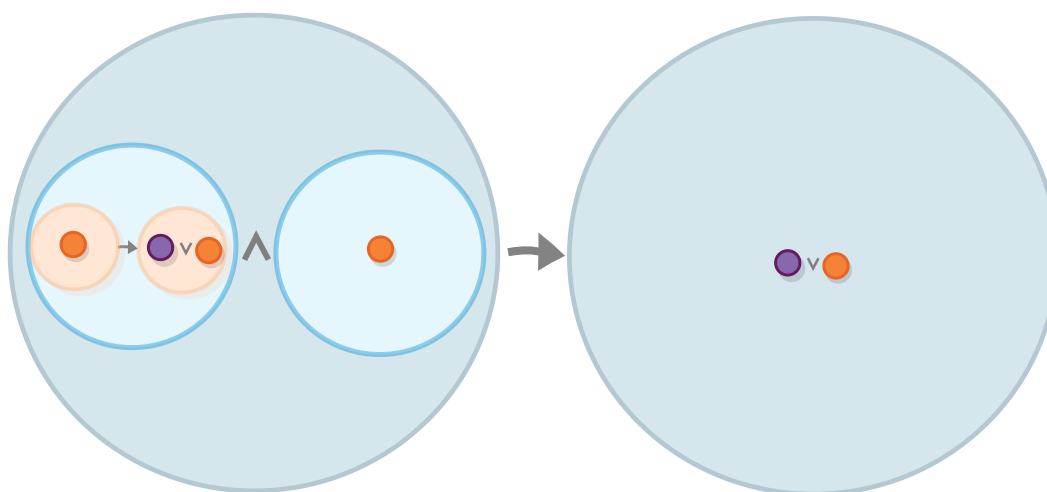


Modus ponens

This structure (the one that looks like a coloring book in our example) is called *axiom schema*. And the propositions that are produced by it are *axioms*.

Note that the propositions that we plug into the schema don't have to be primary. For example, having the proposition a (that is symbolized below by the orange ball) and the proposition stating that a implies $a \vee b$ (which is one of the tautologies that

we saw above), we can plug those propositions into the *modus ponens* and prove that $a \vee b$ is true.



Using modus ponens for rule of inference

Axiom schemas and *rules of inference* are almost the same thing except that rules of inference allow us to actually distill the conclusion from the premises. For example in the case above, we can use modus ponens as a rule of inference to prove that $a \vee b$ is true.

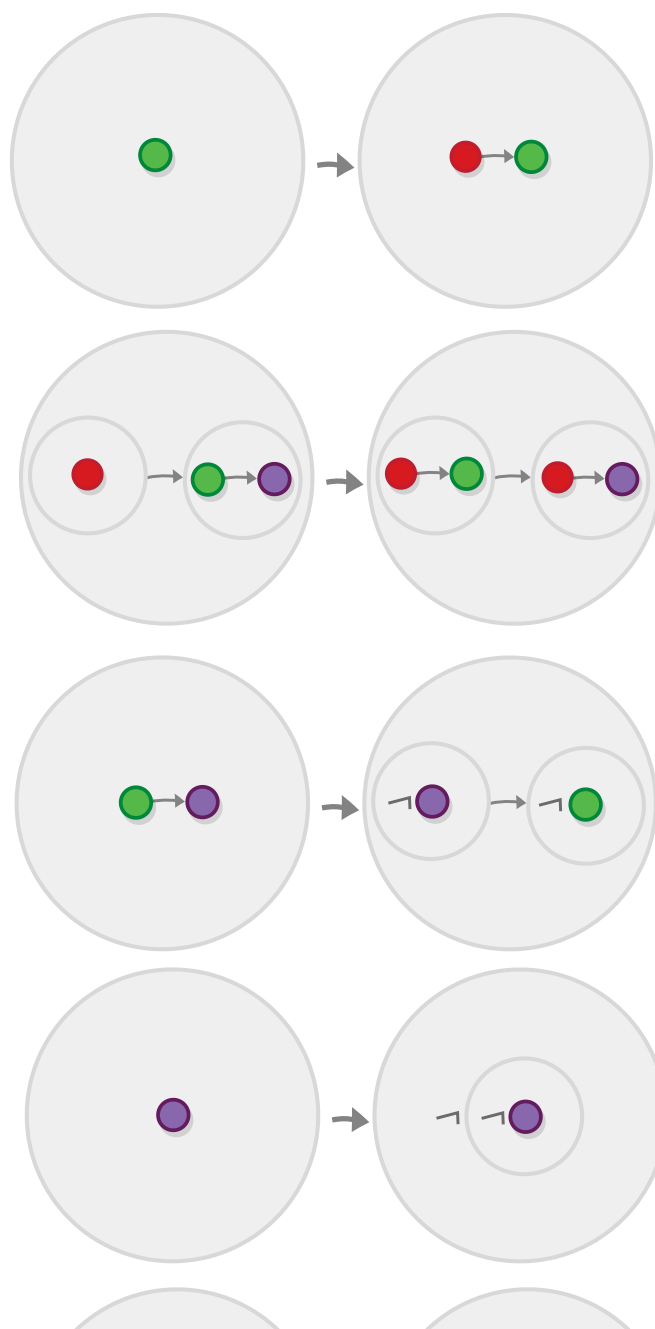
All axiom schemas can be easily applied as rules of inference and the other way around.

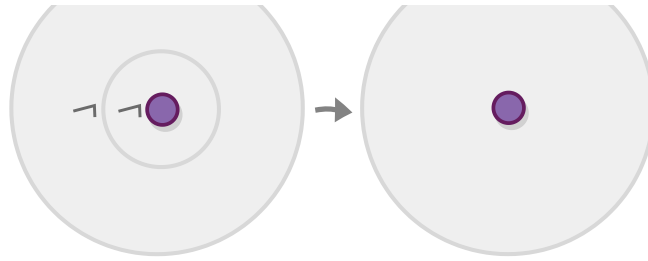
Logical systems

Knowing that we can use axiom schemas/rules of inference to generate new propositions, we might ask whether it is possible to create a small collection of such schemas/rules that is curated in such a way that it enables us to generate *all* other propositions. You would be happy (although a little annoyed, I imagine) to learn that there exist not only one, but many such

collections. And yes, collections of this sort are what we call *logical systems*.

Here is one such collection which consists of the following five axiom schemes *in addition to the inference rule modus ponens* (These are axiom schemes, even though we use colors).





A minimal collection of Hilbert axioms

Proving that this and other similar logical systems are complete (can really generate all other propositions) is due to Gödel and is known as “Gödel’s completeness theorem” (Gödel is so important that I specifically searched for the “ö” letter so I can spell his name right).

Conclusion

We now have an idea about how do some of the main logical constructs (axioms, rules of inference) work. But in order to prove that they are true, and to understand *what they are*, we need to do so through a specific *interpretation* of those constructs.

We will look into two interpretations - one very old and the other, relatively recent. This would be a slight detour from our usual subject matter of points and arrows, but I assure you that it would be worth it. So let’s start.

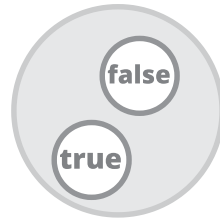
Classical logic. The truth-functional interpretation

Beyond the world that we inhabit and perceive every day, there exist the *world of forms* where reside all ideas and concepts that manifest themselves in the objects that we perceive e.g. beyond all the people that have ever lived, there lies the prototypical person, and we are people only insofar as we resemble that person, beyond all the things in the world that are strong, lies the ultimate concepts of strength, from which all of them borrow and this is true for every single category, e.g. if there is a cup, there is also “cupness”. And although, as mere mortals, we live in the world of appearances and cannot perceive the world of forms, we can, through philosophy, “recollect” with it and know some of its features.

The above is a summary of a worldview that is due to the Greek philosopher Plato and is sometimes called Plato’s *theory of forms*. Originally, the discipline of logic represents an effort to think and structure our thoughts in a way that they apply to this world of forms i.e. in a “formal” way. Today, this original paradigm of logic is known as “classical logic”. Although it all started with Plato, most of it is due to the 20th century mathematician David Hilbert.

The existence of the world of forms implies that, even if there are many things that we, people, don’t know and would not ever know, at least *somewhere out there* there exists an answer to

every question. In logic, this translates to *the principle of bivalence* that states that *each proposition is either true or false*. And, due to this principle, propositions in classical logic can be aptly represented in set theory by the boolean set, which contains those two values.



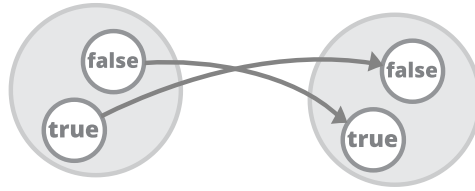
The set of boolean values

According to the classical interpretation, you can think of *primary propositions* as just a bunch of boolean values. *Logical operators* are functions that take a one or several boolean values and return another boolean value (and *composite propositions* are, just the results of the application of these functions).

Let's review all logical operators in this semantic context.

The *negation* operation

Let's begin with the negation operation. Negation is a unary operation, which means that it is a function that takes just *one* argument and (like all other logical operators) returns one value, where both the arguments and the return type are boolean values.



negation

The same function can also be expressed in a slightly less-fancy way by this table.

p	¬p
True	False
False	True

Tables like this one are called *truth tables* and they are ubiquitous in classical logic. They can be used not only for defining operators but for proving results as well.

Interlude: Proving results by truth tables

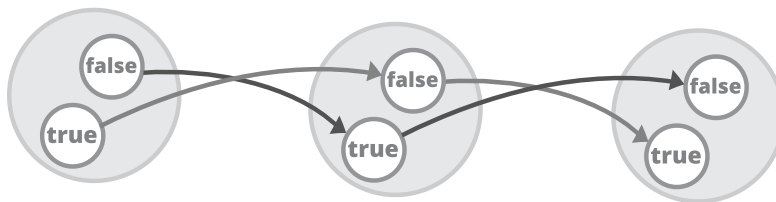
Having defined the negation operator, we are in position to prove the first of the axioms of the logical system we saw, namely the *double negation elimination*. In natural language, this axiom is equivalent to the observation that saying “I am *not* *unable* to do X” is the same as saying “I am *able* to do it”.



Double negation elimination formula

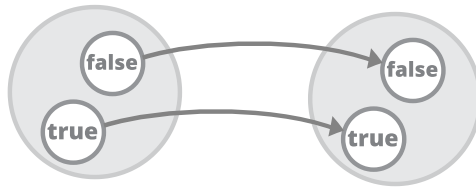
(despite its triviality, the double negation axiom is probably the most controversial result in logic, we will see why later.)

If we view logical operators as functions from and to the set of boolean values, then proving axioms involves composing several of those functions into one function and observing its output. More specifically, the proof of the formula above involves just composing the negation function with itself and verifying that it leaves us in the same place from which we started.



Double negation elimination

If we want to be formal about it, we might say that applying negation two times is equivalent to applying the *identity* function.



The identity function for boolean values

If we are tired of diagrams, we can represent the composition diagram above as table as well.

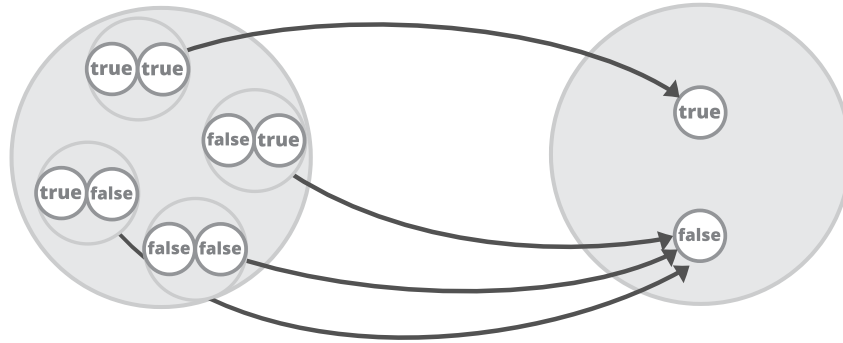
p	$\neg p$	$\neg\neg p$
True	False	True
False	True	False

Each proposition in classical logic can be proved with such diagrams/tables.

The *and* and *or* operations

OK, *you* know what *and* means and *I* know what it means, but what about those annoying people that want everything to be formally specified (nudge, nudge). Well we already know how we can satisfy them - we just have to construct the boolean function that represents *and*.

Because *and* is a *binary* operator, instead of a single value the function would accept a *pair* of boolean values.



And

Here is the equivalent truth-table (in which $\wedge$ is the symbol for *and*.)

p	q	p $\wedge$ q
True	True	True
True	False	False
False	True	False
False	False	False

We can do the same for *or*, here is the table.

p	q	p $\vee$ q
True	True	True
True	False	True
False	True	True
False	False	False

Task 1: Draw the diagram for *or*.

Using those tables, we can also prove some axiom schemas we can use later:

- For *and* $p \wedge q \rightarrow p$ and $p \wedge q \rightarrow q$ "If I am tired and hungry, this means that I am hungry".
- For *or*: $p \rightarrow p \vee q$ and $q \rightarrow p \vee q$ "If I have a pen this means that I am either have a pen or a ruler".

The *implies* operation

Let's now look into something less trivial: the *implies* operation, (also known as *material condition*). This operation binds two propositions in a way that the truth of the first one implies the truth of the second one (or that the first proposition is a *necessary condition* for the second.) You can read $p \rightarrow q$ as "if p is true, then q must also be true.

Implies is also a binary function - it is represented by a function from an ordered pair of boolean values, to a boolean value.

p	q	$p \rightarrow q$
True	True	True
True	False	False
False	True	True
False	False	True

Now there are some aspects of this which are non-obvious so let's go through every case.

1. If p is true and q is also true, then p does imply q - obviously.
2. If p is true but q is false then q does not follow from p - cause q would have been true if it did.
3. If p is false but q is true, then p still does imply q . What the hell? Consider that by saying that p implies q we don't say

that the two are 100% interdependent e.g. the claim that “drinking alcohol causes headache” does not mean that drinking is the only source of headaches.

4. And finally if p is false but q is false too, then p still does imply q (just some other day).

It might help you to remember that in classical logic $p \rightarrow q$ (p implies q) is true when $\neg p \vee q$ (either p is false or q is true.)

The *if and only if* operation

Now, let's review the operation that indicates that two propositions are equivalent (or, when one proposition is a *necessary and sufficient condition* for the other (which implies that the reverse is also true.)) This operation yields true when the propositions have the same value.

p	q	$p \leftrightarrow q$
True	True	True
True	False	False
False	True	False
False	False	True

But what's more interesting about this operation is that it can be constructed using the *implies* operation - it is equivalent to each of the propositions implying the other one (so $p \leftrightarrow q$ is the same as $p \rightarrow q \wedge q \rightarrow p$) - something which we can easily prove by comparing some truth tables.

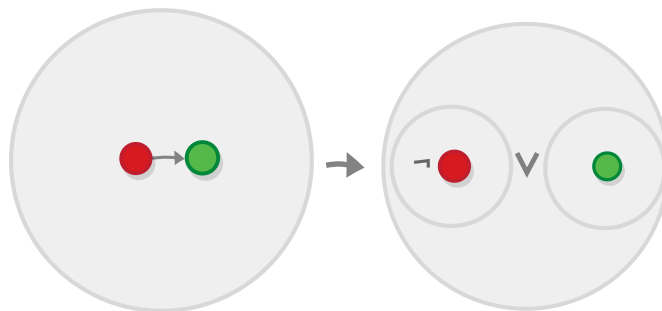
p	q	$p \rightarrow q$	$q \rightarrow p$	$p \rightarrow q \wedge q \rightarrow p$
True	True	True	True	True

p	q	$p \rightarrow q$	$q \rightarrow p$	$p \rightarrow q \wedge q \rightarrow p$
True	False	False	True	False
False	True	True	False	False
False	False	True	True	True

Because of this, the equivalence operation is called “if and only if”, or “iff” for short.

Proving results by axioms/rules of inference

Let’s examine the above formula, stating that $p \rightarrow q$ is the same as $\neg p \vee q$.



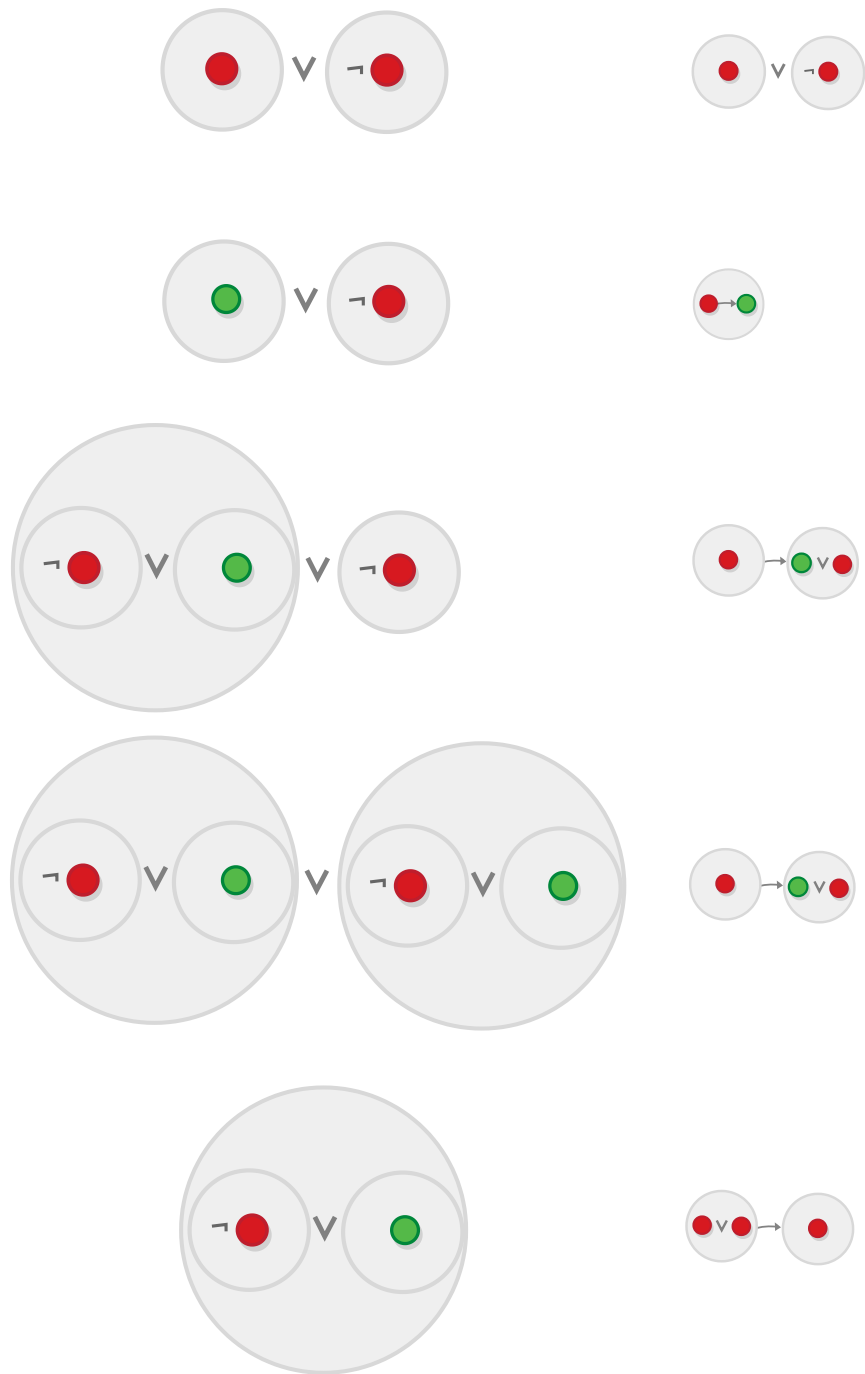
Hilbert formula

We can easily prove this by using truth tables.

p	q	$p \rightarrow q$	$\neg p$	q	$\neg p \vee q$
True	True	True	False	True	True
True	False	False	False	False	False
False	True	True	True	True	True
False	False	True	True	False	True

But it would be much more intuitive if we do it using axioms and rules of inference. To do so, we start with the formula we have $(p \rightarrow q)$ plus the axiom schemas, and arrive at the formula we want to prove $(\neg p \vee q)$.

Here is one way to do it. The formulas that are used at each step are specified at the right-hand side, the rule of inference is modus ponens.



Hilbert proof

Note that to really prove that the two formulas are equivalent we have to also do it the other way around (start with $(\neg p \vee q)$ and $(p \rightarrow q)$).

Intuitionistic logic. The BHK interpretation

[...] logic is life in the human brain; it may accompany life outside the brain but it can never guide it by virtue of its own power. — L.E.J. Brouwer

I don't know about you, but I feel that the classical truth-functional interpretation of logic (although it works and is correct in its own right) doesn't fit well the categorical framework that we are using here: It is too "low-level", it relies on manipulating the values of the propositions. According to it, the operations *and* and *or* are just 2 of the 16 possible binary logical operations and they are not really connected to each other (but we know that they actually are.)

For these and other reasons, in the 20th century a whole new school of logic was founded, called *intuitionistic logic*. If we view classical logic as based on *set theory*, then intuitionistic logic would be based on *category theory* and its related theories. If *classical logic* is based on Plato's theory of forms, then intuitionism began with a philosophical idea originating from Kant and Schopenhauer: the idea that the world as we experience it is largely predetermined of our perceptions of it. Thus without absolute standards for truth, a proof of a proposition becomes something that you *construct*, rather than something you discover.

Classical and intuitionistic logic diverge from one another right from the start: because according to intuitionistic logic we are

constructing proofs rather than *discovering* them as some universal truth, we are *off with the principle of bivalence*. That is, in intuitionistic logic we have no basis to claim that each statements is necessarily *true or false*. For example, there might be a statements that might not be provable not because they are false, but simply because they fall outside of the domain of a given logical system (the twin-prime conjecture is often given as an example for this.)

Anyway, intuitionistic logic is not bivalent, i.e. we cannot have all propositions reduced to true and false.



The True/False dichotomy

One thing that we still do have there are propositions that are “true” in the sense that a proof for them is given - the primary propositions. So with some caveats (which we will see later) the bivalence between true and false proposition might be thought out as similar to the bivalence between the existence or absence of a proof for a given proposition - there either is a proof of it or there isn't.



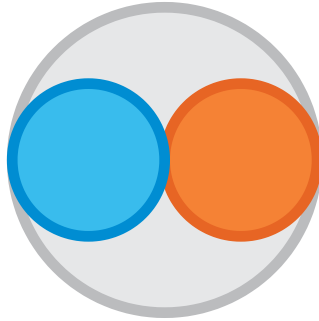
The proved/unproved dichotomy

This bivalence is at the heart of what is called the Brouwer–Heyting–Kolmogorov (BHK) interpretation of logic, something that we will look into next.

The original formulation of the BHK interpretation is not based on any particular mathematical theory. Here, we will first illustrate it using the language of set theory (just so we can abandon it a little later).

The *and* and *or* operations

As the existence of a proof of a proposition is taken to mean that the proposition is true, the definitions of *and* is rather simple - the proof of $A \wedge B$ is just *a pair* containing a proof of A , and a proof of B i.e. *a set-theoretic product* of the two (see chapter 2). The principle for determining whether the proposition is true or false is similar to that of primary propositions - if the pair of proofs of A and B exist (i.e. if both proofs exist) then the proof of $A \wedge B$ can be constructed (and so $A \wedge B$ is “true”).

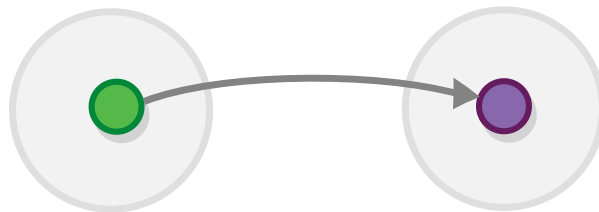


And in the BHK interpretation

Task 2: What would be the **or** operation in this case?

The *implies* operation

Now for the punchline: in the BHK interpretation, the *implies* operation is just a *function* between proofs. Saying that A implies B ($A \rightarrow B$) would just mean that there exist a function which can convert a proof of A to a proof of B .



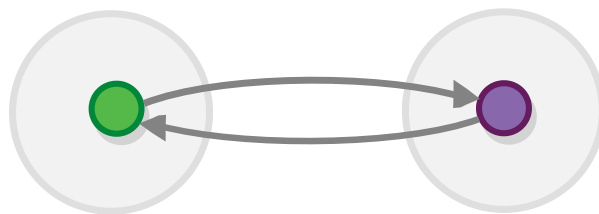
Implies in the BHK interpretation

And, (it gets even more interesting) the *modus ponens* rule of inference is nothing more than the process of *functional application*. i.e. if we have a proof of A and a function $A \rightarrow B$ we can call this function to obtain a proof of B .

(In order to define this formally, we also need to define functions in terms of sets i.e. we need to have a set representing $A \rightarrow B$ for each A and B . We will come back to this later.)

The *if and only if* operation

In the section on classical logic, we proved that two propositions A and B are equivalent if A implies B and B implies A . But if the *implies* operation is just a function, then propositions are equivalent precisely when there are two functions, converting each of them to the other i.e. when the sets containing the propositions are *isomorphic*.



Implies in the BHK interpretation

(Perhaps we should note that *not all set-theoretic functions are proofs*, only a designated set of them (which we call *canonical* functions) i.e. in set theory you can construct functions and isomorphisms between any pair of singleton sets, but that won't mean that all proofs are equivalent.)

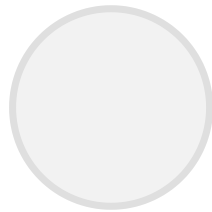
The *negation* operation

So according to BHK interpretation saying that A is true, means that that we possess a proof of A - simple enough. But it's a bit

harder to express the fact that A is false: it is not enough to say that we *don't have a proof* of A (the fact that don't have it, doesn't mean it doesn't exist). Instead, we must show that claiming that A is true leads to a *contradiction*.

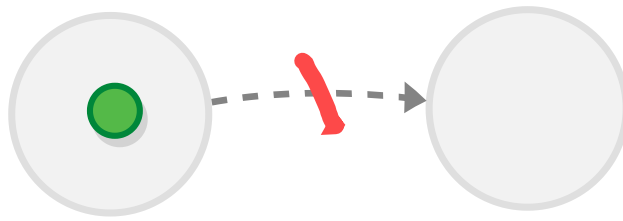
To express this, intuitionistic logic defines the constant $\perp$ which plays the role of *False* (also known as the "bottom value"). $\perp$ is defined as the proof of a formula that does not have any proofs. And the equivalent of false propositions are the ones that imply that the bottom value is provable (which is a contradiction). So $\neg A$ is $A \rightarrow \perp$.

In set theory, the $\perp$ constant is expressed by the empty set.



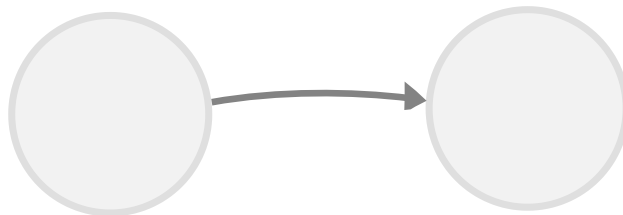
False in the BHK interpretation

And the observation that propositions that are connected to the bottom value are false is expressed by the fact that if a proposition is true, i.e. there exists a proof of it, then there can be no function from it to the empty set.



False in the BHK interpretation

The only way for there to be such function is if the set of proofs of the proposition is empty as well.



False in the BHK interpretation

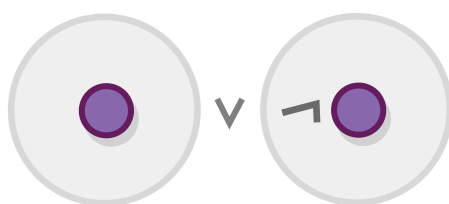
Task 3: Look up the definition of function and verify that there cannot exist a function from any set *to the empty set*

Task 4 Look up the definition of function and verify that there does exist a function *from the empty set* to itself (in fact there exist a function from the empty set to any other set).

The law of excluded middle

Although intuitionistic logic differs a lot from classical logic when it comes to its *semantics*, i.e. in the way the whole system is built (which we described above), it actually doesn't differ so much in terms of *syntax*, i.e. if we try to deduce the axiom schemas/rules

of inference that correspond to the definitions of the structures outlined above, we would see that they are virtually the same as the ones that define classical logic. There is, however, one exception concerning the *double negation elimination axiom* that we saw earlier, a version of which is known as *the law of excluded middle*.



The formula of the principle of the excluded middle

This law is valid in classical logic and is true when we look at its truth tables, but there is no justification for it terms of the BHK interpretation. Why? in intuitionistic logic saying that something is false amounts to *constructing a proof* that it is false (that it implies the bottom value) and there is no method/function/algorithm that can either prove that a given proposition is either true and false.

The question of whether you can use the law of excluded middle spawned a heated debate between the classical logic proponent David Hilbert and the intuitionistic logic proponent L.E.J. Brouwer, known as *the Brouwer–Hilbert controversy*.

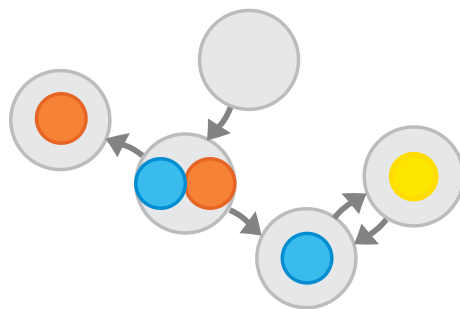
Logics as categories

Leaving the differences between intuitionistic and classical logics aside, the BHK interpretation is interesting because it provides that higher-level view of logic, that we need in order to construct a interpretation of it based on category theory.

Such higher-level interpretations of logic are sometimes called *algebraic* interpretations, *algebraic* being an umbrella term describing all structures that can be represented using category theory, like groups and orders.

The Curry-Howard isomorphism

Programmers might find the definition of the BHK interpretation interesting for other reason - it is very similar to a definition of a programming language: propositions are *types*, the *implies* operations are *functions*, and operations are composite types (objects), and *or* operations are *sum types* (which are currently not supported in most programming languages, but that's a separate topic). Finally a proof of a given proposition is represented by a value of the corresponding type.



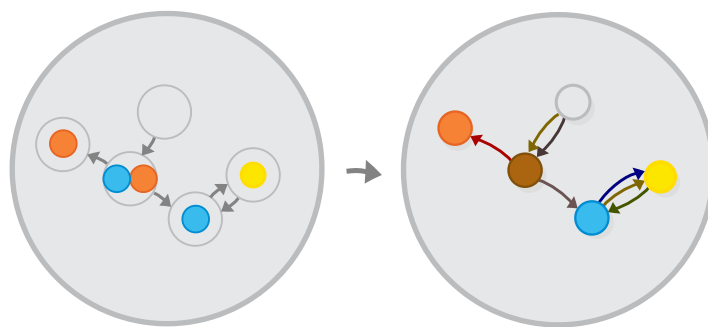
This similarity is known as the *Curry-Howard isomorphism*.

Task 5: The Curry-Howard isomorphism is also the basis of special types of programming languages called “proof assistants” which help you verify logical proofs. Install a proof assistant and try to see how it works (I recommend the Coq Tutorial by Mike Nahas).

Cartesian closed categories

Knowing about the Curry-Howard isomorphism and knowing also that programming languages can be described by category theory may lead us to think that *category theory is part of this isomorphism as well*. And we would be quite correct — this is why it is sometimes known as the Curry-Howard-Lambek isomorphism (Joachim Lambek being the person who formulated the categorical side). So let’s examine this isomorphism. As all other isomorphisms, it comes in two parts:

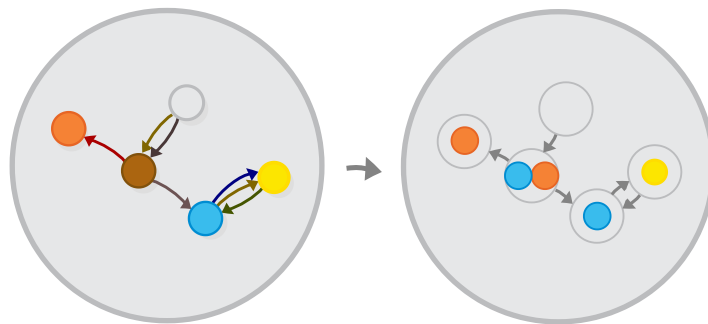
The first part is finding a way to convert a *logical system* into a category - this would not be hard for us, as sets form a category and the flavor of the BHK interpretation that we saw is based on sets.



Logic as a category

Task 6: See whether you can prove that logic propositions and the “implies” relation form a category. What is missing?

The second part involves converting a category into a logical system. This is much harder, and not all categories can be converted to logical systems, only some of them. So, next up, we will enumerate the criteria that a given category has to adhere to, in order for it to be “logical”. These criteria have to guarantee that the category has an object that corresponds to every valid logical propositions and that no objects corresponds to an invalid ones.

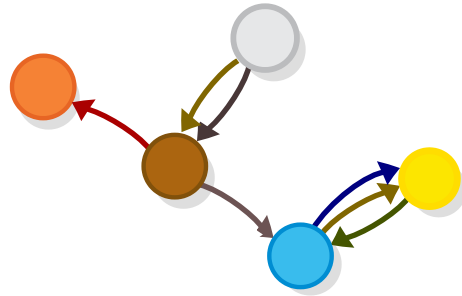


Logic as a category

Categories that adhere to these criteria are called *cartesian closed categories*. To describe them here directly, but instead we would start with a similar but simpler structures that we already examined - orders.

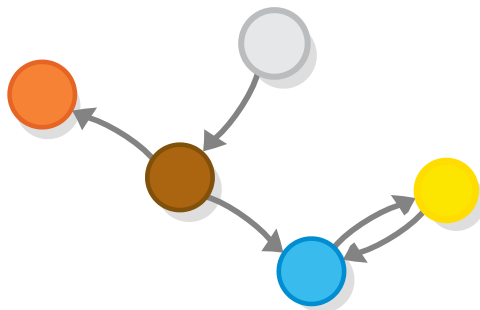
Logics as orders

So, we already saw that a logical system along with a set of primary propositions forms a category.



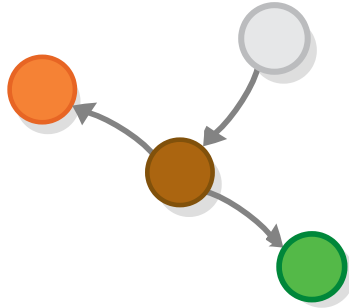
Logic as a preorder

If we assume that there is only one way to go from proposition A , to proposition B (or there are many ways, but we are not interested in the difference between them), then logic is not only a category, but a *preorder* in which the relationship “bigger than” is taken to mean “implies”, so $(A \rightarrow B \text{ is } A > B)$.



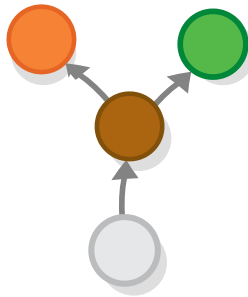
Logic as a preorder

Furthermore, if we count propositions that follow from each other (or sets of propositions that are proven by the same proof) as equivalent, then logic is a proper *partial order*.



Logic as an order

And so it can be represented by a Hasse diagram, in which $A \rightarrow B$ only if A is below B in the diagram.



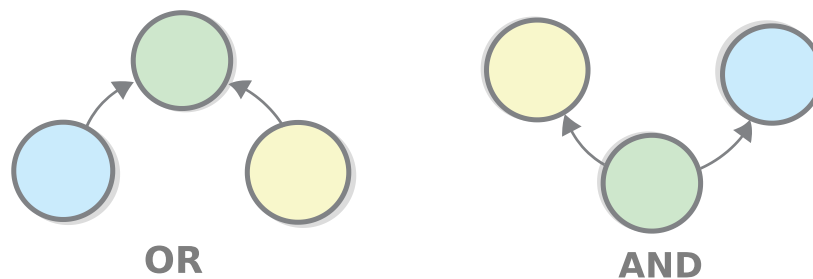
Logic as an order

This is something quite characteristic of category theory — examining a concept in a more limited version of a category (in this case orders), in order to make things simpler for ourselves.

Now let's examine the question that we asked before - exactly which ~~categories~~ orders represent logic and what laws does an order have to obey so it is isomorphic to a logical system? We will attempt to answer this question as we examine the elements of logic again, this time in the context of orders.

The and and or operations

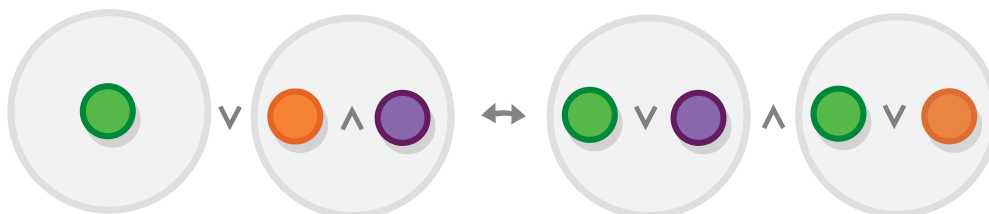
By now you probably realized that the *and* and *or* operations are the bread and butter of logic (although it's not clear which is which). As we saw, in the BHK interpretation those are represented by set *products* and *sums*. The equivalent constructs in the realm of order theory are *meets* and *joins* (in category-theoretic terms *products* and *coproducts*.)



Order meet and joining

Logic allows you to combine any two propositions in an *and* or *or* relationship, so, in order for an order to be “logical” (to be a correct representation for a logical system,) *it has to have meet and join operations for all elements*. Incidentally we already know how such orders are called - they are called *lattices*.

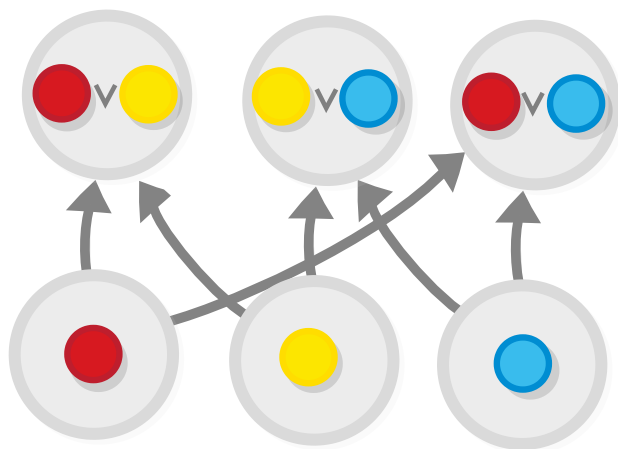
And there is one important law of the *and* and *or* operations, that is not always present in all lattices. It concerns the connection between the two, i.e. way that they distribute, over one another.



The distributivity operation of “and” and “or”

Lattices that obey this law are called *distributive lattices*.

Wait, where have we heard about distributive lattices before? In the previous chapter we said that they are isomorphic to *inclusion orders* i.e. orders of sets, that contain a given collection of elements, and that contain *all combinations* of a given set of elements. The fact that they popped up again is not coincidental — “logical” orders are isomorphic to inclusion orders. To understand why, you only need to think about the BHK interpretation — the elements which participate in the inclusion are our prime propositions. And the inclusions are all combinations of these elements, in an *or* relationship (for simplicity’s sake, we are ignoring the *and* operation.)



A color mixing poset, ordered by inclusion

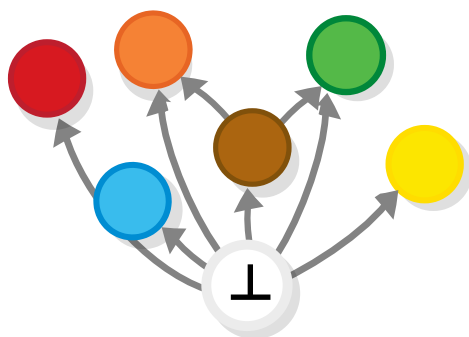
The *or* and *and* operations (or, more generally, the *coproduct* and the *product*) are, of course, categorically dual, which would explain why the symbols that represent them $\vee$ and $\wedge$ are the one and the same symbol, but flipped vertically.

And even the symbol itself looks like a representation of the way the arrows converge. This is probably not the case, as this symbol is used way before Hasse diagrams were a thing — for all we know the $\vee$ symbol is probably symbolizes the “u” in “uel” (the Latin word for “or”) and the *and* symbol is just a flipped “u”) — but I still find the similarity fascinating.

The *negation* operation

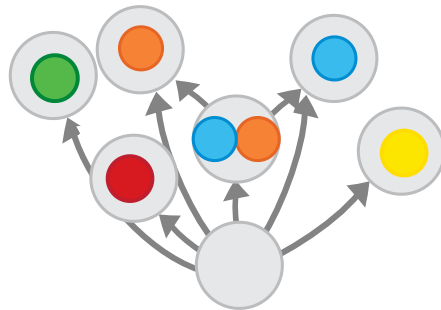
In order for a distributive lattice to represent a logical system, it has to also have objects that correspond to the values *True* and *False* (which are written $\top$ and $\perp$). But, to mandate that these objects exist, we must first find a way to specify what they are in order/category-theoretic terms.

A well-known result in logic, called *the principle of explosion*, states that if we have a proof of *False* (which we write as $\perp$) i.e. if we have a statement “*False* is true” if we use the terminology of classical logic, then any and every other statement can be proven. And we also know that no true statement implies *False* (in fact in intuitionistic logic this is the definition of a true statement). Based on these criteria we know that the *False* object would look like this when compared to other objects:



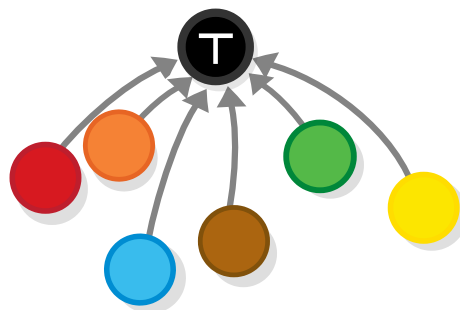
False, represented as a Hasse diagram

Circling back to the BHK interpretation, we see that the empty set fits both of these conditions.



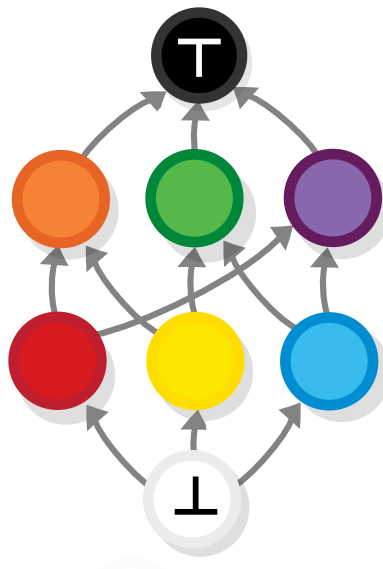
False, represented as a Hasse diagram

Conversely, the proof of *True* which we write as T , expressing the statement that "*True* is true", is trivial and doesn't say anything, so *nothing follows from it*, but at the same time it follows from every other statement.



True, represented as a Hasse diagram

So *True* and *False* are just the *greatest* and *least* objects of our order (in category-theoretic terms *terminal* and *initial* object.)



The whole logical system, represented as a Hasse diagram

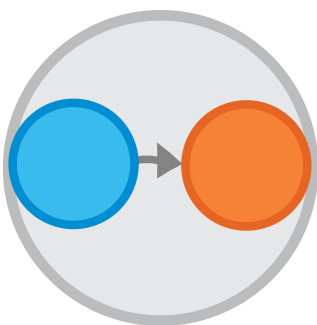
This is another example of the categorical concept of duality - $\top$ and $\perp$ are dual to each other, which makes a lot of sense if you think about it, and also helps us remember their symbols (although if you are like me, you'll spent a year before you stop wondering which one is which, every time I see them).

In fact, the whole lattice can be turned upside down and (switching the directions of the arrows and the dual concepts True/False and/or) the logic inside it will still be valid!

The *implies* operation

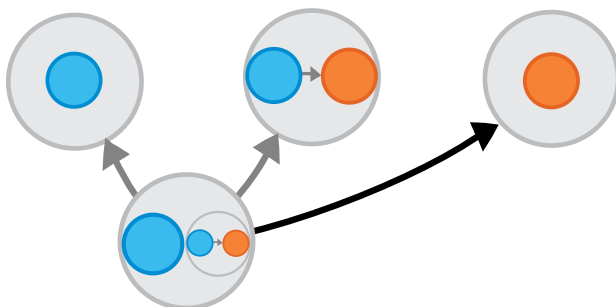
So, by now we know that our distributive lattice has to also be *bounded* i.e. it has to have greatest and least elements (which play the roles of *True* and *False*) in order to represent logic. As we said, every lattice has representations of propositions implying one another (i.e. it has arrows), but to really represents a logical

system it also has to have *function objects* i.e. there needs to be a rule that identifies a unique object $A \rightarrow B$ for each pair of objects A and B , such that all axioms of logic are followed.



Implies operation

We will describe this object in the same way we described all other operations — by defining a structure consisting of a of objects and arrows in which $A \rightarrow B$ plays a part. And this structure is actually a categorical reincarnation our favorite rule of inference, the *modus ponens*.

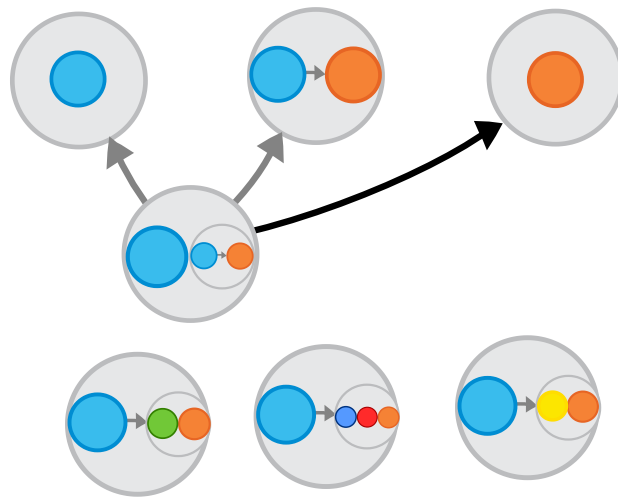


Implies operation

Modus ponens is the essence of the *implies* operation, and, because we already know how the operations that it contains (*and* and *implies*) are represented in our lattice, we can directly use it as a definition by saying that the object $A \rightarrow B$ is the one for which modus ponens rule holds.

The function object $A \rightarrow B$ is an object which is related to objects A and B in such a way that $A \wedge (A \rightarrow B) \rightarrow B$.

This definition is not complete, however, because (as usual) $A \rightarrow B$ is *not the only object* that fits in this formula. For example, the set $A \rightarrow B \wedge C$ is also one such object, as is $A \rightarrow B \wedge C \wedge D$

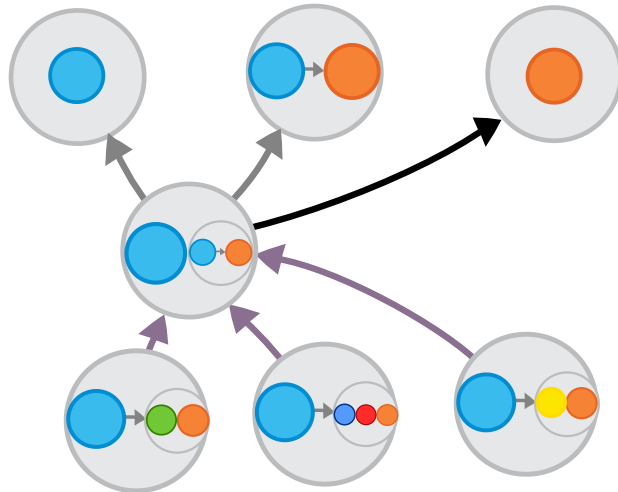


Implies operation with universal property

So how do we set apart the real formula from all those “imposter” formulas? If you remember the definitions of the *categorical product* (or of its equivalent for orders, the *meet* operation) you would already know where this is going: we recognize that $A \rightarrow B$ is the upper *limit* of $A \rightarrow B \wedge C$. So, $A \rightarrow B \wedge C \wedge D$ and all other imposter formulas that can be in the place of X in $A \wedge X \rightarrow B$ are below it. The relationship can be described in a variety of ways:

- We can say that $A \rightarrow B$ is the most *trivial* result for which the formula $A \wedge X \rightarrow B$ is satisfied and that all other results are *stronger*

- We can say that all other formulas lie *below* $A \rightarrow B$ in the Hasse diagram (so, the more trivial the result it, the upper it resides in the Hasse diagram).
- We can say that all other results imply $A \rightarrow B$ but not the other way around (which again means the same thing).



Implies operation with universal property

So, after choosing the best way to express the relationship (they are all equivalent) we are ready to present our final definition:

The function object $A \rightarrow B$ is the topmost object which is related to objects A and B in such a way that $A \wedge (A \rightarrow B) \rightarrow B$.

The existence of this function object (called *exponential object* or *hom-object* in category-theoretic terms) is the final condition for an order/lattice to be a representation of logic.

Note, by the way, that this definition of function object is valid specifically for intuitionistic logic. For classical logic, the definition of is simpler — there $A \rightarrow B$ is just $\neg A \vee B$, because of the law of excluded middle.

Note also, that there might be several objects that play the role of $A \rightarrow B$, for some A and B , but they would be isomorphic to each other i.e. like meets and joins, function object is defined *up to a (unique) isomorphism*.

The *if and only if* operation

When we examined the *if and only if* operation can be defined in terms *implies*, that is $A \leftrightarrow B$ is equivalent to $A \rightarrow B \wedge B \rightarrow A$.



Implies identity

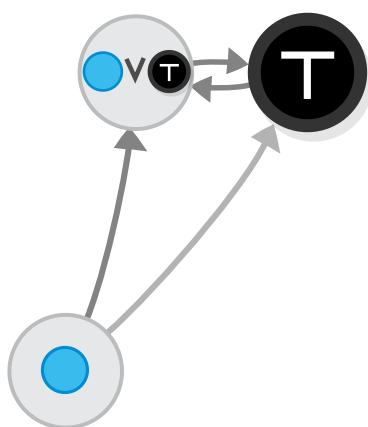
We have something similar for categorical logic as well — We say that when two propositions are connected to each other, then, particularly when we speak of orders, they are isomorphic.

A taste of categorical logic

In the previous section we saw some definitions, here we will convince ourselves that they really capture the concept of logic correctly, by proving some results using categorical logic.

True and False

The join (or least upper bound) of the *topmost* object T (which plays the role of the value *True*) and any other object that you can think of, is... T itself (or something isomorphic to it, which, as we said, is the same thing). This follows trivially from the fact that the join of two objects must be bigger or equal than both of these objects, and that there is no other object that is bigger or equal to the T is T itself. This is simply because T (as any other object) is equal to itself and because there is by definition no object that is bigger than it.



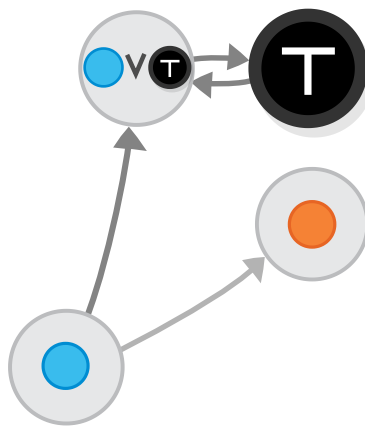
Implies identity

This corresponds to the logical statement that $A \vee T$ is equal to T i.e. it is true. Hence, the above observation is a proof of that statement, (an alternative to truth tables).

Task 7: Think of the duel situation, with False. What does it imply, logically?

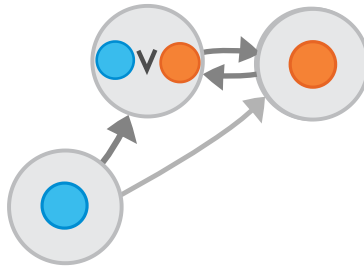
And and Or

Above, we saw that the join between any random object and the top object is the top object itself. But, does this situation only occur when the second object is T ? Wouldn't the same thing happen if T is replaced by any other object that is higher than the first one?



Implies identity

The answer is "Yes": when we are looking for the join of two objects, we are looking for the *least* upper bound i.e. the *lowest* object that is above both of them. So, any time we have two objects and one is higher than the other, their join would be (isomorphic to) the higher object.

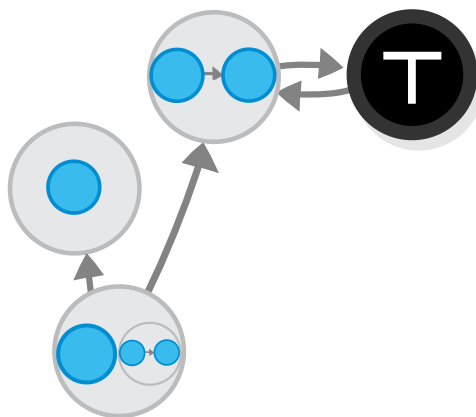


Implies identity

In other words, if $A \rightarrow B$, then $A \vee B \leftrightarrow B$

Implies

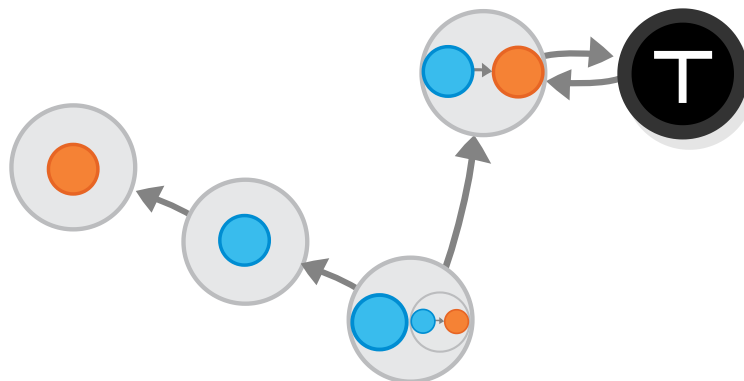
For our first example with implies, let's take the formula $A \rightarrow B$, and examine the case when A and B are the same object. We said that, $A \rightarrow B$ ($A \rightarrow A$ in our case) is the topmost object X for which the criteria given by the formula $A \wedge X \rightarrow B$ is satisfied. But in this case, the formula is satisfied for any X , (because it evaluates to $A \wedge X \rightarrow A$, which is always true), i.e. the topmost object that satisfies it is... the topmost object there is i.e. (an object isomorphic to) *True*.



Implies identity

Does this make sense? Of course it does: in fact, we just proved one of the most famous laws in logic (called the law of identity, as per Aristotle), namely that $A \rightarrow A$ is always true, or that everything follows from itself.

And what happens if A implies B in any model, i.e. if $A \models B$ (semantic consequence)? In this case, A would be below B in our Hasse diagram (e.g. A is the blue ball and B is the orange one). Then the situation is somewhat similar to the previous case: $A \wedge X \rightarrow B$ will be true, no matter what X is (simply because A already implies B , by itself). And so $A \rightarrow B$ will again correspond to the T object.



Implies when A follows from B

This is again a well-known result in logic (if I am not mistaken, it will be a deduction theorem of some sort): if $A \models B$, then the statement $(A \rightarrow B)$ will always be true.

Interlude: Free Heyting algebras – making ourselves a logic

Perhaps the best way to understand the way logic lattices work is to make one ourselves.

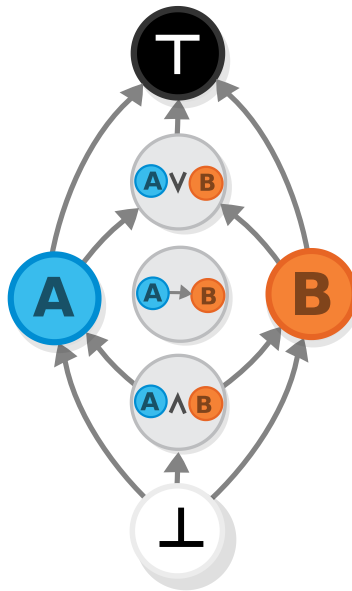
Before we start, let's recap the theoretic part: we saw that intuitionistic logic consists of the values *True* and *False* and the operations *and* *or* and *implies*.



A Heyting algebra

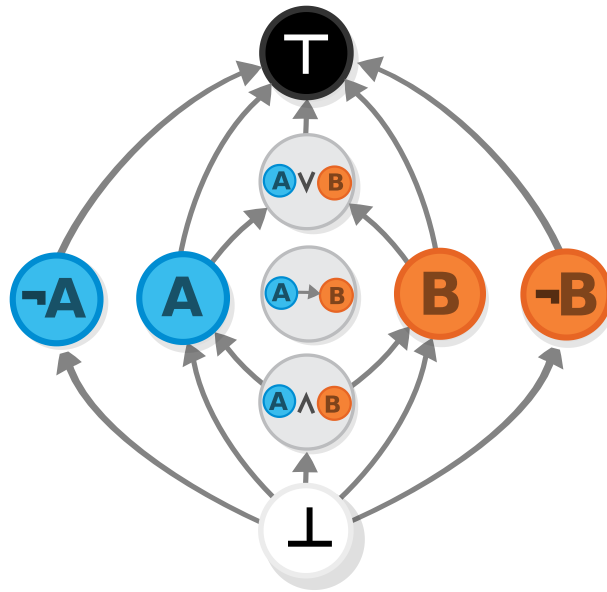
So, for an order to represent logic, an order/category has to have a *greatest and least objects* and it has to have a *meet* and *join* for each two object, and also a function object (the law of distributivity which we mentioned earlier is always true for lattices that have function object). In other words it has to be a

bounded ($\top$ and $\perp$) *lattice* ($\wedge$ and $\vee$) that has *function objects* ($\rightarrow$). Such lattices are called *Heyting algebras*.



Heyting algebra

By the way, a lattice can follow the laws of *classical logic*, as well. it has to be *bounded* and *distributive* and in addition to that it has to be *complemented* which is to say that each proposition A , there exist an a unique proposition $\neg A$ (such that $A \vee \neg A = 1$ and $A \wedge \neg A = 0$). These lattices are called *boolean algebras*.



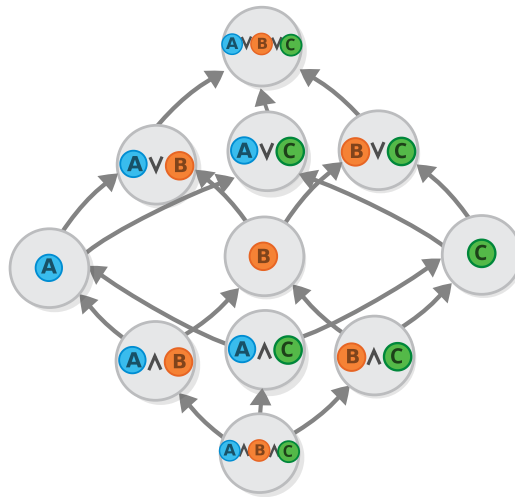
Boolean algebra

Anyway, making a logical lattice involves picking some primary propositions and graphing the connections between them. First, we pick the primary propositions that we want to work with, those are the statements that depend on our problem domain (or, in this case, just our color preferences).



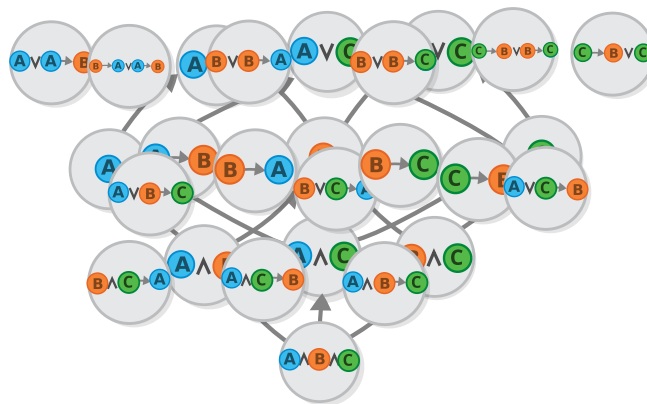
Logic as an order

Then, depending of the flavor of logic that we selected (intuitionistic, boolean), we start graphing the composite propositions, we have to have $A \wedge B$, $A \vee B$ for all A s and B s.



Logic as an order

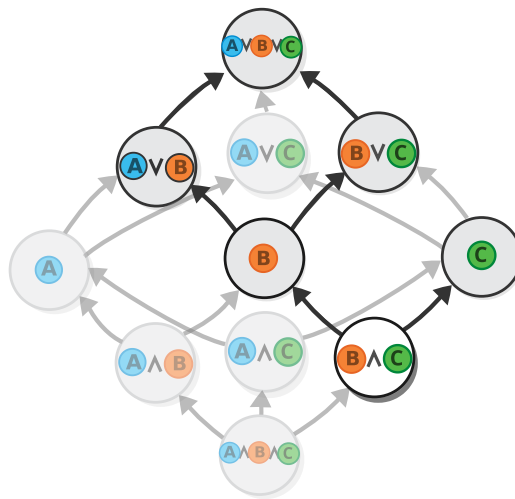
Then, we also have to create a proposition $A \rightarrow B$, for all A -s and B -s, which would make our list of propositions grow indefinitely (side note: drawing such diagrams is very hard and I can never be quite sure which is the correct place for each proposition, so please report me any errors you might see: I can send you a 100\$ check, like Donald Knuth, but only if you promise not to cash it, as I am broke)).



Logic as an order

Whew, that was lengthy. But it is worth it, as when we are finished we will have a list of *all possible propositions that can be true* and we will be able to determine which propositions follow from any proposition by just following the path of the arrows coming from it.

Like, for example, if we discover that the proposition $B \wedge C$ is true, that implies that both B and C are also true in their own right, (which, in turn, implies that $A \vee B$, $A \vee C$ etc. are true).



Logic as an order

In general, doing intuitionistic logic is this — we start by the things that we already know and then we find the path that leads us to the things that we are interested in proving (or, depending on the viewpoint, we construct the proof by manipulating the proofs that we already have). The only thing we are not able to do (in intuitionistic logic, specifically) is to prove that a given fact cannot be reached from on our path, that it cannot be proved from the axioms (“you cannot prove a negative”).

Answers

Task 1: Draw the diagram for *or*

The *or* operation can be represented as a function that takes a pair of boolean values and returns `True` if at least one of them is `True`.

p	q	p $\vee$ q
True	True	True
True	False	True
False	True	True
False	False	False

Task 2: What would be the *or* operation in the BHK interpretation?

In the BHK interpretation, the proof of $A \vee B$ the well-known disjoint union/coproduct/meet — a structure, containing either a proof of A or a proof of B , along with information about which one it is.

Task 3: Verify there cannot exist a function from any set to the empty set.

For any non-empty set A , there cannot be a function $f: A \rightarrow \emptyset$ because: A function must assign to each element of A exactly

one element of $\emptyset$ but $\emptyset$ has no elements, so there's nothing to assign.

The only exception is when A is also empty (see next question).

Task 4: Verify there exists a function from the empty set to any set

There is exactly one function from $\emptyset$ to any set B , called the *empty function*:

A function must assign to each element of the domain exactly one element of the codomain, so if $\emptyset$ has no elements this condition is satisfied

And we mentioned the corresponding logical principle of explosion, that says that everything follows from *False*.

Task 5: Install a proof assistant

Here you are on your own, sorry :)

Task 6: See whether you can prove that logic propositions and the “implies” relation form a category

We want to prove that there is a category with logical propositions as object and implication as morphism. Let's check the axioms:

- *Identity* is covered — as we said, for every proposition A , we have $A \rightarrow A$

- *Composition* too, because $A \rightarrow B$ and $B \rightarrow C$, then $A \rightarrow C$, this easily follows from modus ponens (this can be your first proof with the proof assistant).
- *Associativity* also checks out as $(A \rightarrow B) \rightarrow ((B \rightarrow C) \rightarrow (A \rightarrow C))$.

And, if we want to consider all proofs from $A \rightarrow B$ as equivalent, we get an order, else, a normal category.

Task 7: Think of the dual situation with False

The dual situation concerns the meet operation ($\wedge$) and the bottom element $\perp$ (False):

$$\perp : A \wedge \perp = \perp$$

That is, if we unite any statement with a false statement, the result would be always be false e.g. the statement “The grass is green *and* pigs can fly” is false (and changing the part where we say “The grass is green” to something else won’t change that).

This is, of course dual to the one we mentioned:

$$A \vee \top = \top$$

Functors

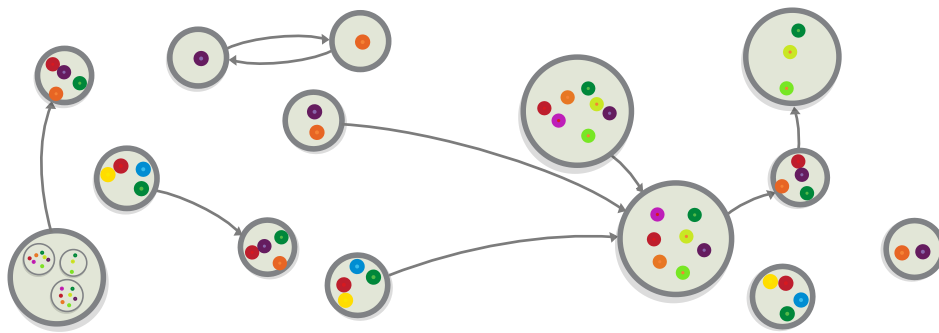
From this chapter on, we will change the tactic a bit (as I am sure you are tired of jumping through different subjects) and we will dive at full throttle into the world of categories, using the structures that we saw so far as context. This will allow us to generalize some of the concepts that we examined in these structures and thus make them (the concepts) valid for all categories.

Categories we saw so far

So far, we saw many different categories and category types. Let's review them once more:

The category of sets

We began by reviewing the mother of all categories — *the category of sets*.

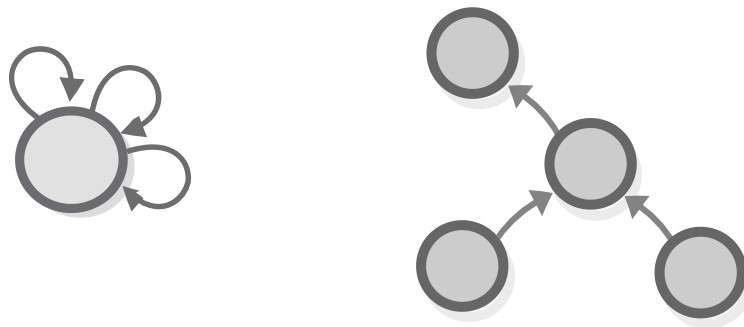


The category of sets

We also saw that it contains within itself many other categories, such as the category of types in programming languages.

Special types of categories

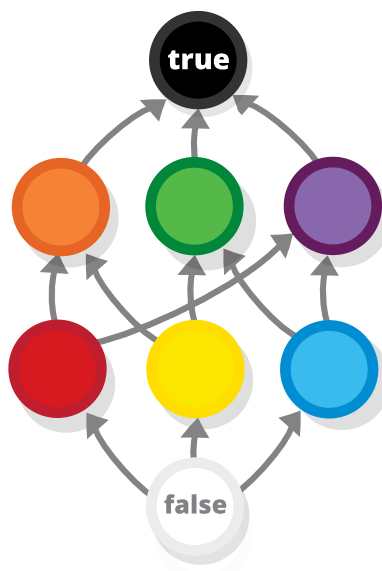
We also learned about other algebraic objects that turned out to be just *special types of categories*, like categories that have just one *object* (monoids, groups) and categories that have only one *morphism* between any two objects (preorders, partial orders).



Types of categories

Other categories

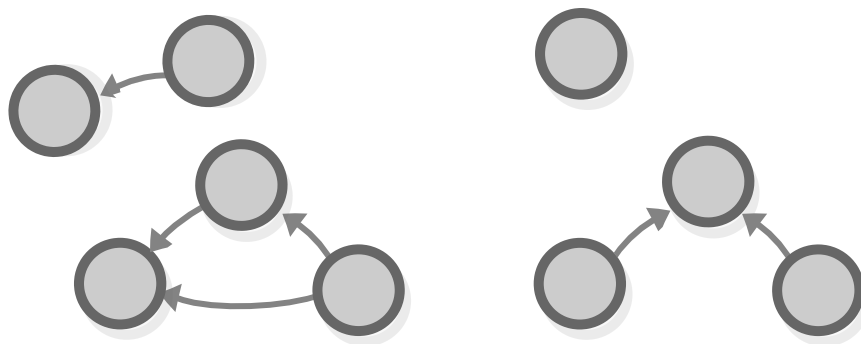
We also defined a lot of *categories based on different concepts*, like the ones based on logics/programming languages, but also some “less-serious ones”, as for example the color-mixing partial order/category.



Category of colors

Finite categories

And most importantly, we saw some categories that are *completely made up*, such as my soccer player hierarchy. Those are formally called *finite categories*.



Finite categories

Although they are not useful by themselves, the idea behind them is important — we can draw any combination of points and arrows and call it a category, in the same way that we can construct a set out of every combination of objects.

Examining some finite categories

For future reference, let's see some important finite categories.

The simplest category is 0 (enjoy the minimalism of this diagram).

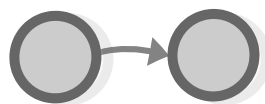
The finite category 0

The next simplest category is 1 — it is comprised of one object and no morphisms besides its identity morphism (which we don't draw, as usual)



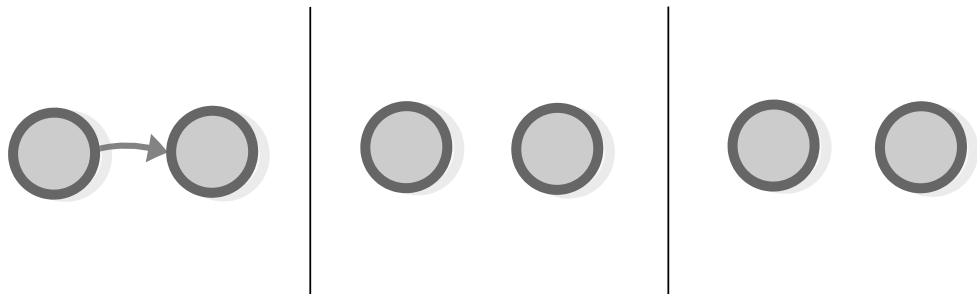
the finite category 1

If we increment the number of objects to two, we see a couple of more interesting categories, like for example the category 2 containing two objects and one morphism.



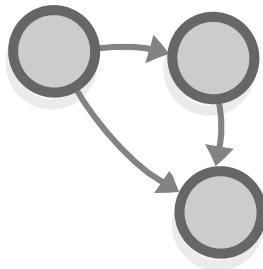
the finite category 2

Task 1: There are just two more categories that have 2 objects and at most one morphism between two objects, draw them.



the finite category 2

And finally the category 3 has 3 objects and also 3 morphisms (one of which is the composition of the other two).



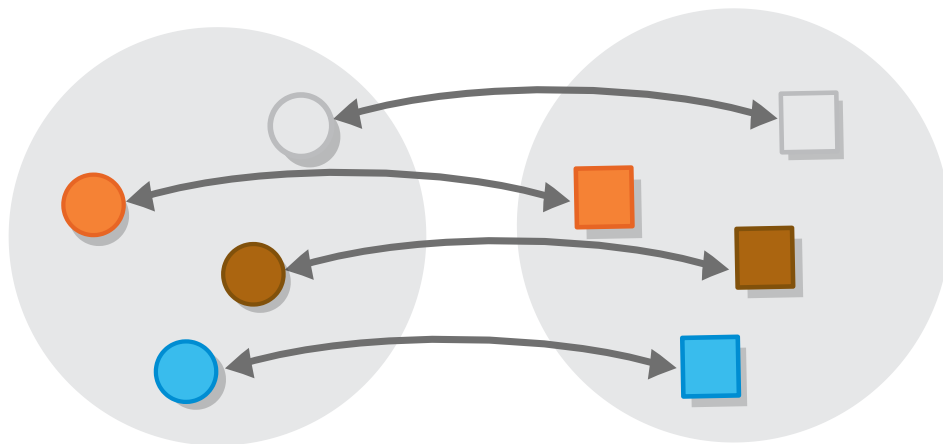
the finite category 3

Categorical isomorphisms

Many of the categories that we saw are similar to one another, as for example, both the color-mixing order and categories that represent logic have a *greatest* and a *least* object. To pinpoint such similarities, and understand what they mean, it is useful to have formal ways to connect categories with one another. The simplest type of such connection is the good old isomorphism.

Set isomorphisms

In chapter 1 we talked about *set isomorphisms*, which establish an equivalence between two sets. In case you have forgotten, a set isomorphism is a *two-way function* between two sets.

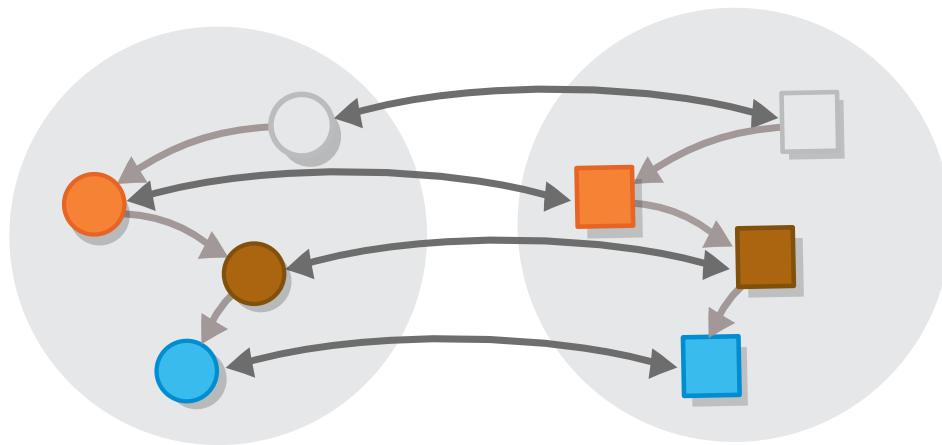


Set isomorphism

It can alternatively be viewed as two “twin” functions such that each of which equals identity, when composed with the other one.

Order isomorphisms

Then, in chapter 4, we encountered *order isomorphisms* and we saw that they are like set isomorphisms, but with one extra condition — aside from just being there, the functions that define the isomorphism have to preserve the order of the object e.g. the greatest object of one order should be connected to the greatest object of the other one, the least object of one order should be connected to the least object of the other one, and same for all objects that are in between.



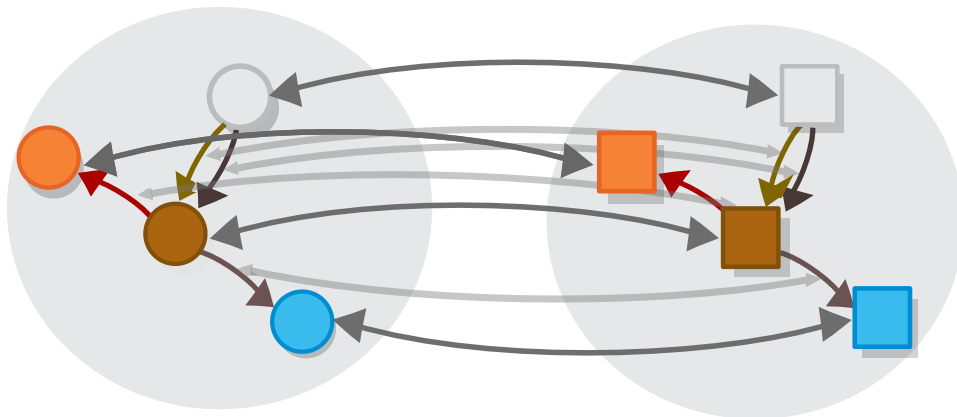
Order isomorphism

Or more formally put, for any a and b if we have $a \leq b$ we should also have $F(a) \leq F(b)$ (and vice versa).

Categorical isomorphisms

Now, we will generalize the definition of an order isomorphism, so it also applies to all other categories (i.e. to categories that may have more than one morphism between two objects):

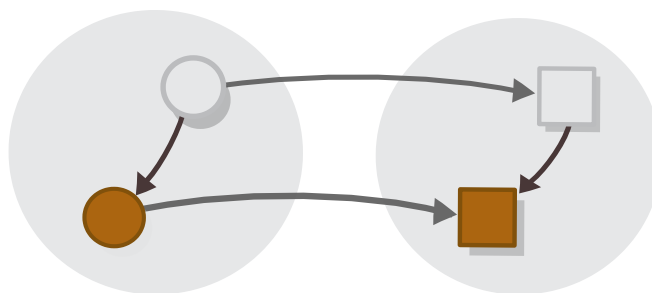
Given two categories, an isomorphism between them is an invertible mapping between the underlying sets of objects, *and* an invertible mapping between the morphisms that connect them, which maps each morphism from one category to a morphism *with the same signature*.



Category isomorphism

After examining this definition closely, we realize that, although it *sounds* a bit more complex (and *looks* a bit messier) than the one we have for orders *it is actually the same thing*.

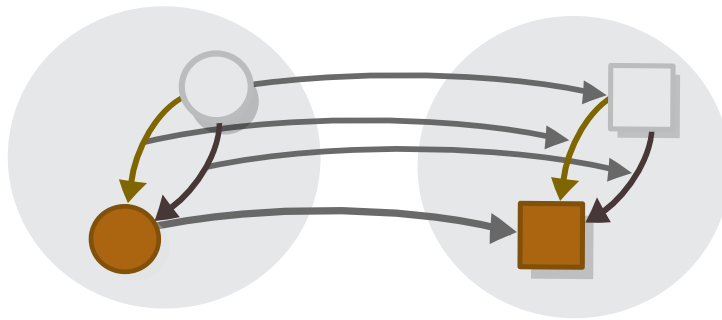
It is just that the so-called “morphism mapping” between categories that have just one morphism for any two objects are trivial, and so we can omit them.



Order isomorphism

Task 2: What is the morphism mapping for orders?

However, when we can have more than one morphism between two given objects, we need to make sure that each morphism in the source category has a corresponding morphism in the target one, and for this reason we need not only a mapping between the categories' objects, but one between their morphisms.



Category isomorphism

By the way, what we just did (taking a concept that is defined for a more narrow structure (orders) and redefining it for a more broad one (categories)) is called *generalizing* of the concept.

The problem with categorical isomorphisms

By examining them more closely, we realize that categorical isomorphisms are not so hard to define. However there is another issue with them, namely that they *don't capture the essence of what categorical equality should be*. I have devised a very good and intuitive explanation why is it the case, that this ~~margin~~ section is too narrow to contain. So we will leave it for the next chapter, where we will also devise a more apt way to define a *two-way connection* between categories.

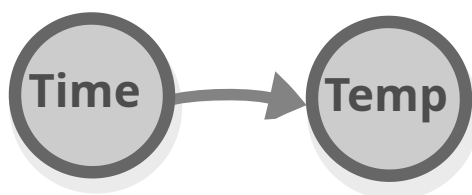
But first, we need to examine *one-way connections* between them, i.e. *functors*.

PS: Categorical isomorphisms are also *very rare in practice* — the only one that comes to mind is the Curry-Howard-Lambek isomorphism from the previous chapter. That's because if two categories are isomorphic then there is no reason at all to treat them as different categories — they are one and the same.

What are functors

The logician Rudolf Carnap coined the term “functor” as part of his project to formalize the syntax for the natural languages such as English in order to create a precise way for us to talk about science. Originally, a functor meant a word or phrase whose meaning can be customized by combining it with a numerical value, such as the phrase “the temperature at x o’clock”, which has a different meaning depending on the value of x .

In other words, a functor is a phrase that *acts as a function*, only not a function between sets, but one between *linguistic concepts* (such as times and temperature).

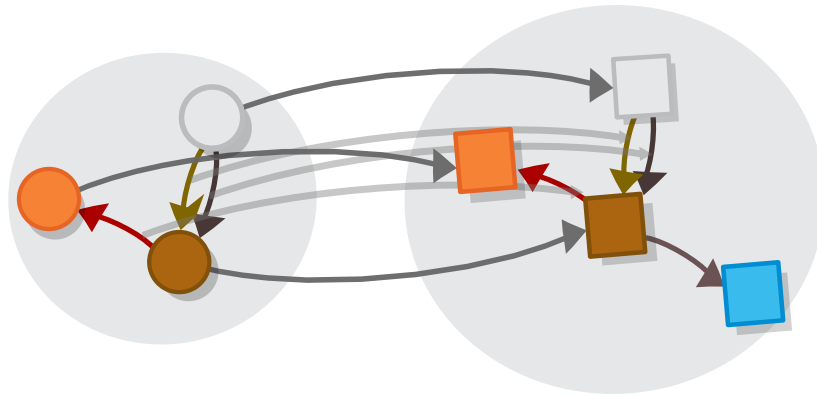


Functor, as envisioned by Rudolf Carnap.

Later, one of the inventors of category theory Sanders Mac Lane borrowed the word, to describe a something that *acts as function between categories*, which he defined in the following way:

A functor between two categories (let’s call them A and B) consists of two mappings — a mapping that maps each *object* in A to an object in B and a mapping that maps each

morphism between any objects in A to a morphism between objects in B , in a way that *preserves the structure* of the category.

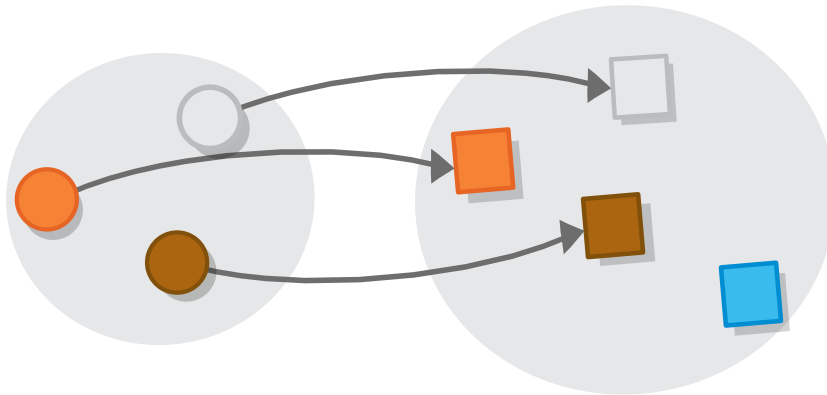


Functor

Now let's unpack this definition by going through each of its components.

Object mapping

In the definition above, we use the word “mapping” to avoid misusing the word “function” for something that isn't exactly a function. But in this particular case, calling the mapping a function would barely be a misuse — if we forget about morphisms and treat the source and target categories as sets, the object mapping is nothing but a regular old function.



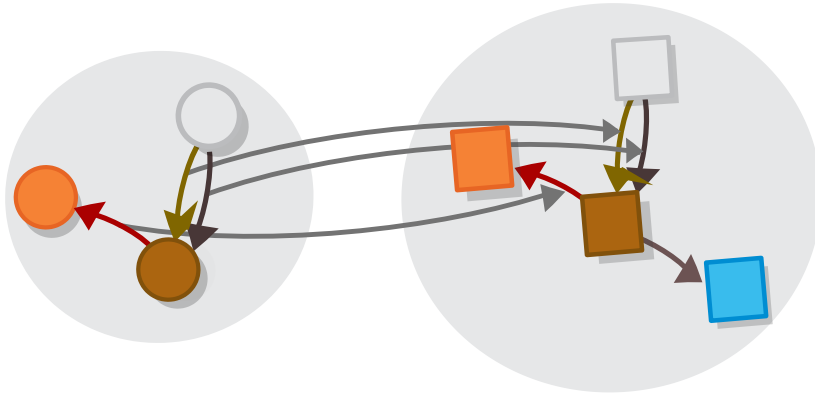
Functor for objects

A more formal definition of object mapping involves the concept of an *underlying set* of a category: Given a category A , the underlying set of A is a set that has the objects of A as elements. Utilizing this concept, we say that the object mapping of a functor between two categories is *a function between their underlying sets*. The definition of a function is still the same:

A function is a relationship between two sets that matches each element of one set, called the *source set* of the function, with exactly one element from another set, called the *target set* of the function.

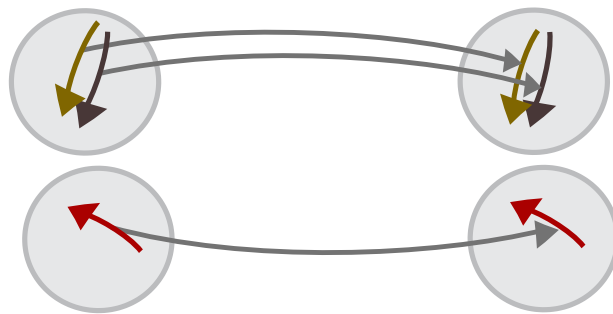
Morphism mapping

The second mapping that forms the functor is a mapping between the categories' morphisms. This mapping resembles a function as well, but with the added requirement that each morphism in A a given source and target must be mapped to a morphism with the corresponding source and target in B , as per the object mapping.



Functor for morphisms

A more formal definition of a morphism mapping involves the concept of the *homomorphism set*: this is a set that contains all morphisms that go between two given objects in a given category. When utilizing this concept, we say that a mapping between the morphisms of two categories consists of a *set of functions between their respective homomorphism sets*.



Functor for morphisms

Notice how the concepts of *homomorphism set* and of *underlying set* allowed us to “escape” to set theory when defining categorical concepts and define everything using functions?

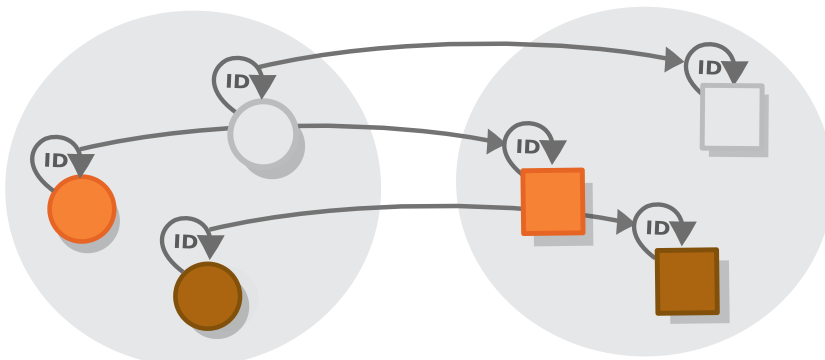
Functor laws

So these are the two mappings (one between objects and one between morphisms) that constitute a functor. But not every pair of such two mappings is a functor. As we said, in addition to existing, the mappings should *preserve the structure* of the source category into the target category. To see what that means, we revisit the definition of a category from chapter 2:

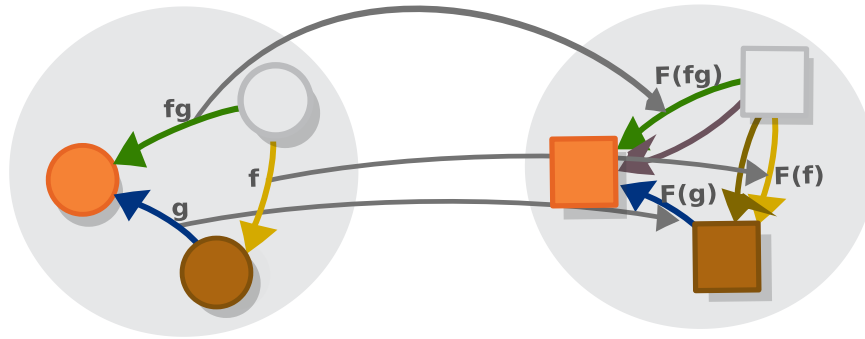
A category is a collection of *objects* (we can think of them as points) and *morphisms* (arrows) that go from one object to another, where: 1. Each object has to have the identity morphism. 2. There should be a way to compose two morphisms with an appropriate type signature into a third one, in a way that is associative.

So this definition translates to the following two *functor laws*

1. Functions between morphisms should *preserve identities* i.e. all identity morphisms should be mapped to other identity morphisms.



2. Functors should also *preserve composition* i.e. for any two morphisms f and g , the morphism that corresponds to their composition $F(g \circ f)$ in the source category should be mapped to the morphism that corresponds to the composition of their counterparts in the target category, so $F(g \circ f) = F(g) \circ F(f)$.



Functor

And these laws conclude the definition of functors — a simple but, as we will see shortly, very powerful concept.

To see *why* is it so powerful, let's check some examples.

Functors in everyday language

There is a common figure of speech (which is used all the time in this book) which goes like this:

If a is like Fa , then b is like Fb .

Or " a is related to Fa , in the same way as b is related to Fb ," e.g. "If schools are like corporations, then teachers are like bosses".

This figure of speech is nothing but a way to describe a functor in our day-to-day language: what we mean by it is that there is a certain set of connections (or category-theory terms a "morphisms") between schools and teachers, that is similar to the connections between corporations and bosses i.e. that there is some kind of structure-preserving map that connects the category of school-related things, to the category of work-related things which maps schools (a) to corporations (Fa) and

teacher (b) to bosses (Fb), and which is such that the connections between schools and teachers ($a \rightarrow b$) are mapped to the connections between corporations and bosses ($Fa \rightarrow Fb$).

Diagrams are functors

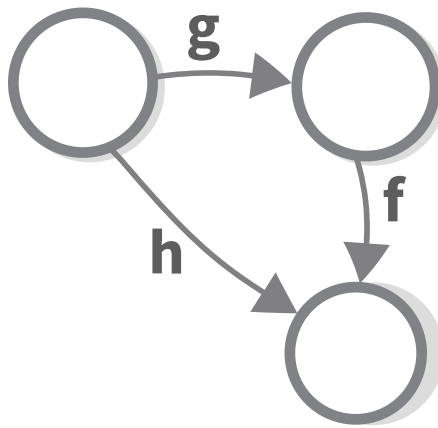
“A sign is something by knowing which we know something more.” — Charles Sanders Peirce

We will start with an example of a functor that is very *meta* — the diagrams/illustrations in this book.

You might have noticed that diagrams play a special role in category theory — while in other disciplines their function is merely complementary i.e. they only show what is already defined in another way, here *the diagrams themselves serve as definitions*.

For example, in chapter 1 we presented the following definition of functional composition.

The composition of two functions f and g is a third function h defined in such a way that this diagram commutes.



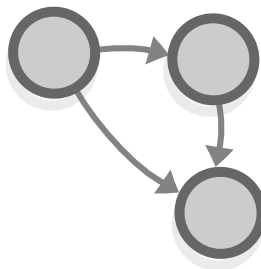
Functional composition - general definition

We all see the benefit of defining stuff by means of diagrams as opposed to writing lengthy definitions like

“Suppose you have three objects a , b and c and two morphisms $f: b \rightarrow c$ and $g: a \rightarrow b$...”

However, it (defining stuff by means of diagrams) presents a problem — definitions in mathematics are supposed to be formal, so if we want to use diagrams as definitions we must first *formalize the definition of a diagram itself*.

So how can we do that? One key observation is that diagrams look as finite categories, as, for example, the above definition looks in the same way as the category 3.



the finite category 3

However, this is only part of the story as finite categories are just structures, whereas diagrams are *signs*. They are “something by knowing which we know something more.”, as Peirce famously put it (or “...which can be used in order to tell a lie”, in the words of Umberto Eco).

For this reason, aside from a finite category that encodes the diagram’s structure, the definition of a diagram must also include a way for “interpreting” this category in some other context i.e. they must include *functors*.

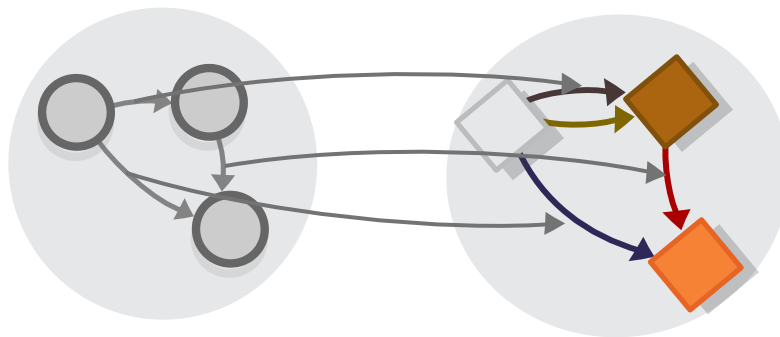


diagram as a functor

This is how the concept of functors allows us to formalize the notion of diagrams:

A *diagram* is comprised of one finite category (called an *index category*) and a functor from it to some other category.

If you know about semiotics, you may view the source and target categories of the functor as *signifier* and *signified*.

And so, you can already see that the concept of a functor plays a very important role in category theory. Because of it, diagrams in

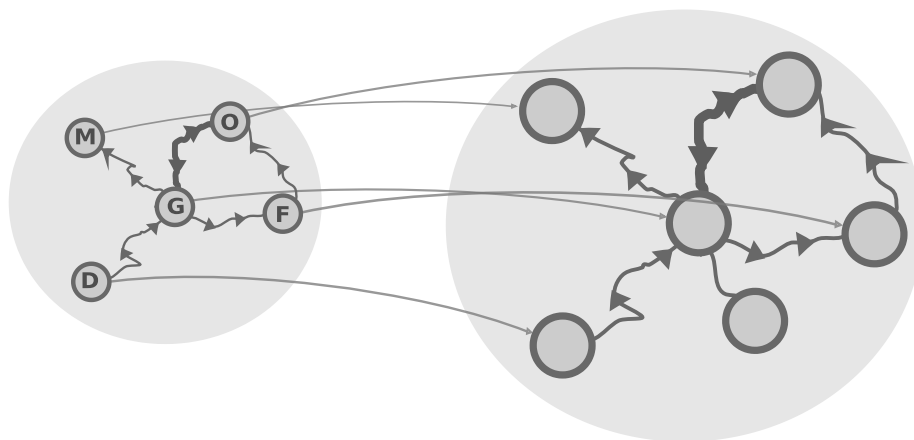
category theory can be *specified formally* i.e. they are categorical objects *per se*.

You might even say that they are categorical objects *par excellence* (TODO: remove that last joke).

Maps are functors

A map is not the territory it represents, but, if correct, it has a similar structure to the territory, which accounts for its usefulness. — Alfred Korzybski

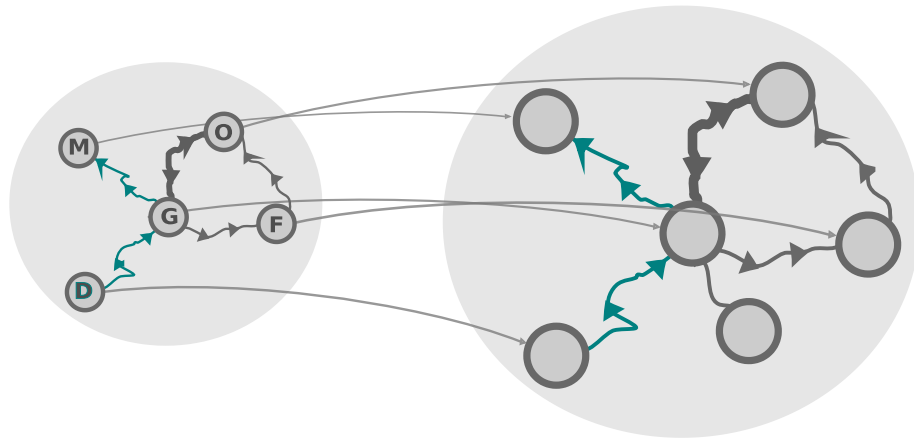
Functors are sometimes called “maps” for a good reason — maps, like all other diagrams, are functors. If we consider some space, containing cities and roads that we travel by, as a category, in which the cities are objects and roads between them are morphisms, then a road map can be viewed as category that represent some region of that space, together with a functor that maps the objects in the map to real-world objects.



A map and a preorder of city pathways

In maps, morphisms that are a result of composition are often not displayed, but we use them all the time — they are called

routes. And the law of preserving composition tells us that every route that we create on a map corresponds to a real-world route.



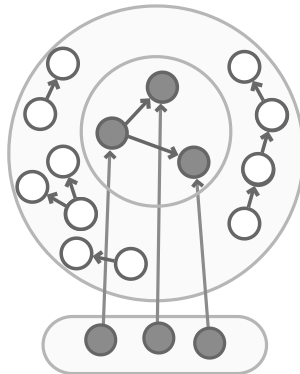
A map and a preorder of city pathways

Notice that in order to be a functor, a map does not have to list *all* roads that exist in real life, and *all* traveling options (“the map is not the territory”), the only requirement is that *the roads that it lists should be actual* — this is a characteristic shared by all many-to-one relationships (i.e. functions).

Human perception might be functorial

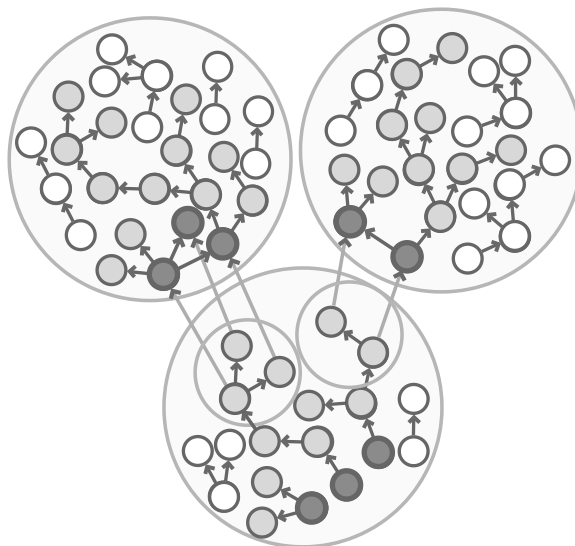
As we saw, in addition to category theory, functors appear in many disciplines that study the human mind, such as logic, linguistics, semiotics and the like. I thought about why is it so in a [blog post](#) that I wrote. My response to that question is that human perception, human thinking, is itself functorial: to perceive the world around us, we are going through a bunch of functors that go from more raw “low-level” mental models to more abstract “high-level” ones.

We may say that perception starts with raw sensory data. From it, we go, (using a functor) to a category containing some basic model of how the world works, mapping the objects we are seeing to some concepts that we formed in our mind.



Perception is functorial

Then we are connecting this model to another, even more abstract model (or models), which provide us with a higher-level overview of the situation that we are in, again using functorial connection (technically these are functors from subcategories).



Perception is functorial

You can view this as a progression of connections that go from simpler to more abstract (i.e. from categories with less morphisms to categories with more morphisms).

These connections are functorial in nature, because they work purely in terms of *structure*: the idea of a given object has nothing in common with the object itself (e.g. the idea of a biscuit isn't round, sweet etc). What ideas have in common with the objects of representation is that the connections they have between one another mimic some connections a real-life biscuit has with other objects.

All this is, of course, just a speculation, but how else would we be capable of forming thoughts, e.g. to imagine a person riding a bike and bumping in a tree, when no part of our brains (nor the impulses they create) resembles in any way people/bikes/trees?

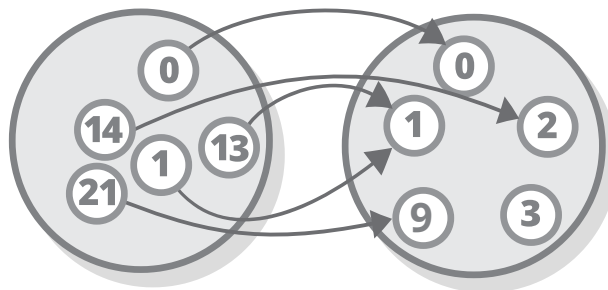
The answer is structure — thoughts have the structure of the situation, that's why they refer to it (although they cannot refer to any of the elements by itself).

Functors in monoids

So, after this slight detour, we will return to our usual *modus operandi*.

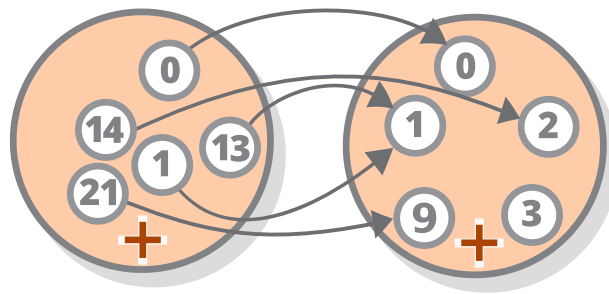
Hey, do you know that in group theory, there is this cool thing called *group homomorphism* (or *monoid homomorphism* when we are talking about monoids) — it is a function between the groups' underlying sets which preserves the group operation.

So, for example, If the time of the day right now is 00:00 o'clock (or 12 PM) then what would the time be after n hours? The answer to this question can be expressed as a function with the set of integers as source and target.



Group homomorphism as a function

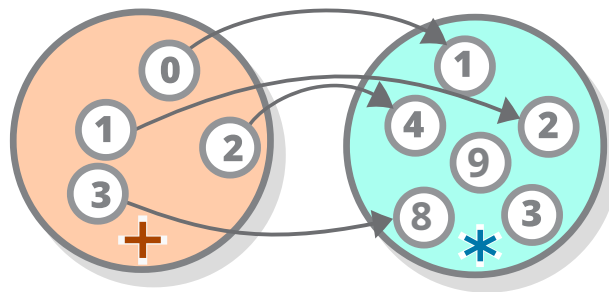
This function is interesting — it preserves the operation of (modular) addition: if, 13 hours from now the time will be 1 o'clock and if 14 hours from now it will be 2 o'clock, then the time after $(13 + 14)$ hours will be $(1 + 2)$ o'clock.



Group homomorphism

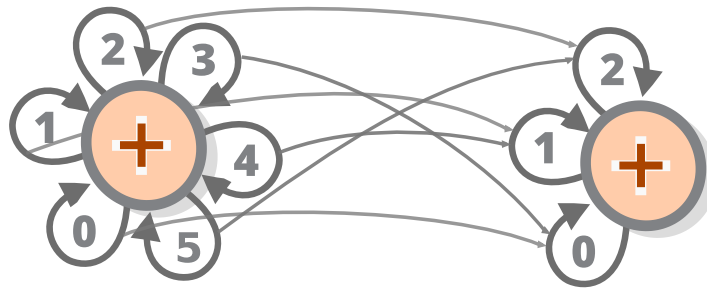
Or to put it formally, if we call it (the function) F , then we have the following equation: $F(a+b) = F(a) + F(b)$ (where $+$ in the right-hand side of the equation means modular addition). Because this equation holds, the F function is a *group homomorphism* between the group of integers under addition and the group of modulo arithmetic with base 11 under modular addition (where you can replace 11 with any other number).

The groups don't have to be so similar for there to be a homomorphism between them. Take, for example, the function that maps any number n to 2 to the *power of* n , so $n \rightarrow 2^n$ (here, again, you can replace 2 with any other number). This function gives a rise to a group homomorphism between the group of integers under addition and the integers under multiplication, or $F(a+b) = F(a) \times F(b)$.



Group homomorphism between different groups

Wait, what were we talking about, again? Oh yeah — group homomorphisms are functors. To see why, we switch to the category-theoretic representation of groups and revisit our first example and (to make the diagram simpler, we use *mod*2 instead of *mod*11).



Group homomorphism as a functor

It seems that when we view groups/monoid as one-object categories, a group/monoid homomorphism is just a functor between these categories. Let's see if that is the case.

Object mapping

Groups/monoids have just one object when viewed as categories, so there is also only one possible object mapping between any couple of groups/monoids — one that maps the (one and only) object of the source group to the object of the target group (not depicted in the diagram).

Morphism mapping

Because of the above, the morphism mapping is the only relevant component of the group homomorphism. In the

category-theoretic perspective, group objects (like 1 and 2 3 etc.) correspond to morphisms (like $+1$, $+2$ $+3$ etc.) and so the morphism mapping is just mapping between the group's objects, as we can see in the diagram.

Functor laws

The first functor law trivial, it just says that the one and only identity object of the source group (which corresponds to the identity morphism of its one and only object) should be mapped to the one and only identity object of the target group For groups, this even follows immediately from the second law and for monoids, it has to be added as an extra condition.

And if we remember that the group operation of combining two objects corresponds to *functional composition* if we view groups as categories, we realize that the group homomorphism equation $F(a+b) = F(a) \times F(b)$ is just a formulation of the second functor law: $F(g \cdot f) = F(g) \cdot F(f)$.

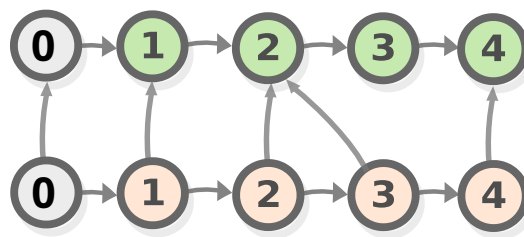
And many algebraic operations satisfy this equation, for example the functor law for the group homomorphism between $n \rightarrow 2^n$ is just the famous algebraic rule, stating that $g^a g^b = g^{a+b}$.

Task 3: Prove that the first functor law (preservation of identities) of groups can be proven from the second law. Note that this is valid for groups, but not monoids.

Functors in orders

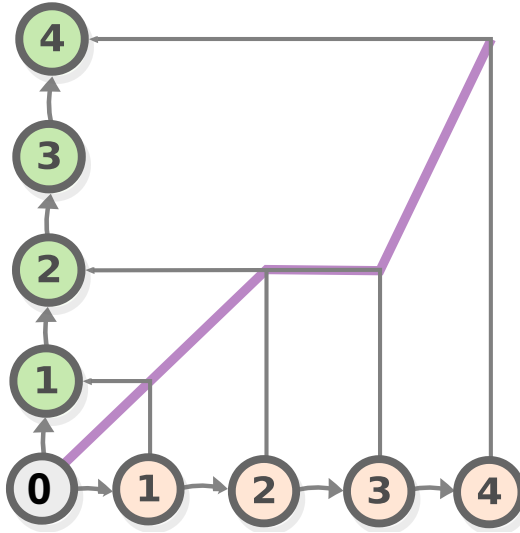
And now let's talk about a concept that is completely unrelated to functors, nudge-nudge (hey, bad jokes are better than no jokes at all, right?) In the theory of orders, we have the concept of functions between orders (which is unsurprising, given that orders, like monoids/groups, are based on sets) and one very interesting type of such function, which has applications in calculus and analysis, is a *monotonic function* (also called *monotone map*). This is a function between two orders that *preserves the order of the objects in the source order, in the target order. So a function F is monotonic when for every a and b in the source order, if $a \leq b$ then $F(a) \leq F(b)$.

For example, the function that maps the current time to the distance traveled by some object is monotonic because the distance traveled increases (or stays the same) as time increases.



A monotonic function

If we plot this or any other monotonic function on a line graph, we see that it goes just one direction (i.e. just up or just down).



A monotonic function, represented as a line-graph

Now we are about to prove that monotonic functions are functors too, ready?

Object mapping

Like with categories, the object mapping of an order is represented by a function between the orders' underlying sets.

Morphism mapping

With monoids, the object mapping component of functors was trivial. Here is the reverse: the morphism mapping is trivial - given a morphism between two objects from the source order, we map that morphism to the morphism between their corresponding objects in the target order. The fact that the monotonic function respects the order of the elements, ensures that the latter morphism exists.

Functor laws

It is not hard to see that monotone maps obey the first functor law as identities are the only morphisms that go between a given object and itself.

And the second law ($F(g \circ f) = F(g) \circ F(f)$) also follows trivially — we just have to prove that if function F preserves order, i.e. that if

$$a \leq b \rightarrow F(a) \leq F(b)$$

and

$$b \leq c \rightarrow F(a) \leq F(b)$$

then obviously

$$F(a) \leq F(c)$$

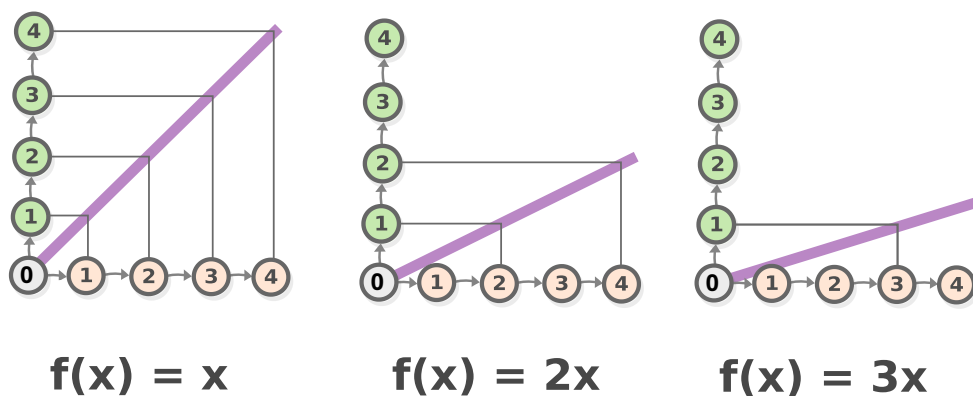
Task 4: Show why the law holds.

Linear functions

OK, enough with this abstract nonsense, let's talk about "normal" functions — ones between numbers.

In calculus, there is this concept of *linear functions* (also called "degree one polynomials") that are sometimes defined as functions of the form $f(x) = xa$ i.e. ones that contain no operations other than multiplying the argument by some constant (designated as a in the example).

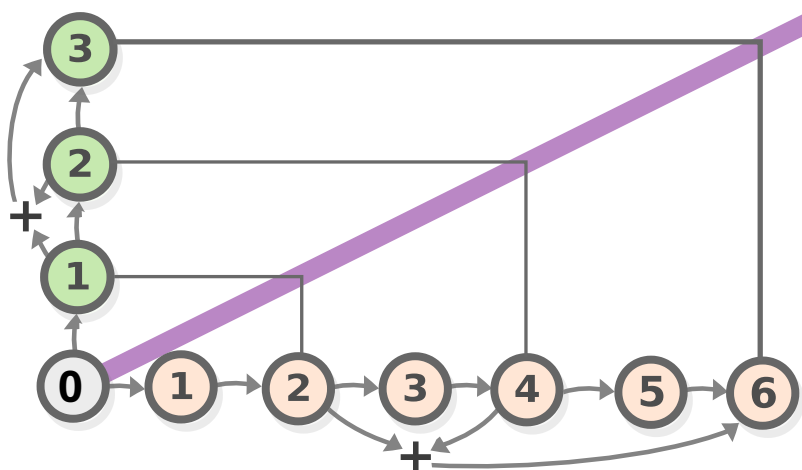
But if we start plotting some such functions we will realize that there is another way to describe them — their graphs are always comprised of straight lines.



Linear functions

Task 5: Why are the graphs of linear functions comprised of straight lines?

Another interesting property of these functions is that most of them *preserve* addition, that is for any x and y , you have $f(x) + f(y) = f(x+y)$. We already know that this equation is equivalent to the second functor law. So linear functions are just *functors between the group of natural numbers under addition and itself*. As we will see later, they are example of functors in the *category of vector spaces*.

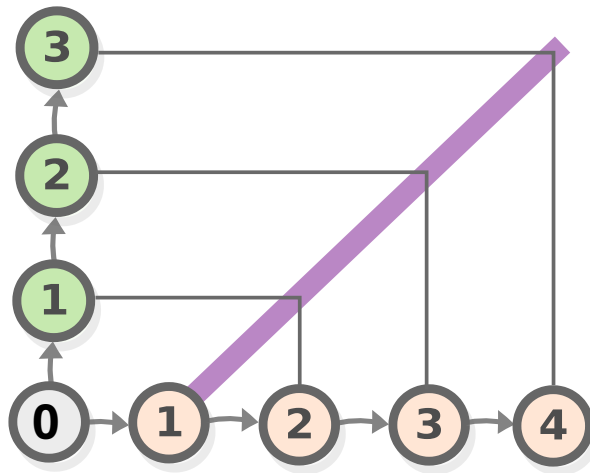


Linear functions

Task 6: Show that linear functions preserve addition.

And if we view that natural numbers as an order, linear functions are also functors as well, as all functions that are plotted with straight lines are obviously monotonic.

Note, however, that not all functions that are plotted straight lines preserve addition — functions of the form $f(x) = x * a + b$ in which b is non-zero, are also straight lines (and are also called linear) but they don't preserve addition.

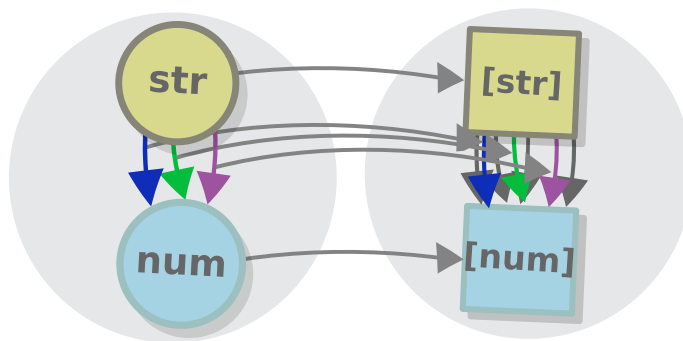


Linear functions

For those, the above formula looks like this: $f(x) + b + f(y) + b = f(x+y) + b$.

Functors in programming. The list functor

Types in a given programming language form a category, and in that category there are some functors that programmers use every day, such as the list functor, that we will use as an example. The list functor is an example of a functor that maps the realm of simple (primitive) types and functions to the realm of more complex (generic) types and functions.



A functor in programming

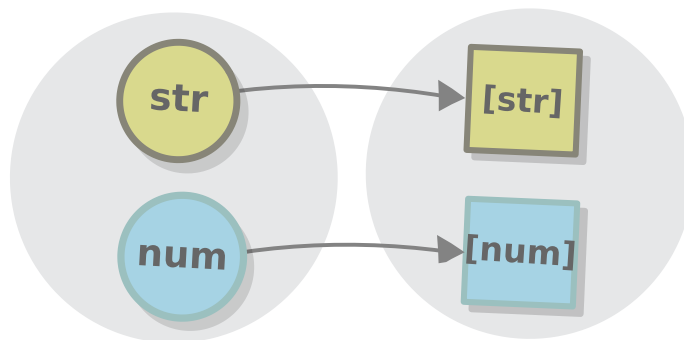
But let's start with the basics: defining the concept of a functor in programming context is as simple as changing the font we use in our formulas from "modern" to "monospaced". And also, using the more "programmy" terms listed in the table in chapter 2.

A functor between two categories (let's call them A and B) consists of a mapping that maps each ~~object type~~ *object type* in A to a type in B and a mapping that maps each ~~morphism~~ *morphism function* between types in A to a function between types in B, in a way that preserves the structure of the category.

Comparing these definitions makes us realize that mathematicians and programmers are two very different communities, that are united by the fact that they both use functors (and by their appreciation of peculiar typefaces).

Type mapping

The first component of a functor is a mapping that converts one type (let's call it A) to another type (B). So it is *like a function, but between types*. Such constructions are supported by almost all programming languages that have static type checking in the first place — they go by the name of *generic types*. A generic type is nothing but a function that maps one (concrete) type to another (this is why generic types are sometimes called *type-level functions*).



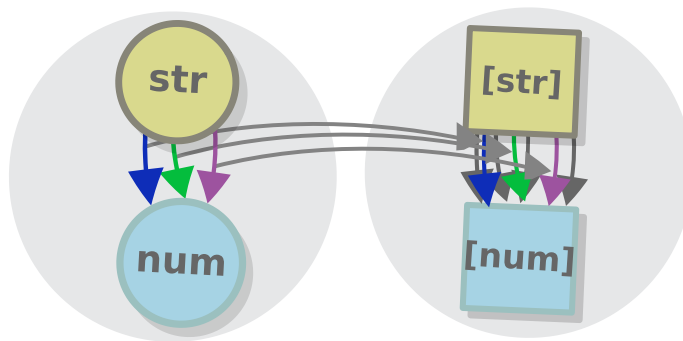
A functor in programming - type mapping

Note that although the diagrams they look similar, a *type-level* function is completely different from a *value-level* function, e.g. a value-level polymorphic function from a , to $\text{List}\langle a \rangle$ (or in mathy Haskell-inspired notation *forall* $a. a \rightarrow \text{List } a$) converts a *value* of type a to a value of type $\text{List}\langle a \rangle$ and is different from the *type-level* function $\text{List}\langle A \rangle$ as that one converts a *type* a to a *type* $\text{List } a$ (e.g. the type `string` to the type *List string*, *number* to *List number*

etc.). We will review value-level polymorphic functions at the end of the chapter.

Function mapping

So the type mapping of a functor is simply a generic type in a programming language (we can also have functors between two generic types, but we will review those later). So what is the *function mapping* — this is a mapping that convert any function operating on simple types, like *string* $\rightarrow$ *number* to a function between their more complex counterparts e.g. *List string* $\rightarrow$ *List number*.



A functor in programming - function mapping

In programming languages, this mapping is represented by a higher-order function called `map` with a signature (using Haskell notation), $(a \rightarrow b) \rightarrow (Fa \rightarrow Fb)$, where F represents the generic type.

Note that, although any possible function that has this type signature (that that obeys the functor laws) gives rise to a functor, *not all such functors are useful*. Usually, there is only one of them that makes sense for a given generic type and that's why

we talk about *the* list functor, and we define `map` directly in the in the generic datatype, as a method.

In the case of lists and similar structures, the *useful* implementation of `map` is the one that applies the original (simple) function to all elements of the list.

```
class Array<A> {  
  map (f: A → B): Array<B> {  
    let result = [];  
    for (obj of this) {  
      result.push(f(obj));  
    }  
    return result;  
  }  
}
```

Functor laws

Aside from facilitating code reuse by bringing in all standard functions of simple types in a more complex context, `map` allows us to work in a way that is predictable, courtesy of the functor laws, which in programming context look like this.

Identity law:

$$a.map(a \Rightarrow a) == a$$

Composition law:

$$a.map(f).map(g) == a.map((a) \Rightarrow g(f(a)))$$

Task 7: Use examples to convince yourself that the laws are followed. What are functors for `===`

Now, that we have seen so many examples of functors, we finally can attempt to answer the million-dollar question, namely what are functors for and why are they useful? (often formulated also as “Why are you wasting your/my time with this (abstract) nonsense?”)

Well, we saw that *maps are functors* and we know that *maps are useful*, so let’s start from there.

So, why is a map useful? Well, it obviously has to do with the fact that the points and arrows of the map corresponds to the cities and the roads in the place you are visiting in i.e. due to the very fact that it is a functor, but there is a second aspect as well - maps (or at least those of them that are useful) are *simpler to work with* than the actual things they represent. For example, road maps are useful, because they are *smaller* than the territory they represent, so it is much easier to go look up the routes between two given places by following a map, than to actually travel through all of them in real life.

And functors in programming are used for similar reason - functions that involve simple types like `string`, `number`, `boolean` etc. are ... simple, and least when compared with functions that work with lists and other generic types. Using the `map` function allows us to operate on such types without having to think about them and to derive functions that transform them, from functions that transform simple values. In other words, functors are means of *abstraction*.

Of course, not all routes on the map and no functions that between generic datatypes can be derived just by functions between the types they contain. This is generally true for many “useful” functors: because their source categories are “simpler”

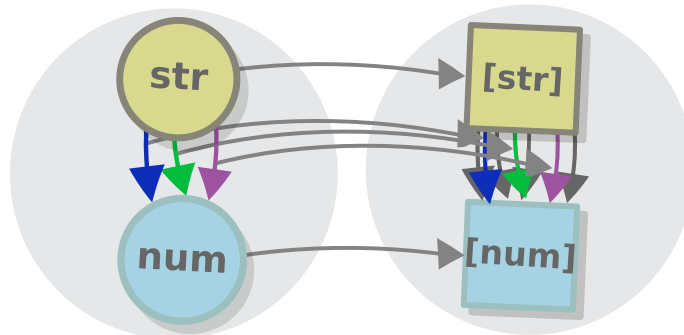
than the target, some of the morphisms in the target have no equivalents in the source i.e. making the model simpler inevitably results in losing some of its capabilities. This is a consequence of “the map is not the territory” principle (“every abstraction is a leaky abstraction”, as Joel Spolsky puts it).

Pointed functors

Now, before we close it off, we will review one more functor-related concept that is particularly useful in programming - *pointed endofunctors*.

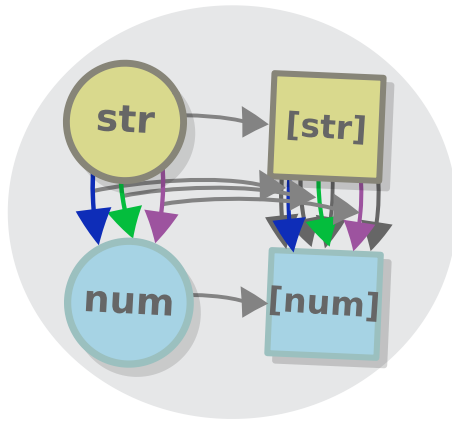
Endofunctors

To understand what pointed endofunctors are, we have to first understand what are *endofunctors*, and we already saw some examples of those in the last section. Let me explain: from the way the diagrams there looked like, we might get the impression that different type families belong to different categories.



A functor in programming

But that is not the case - all type families from a given programming language are actually part of one and the same category - the category of *types*.

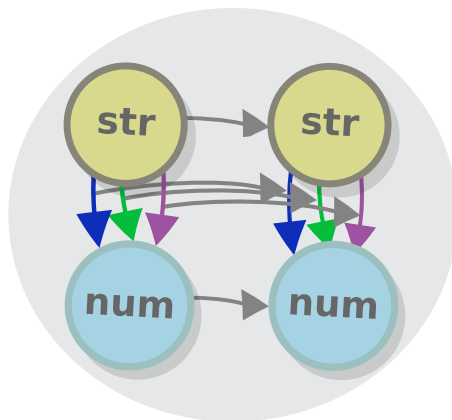


A functor in programming

Wait, so this is permitted? Yes, these are exactly what we call *endofunctors* i.e. ones that have one and the same category as source and target.

The identity functor

So, what are some examples of endofunctors? I want to focus on one that will probably look familiar to you - it is the *identity functor* of each category, the one that maps each object and morphism to itself.

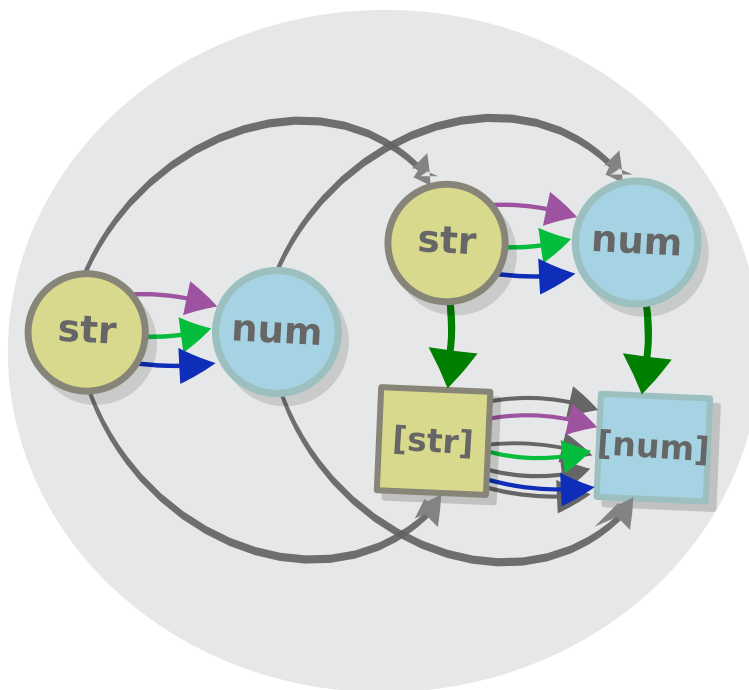


Identity functor

And it might be familiar, because an identity functor is similar to an identity morphism - it allow us to talk about value-related stuff without actually involving values.

Pointed functors

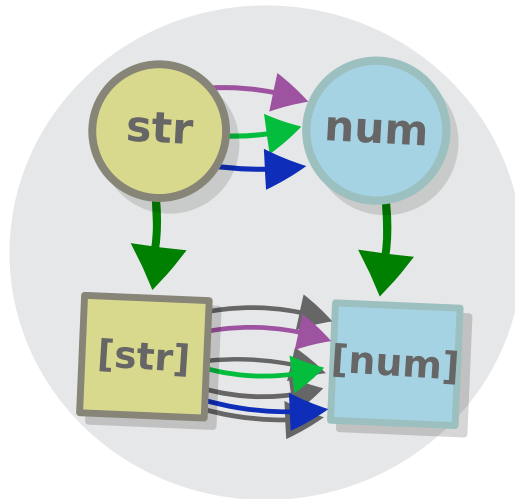
Finally, the identity functor, together with all other functors to which the identity functor can be *naturally transformed* are called *pointed functors* (i.e. a functor is pointed if there exist a natural transformation from the identity functor to it). As we will see shortly, the list functor is a pointed functor.



Pointed functor

We still haven't discussed what does it mean for one functor to be naturally transformed to another one (although the commuting diagram above can give you some idea), however, if we concentrate solely on the category of types in programming

languages, then *a natural transformation is just a polymorphic function* e.g. this one is $a \rightarrow \text{List } a$, that preserves the structure of the types i.e. one for which this diagram commutes.

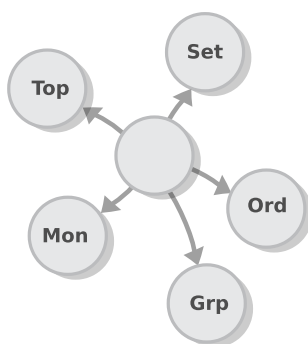


In the case of this functor, the function in question is $a \rightarrow [a]$ — the function that puts every value in a “singleton” list.

We will stop here, as natural transformations are a complex thing, and we want to examine them in a whole chapter (the next one).

The category of small categories

Ha, I got you this time (or at least I *hope* I did) - you probably thought that I won't introduce another category in this chapter, but this is exactly what I am going to do now. And (surprise again) the new category won't be the category of functors (don't worry, we will introduce that in the next chapter). Instead, we will examine the category of (small) categories, that has all the categories that we saw so far as objects and functors as its morphisms, like *Set* - the category of sets, *Mon*, the category of monoids, *Ord*, the category of orders etc.



The category of categories

We haven't yet mentioned the fact that functors compose (and in an associative way at that), but since a functor is just a bunch of functions, it is no wonder that it does.

Task 8: Go through the functor definition and see how do functors compose.

Task 9: What are the initial and terminal object of the category of small categories.

Categories all the way down

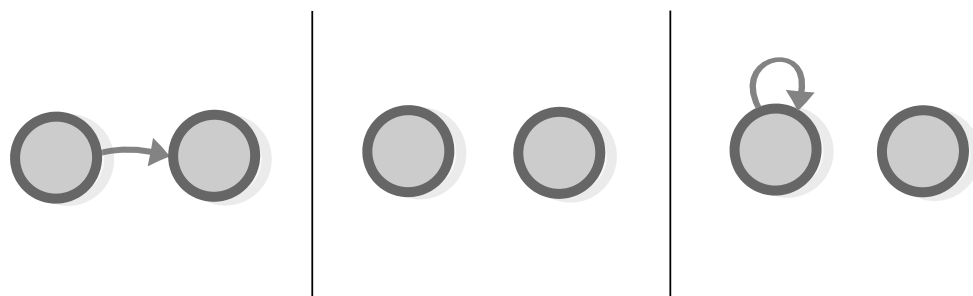
The recursive nature of category theory might sometimes leave us confused: we started by saying that categories are *composed of objects and morphisms*, but now we are saying that there are *morphisms between categories* (functors). And on top of that, there is a category where *the objects are categories themselves*. Does that mean that categories are an example of... categories? Sounds a bit weird on intuitive level (as for example biscuits don't contain other biscuits and houses don't use houses as building material), but it is actually the case. Like, for example, every monoid is a category with just one object, but at the same time, monoids can be seen as belonging to one category - the category of monoids, where they are connected by monoid homomorphisms. We also have the category of groups, for example, which contains the category of monoids as a subcategory, as all monoids are groups etc.

Category theory does *categorize* everything, so, from a category-theoretic standpoint, all of maths is *categories all the way down*. Whether you would treat a given category as a universe or as a point depends solely on the context. Category theory is an *abstract* theory. That is, it does not seek to represent an actual state of affairs, but to provide a language that you can use to express many different ideas.

Answers

Task 1: There are just two more categories that have 2 objects and at most one morphism between two objects, draw them.

The answer is this:



the finite category 2

Isomorphisms are equality in category theory, so flipping the arrow from the left to the right doesn't count as a new category.

For the third category we have to specify what composing the morphism with itself would yield:

$$f \circ f = id$$

This law guarantees that there would be just 1 morphism besides identity: if this law doesn't exist, you would end up with the category with an infinite amount of morphisms (see the free monoid in the chapter on monoids), if it is changed to something else, they would be a finite number of morphisms, but still more than 1.

Task 2: What is the morphism mapping for orders?

The morphism mapping of orders consist just of mapping the only existing morphism between a given pair of objects in one order, to the only existing morphism of their counterparts in the other order. The “order-preserving” condition of order isomorphisms guarantees that this morphism exists i.e. that if you have $A \rightarrow B$ in one order, you would have $F(A) \rightarrow F(B)$ in the other.

Task 3: Prove that the first functor law (preservation of identities) of groups can be proven from the second law i.e. that if C and D are groups and $F : C \rightarrow D$ — a group homomorphism, you have $ID_C = F(ID_D)$. Note that this is valid for groups, but not monoids.

We know that

$$ID_D = ID_D \circ ID_D$$

So

$$F(ID_D) = F(ID_D) \circ F(ID_D) \text{ (second functor law)}$$

But we can add the identity operation anywhere, without changing the equations, so we have

$$F(ID_D) \circ ID_C = F(ID_D) \circ F(ID_D) \text{ (adding identity to the equation).}$$

And cancelling out $F(ID_D)$, we have

$$ID_C = F(ID_D)$$

This last step is valid only for groups, as cancelling out a morphism is done by applying its reverse, and monoid morphisms don't have reverses.

Task 4: Show why the law holds.

In categorical language, the problem states that if we have $f : a \rightarrow b$ and $g : b \rightarrow c$, then $F(g \circ f) = F(g) \circ F(f)$.

The proof uses the same approach as the one in Task 2: because in orders there can be just one morphism with a given type signature, two morphisms with equal type signatures must be equal to one another.

Then, if we compose those two morphisms in the target order ($F(g) \circ F(f)$), we get a morphism $F(a) \rightarrow F(c)$

$$F(g) \circ F(f) : F(a) \rightarrow F(c)$$

If we compose the two morphisms in the *source* order, and we use the functor law to obtain the corresponding morphism in the target order, we get another morphism from object $F(a) \rightarrow F(c)$

$$F(g \circ f) : F(a) \rightarrow F(c)$$

But because in orders there can be just one morphism with signature $F(a) \rightarrow F(c)$ so these two morphisms must be equal to one another:

$$F(g) \circ F(f) = F(g \circ f)$$

Task 5: Why are the graphs of linear functions comprised of straight lines?

A linear function grows with a constant rate, (i.e. their derivative is always constant).

The slope of a function reflects the change in its rate of growth, so in case of linear functions it is a straight line.

Task 6: Show that linear functions preserve addition.

Let's say we have a function f , such that it multiplies the number by a certain constant a , e.g. we have

$$f(x) = a \times x$$

and

$$f(y) = a \times y$$

If we sum the two we get

$$f(x) + f(y) = a \times x + a \times y$$

By the law of distributivity of addition we get

$$f(x) + f(y) = a \times (x+y)$$

but by the definition of f we also have

$$f(x + y) = a \times (x + y)$$

Uniting the two terms that are both equal to $a \times (x+y)$ we get:

$$f(x) + f(y) = f(x+y)$$

You can show that this works in the other direction as well, but it is a little more complicated.

Task 7: Use examples to convince yourself that the laws are followed.

Trivial exercise, the point here is playing a bit to familiarize yourself with the laws, everyone has a favourite set and functions which they use, here are mine:

Identity law:

```
[1, 2, 3].map(a => a) == [1, 2, 3]
```

Composition law:

```
let f = (a) => a + 1
let g = (a) => a * 2
[1, 2, 3].map(f).map(g) == [1, 2, 3].map((a) => g(f(a)))
```

Task 8: Go through the functor definition and see how do functors compose.

Another trivial exercise, with, perhaps, non-trivial setup. It all comes down to go through the elements a functor consists of and to see how the elements of two functors can compose.

The two elements of a functor are the object mapping and the morphism mapping.

The object mapping is just a function, connecting two categories' underlying sets, so if we have two functors with the appropriate type signature e.g.

$C \rightarrow D$

and

$D \rightarrow E$

we also have two functions that connect these categories' underlying sets:

$set(C) \rightarrow set(D)$

and

$set(D) \rightarrow set(E)$.

So the answer, for object mapping is to compose the two functions to get a function (which can be the basis for a $C \rightarrow D$ functor) $set(C) \rightarrow set(E)$.

For morphism mapping, do the same thing for the categories' hom-sets.

Task 9: What are the initial and terminal object of the category of small categories.

If you remember the concepts of initial and terminal objects from the category of sets *Set*, you will find out that they are basically the same for the category of categories *Cat*

The initial object in *Set* is the empty set, the initial category in *Cat* is the empty category. The unique functor from the empty category to any other category is the same — the functor which maps nothing to nothing.

The terminal object in *Set* is the one-element set, the terminal category in *Cat* is the category 1 , which has one object and no morphisms other than identity. The unique functor from any object to the terminal object is the functor that maps all objects to the only object and all morphisms to the only morphism.

Natural transformations

I didn't invent categories to study functors; I invented them to study natural transformations. — Saunders Mac Lane

In this chapter, we will introduce the concept of a morphism between functors, or *natural transformation*. Understanding natural transformations will enable us to define category equality and some other advanced concepts.

Natural transformations really are at the heart of category theory, however, their importance is not obvious at first. So, before introducing them, I like to talk, once more, about the body of knowledge that this heart maintains (I am good with metaphors... in principle).

Equivalent categories

Our first section aims to introduce natural transformation as a motivating example for creating a way to say that two categories are equal. But for that, we need to understand what equal categories are and should be.

So, are you ready to hear about equivalent categories and natural transformations? Actually it is my opinion that you are not (no offence, they are just very hard!). So, we will take a longer route. I can put this next section anywhere in this book, and it would always be neither here nor there. But anyway, if you are studying math, you are probably interested in the *nature of the universe*. “What is the quintessential characteristic of all things in this world?” I hear you ask...

Objects are overrated AKA Heraclitus was right!

The world is the collection of facts, not of things. — Ludwig Wittgenstein

What is the quintessential characteristic of all things in this world? Some 2500 years ago, the philosopher Parmenides gave an answer to this question, postulating that the nature of the universe is permanence, stasis. According to his view, what we perceive as processes/transformations/change is merely illusory appearances (“Whatever is is, and what is not cannot be”). He said that that things never really change, they only *appear* to

change, or (another way to put it), only appearances change, but the *essence* does not (I think this is pretty much how the word “essence” came to exist).

Although far from obviously true, his view is easy for people to relate to — objects are all around us, everything we “see”, both literally (in real life), or metaphorically (in mathematics and other disciplines), can be viewed as *objects*, persisting through space and time. If we subscribe to this view, then we would think that the key to understanding the world is understanding *what objects are*. In my opinion, this is what set theory does, to some extent, as well as classical logic (Plato was influenced by Parmenides when he created his theory of forms).

However, there is another way to approach the question about the nature of the universe, which is equally compelling. Because, what is an object, when viewed by itself? Can we study an object in isolation? And will there anything left to study about it, once it is detached from its environment? If a given object undergoes a process to get all of it's part replaced, is it still the same object?

Asking such questions might lead us to suspect that, although what we *see* when we look at the universe are the objects, it is the processes/relations/transitions or *morphisms* between the objects that are the real key to understanding it. For example, when we think hard about everyday objects we realize that each of them has a specific *functions* (note the term) without which, a thing would not be itself e.g. is a lamp that doesn't glow, still a lamp? Is there food that is non-edible (or an edible item that isn't food)? And this is even more valid for mathematical objects, which, without the functions that go between them, are not objects at all.

So, instead of thinking about objects that just happen to have some morphisms between them, we might take the opposite view and say *that objects are only interesting as sources and targets of morphisms*.

Although old, dating back to Parmenides' alleged rival Heraclitus, this view has been largely unexplored, until the 20th century, when a real mathematical revolution happened: Bertrand Russell created type theory, his student Ludwig Wittgenstein wrote a little book, from which the above quote comes, and this book inspired a group of mathematicians and logicians, known as the "Vienna circle". Part of this group was Rudolph Carnap who coined the word "functor"...

Isomorphism invariance

An embodiment of Heraclitus' view in the realm of category theory is the concept of *isomorphism invariance* that we implicitly touched several times.

All categorical constructions that we covered (products/coproducts, initial/terminal objects, functional objects in logic) are *isomorphism-invariant*. Or, equivalently, they define an objects *up to an isomorphism*. Or, in other words, if there are two or more objects that are isomorphic to one another, and one of them has a given property, then the rest of them would to also have this property as well.

In short, in category theory **isomorphism = equality**.

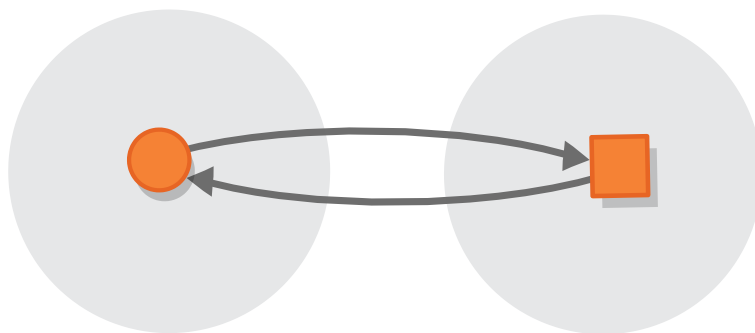
The key to understanding category theory lies in understanding isomorphism invariance. And the key to understanding

isomorphism invariance are natural transformations.

Categorical isomorphisms are *not* isomorphism-invariant

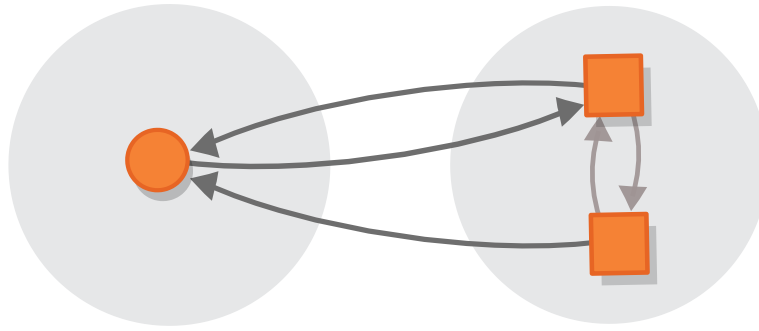
Let's return to the question that we were pondering at the beginning of the previous chapter — what does it mean for two categories to be equal?

In the prev chapter, we talked a lot about how great isomorphisms are and how important they are for defining the concept of equality in category theory, but at the same time we said that *categorical isomorphisms* do not capture the concept of equality of categories.



Isomorphic categories

This is because (though it may seem contradictory at first) *categorical isomorphisms are not isomorphism invariant*, i.e. categories that only differ by having some additional isomorphic objects aren't isomorphic themselves.



Isomorphic categories

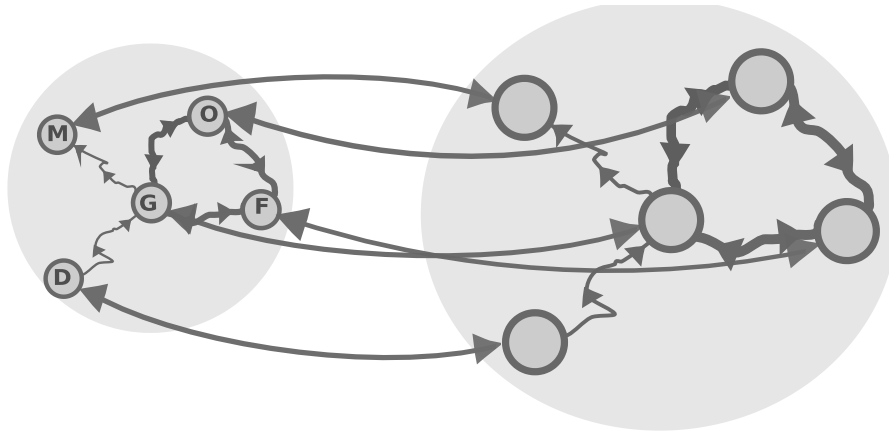
For this reason, we need a new concept of equality of categories. A concept that would elucidate the *differences* between categories with different structure, but also the *sameness* of categories that have the same categorical structures, disregarding the differences that are irrelevant for category-theoretic standpoint. That concept is *equivalence*.

Parmenides: This category surely cannot be equal to the other one — it has a different amount of objects!

Heraclitus: Who cares bro, they are isomorphic.

Equivalences are isomorphism invariant

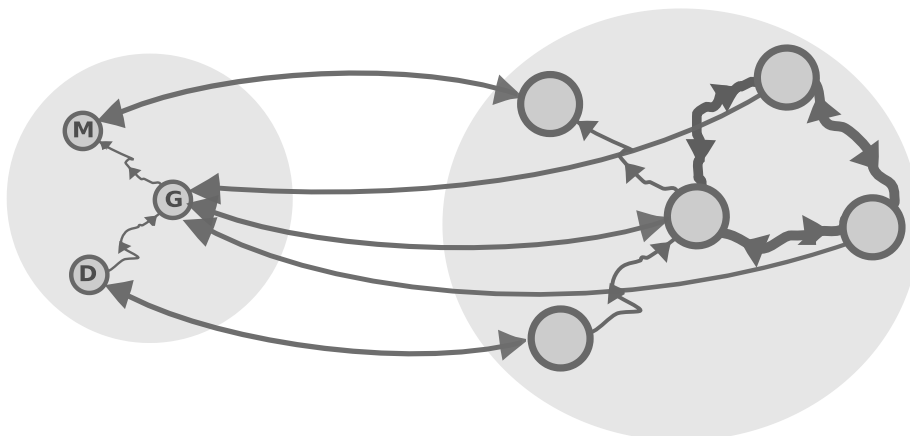
To understand equivalent categories better, let's go back to the functor between a given map and the area it represents (we will only consider the thin categories (AKA orders) for now). This functor would be invertible (and the categories — isomorphic) when the map should represent the area completely i.e. there should be arrow for each road and a point for each little place.



Isomorphic categories

Such a map is necessary if your goal is to know about all *places*, however, like we said, when working with category theory, we are not so interested in *places*, but in the *routes* that connect them i.e. we focus not on *objects* but on *morphisms*.

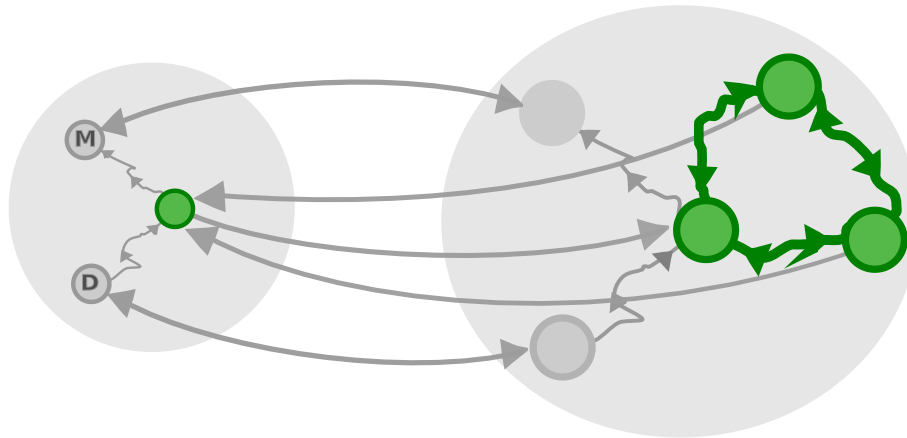
For example, if there are intersections that are positioned in such a way that there are routes from one and to the other and vice-versa a map may collapse them into one intersection and still show all routes that exist (the tree routes would be represented by the “identity route”).



Equivalent categories

These two categories are *not isomorphic* — going from one of them to the other and back again doesn't lead you to the same object.

However, going from one of them to the other would lead you at least to an *isomorphic object*.



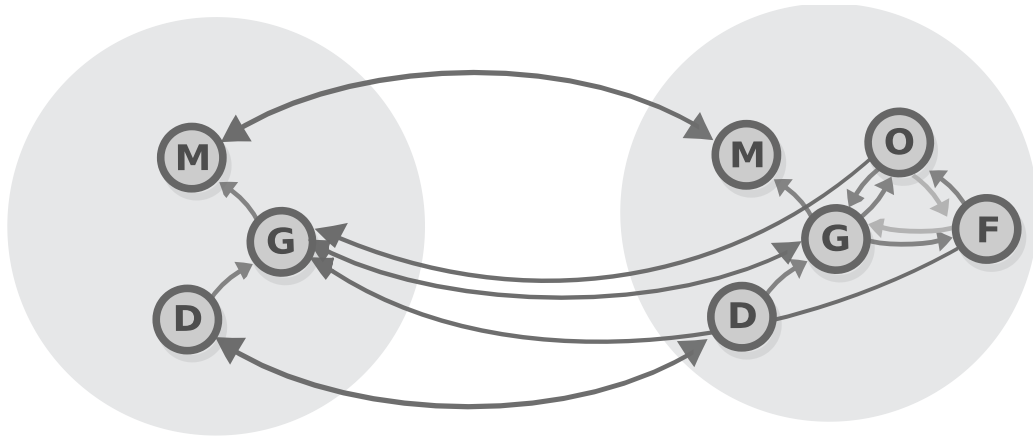
Equivalent categories

In this case we say that the orders are *equivalent*.

Defining equivalence in terms of objects

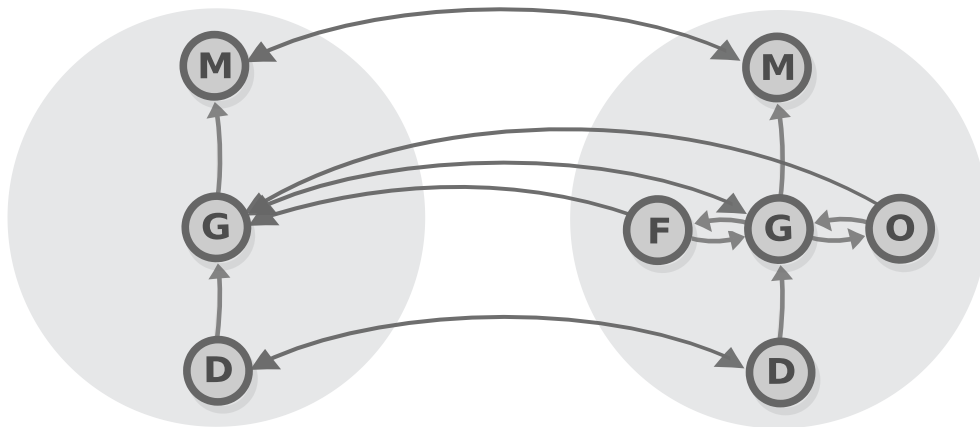
We know that two orders are isomorphic if there are two functors, such that going from one to the other and back again leads you to the same object.

And two orders are equivalent if going from one of them to the other and back again leads you to the same object, *or to an object that is isomorphic to the one you started with*.



Equivalent orders

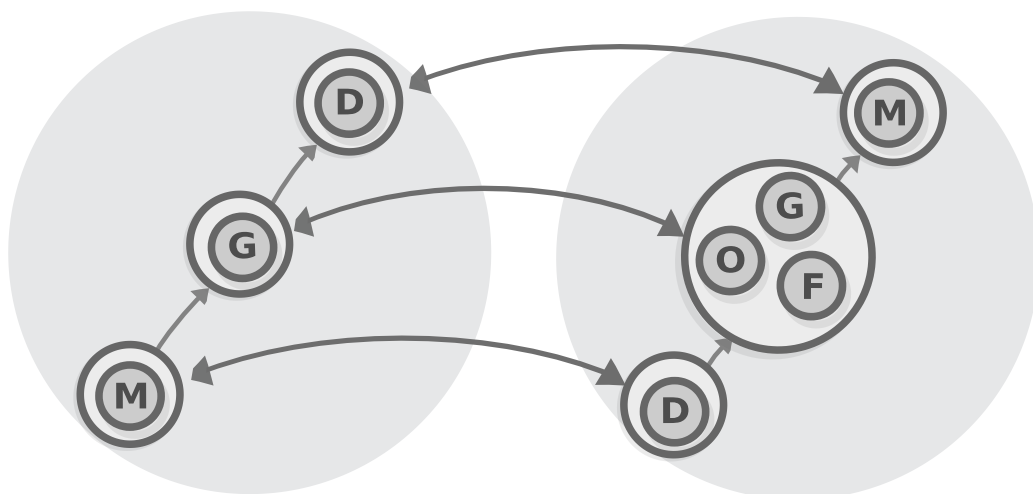
But when does this happen? To understand this, we plot the orders as a Hasse diagram.



Equivalent orders

You can see that, although not all objects are connected one-to-one, *all objects at a given level are connected to objects of the corresponding level.*

To formalize that notion, we remember the concept of *equivalence classes* that we covered in the chapter about orders. Let's visualize the relationship of the equivalence classes of the two orders that we saw above.

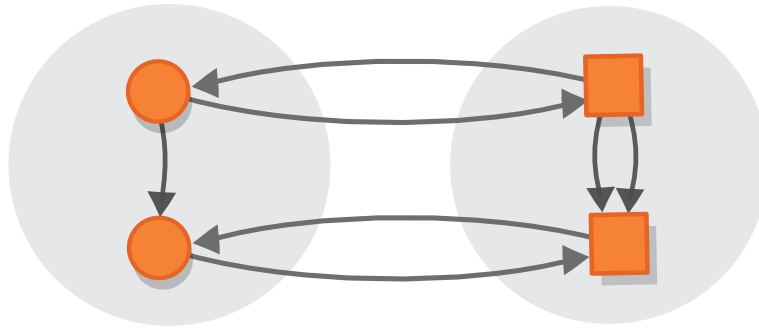


Orders with isomorphic equivalence classes

You can see that they are isomorphic. And that is no coincidence: two orders are equivalent precisely when the orders made of their equivalence classes are isomorphic.

This is a definition for equivalence of orders, but unfortunately, it does not hold for all categories — when we are working with orders, we can get away by just thinking about *objects*, but categories demands that we think about morphisms i.e. to prove two categories are equivalent, we should establish an isomorphism between their *morphisms*.

For example, the following two categories are *not* equivalent, although their equivalence classes are isomorphic — the category on the left has just one morphism, but the category on the right has two.



Non-equivalent categories

One way of defining equivalence of categories is by generalizing the notion of equivalence classes of orders to what we call *skeletons* of categories, a skeleton of a category being a subcategory in which all objects that are isomorphic to one another are “merged” into one object (isomorphic objects are necessarily identical).

However, we will leave this (pardon my French) as an *exercise for the reader*. Why? We already did this when we generalized the notion of normal set-theoretic functions to *functors*, and so it makes more sense to build up on that notion. Also, we need a motivating example for introducing natural transformations, remember?

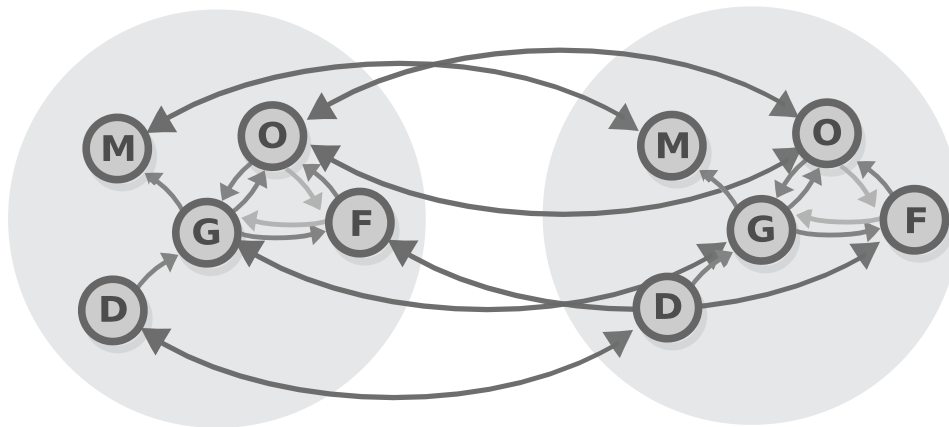
Defining equivalence in terms of morphisms

In the chapter about orders, we presented a definition of order *isomorphisms*, that is based on *objects*:

An order isomorphism is essentially an isomorphism between the orders' underlying sets (invertible function).

However, besides their underlying sets, orders also have the arrows that connect them, so there is one more condition: in order for an invertible function to constitute an order isomorphism it has to *respect those arrows*, in other words it should be *order preserving*. More specifically, applying this function (let's call it F) to any two elements in one set (a and b) should result in two elements that have the same corresponding order in the other set (so $a \leq b$ if and only if $F(a) \leq F(b)$).

That a way to define them, but it is not the best way. Now that we know about functors (which, as we said, serve as functions between the orders and other categories), we can devise a new, simpler definition, which would also be valid for all categories, not just orders, and for all forms of equality (isomorphism and equivalence).



isomorphic orders

We begin with the definition of **set isomorphism**:

Two **sets** A and B are **isomorphic** (or $A \cong B$) if there exist functions $f: A \rightarrow B$ and its reverse $g: B \rightarrow A$, such that $f \circ g = ID_B$ and $g \circ f = ID_A$.

To amend it so it is valid for all categories by just replacing the word “function” with “functor” and “set” with “category”:

Two **categories** A and B are **isomorphic** (or $A \cong B$) if there exist *functors* $f : A \rightarrow B$ and its reverse $g : B \rightarrow A$, such that $f \circ g = ID_B$ and $g \circ f = ID_A$.

Task 1: Check if that definition is valid.

Believe it or not, this definition, is just one find-and-replace operation away from the definition of *equivalence*. We get there only by replace equality with isomorphism (so, $=$ with $\cong$).

Two **categories** A and B are **equivalent** (or $A \simeq B$) if there exist *functors* $f : A \rightarrow B$ and its reverse $g : B \rightarrow A$, such that $f \circ g \cong ID_B$ and $g \circ f \cong ID_A$.

Like we said at the beginning, with isomorphisms, going back and forth brings us to the same object, while with equivalence the object is just *isomorphic* to the original one. This is truly all there is to it.

There is only one problem, though — *we never said what it means for functors to be isomorphic*.

Natural transformations, natural isomorphisms and categorical equivalence

So, how can we make the above definition “come to life”? The title of this chapter outlines the things we need to define:

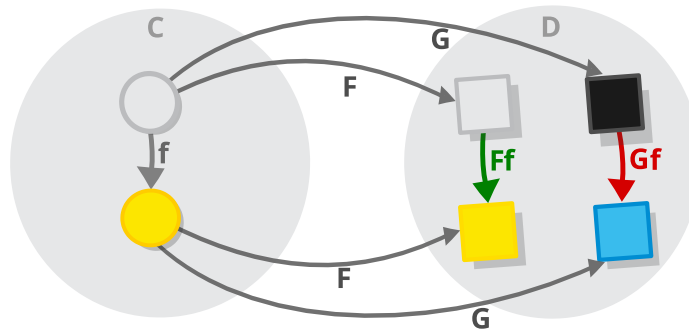
1. *Morphisms between functors* (called *natural transformations*).
2. *Functor isomorphisms* (called *natural isomorphisms*).
3. Finally *categorical equivalences*.

If this sounds complicated, remember that we are doing the same thing we always did — talking about isomorphisms.

In the very first chapter of this book, we introduced *set isomorphisms*, which are quite easy, and now we reached the point to examine *functor isomorphisms*. So, we are doing the same thing. Although actually...

But actually, natural transformations are quite different from morphisms and functors, (the definition is not “recursive”, like the definitions of functor and morphism are). This is because functions and functors are both morphisms between objects (or *1-morphisms*), while natural transformations are *morphisms between morphisms* (known as *2-morphisms*).

But enough talking, let’s draw some diagrams. We know that natural transformations are morphisms between functors, so let’s draw two functors.



Two functors

The functors have the same signature. Naturally. How else can there be morphisms between them?

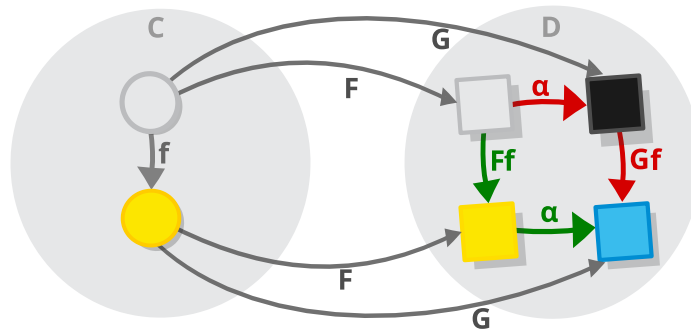
Now, a functor is comprised of two mappings (object mapping and morphism mapping) so a mapping between functors, would consist of “object mapping mapping” and “morphism mapping mapping” (yes, I often do get in trouble with my choice of terminology, why do you ask?).

Object mapping mapping

Let's first connect the object mappings of the two functors, creating what we called “object mapping mapping”.

It is simpler than it sounds when we realize that we only need to connect the object in functors' *target category* — the objects in the source category would just always be the same for both functors, as both functors would include *all* object from the source category (as that is what functors (and morphisms in general) do). In other words, mapping the two functors' object components involves nothing more than specifying a bunch of morphisms in the target category: one morphism for each object in the source category i.e. each object from the image of the first

functor, should have one arrow coming from it (and to an object of the second functor, so, for example, our current source category has two objects and we specify two morphisms.



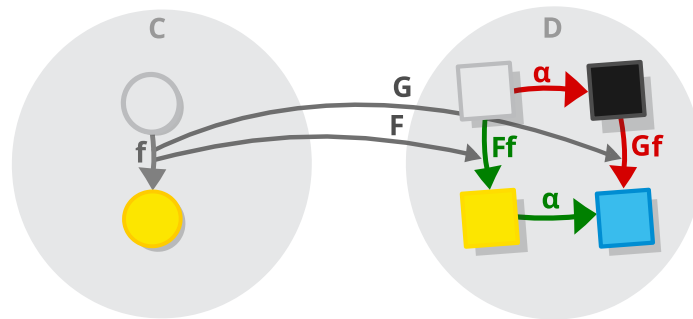
Two functors and a natural transformation

Note that this mapping does not map every object from the target category, i.e. not all objects have arrows coming from them (e.g. here the black and blue square do not have arrows), although, in some cases, it *might*.

Task 2: When exactly would the mapping encompass all objects?

Morphism mapping mapping

The morphism part might seem hard... until we realize that, once the connections between the object mappings are already established, there is only one way to connect the morphisms — we take each morphism of the source category and connect the two morphisms given by the two functors, in the target category. And that's all there is to it.



Two functors

Oh, actually, there is also this condition that the above diagram should commute (the naturality condition), but that happens pretty much automatically.

The naturality condition

Just like anything else in category theory, natural transformations have some laws that they are required to pass. In this case it's one law, typically called the naturality law, or the naturality condition.

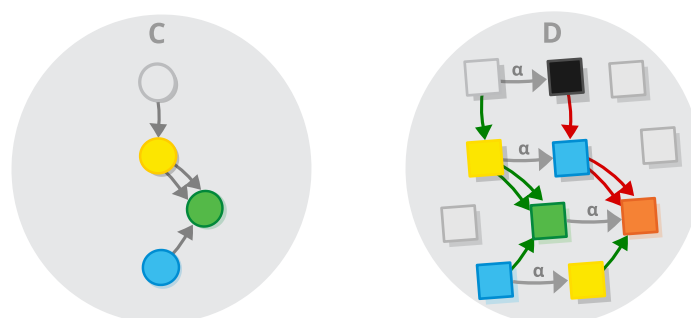
Before we state this law, let's recap where are we now: We have two functors F and G that have the same type signature (so $F : C \rightarrow D$ and $G : C \rightarrow D$ for some categories C and D), and a family of morphisms in the target category D (denoted $\alpha : F \Rightarrow G$) one for each object in C , that map each object of the target of the functor F (or the image of F in D as it is also called) to some objects of the image of G . This is a *transformation*, but not necessarily a *natural* one. A transformation is natural, when this diagram commutes for all morphisms in C .



The commuting square of a natural transformation

i.e. a transformation is natural when every morphism f in C is mapped to morphisms $F(f)$ by F and to $G(f)$ by G (not very imaginative names, I know), in such a way, that we have $\alpha \circ F(f) = G(f) \circ \alpha$ i.e. when starting from the white square, when going right and then down (via the yellow square) is be equivalent to going down and then right (via the black one).

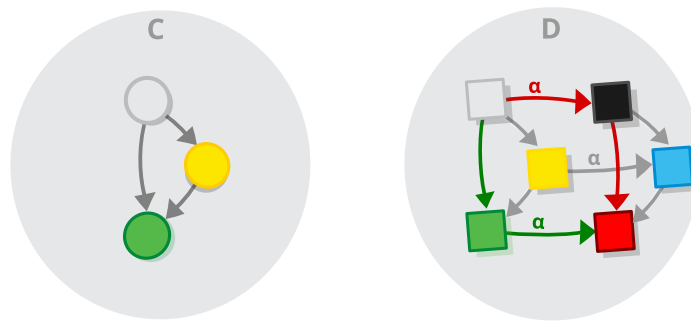
We may view a natural transformation is a mapping between morphisms and commutative squares: two functors and a natural transformation between two categories means that for each morphism in the source category of the functors, there exist one commutative square at the target category.



Commuting squares of a natural transformation

When we fully understand this, we realize that commutative squares are made of morphisms too, so, like morphisms, they

compose — for any two morphisms with appropriate type signatures that have we can compose to get a third one, we have two naturality squares which compose the same way.



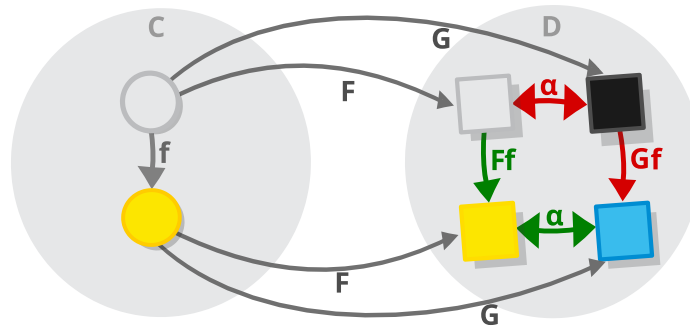
Composition of commuting squares of a natural transformation

Which means natural transformation make up a...

(Oh wait, it's too early for that, is it?)

Natural isomorphisms

After understanding natural transformations, natural isomorphisms, are a no-brainer: a natural transformation is just a family of morphisms in a given category that satisfy certain criteria, then what would a natural *isomorphism* be? That's right — it is a family of *isomorphisms* that satisfy the same criteria. The diagram is the same as the one for ordinary natural transformation, except that α are not just ordinary morphisms, but isomorphisms.



Two functors and a natural transformation

And the turning those morphisms into isomorphisms makes the diagram commute in more than one way i.e. if we have the naturality condition

$\alpha \circ F(f) = G(f) \circ \alpha$ i.e. the two paths going from **white** to **blue** are equivalent.

We also have:

$F(f) \circ \alpha = \alpha \circ G(f)$ i.e. the two paths going from **black** to **yellow** are also equivalent.

Constructing categorical equivalences

I am sorry, what were we talking about again? Oh yeah — categorical equivalence. Remember that categorical equivalence is the reason why we tackle natural transformations and isomorphisms? Or perhaps it was the other way around? Never mind, let's recap what we discussed so far:

1. At the beginning of the section we introduced the notion of equivalence as two functors, such that going from one of

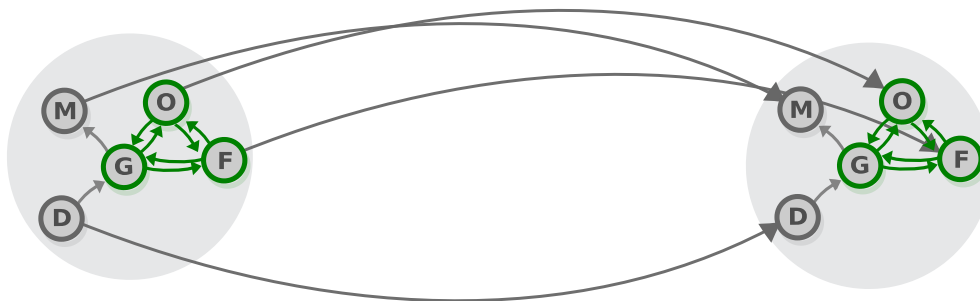
them to the other and back again leads you to the same object, or to an *object that is isomorphic* to the one you started with.

2. And then, we discussed that for categories that are not thin (thick?) the situation is a bit more complex since they can have more than one morphism between two objects, and we should worry not only about isomorphic objects, but about *isomorphic morphisms*.

Now, we will show how these two notions are formalized by the definition that we presented.

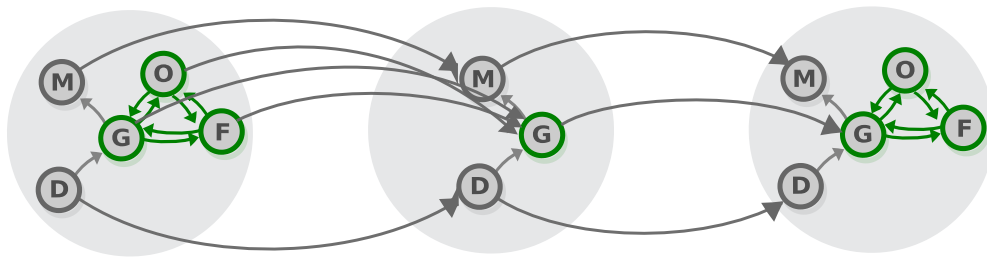
Two **categories** A and B are **equivalent** (or $A \simeq B$) if there exist *functors* $f : A \rightarrow B$ and its reverse $g : B \rightarrow A$, such that $f \circ g \cong ID_B$ and $g \circ f \cong ID_A$.

To understand, this how are the two related, let's construct the identity functor of the category that we have been using as an example all this time. Note that we are drawing the one and the same category two times (as opposed to just drawing an arrow coming from each object to itself), to make the diagrams more readable.



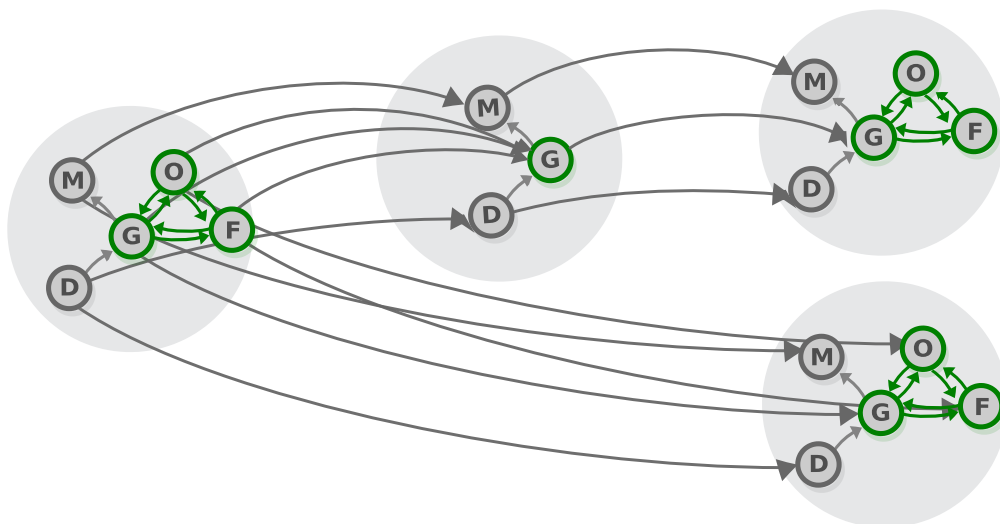
The identity functor

Then, we draw the composite of the two functors that establish an equivalence between the two categories, highlighting the 3 “interesting” objects, i.e. the ones due to which the categories aren’t isomorphic.



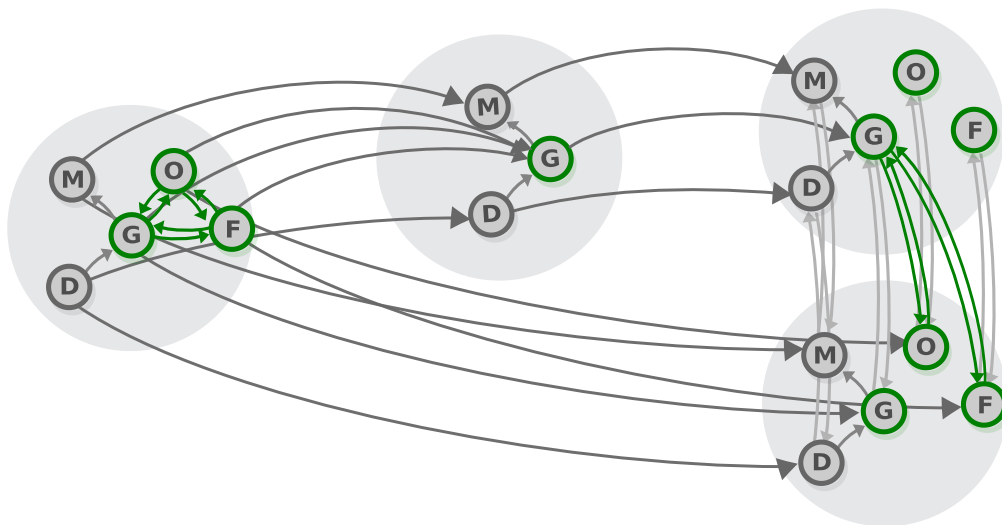
The composite functor between the two functors that make up the equivalence

Now, we ask ourselves, in which cases does there exist an isomorphism between those two functors?



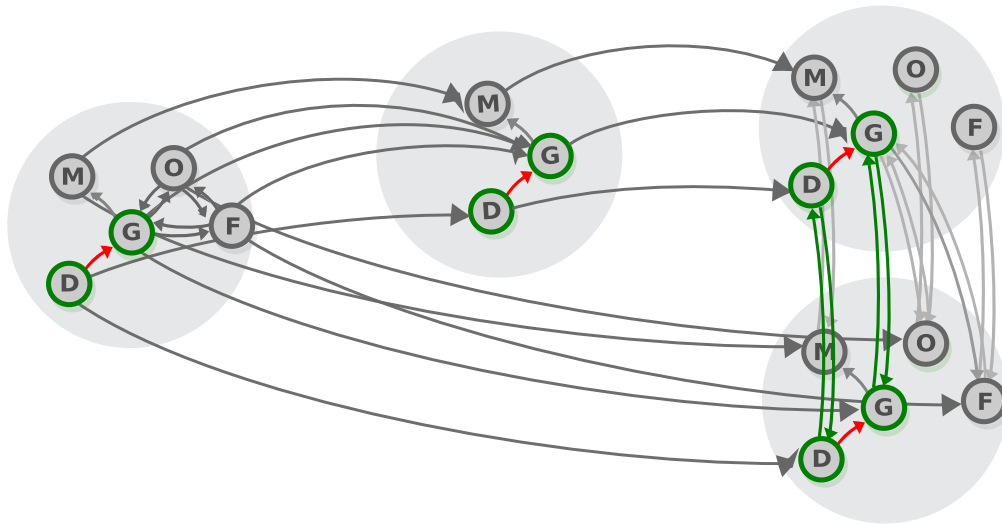
An equivalence diagram

The answer becomes trivial if we draw the isomorphism arrows connecting the three “interesting” objects in a different way (remember, this is the same category on the top and the bottom) — we can see that these are exactly the arrows that enable us to construct an isomorphism between the two functors (the others are just identity arrows).



An equivalence diagram, showing a transformation

And when would this isomorphism be such that preserves the structure of the category (so that each morphism from the output of the composite functor has an equivalent one in the output of the identity)? Exactly when the isomorphism is *natural* i.e. when every morphism is mapped to a commuting square, e.g. here is the commuting square of the morphism that is marked in red.



An equivalence diagram, showing a natural transformation

i.e. naturality condition assures us that the morphisms in the target of the functor behave in the same way as their counterparts in the source.

With this, we are finished with categorical equivalence, but not with natural transformations — natural transformations are a very general concept, and categorical equivalences are only a very narrow case of them.

Natural transformations in programming. Natural transformations on the list functor

In the course of this book, we learned that programming/computer science is the study of the category of types in programming languages. However (in order to avoid this being too obvious) in the computer science context, we use different terms for the standard category-theoretic concepts.

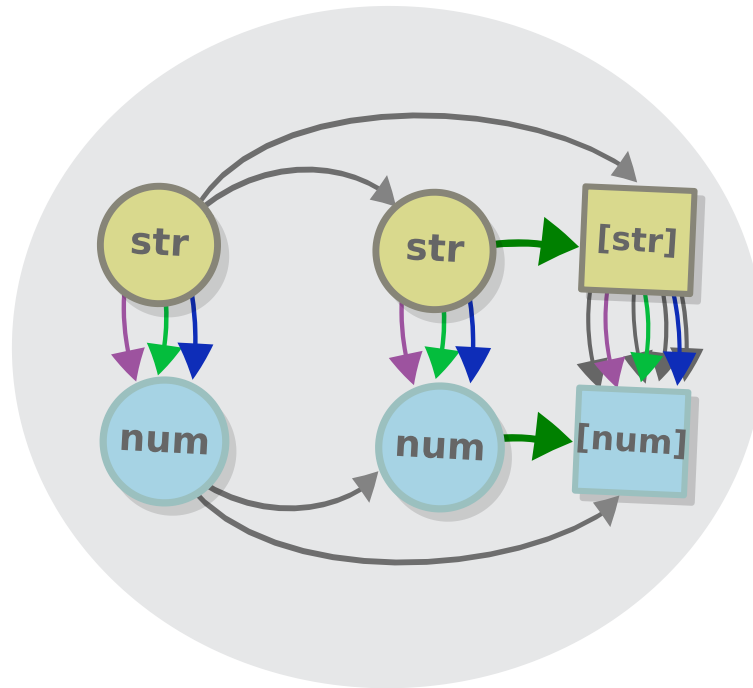
We learned that objects are known as *types*, products and coproducts are, respectively, *objects/tuple* types and *sum* types. And, in the last chapter, we learned that functors are known as *generic types*. Now it's the time to learn what natural transformations are in this context. They are known as *(parametrically) polymorphic functions*.

Pointed functors again

Now, suppose this sounds a bit vague. If only we had some example of a natural transformation in programming, that we can use... But wait, we did show a natural transformation in the previous chapter, when we talked about pointed functors.

That's right, a functor is pointed when there is a natural transformation between it and the identity functor i.e. to have

one green arrow for every object/type.



Pointed functor

And this clearly is a natural transformation. As a matter of fact, if we get down to the nitty-gritty, we would see that it resembles a lot the equivalence diagram that we saw earlier — both transformations involve the identity functor, and both transformations have the same category as source and target, that's why we can put everything in one circle (we don't do that in the equivalence diagram, but that's just a matter of presentation).

Actually, the only difference between the two transformations is that an equivalence is defined by a natural *natural isomorphism* of a given functors to the identity functor ($ID \circ f \cong g$ and $ID \cong g \circ f$), while a pointed functor is defined by a one-way *natural transformation* from the identity functor ($ID \circ f$) i.e. the equivalence functor is pointed, but not the other way around).

Polymorphic functions as natural transformations

We said that a natural transformation is equivalent to a (parametrically) polymorphic function in programming. But wait, wasn't natural transformation something else (and much more complicated):

Two functors F and G that have the same type signature (so $F : C \rightarrow D$ and $G : C \rightarrow D$ for some categories C and D), and a family of morphisms in the target category D (denoted $\alpha : F \Rightarrow G$) one for each object in C . Morphisms that map each object of the target of F (or the image of F in D as it is also called) to some object in the target of G .

Indeed it is (I wasn't lying to you, in case you are wondering), however, in the case of programming, the source and target categories of both functors are the same category (Set), so the whole condition regarding the functors' type signatures can be dropped.

~~Two functors~~ generic types F and G ~~that have the same type signature~~ and a family of morphisms in Set (denoted $\alpha : Set \Rightarrow Set$) one for each object in Set , that map each target object of the functor F (or the image of F in D as it is also called) to some target objects of functor G .

As we know from the last chapter, a functor in programming is a generic type (which, has to have the `map` function with the appropriate signature).

And what is a “family of morphisms in *Set* one for each object in *Set*”? Well, the morphisms in the category *Set* are functions, so that’s just a bunch of functions, one for each type. In Haskell notation, if we denote a random type by the letter *a*), it is *alpha* : $\forall a. Fa \rightarrow Ga$. But that’s exactly what polymorphic functions are.

Here is how would we write the above definition in a more traditional language (we use capital *<A>* instead of *a*, as customary).

```
function alpha<A>(a: F<A>) : G<A> {  
}
```

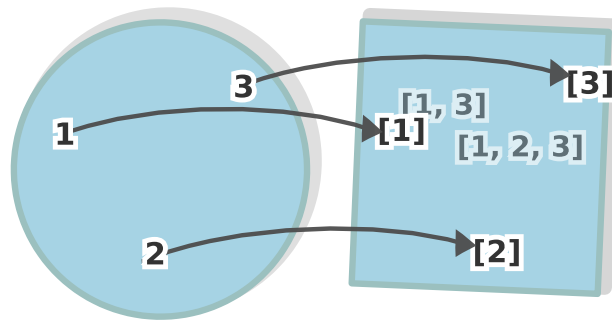
Generic types work by replacing the *<A>* with some concrete type, like `string`, `int` etc. Specifically, the natural transformation from the identity functor to the list functor that puts each value in a singleton list looks like this *alpha* : $\forall a. a \rightarrow List\ a$. Or in TypeScript:

```
function array<A>(a: A) : Array<A> {  
    return [a]  
}
```

Some examples of natural transformations

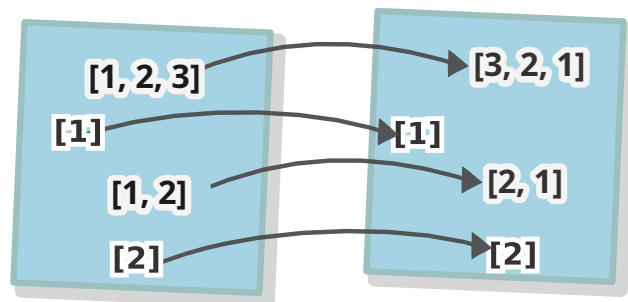
Once we rid ourselves of the feeling of confusion, that such an excessive amount of new terminology and concepts impose upon us (which can take years, by the way), we realize that there are, of course, many polymorphic functions/natural transformations that programmers use.

For example, in the previous chapter, we discussed one natural transformation/polymorphic function the function $\forall a. a \rightarrow [a]$ which puts every value in a singleton list. This function is a natural transformation between the identity functor and the list functor.



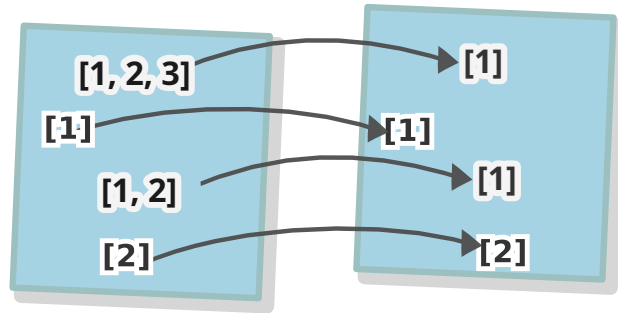
Natural transformation, defining a pointed functor in Set

This is pretty much the only one that is useful with *this* signature (the others being $a \rightarrow [a, a]$, $a \rightarrow [a, a, a]$ etc.), but there are many examples with signature *list* $a \rightarrow$ *list* a , such as the function to *reverse* a list.



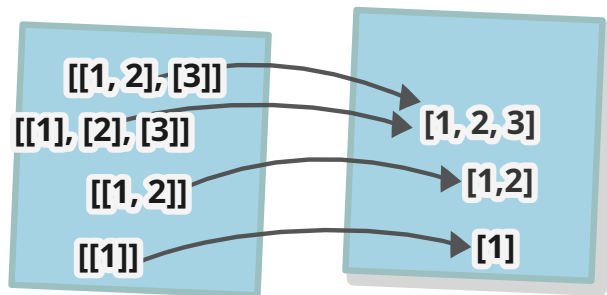
The natural transformation, for reversing a list in Set

...or *take1* that retrieves the first element of a list



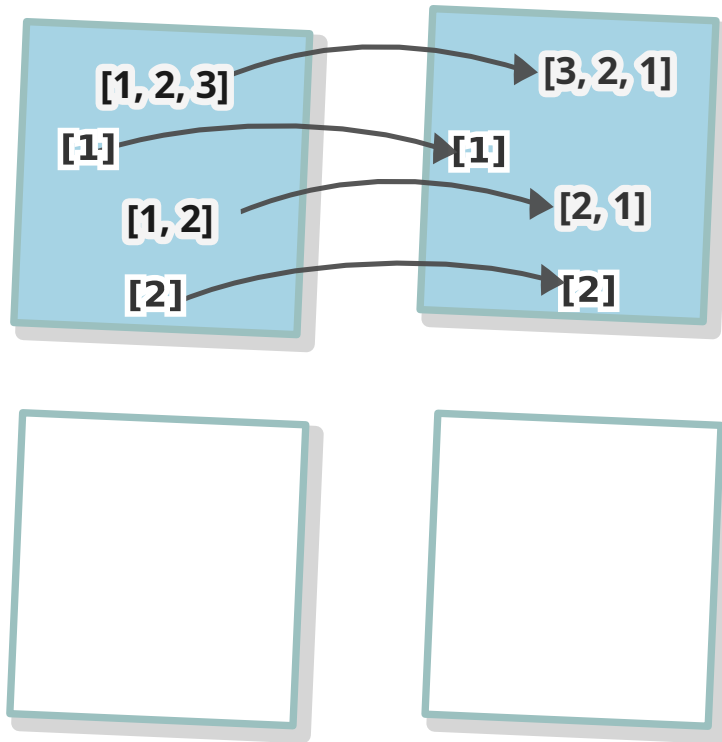
The natural transformation, for taking the first element of a list in Set

or *flatten* a list of lists of things to a regular list of things (the signature of this one is a little different, it's $list\ list\ a \rightarrow list\ a$).



The natural transformation, for flattening a list in Set

Task 3: Draw example naturality squares of the *reverse* natural transformation.



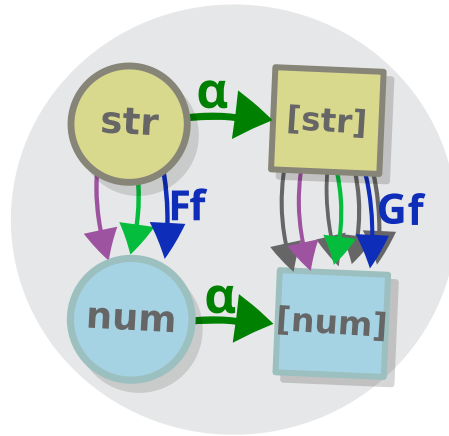
Do the same for the rest of the transformations.

The naturality condition

Before, we said that we shouldn't worry too much about naturality, as it is satisfied every time. Statistically, however, this is not true — as far as I am concerned, about 99.999 percent of transformations aren't really natural (I wonder if you can compute that percentage properly?). But at the same time, it just so happens (my favourite phrase when writing about maths) that all transformations that we care about *are* natural.

So, what does the naturality condition entail, in programming? To understand this, we construct some naturality squares of the transformations that we presented.

We choose two types that play the role of a , in our case *string* and *num* and one natural transformation, like the transformation between the identity functor and the list functor.



Pointed functor in Set

The diagram commutes when for all functions f , applying the Ff , the mapped/lifted version of f with one functor (in our case this is just $Ff : \text{string} \rightarrow \text{num}$ cause it is the identity functor), followed by $(\alpha : : Fb \rightarrow Gb)$, is equivalent to applying $(\alpha : : Fa \rightarrow Ga)$, and then the mapped version of f with the other functor (in our case $Gf : : \text{List } a \rightarrow \text{List } b$) i.e.

$$\alpha \circ Ff \cong Gf \circ \alpha$$

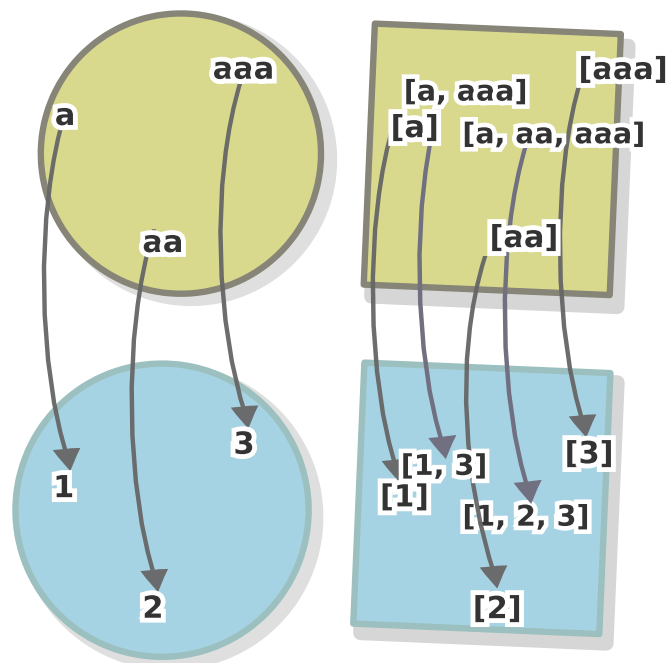
(in the programming world, you would also see it as something like $\alpha(\text{map } fx) = \text{map } f(ax)$, but note that here *map* function means two different things on the two sides, Haskell is just smart enough to deduce which *fmap* to use).

And in TypeScript, when we are talking specifically about the identity functor and the list functor, the equality is expressed as:

```
[x].map(f) == [f(x)]
```

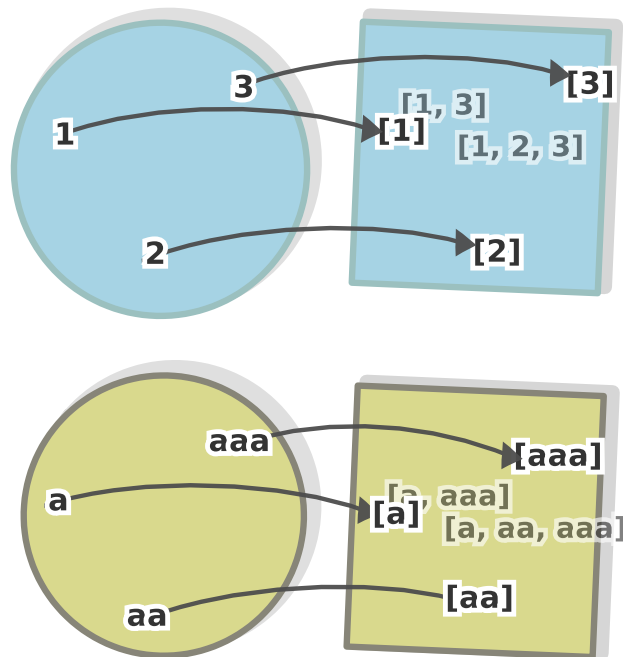
So, is this equation true in our case? To verify it, we take one last peak at the world of values.

We acquire an f , that is, we a function that acts on simple values (not lists), such as the function $length : string \rightarrow num$, which returns the number of characters a string has and convert it, (or *lift* it, as the terminology goes) to a function that acts on more complex values, using the list functor, (and the higher-order function map).



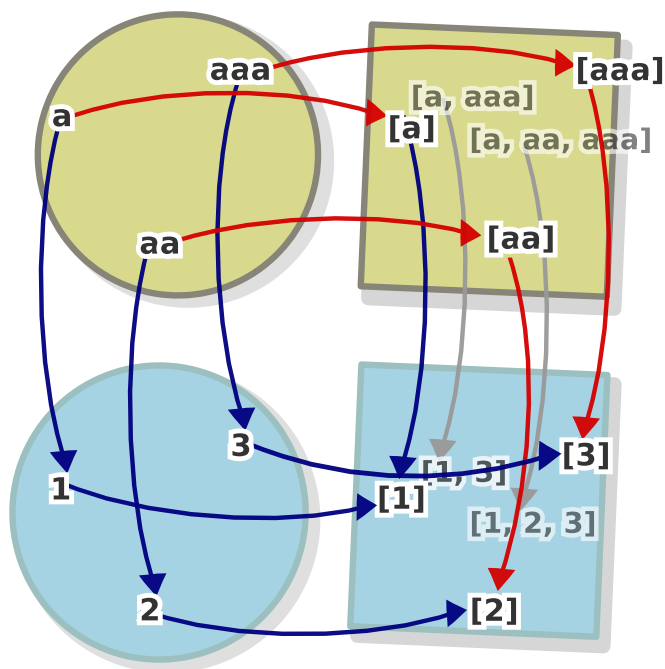
A lifted function

Then, we take the input and output types for this function (in this case $string$ and num), and the two morphisms of a natural transformation (e.g the abstract function $\forall a. a \rightarrow [a]$) that correspond to those two types.



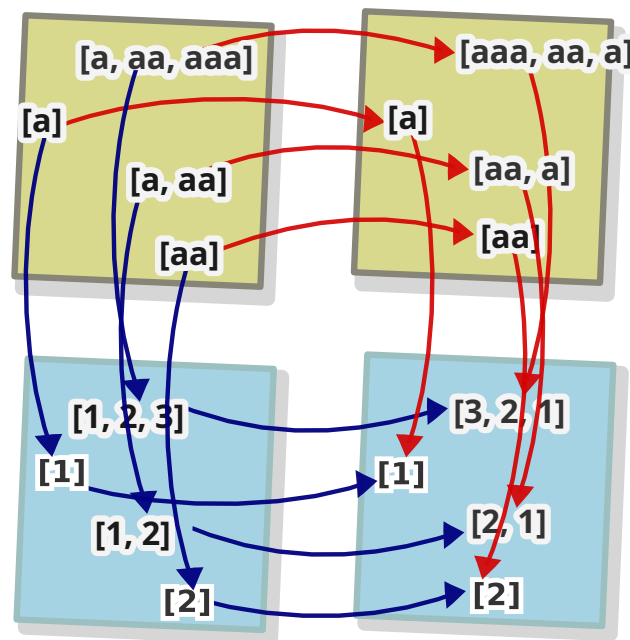
Pointed functor in Set

When we compose these two pairs of morphisms we observe that they indeed commute — we get two morphisms that are actually one and the same function.



Pointed functor in Set

The above square shows the transformation $\forall a. a \rightarrow [a]$ (which is between the identity functor and the list functor, here is another one, this time between the list functor and itself ($\forall a. [a] \rightarrow [a]$) — *reverse*



Pointed functor in Set

(and you can see that this would work not just for *length*, but for any other function).

So, why does this happen? Why do these particular transformations make up a commuting square for each and every morphism?

The answer is simple, at least in our specific case: the original, unlifted function $f: a \rightarrow b$ (like our $length: string \rightarrow num$) can only work on the individual values (not with structure), while the natural transformation functions, i.e. ones with signature

$list : a \rightarrow list\ a$ only alter the structure, and not individual values. The naturality condition just says that these two types of functions can be applied in any order that we please, without changing the end result.

This means that if you have a sequence of natural transformations that you want to apply, (such as *reverse* , *take*, *flatten* etc) and some lifted functions (Ff , Fg), you can mix and match between the two sequences in any way you like and you will get the same result e.g.

$take1 \circ reverse \circ Ff \circ Fg$

is the same as

$take1 \circ Ff \circ reverse \circ Fg$

...Or...

$Ff \circ Fg \circ take1 \circ reverse$

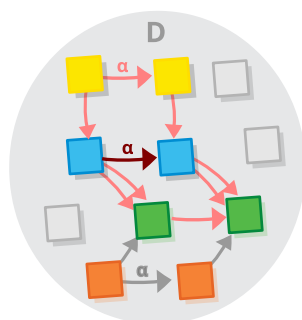
...or any other such sequence (the only thing that isn't permitted is to flip the members of the two sequences — ($take1 \circ reverse$ is of course different from $reverse \circ take1$ and if you have $Ff \circ Fg$, then $Fg \circ Ff$ won't be permitted at all due to the different type signatures).

Task 4: Prove the above results, using the formula of the naturality condition.

Non-natural transformations

“Unnatural”, or “non-natural” transformations (let’s call them just *transformations*) are mentioned so rarely, that we might be inclined to ask if they exist. The answer is “yes and no”. Why yes? On one hand, transformations, consist of an innumerable amount of morphisms, forming an ever more innumerable amount of squares and obviously nothing stops some of these squares to be non-commuting.

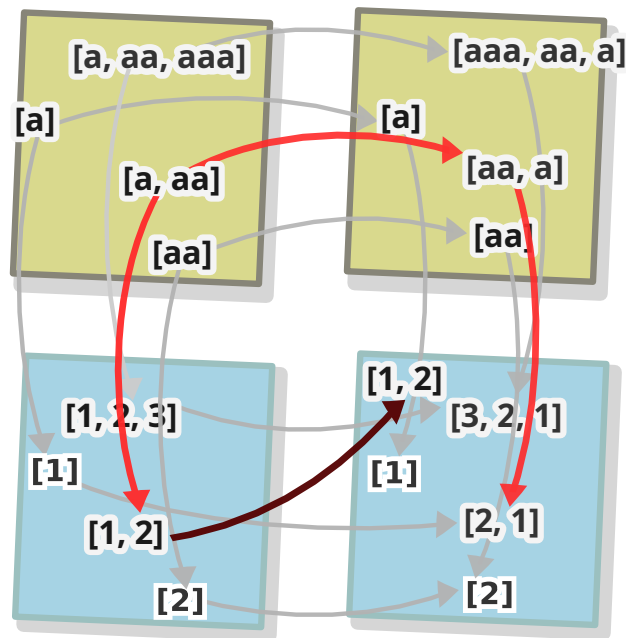
For example, if we substitute one morphism from the family of morphisms that make up the natural transformation with some other random morphism that has the same signature, all squares that have this morphism as a component would stop commuting.



Unnatural transformation

This would result in something like an “almost-natural” transformation (e.g. an abstract function that reverses all lists, except lists of integers).

And in the category of sets, where morphisms are functions i.e. mappings between values, it is enough to move just one arrow of just one of those values in order to make the transformation “unnatural” (e.g. a function which reverses all lists, but one specific list).



Unnatural transformation in set — like reverse, but one arrow is off

Finally, if can just gather a bunch of random morphisms, one for each object, that fit the criteria, we get what I would call a “perfectly unnatural transformation” (but this is my terminology).

But, although they do exist, it is very hard to define non-natural transformations. For example, for categories that are *infinite*, there is no way to specify such “perfectly unnatural transformation” (ones where none of the squares commute) without resorting to randomness. And even transformations on finite categories, or the “semi-natural” transformations which we described above (the ones that include a single condition for a single value or type), are not possible to specify in some languages e.g. you can define such a transformation in Typescript, but not in Haskell.

To see why, let’s see what the type of a natural transformation is.

$\forall a. Fa \rightarrow Ga$

The key is that the definition should be valid *for all* types a . For this reason, there is no way for us to specify a different arrows for different types, without resorting to type downcasting, which is not permitted in languages like Haskell (as it breaks the principle of parametricity).

Interlude: Skolem variables and parametrization

Let's try to define the "semi-natural" transformation that we described above (the ones that include a single condition for a single value or type) e.g. an abstract function that reverses all lists, except the list of booleans). In Typescript, it will look something like this.

```
function unnatural<A> (a: Array<A>): Array <A>{
  if(typeof a[0] === 'string') {
    return a
  } else {
    return a.reverse()
  }
}
```

(Look at this piece of code! Doesn't this seem "unnatural"?)

This will work, but, if you try to do the same in Haskell, for example, it would immediately tell you that you cannot (" a is a rigid type variable" (also known as "Skolem variable" in other context)). Why is it so? There are some *technical reasons*, as runtime type checks like this one, add performance overhead, because they require the runtime to preserve type information

for each value, after compilation, but there is also a strong *philosophical reason*: a general function should work in a general way. And the generality of a function that checks the type of a value at runtime (and behaves differently for different types) is dubious at best.

Such function is like, (if we switch to the logic branch of the Curry-Howard isomorphism) proving a general statement, of the form “All a ’s have a given property” by merely pointing out that the a s that are currently in existence happen to have it. Surely, even if valid in some contexts, such proofs are a very limited in terms of both scope and information they carry e.g. the assertion that all people who are sited at the table next to you have brown hair doesn’t tell you anything of substance, unless there is a deeper reason for it to be true.

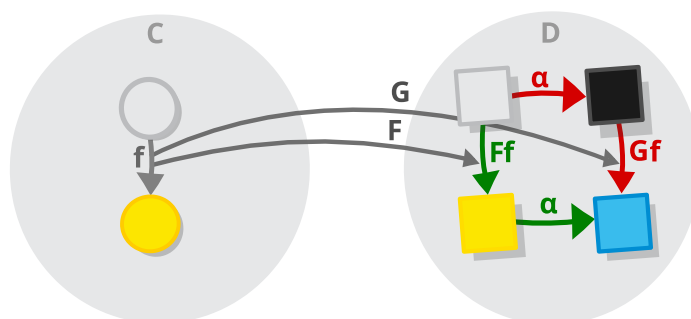
In other words, unnatural transformations wouldn’t work in Haskell, simply because they are ... unnatural i.e. they do not follow the laws.

By the way, in programming, this principle is called “parametricity” and the natural abstract functions are called “parametrically polymorphic”, whereas unnatural polymorphic functions are known as ad-hoc polymorphic.

Natural transformations again

Now, after we saw the definition of natural transformations, it is time to see the definition of natural transformations (and if you feel that the quality of the humour in this book is deteriorating, that's only because *things are getting serious*).

Let's review again the commuting diagram that represents a natural transformation.



Two functors

This diagram might prompt us into viewing natural transformations as some kind of “two-arrow functors” that have not one but two arrows coming from each of their morphisms — this notion, can be formalized, by using *product categories*.

Oh wait, I just realized we never covered product categories... but don't worry, we will cover them now.

Product groups and product categories

We haven't covered product categories, however some pages ago, when we covered monoids and groups, we talked about the concept of a *product group*. The good news is that product *categories* are a generalization of product *groups*...

The bad news is that you probably don't remember much about product groups, as covered them briefly.

But don't worry, we will do a more in-depth treatment now:

Product groups

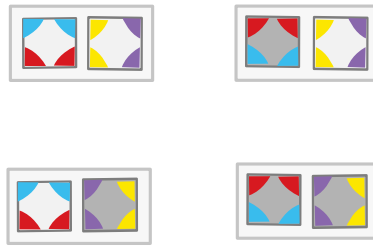
Given two groups G and H , whose sets of elements can also be denoted G and H ...



The Klein four as a product group

(in this example we use two boolean groups, which we visualize as the groups of horizontal and vertical rotation of a square)

...the *product group* of these two groups is a group that has the cartesian product of these two sets $G \times H$ as its set of elements.



The Klein four as a product group

And what can the group operation of such a group be? Well, I would say that out of the few possible groups operations for this set that *exist*, this is the *only* operation that is *natural* (I didn't intend to involve natural transformation at this section, but they really do appear everywhere). So, let's try to derive the operation of this group.

We know what a group operation is, in principle: A group operation combines two elements from the group into a third element i.e. it is a function with the following type signature:

$$\circ : (A,A) \rightarrow A$$

or equivalently

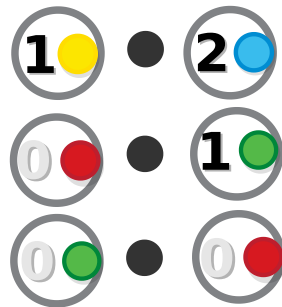
$$\circ : A \rightarrow A \rightarrow A$$

And for product groups, we said that the underlying set of the group (which we dubbed A above) is a cartesian product of some other two sets which we dubbed G and H . So, when we swap A for $G \times H$ the definition becomes:

$$\circ : G \times H \rightarrow G \times H \rightarrow G \times H$$

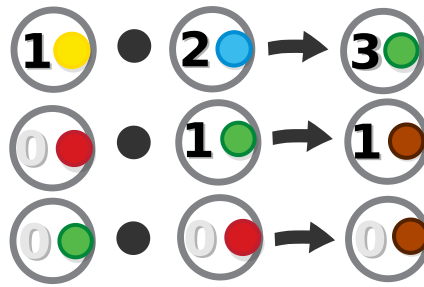
i.e. the group operation takes one pair of elements from G and H and another pair of elements from G and H , only to return — guess what — a pair of elements G and H .

Let's take an example. To avoid confusion, we take two totally different groups — the color-mixing group and the group of integers under addition. That would mean that a value of $G \times H$ would be a pair, containing a random color and a random number, and the operation would combine two combine two such pairs and produce another one.



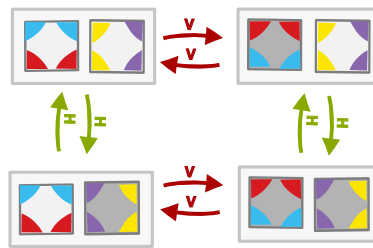
Equations of the product of numbers and colors

Now, the operation must produce a pair, containing a number and a color. Furthermore, it would be good if it produces a number *by using those two numbers*, not just picking one at random, and likewise for colors. And furthermore, we want it to work not just for monoids of numbers and colors, but all other monoids that can be given to us. It is obvious that there is only one solution, to get the elements of the new pair by combining the elements of the pairs given.



Solutions of the product of numbers and colors

And the operation of the product group of the two boolean groups which we presented earlier is the combination of the two operations



The Klein four as a product group

So, the general definition of the operation is the following ($g1, g2$ are elements of G and $h1$ and $h2$ elements of H).

$$(g1, h1) \circ (g2, h2) = ((g1 \circ g2), (h1 \circ h2))$$

And that are product groups.

Product categories

We are back at tackling product *categories*.

Since we know what product *groups* are, and we know that groups are nothing but categories with just one object (and the group objects are the category's morphisms, remember?), we are already almost there.

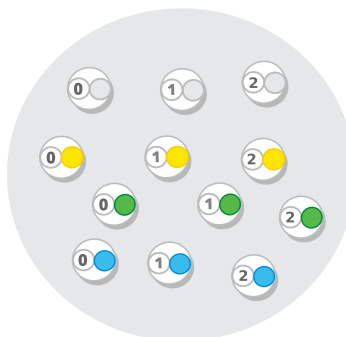
Here is a way to make a product category.

Take any two categories:



Product category - components

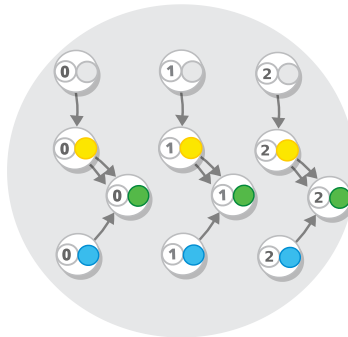
Then take the set of all possible pairs of the objects of these categories.



Product category - objects

And, finally, we make a category out of that set by taking all morphisms coming from any of the two categories and replicate them to all pairs that feature some objects from their type

signature, in the same way as we did for product groups (in this example, only one of the categories has morphisms).

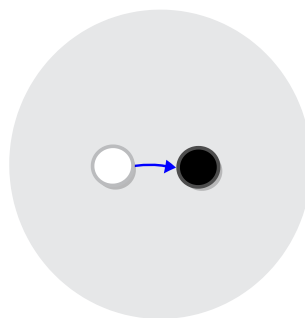


Product category

This is the *product category* of the two categories.

Natural transformations as functors of product categories

In this section we are interested with the products of one particular category, namely the category we called 2, containing two objects and one morphism (stylishly represented in black and white).



The category 2

This category is the key to constructing a functor that is equivalent to a natural transformation:

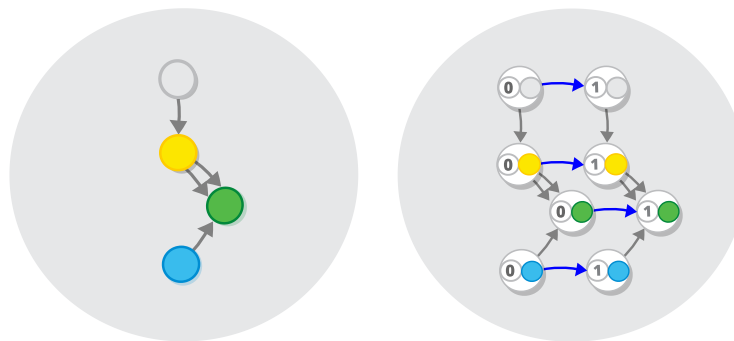
- Because it has two objects, it produces two copies of the source category.
- because the two objects are connected, the two copies are connected in the same way as the two “images” in the target category are connected.

So, given a product category of 2 and some other category C ...



The category 2

...there exist a natural transformation between C and the product category $2 \times C$.



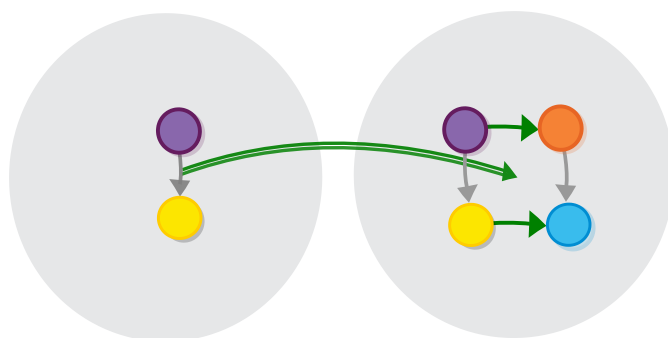
Product category

Furthermore, this connection is two-way: any natural transformation from C to some other category (call it D , as it is customary) can be represented as a functor $2 \times C \rightarrow D$.

That is, if we have a natural transformations $\alpha : F \Rightarrow G$ (where $F : C \rightarrow D$ and $G : C \rightarrow D$), then, we also have a functor $2 \times C \rightarrow D$, such that if we take the subcategory of $2 \times C$ comprised of just those objects that have the 0 object as part of the pair, and the morphisms between them, we get a functor that is equivalent to F , and if we consider the subcategory that contains 1, then the functor is equivalent to G (we write $\alpha(-,0) = F$ and $\alpha(-,1) = G$). Et voilà!

Task 5: Show that the two definitions are equivalent.

This perspective helps us realize that a natural transformation can be viewed as a collection of commuting squares. The source functor defines the left-hand side of each square, the target functor — the right-hand side, and the transformation morphisms join these two sides.



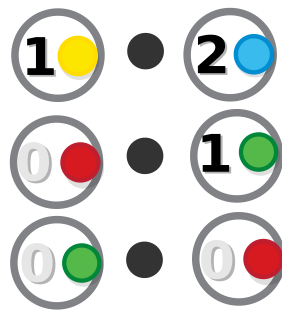
Notation for natural transformation

We can even retrieve the structure of the source category of these functors, which (as categories are by definition structure and nothing more) is equivalent to retrieving the category itself.

Interlude: Naturality in product group operations

Now, we will have one really peculiar interlude, in which we will show that the group operation of product groups is actually a natural transformation.

To understand why this is the case, let's look at the equations once more.



Equations of the product of numbers and colors

We said that in order for the solutions for this equations, to make sense, they would have to work for all monoids, not just numbers and colors. In other words, there should be a mechanism that, given two monoids, produces a third one. This mechanism can be nothing more (and nothing less) than a polymorphic function.

$$\forall GH. G \rightarrow H \rightarrow G \times H$$

We shown above how polymorphic functions are transformations (this one is harder to reason about, since it is parametrized over not one, but two types, but we learned how to represent functions that take two arguments as functions that take one argument in chapter 2).

And the naturality condition guarantees that our solution would produce a number/color etc. *by using the two numbers/colors provided*, not just picking one at random.

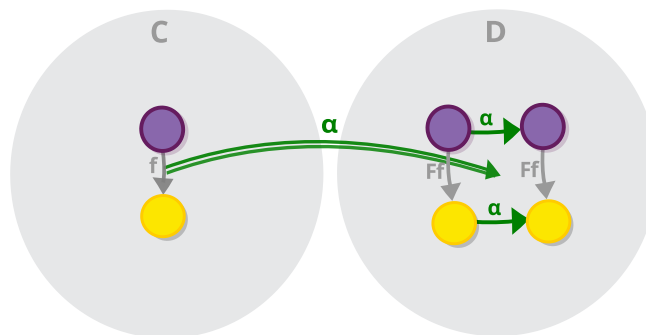
You can prove that the naturality condition indeed does hold (correct by construction) for all product groups.

Composing natural transformations

Natural transformations are surely a different beast than normal morphisms and functors and so they don't compose in the same way. However, they do compose and here we will show how.

The identity natural transformation

Let's first get one trivial definition out of the way: for each functor, we have the identity natural transformation (actually a natural isomorphism) between it and itself.



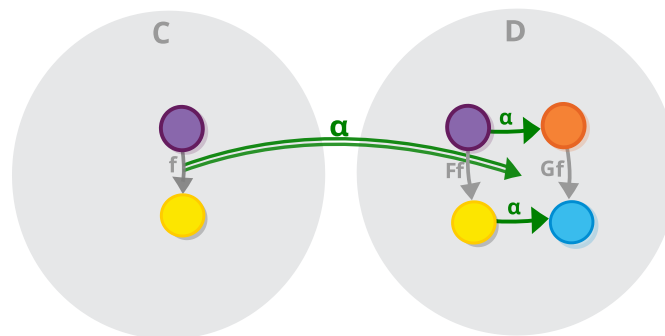
The identity natural transformation

Horizontal composition

The setup for composing natural transformations may look complicated the first time you see it: we need three categories C , D and E (just as composition of morphisms requires three objects). We need a total of four functors, distributed on two pairs, one pair of functors that goes from C to D and one that

goes from D to E (so we can compose these two pairs of functors together, to get a new pair of functors that go $C \rightarrow E$). However, we will try to keep it simple and we will treat the natural transformation as a map from a morphism to a commuting square. As we showed above, this mapping already contains the two functors in itself.

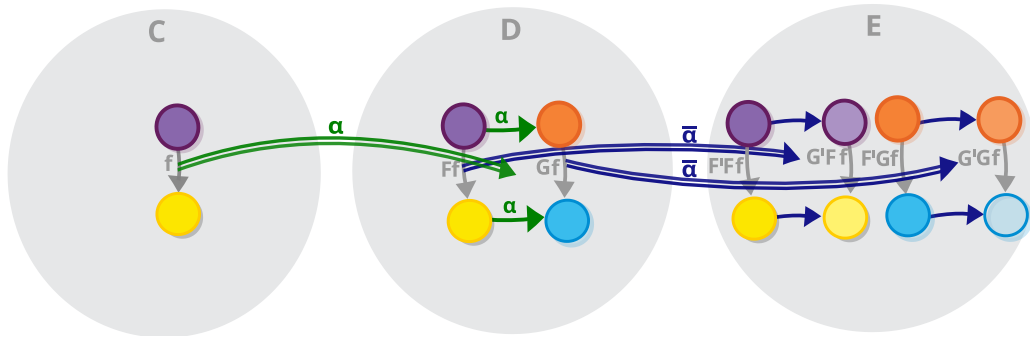
So, let's say that we have the natural transformation α involving the $C \rightarrow D$ functors (which we usually call F and G).



Notation for natural transformation

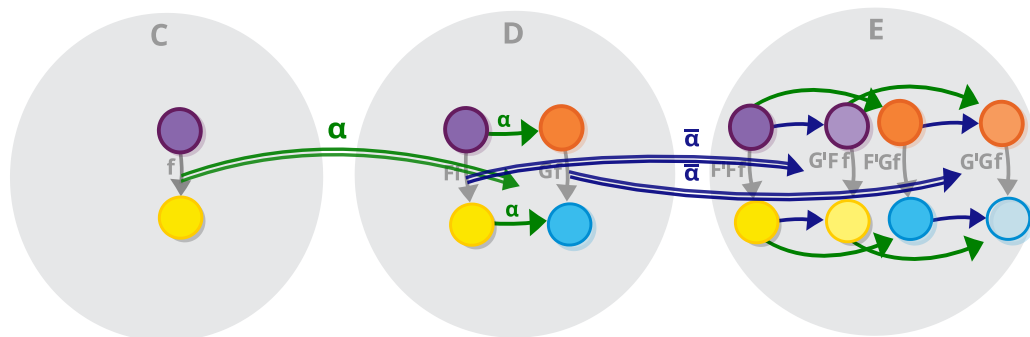
So, what will happen if we have one more transformation $\bar{\alpha}$ involving the functors that go $D \rightarrow E$ (which are labelled F' and G')? Well, since a natural transformation maps each morphism to a square, and a square contains four morphisms (two projections by the two functors and two components of the transformation), a square would be mapped to four squares.

Let's start by drawing two of them for each projection of the morphism in C .



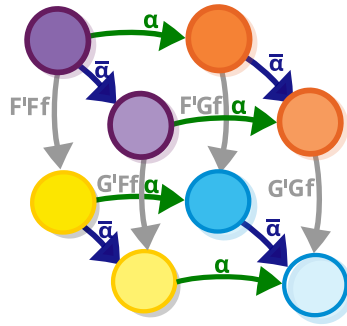
Horizontal composition of natural transformation

We have to have two more squares, corresponding to the two morphisms that are the components of the α natural transformation. However, these morphisms connect the objects that are the target of the two functors, objects that we already have on our diagram, so we just have to draw the connections between them.



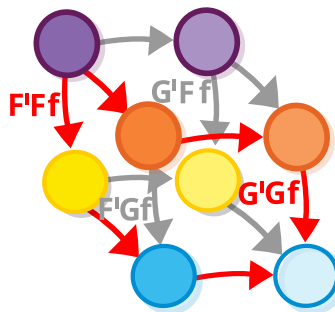
Horizontal composition of natural transformation

The result is an interesting structure which is sometimes visualized as a cube.



Horizontal composition of natural transformation

More interestingly, when we compose the commuting squares from the sides of the cube horizontally, we see that it contains not one, but two bigger commuting squares (they look like *rectangles* in this diagram), visualized in grey and red. Both of them connect morphisms $F'Ff$ and $G'Gf$.



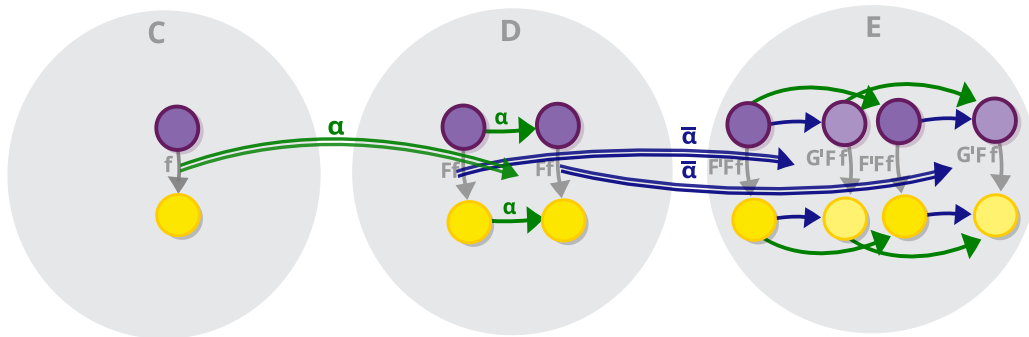
Horizontal composition of natural transformation

So, there is a natural transformation between the composite functor $F' \circ F : C \rightarrow E$ and $G' \circ G : C \rightarrow E$ — a natural transformation that is usually marked $\tilde{\alpha} \bullet \alpha$ (with a black dot).

Task 6: Show that natural transformations indeed compose i.e. that if you have natural transformations $F'Ff \Rightarrow F'Gf$ and $F'Gf \Rightarrow G'Gf$ you have $F'Ff \Rightarrow G'Gf$.

Whiskering

And an interesting special case of horizontal composition is horizontal composition involving the identity natural transformation: given a natural transformation $\bar{\alpha}$ involving functors with signature $D \rightarrow E$ and some functor with signature $F : C \rightarrow D$, we can take α to be the identity natural transformation between functor F and itself and compose it with $\bar{\alpha}$.



Horizontal composition of natural transformation

We get a new natural transformation $\bar{\alpha} \cdot \alpha$, that is practically the same as the one we started with (i.e. the same as $\bar{\alpha}$) so what's the deal? We just found a way to *extend* natural transformations, using functors: i.e we can use a functor with signature $C \rightarrow D$ to extend a $D \rightarrow E$ natural transformation and make it $C \rightarrow E$.

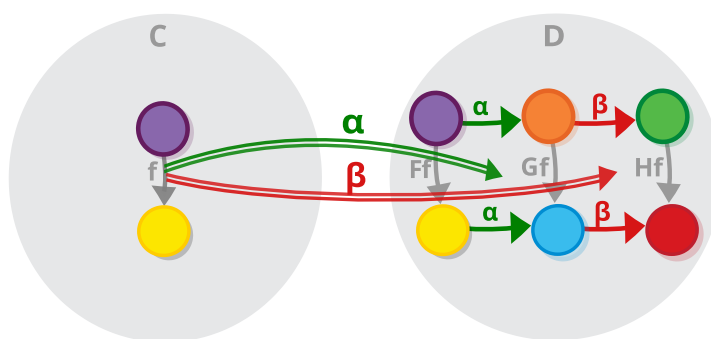
Task 7: Try to extend the natural transformation in the other direction (by taking $\bar{\alpha}$ to be identity).

So, this is how you compose natural transformations. It's too bad that this form of composition is different from the standard categorical composition. So, I guess natural transformations do not form a category, like we hoped they would...

Well, OK, there is actually another way of composing categories, which might actually work.

Vertical composition

Recall that categorical composition involves three objects and two successive arrows between them. For vertical composition of natural transformations, we will need three (or more) *functors* with the same type signature, say $F, G, H : C \rightarrow D$ i.e. (same source and target category) and two successive *natural transformations* between those functors i.e. $\alpha : F \rightarrow G$ and $\beta : G \rightarrow H$.



Vertical composition of natural transformations

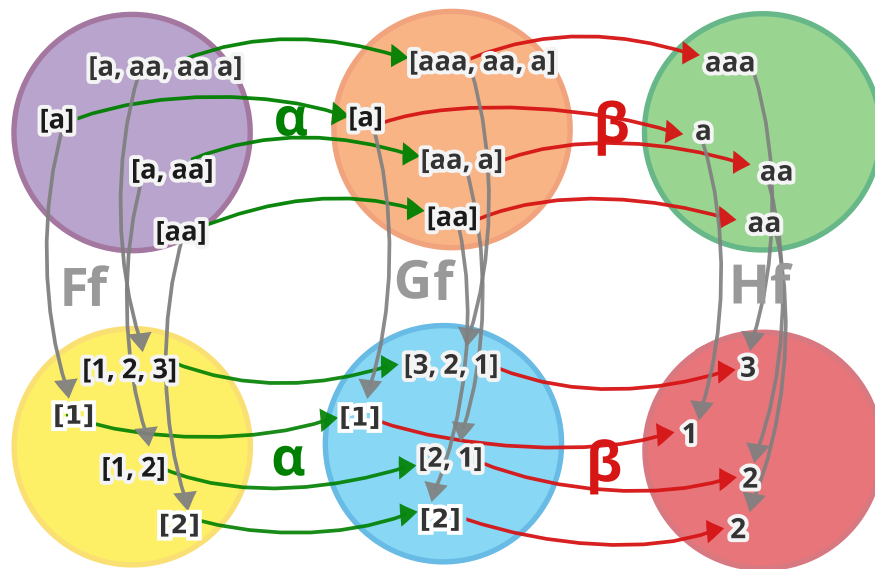
We can combine each morphism of the natural transformation α (e.g. $a : F \rightarrow G$) and the corresponding morphism of the natural transformation β (say $b : G \rightarrow H$) to get a new morphism, which we call $b \circ a : F \rightarrow H$ (the composition operator is the usual white circle, as opposed to the black one, which denotes horizontal composition). And the set of all such morphisms are precisely the components of a new natural transformation: $\beta \circ \alpha : F \rightarrow H$.

Categories of functors

Now, we are approaching the end of the chapter, we will introduce our category and call it quits. To do that, we first

introduce a more compressed notation for vertical composition of natural transformations (where they do indeed look vertical).

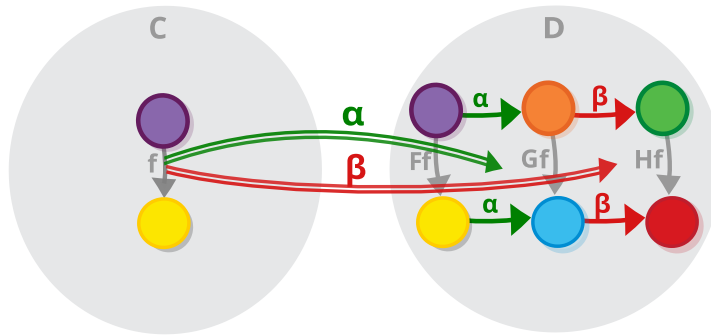
We started this chapter by looking at category of sets and using internal diagrams, displaying the set elements as points and the sets/objects as collections.



Vertical composition of natural transformations - internal diagram

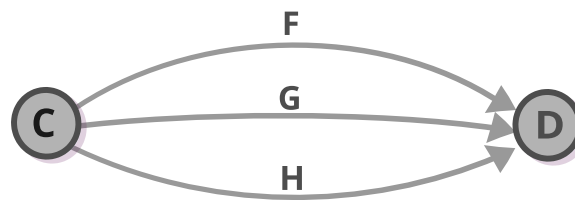
Task 8: identify the function, the three functors, and the two natural transformations used in this diagram.

Then, we quickly passed to normal external diagrams, where objects are points and categories are collections.



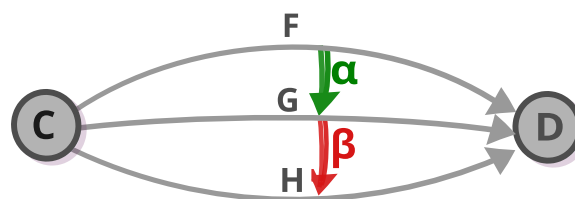
Vertical composition of natural transformations

And now we go one more level further, and show the category of categories, where categories are points and functors are morphisms.



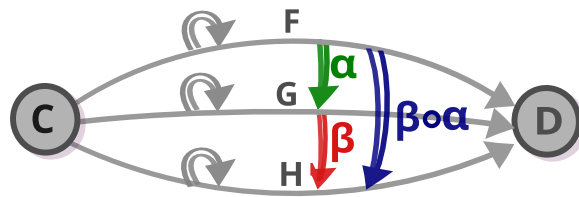
Vertical composition of natural transformations in Cat

In this notation, we display natural transformations as (double) arrows between morphisms.



Vertical composition of natural transformations in Cat

And you can already see the new category that is formed: For each two categories (like C and D in this case), there exists a category which has functors for objects and natural transformations as morphisms.



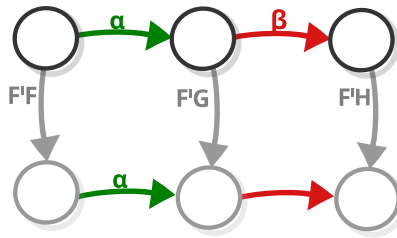
Vertical composition of natural transformations in Cat

Natural transformations compose with vertical compositions, and, of course, the identity natural transformation is the identity morphism.

Interchange law

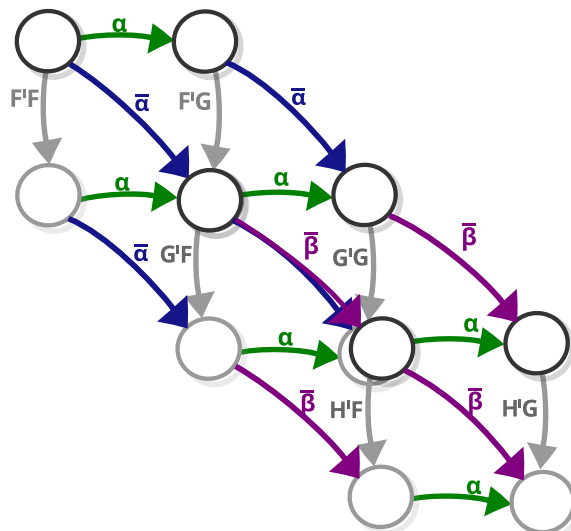
Vertical and horizontal composition of natural transformations are related to each other in the following way:

If we have (as we had) two successive natural transformations, in the vertical sense, like $\alpha : F \rightarrow G$ and $\beta : G \rightarrow H$.



The interchange law – horizontal component

And two successive ones, this time in horizontal sense e.g. $\tilde{\alpha} : F' \rightarrow G'$ and $\tilde{\beta} : G' \rightarrow H'$. (note that α has nothing to do with $\tilde{\alpha}$ as β has nothing to do with $\tilde{\beta}$, we just call them that way to avoid using too many letters)



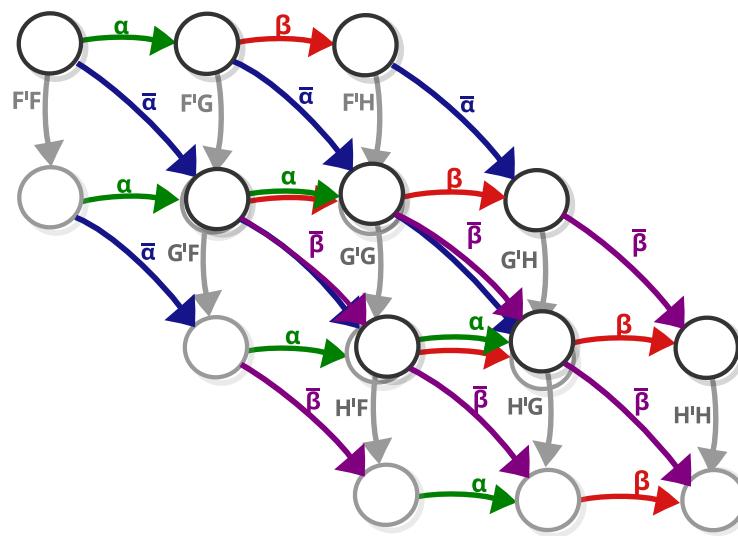
The interchange law – vertical component

And if the two pairs of natural transformations both start from the same category and the same functor, then the compositions

of the two pairs of natural transformations obey the following law

$$(\beta \circ \alpha) \cdot (\bar{\beta} \circ \bar{\alpha}) = (\beta \cdot \bar{\beta}) \circ (\alpha \cdot \bar{\alpha})$$

Task 9: Draw the paths of the two compositions of the transformations (on the two sides of the equation) and ensure that they indeed lead to the same place.



The interchange law

2-Categories

At this point you might be wondering the following (although statistically you are more likely to wonder what the heck is all this about): We know that all categories are objects of Cat , the category of small categories, in which functors play the role of morphisms.

But, functors between given categories also form a category, under vertical composition. Which means that *Cat* not only has (as any other category) morphisms between objects, *but* also has *morphisms between morphisms*. And furthermore, those two types of morphisms compose in this very interesting way.

So, what does that make of *Cat*? I don't know, perhaps we can call natural transformations "2-morphisms" and *Cat* is some kind of "2-category"?

But wait, actually it's way too early for you to find out. We haven't even covered limits...

Answers

Task 1: Check if that definition is valid.

The definition in question is:

Two **categories** A and B are **isomorphic** (or $A \cong B$) if there exist *functors* $f : A \rightarrow B$ and its reverse $g : B \rightarrow A$, such that $f \circ g = ID_B$ and $g \circ f = ID_A$.

We can check it by expanding the definition of a functor.

The functor consists of: 1. Object mapping 2. Morphism mapping 3. Laws

Expanding the object mapping gives us exactly the definition of set isomorphism:

Two **sets** A and B are **isomorphic** (or $A \cong B$) if there exist functions $f : A \rightarrow B$ and its reverse $g : B \rightarrow A$, such that $f \circ g = ID_B$ and $g \circ f = ID_A$.

Expanding the morphism mapping and the law would give us the rest.

Task 2: When exactly would the mapping encompass all objects?

As we say above: > mapping the two functors' object components involves nothing more than specifying a bunch of morphisms in the target category: one morphism for each object

in the source category i.e. each object from the image of the first functor, should have one arrow coming from it.

So the mapping encompasses all object *from the image of the functor*. So when would that encompass all objects period. Simple — when the functor is one-to-one (or onto, if we are with there being more than one arrow per object). Most probably, that would happen when the two categories are actually one and the same category and the functor is the identity functor.

Task 3: Draw example naturality squares of the *reverse* natural transformation.

To draw a square of the $reverse : List\ a \rightarrow List\ a$ natural transformation, we must first: 1. Pick a function, f say $+1 : number \rightarrow number$. 2. Lift it with the functor e.g $Ff : Listnumber \rightarrow Listnumber$ adds one to every number from the list.

Then we: 1. Draw the results of the application of the function on the sets that are at the top, at the corresponding boxes at the bottom e.g. $[1,2]$ becomes $[2,3]$. 2. Draw the connections of applying the *reverse* natural transformation.

If we worked correctly, the square would commute.

Task 4: Prove the above results, using the formula of the naturality condition.

We want to prove that:

$$take1 \circ reverse \circ Ff \circ Fg$$

is the same as

$$take1 \circ Ff \circ reverse \circ Fg$$

We note that part of the equation contains a “lifted” function (one which is the result of the application of functor), followed by a natural transformation:

$$take1 \circ (Ff \circ reverse) \circ Fg$$

The naturality says that

$$\alpha \circ Ff \cong Gf \circ \alpha$$

We can replace α with $reverse$ (since $reverse$ is a natural transformation) and replace both the Ff and Gf with Ff (since F and G are the same functor (list))

$$reverse \circ Ff \cong Ff \circ reverse$$

Applying this we get:

$$take1 \circ (reverse \circ Ff) \circ Fg$$

Task 5: Show that the two definitions [of natural transformation] are equivalent.

This entails extracting a natural transformation from a functor $2 \times C \rightarrow D$, and the other way around.

Here, we will describe one direction of this process:

As we said, we can split the category $2 \times C$ into two subcategories (let's call those C^1 and C^2) which are both

isomorphic to C , one containing the objects that are paired with the first object of 2 and one containing the objects paired with the second object.

Likewise, we can split the functor $2 \times C \rightarrow D$ into two functors $C^1 \rightarrow D$ and $C^2 \rightarrow D$.

Now, all we need to do is show that there is a natural transformation between those two functors i.e. we have to find a family of morphisms in category D that connects the images of those two functors.

This family is the image of the morphisms from the category 2 i.e. if we traverse $2 \times C \rightarrow D$ and collect all morphisms in D which come from the category 2 , we already have our transformation.

This transformation is natural due to the way composition for product categories is defined (it is defined as the component-wise composition of the morphisms of the categories that are part of the product).

Task 6: Show that natural transformations indeed compose i.e. that if you have natural transformations $\alpha : F'F \Rightarrow F'G$ and $\tilde{\alpha} : F'G \Rightarrow G'G$ you have $\tilde{\alpha} \circ \alpha : F'F \Rightarrow G'G$.

To show that two transformations compose, we need to find a way, given two natural transformations with the above signatures, to construct a new one.

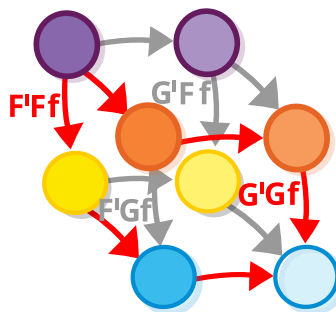
To do that, we remember that a natural transformation is just a family of morphisms, one for each object in the category C (and that we know how to compose morphisms).

For each object c in C , let $\tilde{\alpha}_c$ be the morphism that corresponds to it in the natural transformation $\tilde{\alpha}$ and let α_c be the morphism that corresponds to it in α .

Then, the morphism that corresponds to it in $\tilde{\alpha} \bullet \alpha$ is either $\tilde{\alpha}_c \circ F'(\alpha_c)$, if you follow the grey arrows of the cube, or alternatively $(\tilde{\alpha} \bullet \alpha)_c = G'(\tilde{\alpha}_c) \circ \alpha_c$, if you follow the grey arrows. Or, just $\tilde{\alpha}_c \circ \alpha_c$ if you don't care so much about notation.

That such morphisms form a transformation follows from the signatures of the morphisms.

This transformation is natural, because for all those morphisms we have the commuting square.

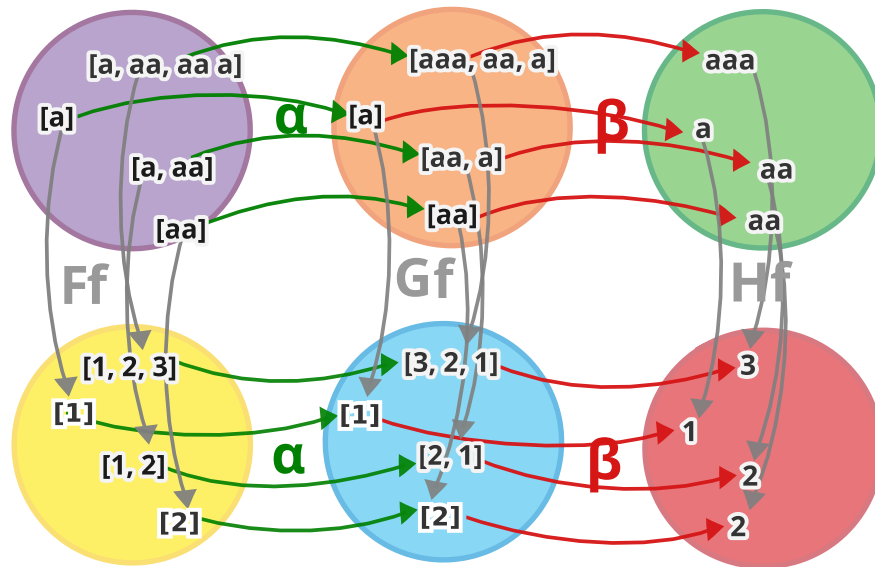


Horizontal composition of natural transformation

Task 7: Try to extend the natural transformation in the other direction (by taking $\tilde{\alpha}$ to be identity).

It works basically the same way and the result is also the same — you get a new natural transformation with a different signature.

Task 8: identify the function, the three functors, and the two natural transformations used in this diagram.



Vertical composition of natural transformations - internal diagram

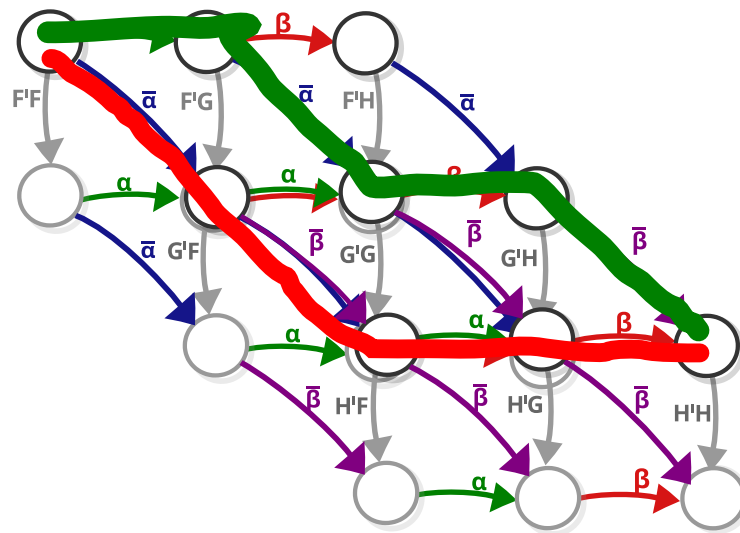
First the functors: F and G are the *List* functor, H is the *ID* functor.

Natural transformations: α is *reverse* : $List \rightarrow List$ and β is *head* : $List \rightarrow ID$ (or, if we want to be punctual, the type should be its *Non-empty* list, as *head* is only a partial natural transformation of *List*).

The function f is, as usual, $length : string \rightarrow int$.

Task 9: Draw the paths of the two compositions of the transformations (on the two sides of the equation) and ensure that they indeed lead to the same place.

One option is this:



The interchange law
